
SATIPANYA BUDDHIST RETREAT

Retreat Talks

*Retreat instruction recordings: guided meditations, evening talks,
and special topics*

Bhante Bodhidhamma

SHROPSHIRE, WALES · UNITED KINGDOM

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Detailed Guided Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min read

This comprehensive guided meditation provides detailed instructions for vipassanā bhāvanā (insight meditation) as taught by the Mahasi Sayadaw of Burma. Bhante Bodhidhamma begins with establishing proper meditative posture and systematic relaxation techniques, then guides practitioners through breath awareness at the abdomen using the characteristic 'rising, falling, touching' noting method.

The meditation deepens into the full Mahasi technique of satipaṭṭhāna—observing whatever arises in the field of awareness with detached, investigative attention. This includes sounds (noting 'hearing'), bodily sensations ('feeling', 'itching', 'heat'), emotions and mental states, and thoughts ('thinking', 'imagining'). The practice cultivates the balanced observer stance essential for insight—maintaining alert awareness while avoiding both attachment and aversion.

Throughout, Bhante emphasizes developing satipaṇṇā (mindful wisdom) to directly perceive the three characteristics of existence: impermanence (anicca), suffering/unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā). This methodical approach to bare attention and non-interfering observation forms the foundation for deeper insight that can lead to the realization of nibbāna. The session concludes with guidance for mindful transition back to daily activities.

A Detailed Guided Meditation Instructions on how to practice *Vipassanā Bhāvanā* insight meditation as taught by the Mahāsi Sayadaw of Burma.

Firstly, we must settle our body into a meditative posture. Some sit on chairs, others use kneeling stools, but the usual position is to sit on the floor with a cushion in a cross-legged posture. Your hands should rest on your lap, preferably one on top of the other. Now whatever posture you adopt it should at first feel comfortable. Then make sure the spine is straight though keeping its natural curvature. It's best not to lean against anything for this will induce sleep.

Now imagine a puppet string running from the base of the spine to the top of the head and it being gently pulled up so that all the vertebrae separate and there's a feeling of growing tall and light. A feeling of energy running up the spine without any tension or tightness. And the head should feel balanced on top. Now just let everything relax off that central column.

Here we can help ourselves relax with some simple exercises. Firstly, let's see how relaxed we can become by simply telling muscles to relax. Start from the top of the head and go down the rest of the body relaxing muscles as best you can. So start at the top of the head, come down over the brow, the eyes, the cheeks, the jaw, especially the jaw, the neck, shoulders, arms, and hands. Just feel everything getting heavier as tension stops supporting them. Now go back to the chest. Relax it. Go down the body to the stomach, to the abdomen. Just relaxing as best as you can. And finally, just feel your legs heavy on the floor.

Superficial surface tension should now be released if only a little, but we may feel a deeper level of tension more habitual and therefore not easy to relax by a mental volition. We can use a second technique here of muscular tension. Where you feel tension tense the muscles in that area as hard as you can and release them slowly. This is especially good for tension in the face. Just screw up the face as much as you can now. Hold it. And relax. Now let's try that again. Hold it. Hold it. And relax. It's also good for the neck and shoulders. Just tighten up that whole area now. Hold it. And relax slowly. Let's try that again. Tighten up the whole area. Neck and shoulders. Hold it. And just relax slowly.

A third technique is best for tensions felt in the chest, though it has an effect on the whole body. Controlled breathing. Take a slow, deep in-breath, fill the lungs to capacity, hold for as long as comfortable, and just let the whole ribcage fall quickly, expelling all the air. Then wait for the next breath to arise naturally, and this will prevent hyperventilation. So now let's take in a deep breath, hold it, and just let it go. Let's try that again. Take a deep breath. Hold it. And just let it go.

Hopefully you will have developed a deep relaxation. So now we should find ourselves in a posture highly conducive for meditation. The spine should be energised but not tense. The rest of the body should feel relaxed, hanging, as it were, off this central column of the spine. And the head should be gently poised on top, symbolizing the balance between physical alertness and relaxation. So now, for a few moments, let's feel this posture as a whole, and recognize its qualities of alert energy and yet calm relaxations.

Now we need to develop the same sense of energetic alertness and relaxed calmness in the mind, and to achieve this we use the breath. Place your attention on the abdomen and feel its rising and falling motion as you breathe naturally. Please note this is not a breathing technique. The breath should not be interfered with. Now it may be that the breath is not obvious to you at the abdomen, in which case see if you can feel it

at the chest, rising and falling. The breath at the nostrils may also be used, but for the Mahāsi technique it is preferable to use the abdomen. See now which one is most obvious to you.

Now whichever place you've chosen, this is your primary object of meditation. This means you will use this place to establish an alert and calm awareness. If you move from one place to another, say from the nose to the abdomen, this will undermine your ability to become concentrated, that is, the ability to watch with an alert but calm attention without flitting away.

If you're watching the breath process at the abdomen or chest, observe the movement, the rising and falling, and use a noting word to still the thinking process. With the in-breath, note rising, rising, and with the out-breath, note falling, falling. After the out-breath, there's a rest, and there's danger that the mind will run away on fantasies. Now, to stop this happening, we choose a touch point. It may be the feeling of your hands on your lap, or the feelings of your legs on the floor. Choose what is most obvious.

So as you feel the abdomen or chest rising with the in-breath, feel those feelings, watch them closely and point your attention directly at them, noting, rising, rising. In the same way as you feel the abdomen or chest falling with the out-breath, feel the feelings, the sensations of the movement. Watch them intently and note falling, falling. If there's a pause before the in-breath, note a touching point. Touching, touching, touching. Now be sure as soon as the in-breath starts to return immediately to the abdomen or the chest.

If you're concentrating at the nostrils, it's the same, except it's more appropriate to use the noting words in-in, out-out, while remembering to concentrate on the sensations at the nostrils or the upper lip, wherever the passage of air is felt most acutely.

Please note it doesn't matter how many times you say the noting word. Once may be enough. What is important is to be attentive to the feelings or sensations as they arise. The word itself is of little importance. It's just a simple and very effective way to stop the mind from wandering. What you must pay attention to are all the sensations caused by the process of breathing.

Now you may find that your mind wanders off on thoughts and fantasies. When you wake up out of them, just note thinking, thinking, or dreaming, dreaming, once or twice, and then quickly and firmly say, go back to watching the sensations of breathing. But you mustn't be rough or forceful. Training the mind is a bit like training a puppy dog to sit. When it gets up, you have to pat it down kindly but firmly. If you get angry and hit it, it will just want to run away.

So now, let's practice this breathing meditation for a while, observing and noting all the sensations. Rising... falling, touching. If your mind is wandering, note what it's doing, dreaming, thinking, worrying, and so on, and bring it back gently but firmly to the breath. If you feel sleepy, put more energy into the spine, sit tall, but not tense.

This part of the meditation is mainly concerned with establishing concentration. It's normal to spend a good ten minutes doing this until the mind becomes fairly still, at least until gross restlessness has gone, and you can watch the object, in this case the breath, fairly constantly. We use the breath because it's a neutral feeling, it doesn't excite or depress us. So the mind becomes still and moves to a point of concentration by way of calm and peacefulness. This is different from the concentration we get when we are doing something engrossing, such as watching a film, or having to do a job carefully. That depends upon stimulation, but the concentration we need for insight must arise out of a quiet and still mind.

And when this concentrated, quiet mind is established, we find another faculty becomes prominent, our intuitive intelligence, *paññā*. Sometimes, when you're trying to listen to shortwave radio, there's so much interference, it's hard to hear exactly what's being said. Once the fuzz goes, everything becomes clear. So it is with *paññā*, our intuitive intelligence. Once the heart is calm and concentrated, and thinking and imagining has stopped, the intuitive intelligence is able to see and understand clearly what's going on.

So now, what we have to do is establish this concentrated attentiveness, alive with intelligence, *satipaññā*, not just on the breath, but on anything that comes into our field of awareness. The example I like is that of a bird watcher. They sit in a so-called hide. They hide there, hidden from the birds they are watching. In this way, the birds are not disturbed, and their natural habits can be observed. All the knowledge, such as of feeding, nesting, mating, and so on, comes by just observing, merely watching. In this way, this ability to be simply observers, interested to discover the true nature of our body, mind, and heart, is the key to spiritual insight.

But this watching, please understand clearly, is not a searching for something. We are not looking for something. We're just non-interfering observers, just looking at whatever comes into our field of awareness, just watching whatever arises right here and now, while it's happening, without any thoughts about it or questions.

So we begin by establishing attentiveness on the breath. Should a sound be heard, we avert to it immediately, noting hearing, hearing. Now, try to catch the quality of the sound at the very eardrum. In this way, we'll stop the mind flying out, as it were, to the object, such as a chirping bird or passing car, and set up a whole train of imaginative

thoughts. The same with smell. Note it as smelling, smelling, right there in the nostrils. And again with any sensations on the body, such as itching and prickling, just note itching, itching, prickling, prickling, right there, where the sensations are felt, and plunge your attention into them.

Then there are feelings that arise in the body, such as heat and cold, heaviness and lightness, all sorts of discomforts and pleasures. A particular word, such as heat or cold, can be used where appropriate, otherwise a general word, feeling, can be used. Now, it's important we don't react to these feelings unless they are too severe to tolerate, for to react to them will lead us into restlessness. And do remember the noting word is a technique we use to keep the attention steady on the object. In other words, it controls the thinking faculty, but the attention itself should bury itself into the actual sensations.

Again, there are feelings in the body arising from moods and emotions. Dislikable ones, such as fear and depression, and likeable ones such as joy and love. We can use specific words here, such as love, guilt, and so on, but all the time feeling fully the mood or emotion, the actual feelings wherever they occur, such as in the chest or stomach.

Finally, there are thoughts and images. Note these as thinking or imagining, and they will stop. Otherwise, they will carry you off onto a daydream, sometimes for the whole of the meditation period. And be especially aware of the judging mind. That's terrible, that's good, that's bad, that's nice, and so on. Don't correct or interfere with such thoughts. Just acknowledge them and note judging, judging.

We're not trying to become spectators, getting involved in all the mental play, supporting this against that. We must take the position of an observer, an objective observer, just allowing all the play to unfold right there before our very gaze. All the time we're trying to maintain that separation, that distance, that detachment from what's going on in the body, mind and heart. We observe all these psychophysical events as something other, as if belonging to someone else. In this way we can investigate objectively. So whatever is offered, a sensation, a feeling, a thought, just watch it carefully.

So now, let's sit tall, and with keen interest, let's watch the flow of physical and mental phenomena. Begin always with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If the mind is wandering, note what it's doing, dreaming, thinking, worrying, and so on, and bring it back to the breath, firmly but gently. If there's sloth, energize the spine, re-establish the posture, slowly, very slowly, or you may disturb your concentration, noting the whole movement, straightening, straightening.

Sometimes there's a lot of pain, aching and tension comes up in the body. This won't be due to posture so long as the posture is correct. They'll probably be caused by unresolved emotions and mental states that have until now been suppressed out of consciousness. It's important to relax around them and develop an attitude of interest. Such discomfort, sometimes severe, may continue throughout a whole sitting or for many sittings until it resolves itself, and it may be that the underlying reason, such as an emotion, will not manifest itself. Just the passing of the discomfort will mean that the curing has taken place.

We need to develop patience to bear this and use the opportunity to see pain as pain, just sensations, and to separate out the suffering which is the aversion or fear we feel towards them. We make both sides, the painful sensations and the mental attitudes, objects to be noted, observed, and understood. So, keep noting, keep observing, maintaining a sharp attentiveness. If you get lost, start again with the breath, your home base and anchor. Always begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If your mind is wandering, bring it back firmly but gently to the primary object of our meditation, the breath. If there's tiredness or dullness, raise energy up the spine by sitting tall, though not tense, remember. Be especially aware of tension around the shoulders, neck and jaw.

Here we are sitting within ourselves, as it were, watching the inner films. The body, mind and heart display themselves just as they want. We don't interfere. It's a natural process of revelation. In time, many things may arise out of the subconscious which have long been suppressed. They'll reveal themselves when the time is right and the time is right when we'll be ready to accept them. In this way, insight meditation brings about a psychotherapy. Even painful traumatic memories from childhood will be eventually cleared out of the system, and with them all the neuroses and tensions they've caused. All we have to do to attain this purification of the heart is to remain steadfast at our observation post.

Now, although the cleansing of our psychology will happen naturally, it's not the aim of our meditation. The aim of our practice is to go to the deepest levels to see why suffering arises in the first place. One way is to note the relationship we have to whatever is being observed. The mind constantly jumps from liking to disliking wanting what it likes not wanting what it dislikes. This involvement is simply a way in which we try to find happiness in pleasurable states and escape unhappiness by running away from unpleasurable states. This constant oscillation, this ricocheting from greed to aversion and back to greed, this is what the Buddha taught as the cause of our suffering in the Second Noble Truth.

So, as pleasurable or unpleasurable objects arise, we must keenly note this secondary reaction of grabbing at them or pushing them away, sometimes turning away in fear, the twin of aversion. In this way, this reaction will cool down and even stop, and we shall experience a deeply satisfying equanimous mind. And this in turn will allow us to investigate deeper into the causes of suffering.

So let all that pain and pleasure surface and express itself. Watch the reaction, the grabbing, the aversion, the fear. Begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If your mind is wandering, note what it's been doing and re-establish your concentration on the breath. If you're sleepy, sit tall and raise energy up the spine.

As we begin to deepen our awareness of all the phenomena arising in our body, mind and heart, we'll become increasingly aware of what the Buddha called the three characteristics of existence. The first is the fact of transience. Everything is arising only to pass away. The second is the difficult teaching of non-self. As we watch all these mental and physical phenomena, we'll notice they arise of themselves. There's no one controlling them. They have their own life, their own energy. At times the body, mind and heart may seem distant, something other.

Before we talked of my sensations, my thoughts, my emotions, but now we find ourselves pointing at them, as it were, through the noting technique. There's a sensation, there's a thought, there's a feeling. We're slowly moving away from a relationship of identity and possession. I am my seeing, I am what I think, I am what I feel. I have a body, I have a mind, I have a heart. Instead, we're moving towards a position of detachment. This is the beginning of the experience of non-self. We discover that the psycho-physical organism we call me doesn't constitute anything substantial. It's just made up of many parts that work in unison, just like a car. But there's no core to it, no substance.

Thirdly, as we've noticed, whenever we do fall into a relationship of attachment, desire or aversion to the body, mind and heart, of identifying and possessing, suffering follows. This is the third characteristic of unsatisfactoriness. We should develop an attitude towards the body, mind and heart as one who rents a house, not as one who owns one.

It is the observation of these three characteristics of transience, insubstantiality and unsatisfactoriness that brings about the spiritual insights that releases consciousness from its delusions and leads to liberation from all suffering. And it is this practice of *vipassanā* which is the tool we use. This bare attentiveness, simply observing all that arises and passes away, this choiceless awareness that does not control or manipulate, this impartial watchfulness that does not question or judge, this intuitive introspection,

fully experiencing each mental and bodily phenomenon as it really is, this is the faculty of intuitive awareness, *satipaṇṇā*, the very faculty that will eventually bring the realization of *Nibbāna*, the unborn, the unbecome, the unmade, the unconditioned.

All we have to do is watch, just observe, whatever arises as it arises and passes away. So let's begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching.

During daily life, to sit like this even for a few moments, long enough to re-establish a calm and alert attentiveness, will stop our emotions from snowballing. It will undermine the causes of stress. Just 15 seconds may be enough to re-establish our center. With practice, this can become a regular state of mind, instead of something that comes only under special conditions. This calm heart and alert mind is the state we ought to be in all the time, even under stress. It is within this inner environment that this intuitive awareness, *satipaṇṇā*, can operate. Otherwise it becomes lost, drowned and controlled by runaway thoughts and emotions.

Constantly make the effort to regain and maintain this inner posture. This is to live fully consciously. And in this way, the practice of *vipassanā*, insight meditation, will seep into every moment of our lives, and we will be rewarded with great benefits.

Now, when we come to the end of a meditation period, it's best not to just jump out of it, but come out slowly. First, opening the eyes and taking in the light, and gently swaying from side to side. Then, rising slowly and mindfully, and in this way our intuitive mindfulness, *satipaṇṇā*, will be maintained.

May you be well, may you be happy, may you soon be liberated of all your suffering, may you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Starting a Retreat

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min read

Bhante Bodhidhamma guides participants through the traditional opening ceremony for a meditation retreat, beginning with an explanation of the ten training rules (sīla) that create the supportive boundaries needed for intensive practice. He leads the formal taking of the Three Refuges (tisaraṇa) in Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha, followed by the recitation of the three Vipassanā verses on impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā).

The session includes comprehensive guided meditation instruction across four postures: standing meditation for developing global awareness of internal and external phenomena, sitting meditation focusing on breath awareness at the abdomen with noting technique, walking meditation using the four-part footstep method (lifting, moving, lowering, placing), and loving-kindness (mettā) meditation extending goodwill from benefactors through difficult people to all beings everywhere.

Bhante emphasizes the importance of surrender, rhythm, and establishing clear boundaries for retreat practice. He explains how these preliminary practices develop the four factors leading to liberation: awareness, calmness, steadiness of attention, and equanimity. Practical guidance is offered for maintaining continuity of Right Awareness throughout daily activities and into sleep, making this an essential foundation talk for retreat participants.

I'm going to explain this little ceremony just to open us into the retreat. And then I'll do a standing meditation, a sitting meditation, a walking meditation, and a loving-kindness meditation, by which you should be thoroughly exhausted and ready to go to sleep.

Now, what we do is the three refuges and precepts. So for those of you who don't know, this is very regular in practice in Buddhist countries. But there are special training rules. Let me go through that first. The first five are pretty straightforward. So not to harm any living being - that's pretty straightforward, not give up killing each other for the weekend. Not to take what is not freely given. Not to indulge in erotic and romantic delight - difficult, but we need all the energy we can muster to make spiritual progress. Not to use wrong speech. That's easy. We keep the silence. Not to take substances that cloud the mind. So even strong tea can make your mind race. So be careful.

Not to overeat. So we keep the rule of not having anything after lunch. Now, for those of you who've never done a fast or have never passed more than three hours without a biscuit or something, I can assure you, one does not die. One continues. If anybody has problems with that, diabetes or something like that, of course it doesn't apply. For everybody else.

Not to oversleep. A bit difficult in the first three days, especially for those who are here for the weekend, because everybody comes with some sleeping imbalance of some sort. Either they're not sleeping well or they're oversleeping. So it just takes a couple of days to get that sorted, and then after that it is definitely sloth and torpor. Don't kid yourselves.

Not to indulge in entertainment. So to observe ourselves, you have to stop the input. You want to observe the output. So you don't want to read. You don't want to write. I mean, to jot a few things down for a diary, that's not a problem. It's just when it gets into an autobiography. And for those of you staying long term, even to keep your eyes down, not to get involved in anything around, you see. Stop the inputs.

Not to indulge in self-beautification. Here we don't have to worry about how we look. It's a relief.

To cherish the noble silence - very important.

Now these are called training rules. They are something that we take on to establish a boundary for ourselves.

The other thing is the schedule. So that's also your discipline. It's not a word we particularly enjoy these days, but that's really something which you devote yourself to so that you get a rhythm. Sitting, walking, sitting, walking. That's important, to get that rhythm going. And if you can, to stay within the boundary of Gaia House. If you think you're going berserk, by all means take a walk up the street, talk to the cows. Very cool and calming, you know. Just watch them chew.

So we'll take those training rules now. When it comes to the *pūjā - buddhaṃ pūjāmi, dhammaṃ pūjāmi, saṅghaṃ pūjāmi* - bowing is a very strong physical language for surrender. And remember, the spiritual life always asks you to do exactly what you don't want. It's always against the flow. So bowing is one way of surrendering to it. If you don't want to actually do it physically, at least do it mentally. Just to give yourself to the course.

So you pronounce Pali as you read it. So this is just honouring the Buddha, honouring the teacher. So the teacher is both the one who has taught us - this is also the exemplar - and the Buddha is also an archetype, because there's the Buddha within us that has to be liberated.

Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi - going to refuge to the Buddha. So traditionally, of course, that's the historical Buddha. But spiritually speaking, it's the Buddha within us. So it's an act of faith, an act of trust that there's something in us to be liberated.

Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. So here it's the teaching specific to the Buddha, but you can also be quite universal about that. These days everybody has their own spiritual portfolio. So if you want to add other things that make sense to the *Dhamma*, then by all means. But it's that which is going to give you your spiritual teachings.

Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi - the community. Traditionally this refers to those people who experience *Nibbāna*, because they are witnesses to the Buddha's own awakening. But you can also open that out to everybody who's on the path, to each other. So we're taking refuge in each other, as you know it's much easier to do something when it's with a group rather than by yourself. Even painting a room - you've got somebody to come along and help, it's easier.

We'll repeat that three times. On the other side, you've got the three *Vipassanā* verses. And this is what we're investigating, really, all week. All conditioned things are impermanent, unsatisfactory, and not self - not me, not mine. So for those of you who haven't come across that teaching before, by the end of the week, that should be pretty clear with a bit of luck.

And then a couple of verses from the Buddha himself just expressing the end game, and then his final words. That's what he said just before he died: "All conditioned things have the nature to decay. Work diligently for your liberation."

And then just before we say "*sādhū, sādhū, sādhū*," I'll just ask you just to spend a moment committing yourself to the course. Remember this is for you. This is an opportunity just to devote your time entirely to your own benefit. And remember, some of you might think well that's selfish, but it's not. It's self-care, isn't it? It's looking after ourselves. And remember that if we get it right within ourselves, when we meet people, they're also affected by our goodness, aren't they? I'm glad you're all shaking your heads vigorously.

So we'll start with that, and then as I say I'll do this standing meditation.

Buddhaṃ pūjāmi
Dhammaṃ pūjāmi
Saṅghaṃ pūjāmi

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa
Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa
Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi
Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi
Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi

Dutiyampi Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi
Dutiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi
Dutiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi

Tatiyampi Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi
Tatiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi
Tatiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi

I undertake the following training rules: not to harm any living being; not to take what is not freely given; not to indulge in erotic or romantic delight; not to use wrong speech; not to take substances that cloud the mind; not to overeat; not to oversleep; not to indulge in entertainment; not to indulge in self-beautification; to cherish the noble silence.

And our verses:

All conditioned things are impermanent. When this is perceived with wisdom, one becomes disenchanted with what cannot satisfy. Just this is the path of purification.

All conditioned things are unsatisfactory. When this is perceived with wisdom, one becomes disenchanted with what cannot satisfy. Just this is the path of purification.

All conditioned things and the unconditioned are not self. When this is perceived with wisdom, one becomes disenchanted with what cannot satisfy. Just this is the path of purification.

There is the unborn, the undying, the uncreated, the unconditioned - refuge, harbour and home, perfect contentment and peace.

Just as the great ocean has only one taste, the taste of salt, so *Nibbāna* has only one taste, the taste of freedom.

All conditioned things have the nature to decay. Work diligently for your liberation.

So just spend a moment there committing yourself to this course. Getting the best out of it that you can for yourself.

Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū.

So we'll do some standing meditation. Just make sure you're standing on some firm ground maybe. It's a bit better, I think. It doesn't matter what you do - your arms by the side or joined in front.

Just lift up to the top of the head. Pass your attention down your face. Jaw relaxed. Lips together, teeth apart. If there's tension there, just waggle it about a bit. Shoulders - if there's a bit of tension there, just give them a good squeeze. If during this exercise you find yourself getting, shoulders becoming tight and what not, just give them a good squeeze, keep relaxing.

Bring your attention to the soles of your feet. Can you distinguish two types of sensations? One to do with pressure, the other with heat, coolness. Are there parts of your feet, the soles on that side, that you can't feel or are very neutral? Any empty spaces? Can you acknowledge how the sensations are continuously changing as the body rebalances itself? And can you acknowledge that these sensations are arising whether you want them to or not? They're not under your control.

In the same way, make your way up the body and just be aware of any sensations on the surface, inside the body, areas where you don't feel anything, like an empty space. When you get to the abdomen, can you feel the breath there? Or is it tight? If it's tight, can you relax it? Not to worry if you can't feel the breath. In the chest, maybe a heart-beat. Shoulders still relaxed. The jaw. And when you get to the scalp, do what you did to the soles of your feet. Just scan it. See what sensations you can feel there.

Keeping your eyes lowered, not looking around, launch your attention outward. Just become aware of what you can see - shape, colour. What you can hear. The sense of other people. Atmosphere of the room. Your attention is completely out there. Don't choose what to experience. Let the experience come to you. One moment we're seeing something, the next moment we're hearing and so on.

And now at the same time bring in the feelings in the body, the breath. So you get a sense of a global awareness, both the inside and the outside. Don't look for something or listen out for something. Just let it come to us. And relax. Just relax into this present-moment, ever-presenting moment, always here, always now. Relaxing into the present moment.

In this way we're not trying to achieve anything. Remember, when we're trying to achieve something we're always doing something now for some future result. Being here like this, completely open, is the achievement. Being like this has no reason beyond itself.

Relaxing, just relaxing into this present moment. No need to plan - there's no future. We're not going anywhere. We've already arrived. Relaxing, just relaxing into this present moment. We're just in a mode of receiving. So there's no need to react or respond. No need to present a personality. Here we can feel the relief of abandoning that hope to become a celebrity.

Relaxing. Just relaxing into the present moment, achieving nothing, going nowhere, being nobody. Relaxing like this, wide awake, full awareness. We're developing four factors that lead to liberation: this awareness itself, calmness, steadiness of attention, focus, concentration, steadiness of attention, and equanimity. Equanimity means not coming from a fixed position, not coming from a place of "I know, I'm sure," but from a place of "don't know, not sure."

This abiding in the present moment, inhabiting the present moment, you can take directly into daily life. After a job, leaving one room for another, waiting for a bus, waiting at the lights, walking upstairs - if you were to add all those times together you may be surprised it comes to an hour, maybe two hours every day where we let the mind wander. Relaxing into the present moment, wide awake.

The great benefit of this is that you can see an intention arising. When we see an intention arising, we can discern whether it's wholesome or unwholesome. And because of our calmness, if we see it's unwholesome we can just wait, wait for that desire to exhaust itself. In this way we uncondition, we decondition those habits we see are unwholesome. And where we see a wholesome intention, we empower it, we reinforce that habit. Just in this very simple way we can completely change ourselves. But it demands this level of attention, awareness, and paradoxically, relaxation.

Our next intention will be to sit. And as we make that intention, just really take your time. Be aware of all the actions it takes to get us into a sitting posture. And if it helps, using the little noting word - touching, pushing, leaning - just to keep the attention steady, we can use this labelling. Intending to sit.

Make sure your posture is comfortable. It's not so important what you do with your legs - whether they're cross-legged or sitting on a chair, it doesn't really matter. It does matter what you do with your spine. Make sure it has its natural curvature and that you're holding it up through the top of the head.

And pass your attention down your face. Eyes gently closed. Jaw relaxed. If there's tension there, just waggle it about a bit. Lips together, teeth apart. Shoulders - give them a squeeze if there's any tension. And it can be quite relaxing to take a deep breath, hold it for a little while and just let the rib cage fall. Hands on your lap, palms facing upward is usually the most comfortable.

And bring our attention to the breath. In the Mahāsi tradition we observe it at the abdomen - rising and falling of the abdomen. Or if you have a shallow breath, rising and falling of the chest. If you're already established at the nostrils you can choose to stay there if you wish. If you make an intention to come into the body, come down into the body to the breath at the abdomen or the chest, it might take just two or three days to establish a different habit.

And as you contact the breath, use a little noting word. The noting word is there to stop the mind wandering. But the intention is to feel, experience the sensations caused by the breath. And as the abdomen rises, "rising." The label has to be, the note has to be concurrent with what's happening. If you say "rising" and then breathe, you'll get the impression you're controlling. Just let the breath breathe, let the body breathe. Rising, falling.

If the mind is wandering, really recognise and acknowledge what it's doing. Planning, planning. Dreaming, dreaming. Fantasising, fantasising. Judging, judging. Just be very clear as to what the mind is doing. You're not concerned with the content. You're concerned with the attitude. And then just gently turn away from that, back to the breath.

As you begin to relax, you might find that the gap at the end of the out-breath before the beginning of the in-breath grows. And if it gets a little too long, the mind can tend to wander. So choose a touch point like your hands. Rising, falling, touching. If you're observing the breath at the nostrils: in, in, out, out. Rising, falling, touching.

If the mind is wandering, be quick to recognise and acknowledge what it's doing. Worrying, worrying. Planning, planning. Not concerned with content, only with attitude. And just turn away from it, just turn back to the breath.

If you're beginning to feel sleepy, tired, lift the spine. You can open the eyes a little, let the light in. You can even stand up. Rising, falling, touching.

If the mind is wandering, be quick to recognise and acknowledge, turn the attention away, back to the breath. Feeling sleepy or tired, lift the spine, open the eyes a little, stand up.

Perhaps we are experiencing the sensations of the breath as calming, maybe even pleasant. Observing the breath silences the mind, calms the heart, stills the body. Observing, feeling, experiencing the sensations caused by the breath. Rising, falling, touching.

If the mind is wandering, recognise, acknowledge what it's doing, bring that attention back to the breath. Feeling sleepy or tired, just make that effort. Hopefully now you feel more steady in your attention, more focused, more calm.

See if you can get a bit closer to the breath. Focusing in, catching the very beginning of the in-breath, following it to the very end. Catching the very beginning of the out-breath, feeling that process to the very end. If when you do that you find yourself getting tense, pull back a bit, relax and keep going towards the breath. Rising, falling, touching.

If the mind is wandering, really recognise, acknowledge what it's doing, patiently bring the attention back to the breath. Feeling sleepy or tired, make the effort. Remember you can stand up.

The breath is our anchor, it's our reference point. When we get confused or lost, we return to the breath and just remind ourselves that this is the simplest of exercises, just to observe, feel, experience whatever is within our awareness. Whatever we become aware of, that we observe, feel and experience. We don't do anything. We don't try and change anything.

So hopefully now we feel more calm, more focused, we can open up. Whatever draws our attention within the field of awareness, inside and outside, that is the object to observe, feel, experience. It may be a sound. We're not concerned with the object making the sound, with the bird. We're interested in the process of hearing.

Maybe a sensation in the body, pleasant or unpleasant. We go to it if it calls our attention. Feel it, experience it. It can be a feeling in the body caused by a mental state - depression, happiness. If it calls our attention, we go to it, we feel it, we observe it, we experience it fully. We don't do anything.

If there's an image in the mind, as soon as we become aware of it, we just note "imagining" and bring ourselves back to the body. When we come out of a thought pattern, we just note what the attitude was that created it and just come back into the body. You may find that when you have an angry thought, for instance, as you come back into the body, you can feel it as a physical state.

And whenever we get lost, we just begin again. Always with the breath. Rising, falling, touching.

Can you catch how you're reacting to what you're experiencing? How when something is pleasant there's a desire to maintain it, to increase it? How when something is unpleasant there's a desire to ignore it, try to push it away, turn away, resist? Noting that also.

And you become aware of how everything you're experiencing is arising and passing away. Nothing remains, having accessed this observation post within ourselves, a perch from which we can observe, feel, experience the body with its sensations and feelings, the heart with its emotions and moods, the mind with its images, even thoughts if we're quick enough.

Can you see that when we're in this mode everything is happening of itself? Not because we determine or will it. It's all happening outside our control. It's not me. Perhaps you can sense a distance, a space between the observer, the feeler, the experiencer and what is being observed, being felt, being experienced. Although this isn't the fullest state of *vipassanā*, here at least we can see clearly that sensations, feelings, moods, emotions, thoughts, images are there, not here. They're objects. Not the subject. Not me.

Putting aside now all instruction, relaxing into the present moment, wide awake. Just observe, feel, experience whatever draws the attention within the field of awareness. And when we lose it, just begin again with the breath.

When we come to the end of a sitting, it's good just to reflect upon it a little. How diligent were we at bringing ourselves back to the present moment? How did we deal with the various physical and mental states that arose? Were we skilful, unskilful, confused? Which of these three characteristics of existence - the impermanence of things, the role of wanting, not wanting, and this not me, not mine - which one of those was most obvious to us? Penetrating any one of these three characteristics leads to liberation. And then it's good to make a determination, a real intention for the next sitting or just as a general attitude.

And now we're going to do some walking meditation and being aware of that moment where we intend to rise. Just be aware of all the actions it takes to get us standing and then to put it on the circle. So if you just find a position on the circle all the way around the room. Intending to stand.

Walking meditation balances the sitting meditation and it's very good for developing the steadiness of attention, focusing, concentration. It's a much louder, more obvious action than the breath, and it's still neutral. And all we're doing is just feeling, observing, experiencing the sensations just around the feet.

So we begin by just feeling the feet on the floor, and a noting word would be "standing, standing." These words are just gently repeated and the purpose is to keep the intellect happy, stop it wandering.

And when we feel established standing, we make the intention: "intending to walk." And there are four parts to the footstep: the lifting as the foot peels off the floor, moving as it moves forward, falling as it moves to the ground or dropping, and then placing as your weight moves into it. And at that point there should be two feet on the floor, and then the next step begins.

Intending to walk. Lifting, moving, lowering, placing. Lifting, moving, lowering, placing. If you haven't got the balance for this, just lifting, placing will do.

And bringing ourselves to a standstill: standing, standing, standing. When that feels established: intending to turn. Turning, turning. Standing, standing. When that feels established: intending to walk. Lifting. And bringing ourselves to a standstill: standing.

Normally you would choose a place where you can do this for 10, maybe 15 steps backwards and forwards.

So now we're going to sit again and draw our practice to an end with goodwill meditation, loving kindness meditation. So make sure you take your time, being aware of all your actions. See if you can find a noting word to match them - stretching, pushing and so on. Intending to sit.

The practice of loving-kindness transforms our understanding into an attitude. We have to be careful that the equanimity that we experience in the process of *vipassanā* doesn't slip into indifference. And we do this by re-engaging, re-engaging with the world.

Mettā, goodwill, is not an emotion. It's an attitude. So you can practise this even when you don't feel so good, if you feel depressed. In time of course the heart resonates with the attitude, but it's not necessary for it to do so to develop goodwill. That's why you can be kind to somebody even though you hate their guts.

The four or five traditional blessings which you can use if you wish: May you be safe. Everybody wants to be safe from danger, both inside and outside. From within ourselves and from the world out there. Everybody wants to be healthy, well. Everybody wants to be free of distress, mental distress. They want to be happy. And to live a life which has contentment, more contentment in it - happy with what we have and in harmony with the world, even when the world is not so pleasant, but to be in harmony with it, working with it. Safe, well, happy, contented, in harmony with the world.

And we start with our benefactors, bringing people to mind who've helped us. This raises gratitude, and with gratitude it's easy to wish them well. And then we offer it to those who are near and dear to us, to friends, people at work and so on. To neutral people - people that we know, or we see rather, but we don't know. Neighbours, people we travel with, even people at work. We offer them the same quality of goodwill.

Then we turn it towards ourselves. And in that heart of goodwill we can bring somebody in we find difficult. Not that they are difficult - we just find them difficult.

Then we begin to radiate outwards, first of all to each other, to our neighbours, and here you can relocate to where you live, all the people in our country, all the peoples of Europe, all peoples on earth, and finally to all beings in all directions. So that this attitude of goodwill becomes universal, not determined by whether we like or dislike somebody.

Bringing to mind a benefactor, somebody who's helped us in our lives. May you be safe, well and happy. May you live contented, in harmony with the world.

Bring to mind those who are near and dear to us. May you be safe, well and happy. Live contented, in harmony with the world.

Bring to mind friends, people at work, whomever we wish. May you be safe, well and happy. May you live contented, in harmony with the world.

Bringing to mind a neutral person or persons, people we see but don't know. Offering them the same quality of goodwill. May you be safe, well and happy. May you live contented, in harmony with the world.

Turning now that stream of goodwill towards ourselves. May I be safe, well and happy. May I live contented, in harmony with the world.

And into the heart of goodwill, someone we find difficult. May you be safe, well and happy. May you live contented, in harmony with the world.

Beginning now to radiate outwards, first of all to each other, our spiritual companions. May we be safe, well and happy. May we live contented, in harmony with the world.

To our neighbours - remember we can relocate to where we live. All the people in our country. All the peoples of Europe. All people on earth - and as you scan the globe, hover a little while over those places where there's war, natural disaster, poverty. And finally, to all beings in all directions.

And we end with a little chant: "*Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu*," which means may all beings be happy. And then "*Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū*," which means well done three times.

Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu
Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu
Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu

Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū.

Take this mindfulness with you now until you fall asleep. So just take your time. Make every action deliberate. Don't do an action which you didn't know you were doing. So this noting, this little noting can be very helpful to do that. You have to slow down, slow down all these actions that we do every day. They become numbed. When was the last time you tasted your toothpaste? And if you really tasted your toothpaste, would you buy that one again?

And finally, when you get to bed, you're lying down - especially those of you who have difficulty sleeping - you do this practice of *mettā*. Make it very simple. Just somebody whom you have no problems with, if there is anybody. If not, just somebody you don't have problems with. And then to yourself, and then to all beings, and choose a very simple phrase, like "may you be happy." And just keep repeating that, just very gently. And it creates a certain level of concentration, and that becomes the substrate of your sleep. That makes you sleep more peacefully. Or just the breath, just the calmness of the breath.

If you find yourself being very restless, tossing from one side to the other, try just lying very still and refusing, under all circumstances, to move. You may be surprised to find that you suddenly wake up tomorrow morning. And of course, you mustn't fall asleep without making a severe determination to wake with the bell.

Abiding in the Present Moment: Developing Equanimity

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

In this guided meditation, Bhante Bodhidhamma leads practitioners through a standing meditation that cultivates deep present-moment awareness and equanimity. Beginning with detailed attention to bodily sensations—from the earth and fire elements felt in the feet to awareness throughout the entire body—the practice expands to include both internal and external experiences as one unified field of awareness.

The teaching emphasizes the profound shift from 'doing' to 'being,' where practitioners learn to abide in the present moment without trying to achieve anything or go anywhere. This receptive stance naturally develops the four factors of awakening (bojjhaṅga): awareness (sati), calmness (passaddhi), concentration (samādhi), and equanimity (upekkhā). Bhante explains how equanimity—characterized as openness and receptiveness from a place of 'don't know'—creates the ideal conditions for investigating the three characteristics of existence: impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā).

The practice demonstrates how calm abiding provides the space and clarity needed to observe wholesome and unwholesome intentions as they arise, offering practitioners the opportunity to skillfully respond rather than react. This foundational approach to mindfulness meditation shows how simple present-moment awareness can have transformative effects on daily life.

So here we are standing. Standing tall. Lifting up to the top of the head. Chin goes in a little. Relax the shoulders. Relax the jaw. Lips together, teeth apart. It helps to bend the legs a little to relieve the back. When the legs get tired, just straighten them up. The eyes gazing downward about a metre or so away.

Let us now bring our attention to the feet. What sensations can you feel on the soles of your feet? Can you distinguish two types? Sensations of pressure, the earth element. Sensations of heat, the fire element. Can you become more aware of how the sensations in the feet are constantly changing, due mainly to the body rebalancing itself?

In the same way, come up the body and see what sensations you can find, both on the surface and inside. And notice those areas where there seems to be no feeling at all. When you get to the scalp, do there what you did at the soles of your feet.

Now launch your attention outward. Keeping the eyes gazing downward, become aware of the colours and shapes, the sounds entering your ears, the atmosphere of the room, the sense of other people. Open up now the awareness to include all the body sensations and feelings as well, so that the distinction between inner and outer lose their strict definition. It's just all one mass of sensations and feelings. And relax into the present moment, wide awake.

Relaxing into the present moment like this, we're not trying to achieve anything. When we're trying to achieve something, we're doing something now for some future result. But being fully aware in this present moment, there's both the achieving and the result.

Relaxing into the present moment like this, we're not going anywhere. Fully aware of each moment, we lose a sense of past and future. So we've not come from somewhere and we're not going anywhere. But by being fully aware in this present moment, we've already arrived.

Relaxing into the present moment like this, just receiving, there's no need to react or respond. So when we are fully aware of this moment, there's no need to perform. There's no need to be a personality, a person.

Relaxing into the present moment, wide awake, achieving nothing, going nowhere, being nobody. When we're in this passive mode, we're developing four factors of awakening. Awareness, calmness of the body and mind, steadiness of attention or concentration, and *upekkhā*.

Upekkhā means openness, receptiveness, receiving whatever comes to us from a place of don't know, not sure. This is the basic ground out of which our curiosity can rise, untainted by conceptual thinking, untainted by history, to investigate the three characteristics of existence: *anicca*, *dukkha* and *anattā*.

In this mode of calm, quiet abiding, we can see intentions arise. If they're unwholesome, we can resist the temptation. We have time, we have space. If wholesome intentions arise, we can decide to empower them. In this very simple way, we can change ourselves for the better.

So you can see, developing this calm abiding in the present moment can have a revolutionary effect on our lives. Intending to sit.

Detailed Guided Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min read

This comprehensive guided meditation provides complete instructions for vipassanā bhāvanā (insight meditation) as taught by Mahasi Sayadaw of Burma. Bhante Bodhidhamma begins with detailed guidance on establishing proper meditation posture and deep physical relaxation through progressive muscle release and controlled breathing techniques.

The teaching progresses through developing samādhi (concentration) using the rising and falling of the abdomen as the primary meditation object, with noting practice to establish alert yet calm awareness. Clear instructions are given for working with the six sense doors - handling sounds, sensations, emotions, and thoughts as they arise during meditation.

The talk explores how vipassanā practice naturally reveals the three characteristics of existence: anicca (impermanence), anattā (not-self), and dukkha (unsatisfactoriness). Bhante explains how maintaining the observer's position - satipaṇṇā (mindful awareness) - allows investigation into the causes of suffering described in the Second Noble Truth, leading toward the realization of nibbāna.

Practical guidance is offered for working with physical discomfort, emotional states, and mental reactions that arise during meditation, emphasizing the therapeutic benefits of sustained observation. The teaching concludes with instruction on transitioning mindfully from formal sitting practice into daily life, making vipassanā a continuous way of being rather than merely a meditation technique.

A Detailed Guided Meditation Instructions on how to practice *Vipassanā Bhāvanā* insight meditation as taught by the Mahāsi Sayadaw of Burma.

Firstly, we must settle our body into a meditative posture. Some sit on chairs, others use kneeling stools, but the usual position is to sit on the floor with a cushion in a cross-legged posture. Your hands should rest on your lap, preferably one on top of the other. Now whatever posture you adopt it should at first feel comfortable. Then make sure the spine is straight though keeping its natural curvature. It's best not to lean against anything for this will induce sleep.

Now imagine a puppet string running from the base of the spine to the top of the head and it being gently pulled up so that all the vertebrae separate and there's a feeling of growing tall and light. A feeling of energy running up the spine without any tension or tightness. And the head should feel balanced on top. Now just let everything relax off that central column.

Here we can help ourselves relax with some simple exercises. Firstly, let's see how relaxed we can become by simply telling muscles to relax. Start from the top of the head and go down the rest of the body relaxing muscles as best you can. So start at the top of the head, come down over the brow, the eyes, the cheeks, the jaw, especially the jaw, the neck, shoulders, arms, and hands. Just feel everything getting heavier as tension stops supporting them. Now go back to the chest. Relax it. Go down the body to the stomach, to the abdomen. Just relaxing as best as you can. And finally, just feel your legs heavy on the floor.

Superficial surface tension should now be released if only a little, but we may feel a deeper level of tension more habitual and therefore not easy to relax by a mental volition. We can use a second technique here of muscular tension. Where you feel tension tense the muscles in that area as hard as you can and release them slowly. This is especially good for tension in the face. Just screw up the face as much as you can now. Hold it. And relax. Now let's try that again. Hold it. Hold it. And relax.

It's also good for the neck and shoulders. Just tighten up that whole area now. Hold it. And relax slowly. Let's try that again. Tighten up the whole area. Neck and shoulders. Hold it. And just relax slowly.

A third technique is best for tensions felt in the chest, though it has an effect on the whole body. Controlled breathing. Take a slow, deep in-breath, fill the lungs to capacity, hold for as long as comfortable, and just let the whole ribcage fall quickly, expelling all the air. Then wait for the next breath to arise naturally, and this will prevent hyperventilation. So now let's take in a deep breath, hold it, and just let it go. Let's try that again. Take a deep breath. Hold it. And just let it go.

Hopefully you will have developed a deep relaxation. So now we should find ourselves in a posture highly conducive for meditation. The spine should be energised but not tense. The rest of the body should feel relaxed, hanging off this central column of the spine. And the head should be gently poised on top, symbolizing the balance between physical alertness and relaxation.

So now, for a few moments, let's feel this posture as a whole, and recognize its qualities of alert energy and yet calm relaxations.

Now we need to develop the same sense of energetic alertness and relaxed calmness in the mind, and to achieve this we use the breath. Place your attention on the abdomen and feel its rising and falling motion as you breathe naturally. Please note this is not a breathing technique. The breath should not be interfered with. Now it may be that the breath is not obvious to you at the abdomen, in which case see if you can feel it at the chest, rising and falling. The breath at the nostrils may also be used, but for the Mahāsi technique it is preferable to use the abdomen. See now which one is most obvious to you.

Now whichever place you've chosen, this is your primary object of meditation. This means you will use this place to establish an alert and calm awareness. If you move from one place to another, say from the nose to the abdomen, this will undermine your ability to become concentrated, that is, the ability to watch with an alert but calm attention without flitting away.

If you're watching the breath process at the abdomen or chest, observe the movement, the rising and falling, and use a noting word to still the thinking process. With the in-breath, note rising, rising, and with the out-breath, note falling, falling. After the out-breath, there's a rest, and there's danger that the mind will run away on fantasies. Now, to stop this happening, we choose a touch point. It may be the feeling of your hands on your lap, or the feelings of your legs on the floor. Choose what is most obvious.

So as you feel the abdomen or chest rising with the in-breath, feel those feelings, watch them closely and point your attention directly at them, noting, rising, rising. In the same way as you feel the abdomen or chest falling with the out-breath, feel the feelings, the sensations of the movement. Watch them intently and note falling, falling. If there's a pause before the in-breath, note a touching point. Touching, touching, touching. Now be sure as soon as the in-breath starts to return immediately to the abdomen or the chest.

If you're concentrating at the nostrils, it's the same, except it's more appropriate to use the noting words in-in, out-out, while remembering to concentrate on the sensations at the nostrils or the upper lip, wherever the passage of air is felt most acutely.

Please note it doesn't matter how many times you say the noting word. Once may be enough. What is important is to be attentive to the feelings or sensations as they arise. The word itself is of little importance. It's just a simple and very effective way to stop the mind from wandering. What you must pay attention to are all the sensations caused by the process of breathing.

Now you may find that your mind wanders off on thoughts and fantasies. When you wake up out of them, just note thinking, thinking, or dreaming, dreaming, once or twice, and then quickly and firmly say, go back to watching the sensations of breathing. But you mustn't be rough or forceful. Training the mind is a bit like training a puppy dog to sit. When it gets up, you have to pat it down kindly but firmly. If you get angry and hit it, it will just want to run away.

So now, let's practice this breathing meditation for a while, observing and noting all the sensations. Rising... Falling, touching. If your mind is wandering, note what it's doing, dreaming, thinking, worrying, and so on, and bring it back gently but firmly to the breath. If you feel sleepy, put more energy into the spine, sit tall, but not tense.

This part of the meditation is mainly concerned with establishing concentration. It's normal to spend a good ten minutes doing this until the mind becomes fairly still, at least until gross restlessness has gone, and you can watch the object, in this case the breath, fairly constantly. We use the breath because it's a neutral feeling, it doesn't excite or depress us. So the mind becomes still and moves to a point of concentration by way of calm and peacefulness. This is different from the concentration we get when we are doing something engrossing, such as watching a film, or having to do a job carefully. That depends upon stimulation, but the concentration we need for insight must arise out of a quiet and still mind.

And when this concentrated, quiet mind is established, we find another faculty becomes prominent, our intuitive intelligence, *pāññā*. Sometimes, when you're trying to listen to shortwave radio, there's so much interference, it's hard to hear exactly what's being said. Once the fuzz goes, everything becomes clear. So it is with *pāññā*, our intuitive intelligence. Once the heart is calm and concentrated, and thinking and imagining has stopped, the intuitive intelligence is able to see and understand clearly what's going on.

So now, what we have to do is establish this concentrated attentiveness, alive with intelligence, *sati-pāññā*, not just on the breath, but on anything that comes into our field of awareness. The example I like is that of a bird watcher. They sit in a so-called hide. They hide there, hidden from the birds they are watching. In this way, the birds are not disturbed, and their natural habits can be observed. All the knowledge, such as of feeding, nesting, mating, and so on, comes by just observing, merely watching. In this way, this ability to be simply observers, interested to discover the true nature of our body, mind, and heart, is the key to spiritual insight.

But this watching, please understand clearly, is not a searching for something. We are not looking for something. We're just non-interfering observers, just looking at whatever comes into our field of awareness, just watching whatever arises right here and now, while it's happening, without any thoughts about it or questions.

So we begin by establishing attentiveness on the breath. Should a sound be heard, we avert to it immediately, noting hearing, hearing. Now, try to catch the quality of the sound at the very eardrum. In this way, we'll stop the mind flying out to the object, such as a chirping bird or passing car, and set up a whole train of imaginative thoughts. The same with smell. Note it as smelling, smelling, right there in the nostrils. And again with any sensations on the body, such as itching and prickling, just note itching, itching, prickling, prickling, right there, where the sensations are felt, and plunge your attention into them.

Then there are feelings that arise in the body, such as heat and cold, heaviness and lightness, all sorts of discomforts and pleasures. A particular word, such as heat or cold, can be used where appropriate, otherwise a general word, feeling, can be used. Now, it's important we don't react to these feelings unless they are too severe to tolerate, for to react to them will lead us into restlessness. And do remember the noting word is a technique we use to keep the attention steady on the object. In other words, it controls the thinking faculty, but the attention itself should bury itself into the actual sensations.

Again, there are feelings in the body arising from moods and emotions. Dislikable ones, such as fear and depression, and likeable ones such as joy and love. We can use specific words here, such as love, guilt, and so on, but all the time feeling fully the mood or emotion, the actual feelings wherever they occur, such as in the chest or stomach.

Finally, there are thoughts and images. Note these as thinking or imagining, and they will stop. Otherwise, they will carry you off onto a daydream, sometimes for the whole of the meditation period. And be especially aware of the judging mind. That's terrible, that's good, that's bad, that's nice, and so on. Don't correct or interfere with such thoughts. Just acknowledge them and note judging, judging. We're not trying to become spectators, getting involved in all the mental play, supporting this against that. We must take the position of an observer, an objective observer, just allowing all the play to unfold right there before our very gaze.

All the time we're trying to maintain that separation, that distance, that detachment from what's going on in the body, mind and heart. We observe all these psychophysical events as something other, as if belonging to someone else. In this way we can investigate objectively. So whatever is offered, a sensation, a feeling, a thought, just watch it carefully.

So now, let's sit tall, and with keen interest, let's watch the flow of physical and mental phenomena. Begin always with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If the mind is wandering, note what it's doing, dreaming, thinking, worrying, and so on, and bring it back to the breath, firmly but gently. If there's sloth, energize the spine, re-establish the posture, slowly, very slowly, or you may disturb your concentration, noting the whole movement, straightening, straightening.

Sometimes there's a lot of pain, aching and tension comes up in the body. This won't be due to posture so long as the posture is correct. They'll probably be caused by unresolved emotions and mental states that have until now been suppressed out of consciousness. It's important to relax around them and develop an attitude of interest. Such discomfort, sometimes severe, may continue throughout a whole sitting or for many sittings until it resolves itself, and it may be that the underlying reason, such as an emotion, will not manifest itself. Just the passing of the discomfort will mean that the curing has taken place.

We need to develop patience to bear this and use the opportunity to see pain as pain, just sensations, and to separate out the suffering which is the aversion or fear we feel towards them. We make both sides, the painful sensations and the mental attitudes, objects to be noted, observed, and understood.

So, keep noting, keep observing, maintaining a sharp attentiveness. If you get lost, start again with the breath, your home base and anchor. Always begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If your mind is wandering, bring it back firmly but gently to the primary object of our meditation, the breath. If there's tiredness or dullness, raise energy up the spine by sitting tall, though not tense, remember. Be especially aware of tension around the shoulders, neck and jaw.

Here we are sitting within ourselves watching the inner films. The body, mind and heart display themselves just as they want. We don't interfere. It's a natural process of revelation. In time, many things may arise out of the subconscious which have long been suppressed. They'll reveal themselves when the time is right and the time is right when we'll be ready to accept them. In this way, insight meditation brings about a psychotherapy. Even painful traumatic memories from childhood will be eventually cleared out of the system, and with them all the neuroses and tensions they've caused. All we have to do to attain this purification of the heart is to remain steadfast at our observation post.

Now, although the cleansing of our psychology will happen naturally, it's not the aim of our meditation. The aim of our practice is to go to the deepest levels to see why suffering arises in the first place. One way is to note the relationship we have to whatever

is being observed. The mind constantly jumps from liking to disliking, wanting what it likes, not wanting what it dislikes. This involvement is simply a way in which we try to find happiness in pleasurable states and escape unhappiness by running away from unpleasurable states. This constant oscillation, this ricocheting from greed to aversion and back to greed, this is what the Buddha taught as the cause of our suffering in the Second Noble Truth.

So, as pleasurable or unpleasurable objects arise, we must keenly note this secondary reaction of grabbing at them or pushing them away, sometimes turning away in fear, the twin of aversion. In this way, this reaction will cool down and even stop, and we shall experience a deeply satisfying equanimous mind. And this in turn will allow us to investigate deeper into the causes of suffering.

So let all that pain and pleasure surface and express itself. Watch the reaction, the grabbing, the aversion, the fear. Begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If your mind is wandering, note what it's been doing and re-establish your concentration on the breath. If you're sleepy, sit tall and raise energy up the spine.

As we begin to deepen our awareness of all the phenomena arising in our body, mind and heart, we'll become increasingly aware of what the Buddha called the three characteristics of existence. The first is the fact of transience. Everything is arising only to pass away. The second is the difficult teaching of non-self. As we watch all these mental and physical phenomena, we'll notice they arise of themselves. There's no one controlling them. They have their own life, their own energy. At times the body, mind and heart may seem distant, something other. Before we talked of my sensations, my thoughts, my emotions, but now we find ourselves pointing at them through the noting technique. There's a sensation, there's a thought, there's a feeling. We're slowly moving away from a relationship of identity and possession. I am my seeing, I am what I think, I am what I feel. I have a body, I have a mind, I have a heart. Instead, we're moving towards a position of detachment. This is the beginning of the experience of non-self. We discover that the psychophysical organism we call me doesn't constitute anything substantial. It's just made up of many parts that work in unison, just like a car. But there's no core to it, no substance.

Thirdly, as we've noticed, whenever we do fall into a relationship of attachment, desire or aversion to the body, mind and heart, of identifying and possessing, suffering follows. This is the third characteristic of unsatisfactoriness.

We should develop an attitude towards the body, mind and heart as one who rents a house, not as one who owns one. It is the observation of these three characteristics of transience, insubstantiality and unsatisfactoriness that brings about the spiritual in-

sights that releases consciousness from its delusions and leads to liberation from all suffering. And it is this practice of *vipassanā* which is the tool we use. This bare attentiveness, simply observing all that arises and passes away, this choiceless awareness that does not control or manipulate, this impartial watchfulness that does not question or judge, this intuitive introspection, fully experiencing each mental and bodily phenomenon as it really is, this is the faculty of intuitive awareness, *sati-pāññā*, the very faculty that will eventually bring the realization of *Nibbāna*, the unborn, the unbecome, the unmade, the unconditioned.

All we have to do is watch, just observe, whatever arises as it arises and passes away.

So let's begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching.

During daily life, to sit like this even for a few moments, long enough to re-establish a calm and alert attentiveness, will stop our emotions from snowballing. It will undermine the causes of stress. Just 15 seconds may be enough to re-establish our center. With practice, this can become a regular state of mind, instead of something that comes only under special conditions. This calm heart and alert mind is the state we ought to be in all the time, even under stress. It is within this inner environment that this intuitive awareness, *sati-pāññā*, can operate. Otherwise it becomes lost, drowned and controlled by runaway thoughts and emotions. Constantly make the effort to regain and maintain this inner posture. This is to live fully consciously. And in this way, the practice of *vipassanā*, insight meditation, will seep into every moment of our lives, and we will be rewarded with great benefits.

Now, when we come to the end of a meditation period, it's best not to just jump out of it, but come out slowly. First, opening the eyes and taking in the light, and gently swaying from side to side. Then, rising slowly and mindfully, and in this way our intuitive mindfulness, *sati-pāññā*, will be maintained.

May you be well, may you be happy, may you soon be liberated of all your suffering, may you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Assisted Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This guided meditation session leads practitioners through the systematic development of satipaṭṭhāna (foundations of mindfulness) using the Mahasi noting technique. Bhante Bodhidhamma begins with establishing proper posture and bodily relaxation, then guides the development of samādhi through breath awareness at the preferred location - noting 'rising, falling, sitting.' The meditation progresses to open awareness, where practitioners observe whatever arises at the six sense doors while maintaining the noting practice.

The guidance emphasizes the natural arising of insight into the three characteristics (tilakkhana) - anicca (impermanence), dukkha (unsatisfactoriness), and anattā (not-self) - through sustained noting rather than intellectual analysis. Practitioners are reminded that satipaṇṇā (intuitive awareness) naturally recognizes these characteristics when the mind is properly established in present-moment awareness.

This session includes practical instructions for dealing with common meditation challenges like wandering mind and drowsiness, emphasizing gentle but firm return to the breath as the foundation practice. The talk concludes with encouragement to extend practice sessions and integrate loving-kindness meditation, carrying this cultivated awareness into daily activities.

A guided meditation. A bell will ring approximately every five minutes and twice after half an hour should you wish to end your meditation then.

So, let us establish the posture. Lift up the spine. Remember the puppet string. Energise but not tense. And everything else relaxed off the central column. And the head poised gently on top. Hands on our laps.

Now let's just spend a few moments relaxing first by a mental volition telling all muscles to relax, then by tensing and releasing them, and finally by deep breathing—whatever you feel is necessary to establish calmness in the body.

Now, let us acknowledge just noting and observing the feeling of the whole body. Sitting, sitting, sitting.

Now let us develop the same qualities of alertness and relaxation in the mind using our breath. Note and observe the sensation caused by the process of breathing at your preferred place. If the mind wanders, just bring it back gently but firmly to the breath. Rising, falling, sitting.

If your mind is wandering, note thinking or dreaming and bring your attention back to the breath, gently but firmly. If you feel sleepy, put more energy into the spine. Sit tall but not tense.

By now we should feel more focused and still, so let's open up the awareness and be attentive to whatever comes into the body, mind and heart. Note and observe carefully any sensations arising at the sense faculties, such as hearing a sound. Note and observe all sensations in the body, cold and heat, itching, stiffness and so on. Note and observe all emotional states as and when they occur. Note and catch all thoughts and images before they lead you astray, and if judging starts up, note it quickly.

Don't be concerned to see the three characteristics of existence, transience, unsatisfactoriness and insubstantiality. The intuitive intelligence, *satipaṇṇā*, once unlocked from the body, mind and heart, will see these three signs naturally. If any thought about them occurs, note thinking-thinking. Thought doesn't have the power to make spiritual insight.

So let's just note and observe each physical, mental and emotional event as it arises and passes away. No need to think about anything, no need to experience something extraordinary. Just ordinary consciousness and ordinary sensations, thoughts and emotions will do.

Always begin with the breath. And if we get lost, start again right there. Rising, falling, sitting. If your mind is wandering, just bring it back gently but firmly to the process of breathing. If you feel sleepy, sit tall and raise energy up the spine.

Don't be concerned by how many times we've wandered away and have had to re-establish our attentiveness. This is the practice, this is the training of the mind we must do persistently and patiently, raising interest to see exactly what's happening at the physical, emotional and mental levels. We keep using the noting technique to tether the mind to all events as they arise and pass away. And if we get lost, we always start again with the breath.

Once you feel confident, try to meditate without the tape and lengthen your time to a good hour once in the morning and once in the evening. Don't forget to practice a little loving kindness meditation, *mettā bhāvanā*. And when you end the sitting, come out slowly and gently and take that *satipaṇṇā*, your intuitive awareness with you, into ordinary daily life.

May your practice bear great fruit. May you be liberated of all suffering. May you experience the peace and bliss of Nibbāna.

Heartcare Mettā Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 9 min read

This guided meditation leads practitioners through a complete mettā bhāvanā (loving-kindness development) practice, one of the four brahmavihāras or divine abodes. Bhante Bodhidhamma emphasizes that mettā is fundamentally about cultivating an attitude of goodwill rather than forcing pleasant emotions to arise.

The session begins with traditional mettā phrases extending blessings to loved ones, friends, oneself, and gradually radiating outward to encompass all beings everywhere. The practice includes both worldly blessings (health, prosperity) and spiritual aspirations (freedom from greed, hatred, and delusion; attainment of Nibbāna). Bhante chants the classical Karaṇīya Mettā Sutta, the Buddha's foundational discourse on loving-kindness.

A significant portion focuses on forgiveness practice, addressing both seeking forgiveness from those we have harmed and offering forgiveness to those who have hurt us. This work involves skillfully observing our emotional reactions without getting lost in fantasy, recognizing unskillful mental states, and cultivating reconciliation through understanding rather than revenge.

The meditation concludes with the four right efforts: abandoning unwholesome qualities, preventing their future arising, cultivating wholesome qualities, and maintaining those already developed. This comprehensive practice nurtures the heart's capacity for unconditional love while providing practical tools for emotional healing and spiritual development.

Mettā bhāvanā, developing goodwill. Don't be concerned if during the exercise loving feelings don't arise. Here we're concerned with attitude, developing an attitude of goodwill, *mettā*. If pleasant emotions do arise, all well and good. If not, the exercise is still working for us and eventually the heart will respond. Remember you can stop the tape any time and develop a part of it further. So make sure you're now sitting in a comfortable position and feel free to move. So long as you move slowly, it won't disturb your concentration.

So let's begin. Bring to mind someone you have a warm regard for, not connected to erotically or romantically – an old friend, friend of the family, and so on, and offer them some worldly blessings: good health, long life, prosperity, whatever's appropriate. And we can offer them some spiritual blessings:

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill-will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Allowing those images to fade away, sensing that goodwill in our hearts, bring to mind all those who are near and dear to us, offering them worldly blessings:

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Allowing those images to fade away and bring to mind friends, people at work, whomever we wish, offering them worldly blessings:

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Allowing those images to fade away and turning the stream of compassion inward towards ourselves, let's offer ourselves some worldly blessings:

May I be free of greed and selfishness. May I be free of hatred and ill will. May I be free of fear and anxiety. May I be free of ignorance and delusion. May I be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May I be forgiving and compassionate. May I be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May I be peaceful and calm. May I be liberated of all my sufferings. May I experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Having generated now this goodwill within our hearts, let's begin to radiate it outwards. First of all, to those immediate to us, in our household, in our group, offering everyone worldly blessings:

May we be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May we be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May we be forgiving and compassionate. May we be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May we be peaceful and calm. May we be liberated of all our sufferings. May we experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Continuing to radiate it outwards till we've covered the whole of our area or town or city, offering everyone the good and bad alike worldly blessings:

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Continuing to radiate it outwards till we've covered the whole of our country, offering everyone worldly blessings:

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Continuing to radiate it outwards till we've covered the whole of the earth, offering everyone worldly blessings:

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Pausing for a while to consider those areas where there's war, destitution, oppression. And now, choosing a phrase which most expresses whatever quality we wish to develop, be it love, compassion, joy or just peacefulness, a phrase such as, may all beings be happy, gently repeating it in our hearts and offering it to all beings, to all beings before us and behind us, to the left, to the right, below and above and all around.

I shall chant The Discourse on Loving Kindness:

*Kāraṇīyam attha-kusalena yaṇ taṃ santaṃ padaṃ abhisamecca
Sakko ujū ca sūjū ca suvaco c'assa mudu anatimānī
Santuṭṭhako ca subharo ca appakicco ca sallahukavutti
Santindriyo ca nipako ca appagabbho kulesu ananugiddho
Na ca khuddaṃ samācare kiñci yena viññū pare upavadeyyuṃ
Sukhino vā khemino hontu sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhitattā
Ye keci pāṇabhūtatthi tasā vā thāvarā vā anavasesā*

*Dīghā vā ye mahantā vā majjhimā rassakāṇukathulā
Diṭṭhā vā ye ca adiṭṭhā ye ca dūre vasanti avidūre
Bhūtā vā sambhavesī vā sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā
Na paro paraṃ nikubbetha nātimaññetha katthaci naṃ kiñci
Byārosanā paṭighasaññā nāññam aññassa dukkham iccheyya
Mātā yathā niyaṃ puttāṃ āyusā ekaputtam anurakkhe
Evaṃ pi sabbabhūtesu mānasam bhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ
Mettaṃ ca sabbalokasmiṃ mānasam bhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ
Uddhaṃ adho ca tiriyaṃ ca asambādhaṃ averaṃ asapattaṃ
Tiṭṭhaṃ caraṃ nisinno vā sayāno vā yāvatāssa vigata-middho
Etaṃ satiṃ adhiṭṭheyya brahman etaṃ vihāram idha-m-āhu
Diṭṭhiṃ ca anupagamma sīlavā dassanena sampanno
Kāmesu vineyya gedhaṃ na hi jātu gabbhaseyyaṃ punar eti ti*

Having established this goodwill, a heart of openness, generosity, compassion, let us now work with that area of forgiveness.

First, bring to mind someone we have hurt, and as the incident comes to mind, the attendant emotions will arise, perhaps a feeling of self-righteousness, or a feeling of shame, guilt, remorse, whatever. As those emotions arise, we will have a reaction to them. We'll want to indulge our self-righteousness and we'll not want to feel or experience our sense of remorse or guilt. So, using that memory to contact these emotions and being wary not to allow the memory to shoot off into fantasy, but just to contact emotions, let those emotions arise, and let's see how we relate to them.

Just working with that little vicious circle: the memory, the attendant emotions, and how we relate to those emotions. Can we see how we cause suffering for ourselves? Can we acknowledge these attitudes and emotions as unskillful, unwholesome, negative, life destructive, not life enhancing, undermining our capacity to love, to relate, leading only to more suffering, not the end of it?

And the antidote, of course, is to ask for forgiveness, arising out of a sense of remorse, a desire to be reconciled, a desire to put right what we did wrong, a desire to compensate.

Bringing that person to mind, let's talk about the situation with them and ask them to forgive us:

Whatever harm I have done to you, in thought, word and deed, by way of greed, hatred and delusion, intentionally or unintentionally, please forgive me.

Perhaps you can see a change in them, a desire in them to forgive, to become reconciled. Can you accept their hand of friendship? Can you accept their forgiveness? Can we forgive ourselves?

Let's offer them some worldly blessings:

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Allowing that image to fade away, sensing that goodwill in our hearts, let's bring to mind someone who has hurt us. And again, using that memory to contact feelings, emotions, the feelings of hurt, the feelings of revenge. And again, to see that reaction, how we don't want to feel the hurt, how we want to indulge our sense of revenge.

Just working with that little vicious circle: the memory, the attendant emotions, and our reaction to those emotions, being careful not to spin off into fantasy. Can we see how we cause suffering for ourselves? Can we acknowledge these attitudes and emotions as unskillful, unwholesome, negative, life-destructive, not life-enhancing, undermining our capacity to love, to relate, leading only to more suffering, not the end of it?

And the antidote, of course, is to forgive. Remembering that to forgive is not to forget, it's not to excuse, it's not to condone. It's simply a change of attitude, away from revenge and hurt, towards understanding and compassion. Driven always by a desire to be reconciled.

Let us bring that person to mind, talk about the event and offer them our forgiveness:

Whatever harm you have done to me, in thought, word and deed, by way of greed, hatred and delusion, intentionally or unintentionally, I forgive you.

Perhaps we can see a change in them, a feeling of relief, a desire to be reconciled. Can we offer them a hand of friendship and with it worldly blessings?

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill-will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Allowing that image to fade away. And now we've completed two of the four great efforts to develop what is beautiful in us and to get rid of what is ugly within us. The next two are to prevent further ugliness and to develop virtues which are not developed.

So first, let us recognize a certain trait, unskillful, unwholesome within us, which we don't want to develop. Using the four affirmations: I can, I am able to resist its temptation; I ought to for my own benefit and the benefit of others; I want to; and I will – can, ought, want, will. And let us make a resolution that should ever a temptation arise, we will be resolute not to fall to it.

Sometimes there's a trait within us, a virtue which is not fully developed. Sometimes we see a virtue in another which we would like for ourselves. Again, using the four affirmations: I can, I am able to develop that virtue; I ought to, for my own benefit and the benefit of others; I want to; and I will. And let us make a resolve that should an occasion offer itself, we will practice that virtue.

So again, let us turn that stream of compassion inwards and offer ourselves again some worldly blessings:

May I be free of greed and selfishness. May I be free of hatred and ill will. May I be free of fear and anxiety. May I be free of ignorance and delusion. May I be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May I be forgiving and compassionate. May I be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May I be peaceful and calm. May I be liberated of all my sufferings. May I experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

And so finally, let us offer our goodwill once more to all beings in all directions:

May all beings be free of physical pain. May all beings be free of mental distress. May all beings be liberated of all their sufferings. May all beings live in contentment and joy. May all beings live together in peace and harmony. May all beings experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu. Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu. Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu.

Bodycare Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 8 min read

In this comprehensive guided meditation, Bhante Bodhidhamma leads practitioners through a transformative practice of offering mettā (loving-kindness) to the physical body. The session begins by addressing our mistaken relationship with the body—seeing it as 'me' or 'mine'—and works to undermine both attachment and aversion through contemplation of bodily realities. Drawing from the Buddha's own teachings, the practice includes the three contemplations that inspired the Buddha-to-be's spiritual quest: reflecting on the body's susceptibility to sickness, aging, and death.

After loosening unhealthy attachments, the meditation shifts to developing a right relationship with this 'precious rebirth.' Bhante guides practitioners through a systematic blessing of the entire body from head to toe, offering healing intentions to each part. The practice incorporates visualization techniques adapted from the Medicine Buddha tradition, imagining golden healing light flowing through the body. The session concludes by extending mettā to all beings, recognizing the universal nature of physical existence and the shared aspiration for freedom from suffering. This practice offers a skillful middle way between bodily indulgence and harsh rejection, cultivating the wise care necessary for spiritual development.

Body care. Offering *metta*, goodwill, loving-kindness to the body. Remember you can stop the tape any time to develop a particular section.

First we need to undermine the wrong relationship we have to the body. We think it to be me or mine. As we weaken this identity and possession, so we can develop a more wholesome, skillful relationship.

Working first with possession. We hold on to what we like, we discard, we don't look at what we dislike. Bringing to mind a part of the body that disgusts us to some extent, here's some of the Buddha's own list: phlegm, bile, pus, blood, sweat, fat, urine. Choose something, something to get in touch with, to feel that disgust. Now change your perspective and see it from a biological point of view. Perhaps your feelings are changing to equanimity, even interest.

Now take a part of the body you dislike because it's ugly. Too thin, too fat, too long, too short, and so on. Again, get in touch with that feeling of dislike. Beauty and ugliness come from the judgmental mind. Can't things be just okay as they are? See if you can turn towards those parts with the heart of acceptance.

Finally, there are those parts that bring us great pleasure. Take any of the five senses, for instance. Consider now suffering from an impairment or loss of one of them, say hearing or sight. As we know from people with disabilities, it doesn't mean we couldn't live equally fulfilling lives. So we can see that such suffering comes from attachment.

Now let us work a little with the delusion of identity. Here we can use the three contemplations that awoke the Buddha-to-be to his search for the end of suffering, repeating each phrase in the heart and accepting its truth value.

First, to undermine our obsession and intoxication with health: This body is subject to disease. This body is of a nature to fall ill. This body has not gone beyond sickness.

Now to undermine our obsession and intoxication with youthfulness: This body is subject to aging. This body has not gone beyond aging. This body is now in a process of aging.

And now to undermine our obsession and intoxication with life itself: This body is subject to death. This body has not gone beyond death. This body will die.

Having undermined to some extent the wrong relationship we have to the body, we can now develop a right relationship. The Buddha said this was a precious rebirth. Here we experience joy and woe and we have the intelligence to rise above them.

Firstly, we can't be here without a body. It's as simple as that. Secondly, it's through the senses that we experience the world and learn. Thirdly, it's through the body we relate, communicate and express ourselves. And finally, in this tradition, it's through the very breath of the body that we can develop the spiritual faculties.

Once we realise how precious the body really is, we can't but want to care for it. Now, we haven't done so in the past. So before we can offer it loving kindness, let us apologise for all the rough times we've given it and perhaps are still giving it. Whatever harm I have done to you in thought, word and deed, by way of greed, hatred and delusion, intentionally or unintentionally, I'm heartily sorry for it, and I determine from this day on to treat you with due care and respect.

So now we can begin to offer our blessings to the body. Choose a phrase which expresses for you healing or well-being. Place it in the heart and offer that blessing to the whole body. Now it may be that you see light or feel heat, all well and good, but there's no need for such manifestations as such. What is working for us is our acts of will, our intentions.

So now let's take our time and go through the whole body from the top of the head to the tip of the toes. Starting at the hair and scalp, offer your blessings there. Come down into the brain and fill it with loving-kindness. Bless your eyes and your ears. Bless your nose and nasal cavities. Bless your mouth with its tongue, teeth, lips. The jaw. Pour your blessing into your throat, the precious voice box, so that the whole head feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Turning our attention now to the top of the spine and make your way down, offering each vertebra your blessing. Come down the neck, down the back, down the small of the back, down to the very tip so the whole spine feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Starting at the left shoulder, massage it with loving kindness. And make your way down towards the elbow. Down towards the wrist. And into the hand. Massage your hand with warm loving kindness. So the whole arm feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Moving to the right shoulder. Again, massage it with loving kindness. Making our way down to the elbow. Down to the wrist, and into the hand. Massage your hand with warm, loving kindness. So the whole arm feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Turning our attention now to the chest area. Now you can either offer your blessings to particular organs or you can just fill that felt space with loving-kindness. So the whole chest feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Moving down to the midriff, the stomach area. Again, fill that area with warm, loving kindness. So the whole area feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Moving down into the abdomen with all its varied systems. Offer your blessings there. Fill that area with warm, loving kindness. So the whole area feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Moving to the left hip. Massage it with loving-kindness, making our way down to the knee and down to the ankle and down to the foot. Massage your foot with warm, loving kindness. So the whole leg feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Moving to the right hip. Offer your blessing there. And making your way down to the knee. And down to the ankle. And into the foot. Massage your foot with warm loving kindness. So the whole leg feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

So now we fill the whole body with warm blessings. Now perhaps there's a part of the body that needs special attention. Go there now and spend a while filling that area with goodwill, loving-kindness.

So now it's time to open ourselves up to whatever source of energy there is in the universe, using a method taken from the Tibetan tradition of the Medicine Buddha. Imagine there's a golden light descending upon you from above. Remember, any colour will do, which you feel is healing or energising. And as it pours down, it begins to form a ball just above your head. Don't worry if the image is not strong. Let it pour down until the ball takes on the feel of warm water, the consistency of warm water, and it slowly begins to rotate on itself.

Still pouring down from above, the ball gets heavier, and we can begin to feel it upon our scalps. Let it slowly descend down through the scalp, gently rotating, feeling it over the forehead and the back of the head, descending into the brain, filling it with that warm, vibrant energy. Feel it enter into our eyes and ears. Feel its energy and warmth entering into your nose and nasal cavities. Slowly, gently rotating. Still pouring down from above. And we can feel its energy now entering into our mouths, filling our mouths with its warm golden energy. Down into the jaw. Still pouring in from above, the ball gently rotating. And we can feel its warm, golden, vibrant energy filling our throats. The whole head is now this golden ball, gently rotating, full of energy, warmth.

Still pouring down from above, we can feel it beginning to spread over our shoulders and continuing to rotate, gently sinking into our chest, deep into our arms, deep into our chest, filling that whole area with warm golden delight. And it's still pouring down from above, down through the head, down the throat, into this ball gently rotating around our chest. And it continues downward, filling the rest of our arms, down to the elbows, filling that whole midriff, the stomach, that whole area, filling it with this warm golden delight.

Still pouring down from above, down through the head, down the throat, down the arms, the chest, into this ball, gently rotating around our stomach. And it continues to go downwards, gently turning, filling the whole abdomen with its warm, golden delight. Still pouring down from above, down through the head, down the throat, down the arms, down the chest, through the stomach into this ball, gently rotating around the abdomen. And we feel it descending, filling our hands, filling our hips, gently filling those areas with warm, vibrant, golden energy, spiralling downwards, slowly. We can feel it entering our knees, downwards until we can feel it around our feet, filling our feet with its warm golden energy.

Still pouring in from above. Down through the head, down the throat, down the arms. Down through the chest, through the stomach, into the abdomen, down through the hips and legs, into this ball, gently rotating around our feet.

So now we can use this energy. With the in-breath, draw that energy, with our own energy, up the spine to the top of the head. And there, let it join with all that energy still pouring down from above. And with the out-breath, let it all cascade down the body. Just breathing in and up, breathing out and down. Just breathing in and breathing out. And if there's a part of the body that needs special attention, let it pass through that part like water through a sponge.

So now we can share this energy with individuals by bringing people to mind and offering them our blessings. And finally, we can offer our blessings to all beings in all directions. Just breathing in, into the heart and breathing out to all beings.

May all beings be free of physical pain. May all beings be free of mental distress. May all beings be liberated of all their suffering. May all beings be well and strong. May all beings treat their bodies wisely. May all beings strive diligently for their liberation. May all beings experience the peace and bliss of Nibbāna.

Sābe satā sukītā hantu
Sābe satā sukītā hantu
Sābe satā sukītā hantu.

Eating Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 7 min read

Bhante Bodhidhamma explores how eating can become a profound meditation practice that teaches us to relate skillfully to pleasure without attachment. He emphasizes approaching food with the right intention—nourishing the body rather than seeking lasting happiness through taste—and deconstructing the eating experience into its component parts: bodily sensations, emotional responses, mental attention, and the will or intention behind our actions.

The talk provides detailed guidance on maintaining awareness throughout the eating process, from the initial contact with utensils to the explosion of taste on the tongue, noting 'tasting, tasting, tasting' to stay present with direct experience rather than conceptual thinking. Bhante explains how to recognize the crucial distinction between gratification (feeding desire until satisfaction) and contentment (the mind without desire), which he describes as fundamental to understanding the path toward liberation.

This practical teaching demonstrates how everyday activities become opportunities for insight meditation, developing the three factors leading to awakening: calmness of body and heart, steadiness of attention through continuous noting, and the receptive attitude of 'just receiving.' The talk concludes with guidance on post-meal reflection (yoniso manasikāra—right attention) and the practice of quiet abiding, where insights can arise naturally through receptive awareness.

So now it's time to eat again. And just to spend a bit more time reflecting on this process. So remember that we have to find a way of being with pleasure and the joys of life in a way that it doesn't have this aftermath, this comeback. Frustration when you can't get it, grief when you lose it, and take out insurance just in case you do. All that is underneath. While we're enjoying stuff, it's not a problem. Nothing like it. So, food or eating, which we have to do every day, is just the opportunity to remind ourselves about how to be with pleasure in a non-attached, non-indulgent way.

And the beginning is to get the right attitude. So if there's an attitude in the mind which is going to really enjoy this food, then there's going to be a danger that it's indulging it. And what we mean by that is that we're seeking happiness in food. Real happiness, lasting happiness. It's momentary, but it doesn't deliver the ultimate that we're looking for. So, you have to put the right intention into the mind, which is to nourish the body. Food is just medicine for the body. And I do a chanting, it's more formal this

lunchtime, I receive the food and then I do a chant which basically says that I'm not eating food in order to escape my problems or to add to them or to get the pleasure of it, I'm just eating the food for the purpose of keeping the body healthy so that I can live the spiritual life.

So that's important to actually when you take your food and you sit in front of it you remind yourself. So there's your attitude and this leaves you free to investigate the process around the whole action of eating.

So as you make your intention to eat, you see, and you pick up your fork or whatever you see. Really begin right at the beginning by contacting the body. So how does the metal feel? Begin right there at the sense of touch. And then as you scoop it and put it into your mouth, just that first delightful explosion on the tongue. Just stay there right with it. Keep the attention right on the tongue. And if you use a word like tasting rather than curry or whatever, then it keeps you attentive to the process that's happening. And we're just trying to find out what taste is before it fits into some conceptual pattern.

That's another problem we have, that we keep looking at things from history. We keep looking at things from a past experience. So we need to get back to a very original mind, which is a direct experience of things. And it's not that difficult to develop. It's just a case of keeping the attention very close to the sense base. So while you're tasting, tasting, tasting, your attention is right there on what's happening at the tongue, what it's doing, how you're chewing. You're just there with the mechanics of it.

And you're aware of the pleasure. That's the point. You're aware of the pleasure. The pleasure is pleasurable, right? You don't have to say to yourself, this is pleasurable taste, but it's most unpleasurable. It's pleasurable taste. It's a total openness to it, a receiving of what that sense base is giving you.

And it may be that after some time, after you've swallowed the first, you can just stop for a moment and just recognize what's happened within the heart, the emotional base. Hopefully, it is now in a state of delight. And to feel that, to get into the feel of it so that you know, well, this is also a form of energy, a form of energy, but it's not the same as the gross physical energy. And it's making that distinction, deconstructing our experience, which begins to undermine this idea of who I am. So by disconnecting, as it were, the body with its sense space, with its sensations, and the heart with its more subtle emotional feelings, we're beginning to deconstruct the event.

Then as you, before the next bite or sometime, just to hold on for a minute and just to feel that intention to eat. Make it very obvious to yourself. So that intention is coming from a natural base, it's just appetite, the body wanting some nourishment. But there's

also, remember, behind it, this seeking for desire, this seeking for happiness. Just stay with it, feel it. Is that an emotion? What is it? What is that force that drives us to eat? What is it? And it's not a case of an intellectual answer. It's a case of a direct experience of it.

Normally speaking, all this is just one thing, isn't it? You go into a restaurant and eat a pizza. That's it. It's like it's one experience. But here we're trying to deconstruct the event. It's the same with the cinema. You go in the cinema or watching a DVD, it's one experience. You hear and you're seeing and you're empathizing. You're doing all sorts of things all in that one moment. But actually there's a whole load of processes going on. The hearing isn't the seeing and the seeing isn't the empathizing. So it's really just trying to investigate this.

And remember our purpose is to get to the end of suffering, or to put it more positively, is to be happy, right? We're trying to get to a decent happiness, that's what we're trying to get to. So this process isn't just a nice little exercise we're doing, we're actually trying to get to a point where we're happy, heaven's sake.

So, we've made these three distinctions now, there's the body, there's the heart with its, of course we've got the mind, the mind's, we're using the mind to keep the attention steady, so it's down to one word, so it's not thinking about anything. See, that's our greatest hindrance, to think about something. And then we've got this process of the will, right? The will, intention.

And hopefully there'll come a part of the meal where you get this feedback from the body saying enough. And it's hanging on there with that and just feeling the override and just knowing that that's the old greed. Now, normally speaking what we would do is just keep eating till even the greed was satisfied. That's when the body signals back that it's getting sick. And at that point you might say it's a point of gratification. So we feel gratified, and we have a little rest period, and then the old desire rises again.

However, if we stay with the desire and not feed it, we put our attention just on the desire, that wanting, wanting, and just wait for that to fade out, we get to something which feels like gratification, but it's better called contentment, because this is the mind without desire. Now to know the distinction between being gratified and being contented is crucial. Because one leads you towards liberation and the other one towards hell. So it's worth making that distinction.

Now it may be that you've taken a little too much food and you've got this food left and your body's telling you actually you've had enough. So now you've got a choice. You can either stuff it into your body knowing it's not going to do the body any good or

throw it away and feel guilty. Because all these people, especially these days, are having a shortage of food in some areas. So now, what I would suggest you do is that you throw it away and feel guilty. And the reason for that is that as you contact your guilt and really feel it, that then becomes your guardian. Because the next time you approach food, you'll say to yourself, now I don't want to feel that guilt again. That's horrible. So you take a little less and there's always a chance of getting some more food afterwards. Yeah? So, even though that's not PC, that's what I would suggest you do. And feel the guilt.

Then, when it comes to the end of the meal, just stop for a minute and just recollect. What was it you've experienced? This recollection is important because it makes you revisit those places. And by doing that, it becomes a habit in the mind, a moment of reflection. It's one of the things the Buddha constantly goes on about. *Yoniso manasikāra*, it means right attention, right reflection, to think about things properly.

Now, after the meal, there's a little break there, and what is good to practice there is this quiet abiding. So there's these three factors that lead to enlightenment. The calmness, calmness of the body, calmness of the heart. Even if you feel agitated or the heart's very troubled or whatever, you can still, as it were, take it for a walk. Just relax around it. Steadiness of attention that's always there so you have to keep the noting going or else the mind will just wander and this attitude of just receiving just receiving not doing anything about anything and just dropping for a while the inquiry, the inquiry as an actual intention.

You'd be surprised that in those receptive moments insights arise naturally, because although we make a distinction between awareness and this intuitive intelligence, they're two sides of the same coin. One is passive, receiving, and one is active in insight. So it's the same, when something goes wrong, I don't know, you can't find something or something goes wrong with your car or something, you open the bonnet. First you look. Look, that's the receiving. And then you see, the engine's gone. It's like there's always that listening and then understanding, hearing and then listening, understanding. So there's always this flick from the passive to the active.

So after lunch, if you want to take a walk around the paddock or whatever, then just practice that. You can practice walking up and down in meditation, but with the attitude of just relaxing into the present moment, wide awake. And then, by all means, feel free to take a rest.

Morning Chant with Refuges and Precepts

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

This traditional morning chanting session includes the foundational elements of Buddhist daily practice. Bhante Bodhidhamma leads the recitation of the Tiratana (Triple Gem) - taking refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha - followed by the Pañcasīla (Five Precepts) that form the ethical foundation for all Buddhist practice.

The chanting continues with praise verses for the Three Jewels, the complete recitation of Paṭicca Samuppāda (Dependent Origination) showing how suffering arises and ceases, and concludes with the Karaṇīya Mettā Sutta - the discourse on loving-kindness that cultivates universal goodwill toward all beings.

This morning ritual establishes the proper foundation for meditation practice and daily life, connecting practitioners with the core teachings while cultivating ethical conduct, right intention, and loving awareness. The rhythmic Pali recitation itself becomes a form of mindful concentration, preparing the mind for deeper contemplative practice throughout the day.

Buddhaṃ pūjayāmi, Dhammaṃ pūjayāmi, Saṅghaṃ pūjayāmi.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi.

Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Abrahmacariyā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Musāvādā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Surāmerayamajjapamādaṭṭhānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi.

Iti pi so Bhagavā arahaṃ sammāsambuddho vijjācaraṇasampanno sugato lokavidū anuttaro purisadammasārathi satthā devamanussānaṃ buddho bhagavāti.

Ye ca buddhā atītā ca ye ca buddhā anāgatā paccuppannā ca ye buddhā ahaṃ vandāmi sabbadā. Natthi me saraṇaṃ aññaṃ buddho me saraṇaṃ varaṃ. Etena saccavajjena hotu me jayamaṅgalaṃ. Kāyena vācā cittaṃ pamādena mayā kataṃ accayaṃ khāmatu me buddhavaraṃ tattāgatāhaṃ.

Svākkhāto Bhagavatā dhammo sandiṭṭhiko akāliko ehipassiko opanayiko paccattaṃ veditabbo viññūhīti.

Ye ca dhammā atītā ca ye ca dhammā anāgatā paccuppannā ca ye dhammā ahaṃ vandāmi sabbadā. Natthi me saraṇaṃ aññaṃ dhammo me saraṇaṃ varaṃ. Etena saccavajjena hotu me jayamaṅgalaṃ. Kāyena vācā cittaṃ pamādena mayā kataṃ accayaṃ khāmatu me dhammo sandiṭṭhiko akāliko.

Supaṭipanno Bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho ujupaṭipanno Bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho ñāyapaṭipanno Bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho sāmīcipaṭipanno Bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho. Yadidaṃ cattāri purisayugāni atṭha purisapuggalā. Esa Bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho āhuneyyo pāhuneyyo dakkhiṇeyyo añjalikaraṇīyo anuttaraṃ puññakkhettaṃ lokassāti.

Ye ca saṅghā atītā ca ye ca saṅghā anāgatā paccuppannā ca ye saṅghā ahaṃ vandāmi sabbadā. Natthi me saraṇaṃ aññaṃ saṅgho me saraṇaṃ varaṃ. Etena saccavajjena hotu me jayamaṅgalaṃ. Kāyena vācā cittaṃ pamādena mayā kataṃ accayaṃ khāmatu me saṅgho puññakkhettaṃ anuttaraṃ.

Anekajāti saṃsāraṃ sandhāvissaṃ anibbisaṃ. Gahakāraṃ gavesanto dukkhā jāti punappunaṃ. Gahakāraka diṭṭhosi! Puna gehaṃ na kāhasi. Sabbā te phāsukā bhaggā gahakūṭaṃ visaṅkataṃ. Visaṅkhāragataṃ cittaṃ taṇhānaṃ khayamajjhagā.

Avijjāpaccayā saṅkhārā saṅkhārapaccayā viññāṇaṃ viññāṇapaccayā nāmarūpaṃ nāmarūpapaccayā saḷāyatanaṃ saḷāyatanapaccayā phasso phassapaccayā vedanā vedanāpaccayā taṇhā taṇhāpaccayā upādānaṃ upādānapaccayā bhavo bhavapaccayā jāti jātipaccayā jarāmaraṇaṃ sokaparideva dukkhadomanassa upāyāsā sambhavanti. Evametassa kevalassa dukkhakkhandhassa samudayo hoti.

Yad' āhave paṭubhavanti dhammā ātāpino jhāyato brāhmaṇassa atha khayaṃ gacchanti mārasena saṇyāva obbhasan' antalikaṃ.

Avijjāya tveva asesavirāgaṇirodudhā saṅkhāraṇirodudhā saṅkhāraṇirodudhā viññāṇaṇirodudhā viññāṇaṇirodudhā nāmarūpaṇirodudhā nāmarūpaṇirodudhā saḷāyatanaṇirodudhā saḷāyatanaṇirodudhā phassaṇirodudhā phassaṇirodudhā vedanāṇirodudhā vedanāṇirodudhā taṇhāṇirodudhā taṇhāṇirodudhā upādānaṇirodudhā upādānaṇirodudhā bhavaṇirodudhā bhavaṇirodudhā jātinirodudhā jātinirodudhā jarāmaraṇa sokaparideva dukkhadomanassa upāyāsā nirujjhanti. Evametassa kevalassa dukkhakkhandhassa nirodudhā hoti.

*Yad' āhave paṭubhavanti dhammā ātāpino jhāyato brāhmaṇassa vedanānaṃ khayam
ñatvā tiṭṭhati mārasena sainyāva obbhasan' antalikaṃ.*

Hetupaccayo ārammaṇapaccayo adhipatipaccayo anantarapaccayo samanantarapaccayo saḥajātapaccayo aññamaññapaccayo nissayapaccayo upanissayapaccayo purejātapaccayo pacchājātapaccayo āsevapaccayo kammaṇapaccayo vipākaṇapaccayo āhārapaccayo indriyapaccayo jhānapaccayo maggaṇapaccayo sampayuttapaccayo vippayuttapaccayo attipaccayo nattiṇapaccayo vigatapaccayo avigatapaccayo.

Sabbe saṅkhārā aniccāti. Yadā paññāya passati atha nibbindati dukkhe. Esa maggo visuddhiyā. Sabbe saṅkhārā dukkhāti. Yadā paññāya passati atha nibbindati dukkhe. Esa maggo visuddhiyā. Sabbe dhammā anattāti. Yadā paññāya passati atha nibbindati dukkhe. Esa maggo visuddhiyā.

Aniccā vata saṅkhārā upādavayadhammino. Uppajjitvā nirujjhanti tesam vūpasamo sukho. Dukkā vata saṅkhārā upādavayadhammino. Uppajjitvā nirujjhanti tesam vūpasamo sukho. Anattā vata saṅkhārā upādavayadhammino. Uppajjitvā nirujjhanti tesam vūpasamo sukho.

Bringing to mind those whom we know are suffering terminal illness or dying.

Karaṇīyam atthakusalena yaṃ taṃ santaṃ padaṃ abhisamecca. Sakko uju ca suhuju ca suvaco cassa mudu anatimāni. Santussako ca subhāro ca appakicco ca sallahukavutti. Santindriyo ca nipako ca appagabbho kulesu ananugiddho.

Na ca khuddaṃ samācāre kiñci yena viññū pare upavadeyyuṃ. Sukhino vā khemino hontu sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā. Ye keci paṇabhūtattā tasā vā thāvarā vā anavasissā. Dīghā vā ye mahantā vā majjhimā rassakāṇukathulā. Diṭṭhā vā ye ca adiṭṭhā ye ca dūre vasanti avidūre. Bhūtā vā sambhavesi vā sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā.

Na paro paraṃ nikubbetha nātimaññetha katthaci naṃ kiñci. Byārosanāpaṭighāsāññā nāññamaññassa dukkham iccheyya. Mātā yathā niyaṃ puttaṃ āyusā ekaputtam anurakkhe. Evaṃ pi sabbabhūtesu mānaṃ bhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ. Mettaṃ ca sabbalokasmi mānaṃ bhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ. Uddhaṃ adho ca tiriyaṃ ca asaṃbādhaṃ averaṃ asapattaṃ.

Tiṭṭhaṃ caraṃ nisinno vā sayāno vā yāvat' assa vigatamidho. Etaṃ satiṃ adhiṭṭheyya brahmaṃ etaṃ vihāraṃ idhaṃ āhu.

And our resolution for the day:

Imāya dhammānudhamma paṭipattiyā buddhaṃ pūjemi. Imāya dhammānudhamma paṭipattiyā dhammaṃ pūjemi. Imāya dhammānudhamma paṭipattiyā saṅghaṃ pūjemi.

Evening Mettā Chant

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1 min read

This traditional evening mettā chant, led by Bhante Bodhidhamma, offers the classic Pali recitation for cultivating loving-kindness (mettā) toward all beings. The chant systematically extends compassionate wishes beginning with oneself, then to benefactors and teachers, to all practitioners and monastics, and finally radiating mettā to all sentient beings throughout the ten directions.

Following the structure found in traditional Theravāda practice, the chant includes the fundamental mettā phrases: "May I be free from enmity, free from ill-will, free from anxiety, may I maintain well-being in myself" (averā homi, abyāpajjhā homi, anīghā homi, sukhī attānaṃ pariharāmi). These wishes are then extended progressively outward to encompass all beings everywhere.

This practice of chanting mettā serves as both a meditative exercise and a way to conclude the day with wholesome intentions. Regular recitation helps develop the brahmavihāra of loving-kindness, supporting both formal meditation practice and the cultivation of compassionate awareness in daily life. The rhythmic chanting also serves as a calming transition into evening reflection or rest.

Ahaṃ avero homi, abyāpajjo homi, anīgho homi, sukhī attānaṃ pariharāmi, dukkhā mucāmi, yathāladdhasampadāto, mā vigaccāmi. Amhākaṃ cātupaccayadeyyakā, averā hontu, abyāpajjā hontu, anīghā hontu, sukhī attānaṃ pariharantu, dukkhā mucantu, yathāladdhasampadāto, mā vigaccantu. Amhākaṃ mātāpitūnaṃ ācāriyānaṃ ñāti-mittasaṅghānaṃ averā hontu, abyāpajjā hontu, anīghā hontu, sukhī attānaṃ pariharantu, dukkhā mucantu, yathāladdhasampadāto, mā vigaccantu.

Imasmiṃ vihāre sabbe bhikkhū sabbā bhikkhuniyo sabbe upāsakā sabbā upāsikāyo averā hontu abyāpajjā hontu anīghā hontu sukhī attānaṃ pariharantu, dukkhā mucantu, yathāladdhasampadāto, mā vigaccantu. Imasmiṃ gāme janapade, Europe, loke sabbe janatā. Averā hontu, abyāpajjā hontu, anīghā hontu, sukhī attānaṃ pariharantu, dukkhā mucantu, yathāladdhasampadāto, mā vigaccantu.

Puratthimāya disāya, pacchimāya disāya, uttarāya disāya, dakkhiṇāya disāya, puratthimāyānudisāya, pacchimāyānudisāya, uttarāyānudisāya, dakkhiṇāyānudisāya, heṭṭhimāya disāya, uparimāya disāya: sabbe sattā, sabbe pāṇā, sabbe bhūtā, sabbe puggalā, sabbe attabhāvapariyāpannā. Sabbā itthiyo, sabbe purisā, sabbe ariyā, sabbe anar-

iyā. Sabbe devā, sabbe manussā, sabbe vinipatikā, averā hontu, abyāpajjā hontu, anīghā hontu, sukhī attānaṃ pariharantu, dukkhā mucantu, yathāladdhasampadāto, mā vigaccantu. Kāmasukā.

The Technique

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min read

In this foundational retreat talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the essential techniques of Mahasi Vipassana meditation, emphasizing skillful means over spiritual attainment. He explains how proper intentions must focus solely on developing meditation skills rather than seeking enlightenment directly, as such goals belong to the ego-mind that must be transcended.

The talk details the noting technique (vitakka and vicāra stages leading to pure vipassanā), the practice of going slow to reveal subtle mind-body connections, and continuous awareness throughout daily activities. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) and Dhammapada teachings, Bhante emphasizes the relentless commitment required—described by the Buddha as ātāpī sampajāno satimā (ardent, clearly comprehending, aware).

Practical guidance covers common errors in noting, dealing with boredom as meditation object, and maintaining technique purity. The ultimate aim is positioning consciousness (satipaṇṇā) to observe body, heart, and mind objectively, allowing paṇṇā (intuitive wisdom) to realize the true nature of phenomena and achieve liberation from suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

The first thing we need to do when we start on a course is to make sure that we have the right intentions. If we have the wrong intentions, the practice will be skewed and we'll just end up disappointed. So we need to ask ourselves why we've come on a course of meditation. Now it's only fair to think that it's going to bring some sort of physical and psychological benefit, some sort of clarification of our thought, and some spiritual benefit. But if we make these objectives our moment-to-moment aims, then we'll simply get into that old grasping, getting, attaining mindset, and end up all frustrated and go away swearing we'll never waste our time doing something so useless again.

Why? Because the self brings into any equation a distortion, a projection. Remember, it is the self itself which is the delusion, and if we allow its ambitions to guide us, it really will be a case of the blind leading the blind. So ultimate objectives—the purification of the heart from all self-driven desire and the realization of *nibbāna*—are beyond the capability of self, beyond the capability of self-will. And as we progress in the course, the reasons for this should become apparent, I hope.

For instance, many of you will have heard of the *vipassanā* ñāṇa, the spiritual insights, of the four stages of sainthood, which lead to the awakening of the *arahat*, of course, the enlightened person, and *nibbāna*. It's impossible, I think, to come onto a course of this nature and not have some such ideas of attainment floating about in the mind. Well, let them float. Don't hang on to them. Because for sure, such desires are definitely beyond the self, for such attainments transcend the self itself.

Worse still, if we have some idea as to what spiritual attainments are, then only two things can happen. Either we won't attain what we've conceived and be disappointed, or worse we will and be utterly deluded. For whatever spiritual insights are, they are not expressions of our concepts, our thoughts, our imaginings. They are direct experiences beyond the capability of the mind to imagine. Indeed, all we do when we attain our concepts is to make manifest in the material world what we had imagined, just as a designer might finally get their dream car built. But cars, houses, jewellery are all of this phenomenal world. Our sights are aimed a little higher. Indeed, they are aimed at the supramundane world, beyond the phenomenal world.

Now so committed are we to these ideas that sometimes, when something strange or wonderful begins to happen in our meditation, we'll suddenly grasp onto it. "This is it, this is it," and we're all bated breath, hoping to attain. Now that's a very misleading word. The better word, if there can ever be a word, is to realize. Suddenly there's a seeing, and that's it. Insight. And the only way we're going to realize an insight is, paradoxically, to get out of the way.

It's a bit like working out a mathematical problem. Take Archimedes. Now the king had asked him to prove that the crown was pure gold. To make sure, he had to get the specific gravity. And to get that, no doubt you remember your maths, you need to know the weight and volume of a given object. Now getting the weight was easy, but how to get the volume of an irregular shape? A real koan. He had given up and went to relax in the bath. Where else? And right there, "Eureka! I found it, I got it!" As his body slipped into the water, he saw that the amount of water rising was equal to the volume of his irregular-shaped body. Just then, when he was not thinking about it at all, when Archimedes was no longer in the way.

I think this sort of thing happens to us all the time. Sometimes we even sleep on a problem and wake up with the answer. There's some intelligence there which doesn't think. It just perceives directly. It realizes something just like that. Well, that's the very same faculty that sees the way things really are and brings about the liberation from our delusions and consequent sufferings. So the truth of the matter is, we have to get

out of the way, get out of the way completely and let *paññā*, that wonderful intuitive intelligence within us, do the work. We have to have faith in this higher power, a higher power within us to set us free from our delusions.

The fact is that the truth is always there to be seen. It's more like looking into a dark room and suddenly the light goes on and we see everything. Just like that. Now the light didn't create the objects in the room. They were always there, always there to be seen. So the question is, how do we turn this light on? That's definitely THE question.

Well, the first thing is to be absolutely clear that we can't make physical, psychological, intellectual and certainly not spiritual aims the purpose of our meditation course because that's all self-desire, self-driven ambition. What then can we make a legitimate aim and thereby not end up disillusioned? Well, that aim is simply and solely to develop the skills of meditation. And the reason for this is that all skills involved in *vipassanā* training, whatever these skills may be, and they differ from school to school, are concerned with lifting consciousness out of its embeddedness, its confusion with the body, heart and mind, and to make those very areas of experience the object of consciousness itself.

In other words, all skills are there so that this intuitive consciousness, *satipaññā*, that which knows, can see and understand exactly what the body, with all its sensations, the heart, with all its feelings, and the mind, with all its thoughts, actually are. It is a process of investigation by way of direct experience and this can't be done without consciousness lifting itself to a higher ground.

You'll already be familiar with my favourite metaphor of the ornithologist from the *Vipassanā* tape. To study birds, indeed any wildlife, the scientist has to be hidden from them so that their presence doesn't distort the creature's natural behaviour. And just by watching, they come to know. Just watching. Another image is to be up on the crow's nest of a ship, able to see what's happening on the ship and far beyond. And consider how our vision of planet Earth changed once we got those pictures from the moon. Suddenly, everybody's talking about the global village. We have to discover a similar vantage point within ourselves and once discovered, then the work truly begins. The work, the labour to maintain it. All of this will be down to the skilful means we employ.

Now the Buddha was brought up in the Kshatriya caste, the warrior caste. So he would have been well acquainted with the needs and demands of skills training. He'd have practiced archery, wrestling, and he probably learned how to play an instrument. He would have known the need to repeat the same action over and over again. Practice makes perfect. How many times do world-class tennis players practice serving backhands and volleys? So when Siddhartha Gautama set off on his spiritual quest to find

the end of suffering, it's no wonder he sought out teachers who would show him how, the techniques of meditation. And the two teachers who helped him showed him how to attain all the blissful absorptions. But as we know, he wasn't satisfied with that, and that's when he went off on his own. And part of his greatness lies in the fact that he treads new territory and finds the solution to the great and overwhelming problem of human suffering.

In the same way, we ourselves need to become spiritual athletes. To become athletes demands constant devotion to the practice of skills. We can't stop until we're fully enlightened. So it's best to cultivate an attitude that the training period for the spiritual gold medal is going to take a long time. So let's start right now, little by little. Sometimes we take time off, sometimes we just forget. Well, that's all right, so long as we acknowledge that we'll have fallen back a bit and that it's going to take a little special effort to get us back on track.

Now, all skills training has to be self-reflective. We must in time be fully aware of what the skills are, why we're using them, when we should use them and so on. And we should know them so well that we can eventually guide ourselves and make teachers redundant. This is achieved not simply by practicing the techniques but also by reflecting on them, practicing the techniques and becoming aware of the feedback and becoming more and more aware of what the techniques are trying to help us do and how we can use them more and more skillfully.

All this focus on skills training, however, can lead to one big mistake. And I want to warn you right now, right at the beginning, because it's so important not to have this wrong understanding. We can become so involved in technique that we can't see the wood for the trees. Worse, we actually begin to believe that the technique is what really achieves the insight. The technique becomes a sacred ritual which has to be performed exactly right or nothing will be gained. Meditators become entirely wrapped up in the details and cordon off their retreat from others, saying it's the best or the pristine or quicker or even, so I've heard, more modern.

What we can say is that every valid system of *vipassanā* has its own built-in logic, checks and balances, and that ultimately a person centres on a particular technique for a variety of reasons, such as their personality, their relationship with the teacher, the availability of courses, and so on. When this mistake of mystifying a technique is made, the reason is that the aim of the techniques has been lost and the aim is simply to get that consciousness of ours onto a steady position of inward observation. Once that is done we can let go of all technique.

Having said that, don't think that you can drop the technique within a week. Surely there'll be moments, minutes perhaps, when we can just observe. But then as soon as we lose it, we need to get back to the technique. The whole point then of the skills of meditation is to take us beyond themselves. They're part of the raft the Buddha talked about that takes us to the other shore. Once we've arrived, there'll be no need to carry it about, no need to carry the raft on our backs.

So the purpose then of all technique is to raise consciousness to a level where it can observe quite impartially the goings on of the body with all its sensations from the sense bases and all its feelings, the heart with all its varied moods and emotions, and the mind with all its teeming thoughts and imaginings. Just to be able to sit back and watch, as if at a cinema, just watching the film on the screen, the screen of cognition, our cognitive faculty. In this way we begin to taste the unconditioned consciousness that the Buddha exclaimed he had attained upon enlightenment. That's part of the verses we chant in the morning, the celebration of his liberation from suffering and unsatisfactoriness.

Now as time passes, the teaching becomes dulled. It's been over two and a half thousand years now since the teachings were first expounded. But there are always reformation movements throughout the history of Buddhism, some large and some small, which revitalize the teachings, the Dharma. And the Mahāsi Sayadaw must be accredited as one of the key teachers, if not the main influence, in revitalizing the practice of *vipassanā* in Theravāda Buddhist countries.

The Mahāsi had been teaching in the north of Burma when some people went looking for a teacher to start a meditation centre in Rangoon. Please note this was lay-led and the special quality of a Mahāsi centre is that there are always lay teachers and the majority of the centres are within the city or town boundaries. This in itself, it seems, was a revolution, since up until then it was generally presumed that only monastics could gain anything from meditation.

In fact, the lie goes deeper. It is still propagated by some, and some high-ranking members of the monastic Sangha, unfortunately, that no one can make any spiritual progress these days, let alone become enlightened, because of the corruption of the Buddha Dhamma. As far as I'm concerned, that may say more about them than the state of the Buddha Dhamma. The Mahāsi developed a technique which has helped so many people to develop their spiritual lives and attain the noble paths and fruits.

So what are these techniques he developed? The first of these techniques is to do with sitting meditation. Well, we've been through those on the tape you've just heard and you'll have noticed how detailed they are—there's a direction given for any and

every situation that might arise in the sitting posture. Again, there are directions for walking meditation, which progresses from walking as fast as you want for exercise, to walking as slowly as humanly possible. And when standing there are also clear instructions, though the ones I give, as far as the posture itself goes, are taken from the Chinese discipline of Qigong. But you can stand quite ordinarily if you want. And for other daily activities, such as eating, washing and lying down, there are equally direct instructions. But here I want to concentrate on why these different techniques are used.

The first technique that is, I believe, specific to the Mahāsi method, is noting. Although it may be pointed out that if there's any thinking, it's not real *vipassanā*, what is misunderstood here is that this is a technique to get a meditator beyond thinking. It's not an end in itself. According to the Buddha's teaching, there are two stages of concentrated thought before full concentration is established. The first is a simple noting or naming of the object. This simple thought, naming, noting, is known as *vitakka* and is likened to a bee flying towards a flower. A word which encapsulates the whole experience.

In a child this is very obvious and simplistic. When a two-year-old is beginning to speak, they'll rejoice at being able to name an object. "Ca, ca, ca." For that mind at that level of language, the word car simply points at the object, and there's not much thought around it, since language itself, which allows us to think about an object, is not developed enough for this to happen. But for us, the word car conjures up a host of memories and desires. This thinking about an object, this mentation, is known as *papañca*. Now there's a lovely word, *papañca*. It's proliferation.

And the effect of this thinking and daydreaming is to keep us off the presenting object and distract the mind. The Buddha likened it to a monkey jumping from branch to branch. Now this is exactly what we've got to stop. We've got to stop the mind moving off the present moment. So shrinking thought down to a single word is the preliminary effort. But at this stage the meditator is forever having to pull the attention out of wandering and into watching. When we find ourselves complaining that the mind won't stay still, we fail to understand that this is exactly what the training is about. It's all about reconditioning the mind to be present, to be attentive to what's happening now, not to what it would like to happen. So this is the stage of *vitakka*.

The meditator uses the noting word to limit the thinking mind and retrain the attention to rest upon the object. Now this noting has to be done with precise effort, a determined noting. Rising, falling, rising, falling. And although there is careful noting, the attention is not placed on the word itself, but on the experience, the feeling of a sensation, the sensation of an emotion, the knowing of a thought. Now thought can be split

into two categories, a concept and an image. At the breath, for instance, as we note, there will be a concept of rising and falling, and also an image of the abdomen in the mind. We don't try to destroy them, we just keep pointing the attention at the feeling of movement, the sensations.

And this attention will then grow in strength until thought cannot distract it. The meditator is still noting, but the attention, instead of wanting to wander off, becomes stuck, as it were, on the object. This is the second stage of developing right concentration and is called *vicāra*. This is likened to a bee landing on and sucking the nectar of a flower. The meditator continues to note diligently, placing the attention more and more on the object, really feeling those sensations, really experiencing them as they arise and pass away.

This unflagging effort will draw all the energy out of thought to a point where thought stops. Remember, thinking is always about something. It always comes after the event. So when thinking stops, that must mean we are right in the present moment. And it's at this point of bare knowing that the true *vipassanā* consciousness, *sammā sati*, right awareness, arises and our intuitive intelligence, *paññā*, free from the distortion of thought and image, can finally begin to see the way things really are.

So we don't have to worry about when to stop the noting. It will stop once we've arrived at a high enough level of awareness and concentration. These moments of pure *vipassanā* are few and far between and very short in duration but they have great potential for insight. Such moments are known as *khaṇika samādhi*, momentary concentration which lengthen into a moment to moment to moment concentrated awareness. And as we progress such moments of continual awareness lengthen and increase. It takes perseverance. So don't give up. When the going gets tough, the tough get going.

Now when it comes to choosing a word, the simplest and most direct will do. And if a word doesn't come to mind, then any general word such as feeling, moving and so on will do. The word in itself is not all that important. Its purpose, remember, is to stop the mind wandering away. If we start looking for a word as a poet might, and we ask for a dictionary, well then we've definitely lost the plot. Sometimes strange stuff comes up and it's difficult to be precise, so any approximate word will do. Actually, when strange feelings do arise, the attention is so riveted that noting usually falls away anyway.

Apart from noting in the basic postures of sitting, walking, standing and lying down, it's important to realize that we can't just limit our efforts to that. As the Mahāsi pointed out, it's the continuity of awareness that brings success. You can't just stop, take a break or go for a short holiday. Spiritual practice is relentless. To make a good sustained effort

in the sitting and then to get up and let the mind run around like a headless chicken is like blowing up a balloon and letting all the air out before you've tied it up. Well, the awakening balloon doesn't get tied up till we're fully liberated. So we've just got to keep blowing up that balloon.

At various times of the day, we're not practicing formal meditation. Take the process of rising in the morning. As soon as we hear the bell and become aware of it, we immediately begin the noting. Hearing, hearing, aware of the process of hearing. And we are attentive to all the surrounding feelings. Tiredness, heaviness, depression, joy, interest, enthusiasm. We recognize all the surrounding thoughts that arise. "Damn bell, oh hell, can't get up, I'm too exhausted." "Bell, time to get up, quick, rush, rush, you'll be late." "Bell, how wonderful, time to meditate." And we observe it all, noting it all as best we can.

When finally a certain equanimity falls, we make our first intention, intending to rise. We pull back the bedclothes, pulling, pulling. But we also feel the feeling of the sheets, of the weight of the duvet. We're taking our time, noting and experiencing fully every movement, emotion and thought, using that noting to keep the mind steady on the object. Now don't be concerned if you can't get to this level for the first few days, but hopefully, with persistent effort, you'll experience this moment-to-moment mindfulness before too long.

When it comes to the bathroom, there are obviously certain things we have to do at a normal speed, such as brushing our teeth. But even here we can slow down a little and become aware of all the intricate movements involved. We should become especially aware of that area around the necessary human activity, the calls of nature. Feeling the passing of water. Be aware of the thoughts and feelings surrounding the act. The same with the passing of stools. Normally our minds would prefer to be somewhere else. That's why we'll often stuff our toilets with holiday magazines. Well, this is an opportunity to find out how we really feel about those parts of our body that may disgust us. Is disgust necessary? A meditation course is a wonderful time to investigate the whole of our relationship to this body.

Then there are meal times and tea breaks. And I shall go into this in more detail tomorrow morning. But it's the same. Noting and experiencing every intention and noting and experiencing every action, every feeling, every thought.

Now you will have noticed that we are asked to note our intentions. Intentions play a crucial role in our psychology, according to the Buddha. They are thoughts laced with desire, both negative and positive, wanting and not wanting. These desires have all

been conditioned by our past behavior, and the bulk of them have become habitual and barely conscious. How many of us are truly aware of our desire and intention to eat or sleep or talk to someone? We just find ourselves eating, sleeping and talking.

All these habitual intentions have to be made quite conscious so that we can come to understand clearly how we ourselves are conditioning our own minds. And of course what we'll begin to do is to reinforce those habits that are good and skilful, such as eating for health's sake, but not reinforce those that do us harm, such as eating for greed. In this way, we can begin to take control of our lives and guide it towards the good, the beautiful and the happy. This self-knowledge concerning our intentions and their role in our lives is a very important part of the process of purifying the heart. So please do make a special effort to note intentions before doing anything.

So, noting is a way to bring the thinking mind into the service of that higher consciousness, *satipaññā*, awareness with intuitive intelligence. However, there is something a little more subtle going on. As soon as we use a word to point at something, it distances the object from that which knows. When a child shouts car, car, they're actually saying there's a car, there, over there, out there. The child is objectifying the world. It is detaching itself from the world.

So what we're doing by pointing at all that we experience within us is to objectify the inner world. We are detaching ourselves from this inner world. We see it as if we were looking at a landscape. Only the landscape is within us. What Gerald Manley Hopkins, the poet, most happily called the inscape. Now, whenever we do that, we're experiencing in some little way the meaning of *anattā*. This is the doctrine that this body, these emotions, these thoughts, this personality doesn't constitute anything substantial. It's all made up of pieces and parts. And that there is some faculty within us that can stand above it and come to know these psychophysical phenomena for what they are.

So noting something, naming it, allows that intelligence, *paññā*, to distance itself from the body, mind and heart and in so doing slowly comes to realize its own nature. In this way, noting becomes a very powerful tool to position that intelligent consciousness, *satipaññā*, so that it can come to realize the way things really are.

Now there are three things that can go wrong with the noting technique. The first happens if we stop doing it deliberately. It then becomes like a background mantra. And you'll be surprised to find that when you go off onto a fantasy, to Tuscany or somewhere, on return to the meditation room, the mind is happily repeating, "rising, falling, rising, falling." That's the amazing thing about the body-mind complex. It can be trained to do anything. Think of those concert performers. They're not directing their fingers,

though they may be aware of them. They're using them to draw the sound they want out of the instrument. They play automatically, while the artist concentrates on feeling and expression.

The second error is to become lazy. As soon as we stop putting right effort into the noting the whole thing begins to drop away and we start to lose the sharpness of the seeing. And often that laziness sits on the irritated dullness of boredom. Now beware of boredom. Boredom will always blame the practice for being boring. But what the wise meditator does is not to listen to boredom and give it any credence whatsoever, but to make that boredom, that subtle state, the object of meditation. They note "boredom, boredom," while feeling the texture of boredom and losing their discomfort of being with the heart when it's in a bored state.

Remember, as soon as we say to ourselves, "I'm bored," well, we are bored. We've taken on that identity. So be careful. When boredom arises, see it for what it is. Yet another negative, unwholesome attitude that has to be noted, felt, observed, experienced and understood. And what is it that we come to understand about boredom? Well, the last thing we want to do is to appease it. Boredom tells us that if we don't want to get bored, we need distraction, we need a break, we need entertainment, we need a cup of tea, watch a bit of telly, call a friend and tell them how bored we are. Well, again, that's just playing into the hands of boredom.

And do we really believe that distraction will satisfy boredom? Not at all. The more you feed boredom, paradoxically, the bigger boredom gets. Boredom feeds off distraction. No, the way to undermine boredom is to keep repeating what we are doing with added attention while feeling the boredom. We even turn upon the feeling of boredom itself and make that the object to be noted, felt, observed, experienced and understood. Boredom sits on the flames of expectation of something engrossing, anticipation of something exciting. One road to depression and Prozac. When through diligent practice, boredom begins to lose energy to our amazement, that energy turns into interest.

The third mistake is to pay too much attention to the word itself. The word, remember, is there only to point the mind at the object. We're putting our attention onto the process of physical and mental feelings and thoughts, not onto the thought itself, the noting itself. Occasionally, a person finds the use of words intrusive. It's as though they can only hear and think of the word, and it seems an obstacle to any real contact with the feelings and sensations they're supposed to be experiencing. What this is showing to the meditator is how much they're experiencing the world through the medium of thought.

By simply continuing to note, but with a clear intention to observe and experience sensations and feelings, this delusive way of experiencing the world will be slowly undermined and it will also correct the way we perceive the world. So it's worth persevering with. So noting should be done precisely as each object comes into the attention and it should be done deliberately.

The next technique which is particular to the Mahāsi method is to go slow. The body and mind work in total unison. Remember the Buddha said that it was like milk in water. The one affects the other. Sometimes the body affects the mind. When we get pain in the knees, we feel a mental discomfort as well. Sometimes the mind affects the body. When we feel depressed, the body feels heavy and dense. How well the body feels when we're in a state of joy or excitement.

Now, if we slow the body down and do everything very slowly and deliberately, then this connection between the mind and the body will become very apparent. It affects the speed at which the mind is working. The slower the mind goes, the more clearly we perceive its workings, especially in that area where suffering is created, that whole area of desire, will and action.

Take a film. The more you slow a film down, the more you can see. It's amazing to watch wildlife in slow motion. The balletic movements of a leopard in chase, usually just a blur. The flick of a frog's tongue as it catches a fly, usually we simply don't see it. But then we can actually stop a film and see things frame by frame. And did you know? A frog catches a fly underneath the tongue. Now there's something. In the same way, we find that as we go slower and slower, so many understandings will arise about how this human organism works. And because we are especially interested in this whole area of human suffering, we really begin to see how we get ourselves into a mess.

Now you'll find that old habits easily assert themselves. If you find yourself rushing, rushing, rushing to eat, rushing to get to meditation on time, then stop. Take a deep breath. Get in touch with what's impelling you. Anxiety, worry, fear of embarrassment, or just pure habit, whatever. Talk to yourself and quieten the whole body down and wait till peace and equanimity have re-established themselves. Now one good trick is to do the action again. If you find yourselves rushing, then stop. Wait for calmness to return, go back to where you started, and begin again. And it's surprising how effective it is to do right what we do wrong. If you remember at school, we were always told to do our corrections. You see, our education wasn't that bad after all.

Now take the simple and constant action of opening doors. Standing in front of a door, we make the intention to open it. We reach out, reaching, reaching. We touch the handle, touching, touching, experiencing just that sensual contact, the feel of metal. We

turn the handle, feeling the resistance of the spring, turning, turning, applying the exact amount of pressure, and so on. Just think how many handles we've wrenched with oblivious cruelty. In this way, we communicate with the door.

When it comes to how slow we should move around or do things, we can modulate our speed. In walking meditation, for instance, we can go fast for exercise. In the dining room, in the bathroom and other places where we share facilities and services, we need to be aware that other people are waiting, and we can move at a faster pace, perhaps even at a normal pace in certain circumstances. The important times to go very slow are towards the end of a walking period, so that we build up a maximum attention and concentration to bring into the sitting meditation, and any other action where we want to really microscope in on what is actually happening at the physical and mental bases. Mealtime, for instance, is an excellent opportunity to do this.

Right at the start, we said that to become skilful we need to reflect on our experience. We need to acknowledge feedback. You'll see that after every sitting, I ask meditators to reflect on the experience of that hour. So we should every so often reflect on what's happening. And of course that's my job too, to reflect back to you how you're meditating. It's something I shall be constantly reminding you to do. However, there can arise here a confusion between being aware and being self-aware. We're not trying to be aware of ourselves practicing *vipassanā*. We are simply being aware of anything that arises and passes away. We're not trying to be aware of ourselves doing things. We're trying just to be mindful doing things.

If I'm washing the pots, I'm attentive to the actions. I'm not trying to be aware of myself washing pots. If, for instance, you try to be aware of yourself writing a letter or adding up a bill, you'll just get confused. Self-awareness will, of course, arise naturally. So note it, "self-aware, self-aware," and then put your attention entirely on what you're actually doing.

A final request. Please do not mix techniques. Give up for this period any other *vipassanā* technique you've learnt or technique from another religion. Anything Tibetan, anything Hindu, yoga breathing, visualization, mantra, beading, bowing and so on. Judeo-Christian prayer and exercises can be put aside for a while too. Why? Firstly, it will confuse your practice. Secondly, it will confuse me. And thirdly, you won't get the full benefit of what this course has to offer and for those of you who are new to this it will also mean that you will not know whether this form of meditation really suits you or not. You've got to give it your all. If you've any problems over this please talk to me about them at interview. So again, please do not mix techniques.

Let's pause here for a moment. So to recap, spiritual practice is utterly relentless and agonizingly repetitive. The purpose of our meditation course, and I prefer to call it a course and not a retreat for this reason, is to hone our skills of *vipassanā* meditation. The purpose of all these skills is to get consciousness to observe physical sensations, emotional feelings and thought objectively. The noting technique is used primarily to stop the mind thinking about things, stop the mind launching itself into thought and daydream. By noting diligently, we shall progress through the two stages of concentrated thought into pure *vipassanā*.

Going slow has the purpose of centering us into this very moment and make us more and more aware of even the smallest movement of the body, heart and mind and how they are interrelated. And we need to become especially aware of intention and the role of intention.

Now we ought to practice with sincere effort and great diligence. In the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, the Discourse on Establishing Right Awareness, the Buddha uses the words *ātāpī sampajāno satimā*. *Satimā* means with awareness, with mindfulness. *Sampajāno* means with intuitive intelligence, with understanding. From these two words the compound *satipaṇṇā* has been formed which encapsulates the enlightened mind, the awakened mind. And *ātāpī* comes from *tapo*, which means heavy ascetic mortifications. Now that's the sort of commitment and energy the Buddha is asking us to put into the practice.

The Buddha warns in the *Dhammapada*, a collection of verses: "Vigilance is the path to the deathless. Negligence, the path to death. The heedful do not die. The heedless are as if already dead." Now, let's not be dead, heaven forbid. Let's be alive, alive with bright awareness and sharp intelligence.

May your moment-to-moment vigilance and unshakable commitment to the practice bear you great fruit. May you be liberated from all suffering and attain the blissful freedom of *Nibbāna* sooner rather than later.

The Hindrances

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 26 min read

In this comprehensive evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma provides practical guidance on working with the five nīvaraṇa (hindrances) that challenge every meditator: sensual desire (kāmacchanda), aversion (byāpāda), sloth and torpor (thīna-middha), restlessness and worry (uddhacca-kukkucca), and skeptical doubt (vicikicchā). Using the Buddha's vivid imagery of a pool of water obscured by different conditions, he explains how these mental states hinder calm abiding while serving as valuable objects of investigation in vipassanā practice.

The talk focuses particularly on working with physical and emotional pain through the lens of aversion, exploring how suffering arises not from pain itself but from our relationship to it. Drawing on teachings about patience as the highest ascetic practice, Bhante emphasizes learning to distinguish between pain and suffering, using practical instructions for noting and investigating our reactions. He shares guidance from the Buddha's advice to Moggallāna on overcoming dullness and lethargy, offering nine progressive techniques before considering rest.

Throughout, the emphasis remains on accurate recognition and wise response to these hindrances, seeing them as Māra's temptations that lose power when clearly perceived. This teaching provides essential foundation for developing the vigilance needed to navigate the challenges of intensive meditation practice while maintaining the spiritual aim of understanding the arising and passing of suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

Yesterday we talked about the skills of meditation, how to become focused and one-pointed, attentive with a sharp intelligence. And what we find is that the mind rebels. All our hopes of quick success are dashed as the armies of Mara, the evil one, burst upon us. These, of course, are the so-called hindrances, the nīvaraṇa.

I say they're so-called hindrances because, in vipassanā, they're one of the areas of mental and emotional activity we have to observe. What they're a real hindrance to is a peaceful state of mind. They're really hindrances to attaining samatha, or a calm, mental, joyful state of mind that leads to the absorptions, the jhāna. Here in Pure Vipassana,

we're not concerned to fabricate or develop wonderful, spaced-out, ecstatic states of mind. If they come, all well and good. But even then, they're just objects to note and watch, feel and observe, experience and understand.

So what are these hindrances? Well, I don't think they'll come as a surprise. The Buddha gave some apt imagery to go with the teachings. Imagine looking into a pool of water, the body, heart, mind. Suppose it's all kaleidoscopic with variegated colours. Well, you just can't see beyond these colours into the pool, and they entrance. That sends your desire for you. Suppose the water's boiling. You can't see into the pool then either. That's aversion, hatred and anger. Then the pool is covered with mosses. That's the effect of sloth and torpor, dullness and lethargy. Suppose a wind blows across the pool and makes waves. You can't see into the depths then either. That's the effect of restlessness, anxiety and guilt, remorse. And finally the pool is turbid and muddy. That's the insidious pervasiveness of sceptical doubt.

Here I'm not going to talk much about the area of sensual desire, because we've talked a little bit about it when it comes to eating, and I shall be giving further ideas as we progress. But I'll tackle the subject in a couple of days, when all the pain and horror of settling in over these first three days finally subsides. And I promise newcomers, it does, it does subside. The old sloggers will tell you.

So I'd like instead to tackle the whole problem of pain, which is what we're all probably going through to some degree or other right now. But first, let me just give one or two pointers about pleasure.

Firstly, the fact is that sensual pleasure gives rise to happiness. That is a pleasant mental state. We have to make that distinction. Just because there's a pleasant taste on the tongue doesn't mean you have to get excited about it. Indeed, sometimes people feel quite negative when they eat. So separating happiness as a mental state from the pleasure, a physical state, allows us not to get caught up in fantasies that originate in sensual pleasure. The most obvious and obsessive, of course, are the ones around sex and romance. Hardly a surprise.

And with this one especially, we have to be very careful. It can really take over. As always, the instruction is to note the fantasy for what it is, sexy, romantic, and so on, and turn your attention away, back to the breath, or if there are sexual feelings in the body, to those. Now, when you turn away, you have to stop for a moment and make the decision to abandon such thoughts. Sometimes you may feel the pull to go back there. That's the *taṇhā*, the attachment. If you can, stay with that subtle feeling until it dies

away. In that way, you will disempower the habit of seeking happiness in sexual and romantic pleasure. Now, even if you can't make this a lifetime objective, at least you can do it for a few days or weeks that you're on this course.

The second thing to understand is why sensual pleasure is so attractive. It's not just that it's pleasurable in itself. It is also that it provides an escape from unpleasurable and unhappy states. Why else do we refer to comfort food? Feeling a bit bored, a bit lonely, nothing better than a piece of cake and a cup of coffee. So there is an underlying force that keeps us at the pleasurable obsession. Its job is to keep us away from pain and suffering, and that is a very great force in our psyche.

I knew of two young men travelling around Sri Lanka who took drugs all the time. They even took tranquillizers when travelling on a long bus ride. They just didn't see the point of being even slightly uncomfortable. That's the sort of denial we can get into. Our job is not to escape the fact of unsatisfactoriness, the fact of discomfort and pain, and the fact of suffering in our lives. What a futile effort! But to find equanimity with the uncomfortable and the painful. And in so doing, we discover that this is the way to the end of unsatisfactoriness and suffering. This also means we have to find equanimity with the pleasurable, not to believe that transient pleasant feelings and sensations are something we can base our happiness on.

I ask you why should our interior lives be so dominated by pleasant or unpleasant sensual feelings? So be careful when this trait to run away from the unpleasant arises. For instance, should you find abandoning thoughts of romance brings up feelings of loneliness, take that as an opportunity to investigate loneliness. Since we have escaped loneliness by indulging in romantic fantasy, when the loneliness dissolves, so the romantic fantasies lose some of their obsessiveness.

So, whenever we find ourselves caught up in pleasing fantasies, really note, recognize and acknowledge them. Just for a moment, seize that reflection. This is romance. This is greed. This is avarice. This is about fame. This is about power. Turn your attention away from the mind, into the body. Should you feel that pull to go back into the fantasy, stay there with that feeling. Wait till it dies away. Then return to the breath or other sensation or feeling that draws your attention. If you find yourself struggling and fighting and getting tense, then stop. Relax. Take a deep breath. Relax. The process is one of gently letting go, allowing it to arise and pass away.

So I'd like now to go on to the second of the hindrances, aversion. And I would like to centre on pain because that's what we all feel a great deal of when we start a course. There are two types of pain, physical and mental.

When it comes to physical pain proper, then it's only natural that it should arise. In fact, it's nature's way of telling us that something is wrong. Toothache, earache and so on. In meditation, there seems to be three common areas of physical pain. Pain in the knees, the back and the neck. It's often because of bad posture, by the way. But if the posture is correct, any pain we get will either be because the body is being made to sit correctly, or the internal tensions are allowed to manifest. And they are all usually some form of suppressed emotions.

So if the posture is good, there's really only one place where physical pain proper should arise, and that's at the knees. Whether you're sitting cross-legged or kneeling. And that will disappear once the tendons at the top of the leg stretch and allow the leg to lie more flat, or, in the case of kneeling, once the knees have got used to the pressure. We can ease all this with cushions, and you shouldn't be in the slightest way embarrassed by doing so.

Now, our attitude as Vipassana meditators is not to fight pain. We're not trying to develop into masochistic self-mortificators. Nor are we trying to be macho, trying to prove we're not crybabies. I can take it. Give me more. The purpose we suffer pain gladly is to see how suffering arises. Is pain suffering? That's the question. And if it isn't suffering, then how can we suffer when there's pain? So our purpose is not to make the pain go away, to stare it out, so to speak, or worse, to blast it out with vigorous noting. Be careful here, it's a common tendency. What we want to do is to investigate our relationship to it, our relationship of aversion, that desire of wanting it to disappear, and the fear, that desire to run away from it. The fight-flight syndrome we see in any sentient being who is suffering pain. Are these sorts of responses necessary?

Just as we discover that pleasure and happiness are not the same, so we have to discover that pain and unhappiness are not the same. Now there is one great advantage to pain for all of us. When pain does arise, in the knees for instance, it definitely draws our attention. That's the wonderful thing about pain. It makes us very attentive, and our ability to remain focused grows naturally, though it has to be said this sort of concentration is not very reliable, it's not very strong, since it's dependent on a loud stimulus. Yet if only for this reason, the ardent meditator rejoices at the appearance of pain.

So what do we do? Well, we note. Pain, pain. And our attention beelines in on the physical sensations. As it does so, it notices the emotional reaction of aversion and all the thinking that comes up. It hurts. I can't stand it. Why should I suffer this? It might be doing damage. My knee could implode. As the attention becomes aware of that, it notes aversion, aversion. Then we begin to see how the self wants to indulge the suggestions of aversion, to move and relieve the pain. We need to work with this vicious cycle, the

physical pain, the emotional reaction and the dialogue, and the desire to act by way of aversion, each feeding off the other. The meditator begins to realize the separateness of the physical from the mental base, and yet their utter interdependence. They see clearly how suffering arises because of a wrong relationship to pain.

Now it may be that pain becomes too severe. Then fear screams, the knee will crack, the tendons will snap, I'll never walk again. Can we stay right there at least for a while to see how it all works? Now we have to be sensible about this and know when to yield gracefully, as it were, to body messages. We don't have to break our knees to become enlightened.

So here's the reason we must learn to sit patiently with pain, to bear patiently, to endure. The Buddha said that patience was the highest form of ascetic practice. And he asks us to bring this virtue to perfection. He says, even if someone were to start sawing you limb from limb with a double-handed saw, and if for a moment you indulge in thoughts of hatred and revenge, then you are not following his teachings. A tall order indeed. And we shall understand how he can ask such a thing when we see how the reaction of aversion and fear are the true suffering, and that pain is, in the end, just physical sensation.

When we see this, really experience it and begin to allow the aversion and fear to subside instead of identifying with them and so not react to them, not to be hijacked by them, we are slowly but surely taking the suffering out of pain. Interestingly enough, if pain is watched long enough, it may very well disappear. Either the reason for it passes or the body creates its own painkillers. But let that sort of thing happen by itself. Don't try to make it happen. If you find yourself gritting your teeth and struggling with pain, the pain will get worse, for that reaction simply adds more turbulence. And if we are victorious, it will simply mean we've suppressed it all, and that's trouble stored up for the future.

So now we've come to a point where we've decided we can't take any more and we have to move. Here is another wonderful opportunity for insight. First, we note the intention, intending to move, intending to move. Then we slowly, ever so slowly, move from one posture to another, noting all the while. We experience the lessening of the physical pain, and we are attentive to the changing emotions, the relief, the joy, the comfort that arises, and all the dialogue, the sighs. We finally settle into another posture and feel so comfortable that we can return to noting and feeling the breath. Ah, what contentment!

Now this is what meditation is all about. Then there it starts, a little tingling as it were, then a slight discomfort, and before long those damn knees are at it again. Is there no peace? And so it goes on, you see. Here we're experiencing the roller coaster of the pain-pleasure syndrome. Can we get off it? Can we take the suffering out of pain and the indulgence out of pleasure? Well, of course we can. Of course we can. We do it so long as we can retain the observation post, that aloofness, that inner solitude above the madding crowd of our sensations, feelings and thoughts. And how do we do this? By turning upon everything in the attitude of the interested scientist, the one who wants to know how it all works, and in this instance, what is pain, what is suffering, is pain suffering or is it something else? And how can suffering be brought to an end?

And this leads us directly into another area of physical pain, the pain, the discomfort in the body caused by emotions. Mental states express themselves in the body and the physical electrochemical base reacts. We all know that. Stress gives us cramped shoulders and headaches. Anxiety makes us feel queasy and gives us ulcers. And so on. These emotions are products of past behaviour. Please don't think the meditation is fabricating them. Stuff comes up fairly fast and heavy. And at times one wonders... Would I be suffering this if I weren't doing meditation? Well, you probably wouldn't be suffering them, not so sharply anyway, but they're still there, locked in the system. Vipassana simply unlocks them and allows them to express themselves.

In fact, when you start meditating, it's a bit like lifting the lid off a dustbin, the lid of suppressive tendencies. And what are these suppressive tendencies? Why, aversion and fear, of course. Who wants to feel the heaviness of depression, the burning of jealousy, the sickliness of anxiety? No one. Best to keep them locked up in the body. But we know they're doing damage. Surely it's best to let them out into the open. Give them air so they can evaporate. And what is that open air? That is but the spaciousness of our own awareness.

And when we do that, we begin to realize that this is therapeutic. This is the way the heart heals itself. And that the healing has to be a conscious process. Such emotions have to burn out in consciousness. We have to suffer them gladly. That's why we have to learn to sit patiently amidst the flames.

But why do they have to burn out in consciousness? Why can't emotions just die away quietly somewhere? For all intents and purposes, we cannot separate the body and the mind. They interreact intimately. So when the mind has turbulence in it, which isn't allowed to express itself, it gets buried into the cellular life and starts expressing itself there through physical symptoms. Just because we're not aware of repressed emotions doesn't mean they're not there, and doing damage. That's the reason we have

psychosomatic illnesses. Often, through the meditation, because these turbulences are allowed to come out, such diseases are cured. This is one reason, from a health point of view, why we have to let those flames burn, why we have to train ourselves to feel the scorch and smile.

Now when these negative emotions arise and are felt in the body, we find we have the same reaction as to pain. And yet again, we note, feel, observe, experience and come to understand how we always want to fight or run away from unpleasantness. Yet again the question arises, is the original emotion coming up pain or suffering? Or are the reactions of aversion and fear pain or suffering? How does suffering arise? Can we take the suffering out of pain? Can we so position ourselves that we can see, feel, experience the original pain or emotion and also see, feel, experience the reaction of aversion or fear towards it? And when we're in that position, is there suffering?

Finally, there are emotions in the body, emotions that are so blocked and severely repressed that all we will ever feel is physical pain. Headaches and backaches are sometimes like this. But it could be pain virtually anywhere. Again, we observe the process of aversion and fear, allowing the pain to be just pain, to allow it to express, to expend, to release its malevolent energy. That's the cure.

There was a dramatic incident recorded at the Mahasi Center in Rangoon. A man came with terminal cancer, refusing to take medication. He just sat with the pain. As he describes it, there was an explosion in the stomach and the cancer vanished. Now, whenever I tell this story, I like to add very quickly that Vipassana is not a cure-all. And as I said yesterday, on the one hand, if you practice for the sake of health, you will lose the spiritual aim, and on the other, if you don't get better, you will lose faith in the meditation. Let Vipassana do what it wants to do. Keep that deceiving self, the fiendish Mara, out of the way.

Now, isn't it wonderful? Have you noticed that every time we talk about curing the heart of all her emotional problems, it's always in conjunction with just watching, just feeling. And when we're just experiencing like this, we're doing nothing, nothing at all. That's the wonder of it. If we just leave the heart alone, just get out of the way for once, she does it all by herself. She doesn't need any help from us. The heart can cure herself of all the illnesses we've intentionally or unintentionally caused by our greed, hatred and delusion. Have faith. There are powers in us beyond our control and they're working always towards our well-being.

The next big hindrance is dullness and lethargy. First, I'd like to link this with restlessness. As far as I've come to experience it, these are two sides of the same coin. It's like fission and fusion energy or black holes and exploding stars. The turbulence in our

psyche can either go inward and make us feel tired and drawn or outward into restless energy. Interestingly, there's a condition called restless depression where the person feels depressed and yet needs to move about restlessly. So we'll often experience these two states even in one sitting, sometimes one after the other. Even in daily life we can be feeling down one minute, then a friend calls and suddenly we're rushing all over the place getting ready to go out.

Secondly, we mustn't confuse dullness and lethargy with laziness. Dullness refers to porridge head, when the mind feels like sludge, and lethargy refers to the physical heaviness we feel, the body feels like a slug. Occasionally the one comes without the other, but both are products of past conditioning, sometimes because we have been lazy in the past. Sometimes because we've used sleep to annihilate ourselves when the going gets too hard, or things upset us, and so on.

So here we are back to that old duality. We enjoy sleeping, at least there's no pain in oblivion, and we wake up refreshed. But we also often use it to escape unhappy states. Consider. When we're children and we're naughty or weepy, our parents say it's because we're tired, and it's probably true. And what we need is a little sleep. So we learn early on that one way to escape painful feelings is to go to sleep. And hey presto, you wake up refreshed. Or at least you do most of the time. But this sort of sleep is a suppressive measure, a conscious effort to force the unpleasant out of the mind by radically ignoring it. And where has all that unpleasant energy gone? Surely it's stored somewhere to reappear on some cloudy day.

Now, dullness and lethargy can be caused by any repressed or suppressed emotion, in which case they can arise with feelings of depression. So whatever the cause, and remember we're not concerned to find ultimate causes, dullness and lethargy, when they arise, have to be dealt with in such a way that the energy is allowed to disperse itself. And we do that by making the sensations and feelings, the objects to be observed and felt, experienced and understood. It's as simple as that.

Two of the first few disciples of the Buddha, who were later to be seen as his most important, were Sāriputta and Moggallāna. Now Sāriputta took a whole two weeks to become enlightened. It took this long, it said, because he wanted to investigate every bit of the path on the way. In the end, such was his grasp of the Dharma that he became known as the general of the Dharma, and the Buddha acknowledged him as second only to himself in understanding. Moggallāna, however, was not so intellectually inclined. He was more of a magician, able to exercise psychic powers, again second only

to the Buddha. When he began to meditate, the one big hindrance that came up was dullness and lethargy. So great were they that he had to ask the Buddha for guidance, and on this account, it is said, he became enlightened in only one week.

So what were the directions the Buddha gave? Well, first, he told Moggallāna not to take any notice, but at the first signs of dullness and lethargy, to simply put more energy into the practice, put more energy into the posture, lift up that spine. If attacked again, to consider the Dharma, to recognize the danger of this hindrance. This dread of consequences should lift up the energy enough to stay awake till it passes. If that failed to recite the Dharma, give the mind something simple to do like repeating the verses of the Dharma and so dispel the torpor.

On one meditation course, I was suffering from this so much I decided to repeat the times tables and I got as far as 17 both forward and backward over a period of several days mind. My teacher at the time, Sayadaw Ujjanaka, told me that was skillful, but I think it would probably have been better to recite the discourses, if I'd have known any.

If this should fail, it's time to do something. The Buddha advised Moggallāna to rub his ears. Now at first that seems a little odd, but then, when we remember there are all those acupuncture points in the ears that affect every organ, it's definitely worth trying. If that fails, rub the legs. So now we've changed our posture. Then get up and wash the face in cold water. Sit in light or look at the light with the eyes open. Then, which works only for those who've practiced concentration meditation, create a light source in the mind itself. Moggallāna would have been adept at this, but for us, we would probably go on to the next, which is to walk up and down. And then, only then, when after nine different efforts, still the lethargy and dullness is pressing down, can we consider redefining it as tiredness, and so take a rest.

The Buddha's advice shows us how persistent and also how gently we have to parry the blows of these hindrances. And we have to be inventive too, for what worked one time often doesn't have the same effect again. Remember, only after nine determined efforts can we take a rest.

Taking these ideas as a standard, we can work out our own. As for myself, at the first signs I note more rapidly. I can put more energy into the posture. At the second, I take sloth as an object to observe. I note, feel its texture, observe it. Thirdly, if it comes back, I keep doing this but with the eyes open. Letting in light often wakes you up. But the eyes, which you can keep wide open, are turned towards the ground a couple of feet or so ahead. You can also look through a window or at a light, but there's danger of being distracted. So be careful not to look around. Then I'll stand and perhaps do a quiet stretch. Finally, if it's just too heavy, I'll do walking meditation. Not to beat it by walking

fast, but to stay awake, still feeling the dullness and the lethargy fully, still allowing it to dissipate its energy. And if I do walking meditation with dullness and lethargy, I don't do it slowly, but at a normal pace, just keeping the attention on the feelings in the body.

Alternatively, I can just decide to struggle with it on the cushion. I just keep gently pushing up against it. I may fall asleep, but as soon as I wake, I make this effort to straighten up and just keep sitting. The danger of this is that I can give in and fall asleep properly. But usually, if you fall into sleep in a meditation posture, the body jerks forward and that's enough to waken you. And sometimes you may find yourself in that strange world of neither asleep nor awake, and the body swaying.

There was also a time, something I picked up from another monk, when I sat facing a wall, in really old Bodhidharma style. Some of you may know the legend of the great Bodhidharma, with an R by the way, to whom Zen is accredited. He sat for nine years facing a wall. When you face a wall in meditation and you fall asleep, bang! Boy, does that head hit that brick. And do you know, this stuff can be so heavy, you still keep falling asleep. Well, after a few bangs, I began to sense brain damage. I did eventually find a kinder way. I used to sit under a mosquito net, and just the gentle brush of the net against the forehead would be enough to startle me from sleep.

My teacher then, Sayadaw Ujjanaka, used to call dullness and lethargy my two very good friends. And they are, aren't they? You'll hear them. Oh, you're so tired. You've not had enough sleep. You aren't ready for such rigorous training. What you need is a little kip, a ziz, a power nap. You'll feel so much better. You always do. Ten minutes, and you wake up two hours later. So, refuse to be annihilated. Refuse to be annihilated.

Now, some of you may think we don't get enough sleep. But it does take a day or two to lift the energy. But we're hardly doing anything strenuous, physically or mentally. It's not as though we're out there digging roads. We're not working out accounts. We don't have to deal with fractious people. The whole situation here is one of outward calm, taking our time, the joy of knowing we have nothing to achieve, nowhere to go. And since we're not communicating, we don't even have to be somebody, a personality. If only on account of that, we don't need as much sleep as we might in ordinary daily life.

Some of you may know we sleep in one and three quarter hour rhythms, and it's the first two only where we actually sleep at the deepest of four levels. After that, we never sleep so deeply again. So decide that the five and a half hour sleep is enough, and honestly recognize any so-called tiredness as dullness and lethargy. Work against them, and so lift up your energy level. You'll see, it's like running. You suddenly get second wind.

In a longer course, you could all reduce your sleep to less than four hours, and sometimes go through a day or two without sleep. So calming and energizing can this *vipassanā* meditation be.

Now I mentioned earlier that dullness and lethargy are not to be confused with laziness. If by laziness, we mean an actual decision not to put energy into what we're doing. Laziness is the obvious enemy of effort, and we can say our meditation period has been poor if we don't work against the tendency to be lazy. Of course, the more we give in to laziness, the more we add to the store of conditioned laziness, which is one of the factors that go to make up dullness and lethargy in the first place. And the more we fail to work up our energy, the more difficult it will be to raise energy in the future. Remember, it's all about conditioning.

They say Margaret Thatcher only slept four hours a night while in office. Now this is not a political statement. Anyway, beware. Let sloth and torpor, dullness and lethargy come and go and under no circumstance make a decision to be lazy.

So now we come to restlessness. It's the same. Always do the opposite to what the hindrance is advising you to do. Sloth suggests you take a nap. Restlessness suggests you walk about and do something. But don't. Refuse to be a slave to these dictators. Refuse. Sit. Sit still. Observe that feeling and how we react with aversion. Note, feel, experience, observe both the dislike we have of it and the desire we have to appease it. Make that little vicious circle the object to understand, the physical feelings, the mental state and the relationship we have of aversion. Slowly, the discomfort of being with restlessness will lessen and we'll be able to sit still even amidst a tornado.

Another thing you can do is scan the body. Start from the top of the head and just pass your consciousness through every part all the way down to the tip of your toes and back up again and just see where restlessness is actually felt. Do we really feel restless at the end of our noses? Just moving the consciousness up and down the body like this can have a calming effect but don't do it for that reason for then we lose our spiritual purpose. And we fall into the trap of trying to establish a comfort zone. We do it to observe, to watch, to feel, to experience and to understand.

If, however, the restlessness gets too much and we decide to move our posture, well, just as we move out of pain, note intending to move, intending to move. Move very slowly, noting, feeling, observing, experiencing all the different changes in posture, sensations and emotions as you do so.

If restlessness is only in the mind, thoughts tumbling one after the other, obsessive thinking, then we need to be patient. Every time we wake up out of a stream of thought or daydream, note the content. Lust, ambition, worry and so on. And gently but firmly bring the attention back to the breath. But the intention must be very empowered. It must be a resolute intention, a determined determination to observe the breath. Alternatively, you may look into the heart centre and see if you can identify, feel and note the emotions which are impelling the thoughts. Actually, I always find this most productive, for all thought has an emotive value. However, sometimes the mind is just frivolous and simply needs to be tamed. The meditator must decide this for themselves.

The final hindrance is sceptical doubt. This can become a serious spiritual disease. Actually, such doubts can undermine our work, our relationships, our whole life. It's the sort of thing that stops you doing. It's a fear, a fear of failure, a lack of confidence, a lack of trust. We question everything, but we won't try it.

Suppose you go to a doctor with an ailment. But you're not sure of the doctor. You feel you've not been listened to, or because you've had a bad experience before with another doctor. You've lost confidence in doctors and modern medicine. You read the leaflet that comes with the medicine, and you become afraid of the side effects.

Suppose you go for a job, which every one of your friends and colleagues say suits you, but you don't feel up to it. You actually get the job, but talk yourself into failure.

You form a relationship with someone, but you can't quite finalise it into a closer partnership or a marriage. You don't trust them, you don't trust yourself. You feel your past relationships, for one reason or another, didn't last, so why should this one? Why go through the pain of separation again? Let's keep the relationship superficial.

It's the same in the spiritual life. You can't trust the Buddha and his teachings. It's all very interesting, but you don't try it. Well, at least, since you're all here on this course, you've overcome that one. There's a loss of confidence in the teacher, heaven forbid. Not that there isn't good reason for leaving a teacher, but to leave them because they've asked you to do something, simply because you don't trust them anymore, may be giving into sceptical doubt.

Then, of course, there's doubting oneself. Everyone else can do the meditation, but I can't. I'm special that way. It's an inverted conceit, isn't it? Instead of being great and wonderful, I'm useless and disgusting. But such thoughts and feelings about ourselves have to be noted and recognised, watched and observed, experienced and understood.

Such doubts as these can all come up very strongly, and at various times it can be very confusing. And that's one of the reasons for doubt, the confusion and the anxiety around confusion, those times when we don't know. We find it very difficult to be in a state of don't know. If you feel assailed by such thoughts, be sure to approach me about them. For heaven's sake, don't run away, or at least don't run away without telling me.

As we shall see when we come to talk about the factors of enlightenment, the Buddha wants us to cultivate right doubt, not sceptical doubt. And right doubt is not to believe what he teaches, but take his teachings as hypotheses that we have to prove right for ourselves. In other words, he wants us to develop curiosity, an enduring desire to want to know, and specifically to want to understand how we create suffering for ourselves.

So, these are our hindrances, all the alluring sirens of desire, from a simple desire to rest to those vast overwhelming cravings of lust for sex, for money, for fame, for power. Then there are all the goblins of aversions, from minor irritations to meditation rage. There are also all those wailing ghosts of anxiety, fear and terror. Then there are the whirlpools of sloth and torpor taking us down into oblivion, plus the gusts and hurricanes of restlessness from fidgetiness to the manic agitation of guilt. And finally there are the cold, anxious fogs of doubt.

As they come up, one after the other, the hosts of Mara, we need to accurately acknowledge them. Be precise. Then consider what to do. Don't let them creep up on us, unawares. That's when they easily ensnare us. And once we've fallen into the trap, it takes an even greater effort to extricate ourselves.

There was a tale told of a Zen master and a nun. It seems the nun suddenly began hallucinating, snakes all over the place, and all over her. They called doctors and other professionals, but to no avail. Then they called a Zen master, and when he came, he told the nun that he could do nothing unless he knew all the details of the snakes

The Factors of Awakening

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min read

In this evening retreat talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma shifts focus from the hindrances to the brighter side of meditation: the seven bojjhaṅga (factors of awakening) and five spiritual faculties (indriya). Beginning with an extended guided meditation on breath awareness, he demonstrates how these factors naturally arise: sati (awareness), dhammavicaya (investigation of Dhamma), vīriya (effort), pīti (interest/joy), passaddhi (tranquillity), samādhi (concentration), and upekkhā (equanimity).

The talk weaves together the spiritual faculties of saddhā (faith), vīriya (energy), sati (awareness), samādhi (concentration) and paññā (wisdom), showing their interconnected development. Bhante addresses the crucial distinction between faith and blind belief, examining three forms of spiritual doubt and their remedies. Drawing on stories of Sāriputta, Ajahn Chah, and the monk Soṇa's vīṇā metaphor from the suttas, he illustrates the delicate balance needed between effort and tranquillity.

Emphasizing that 'Right Awareness' is the controlling factor that leads all others, Bhante concludes that establishing sammā-sati is sufficient for direct insight to arise. This practical teaching offers both newcomers and experienced meditators essential guidance for developing the positive mental factors that support the path to full Awakening.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

Yesterday we tackled some of the worst hindrances we come across in meditation. All hindrances, of course, are as bad as one another. The fact is, every one of us has their own peculiar constellation, and there'll always be one or two that hang on till the end of time. Time governed by the self ends, of course, only with the fully awakened being.

However, what we find is that in *vipassanā*, although they are called hindrances, once they become objects to observe, they unwittingly become aids to our liberation. For by watching the hindrances do we come to understand how suffering arises and how it passes away.

This evening we're going to look at the brighter side of meditation, the factors of enlightenment. And we're going to start with a guided meditation so that you can actually experience these factors. None of them, unfortunately, are wow experiences. They are really quite ordinary states, heightened, no doubt, and directed at a certain investigation, that investigation of our interior life.

So as always, start with the body, energize the spine, get everything to relax and feel comfortable. Settling now on the feeling of the breath in the abdomen. Get in contact with it. Just observe and note it. Rising. Falling. Touching. But feel it. What does it feel like? How would you describe the feeling of it? Hopefully you'll say something like calm, gentle, soft, deep. If so, feel it, acknowledge it. But it could also be tight, coarse, short, unrelaxed. If so, just feel it, acknowledge it. Recognising these qualities is the factor of awareness, that knowing. Stay with these feelings now for a while, and of course, should the mind wander, just note it, what it's getting caught up in, and return to the breath.

Rising. Falling. Touching. Can you feel the calmness of the breath? Or, if it has been tight or agitated, that it's getting calmer? This is the quality of calmness. Perhaps you sense, surrounding these calm sensations, a general feeling of composure, even serenity. This is all the factor of tranquillity. It manifests as calmness in the heart, quietness in the mind and stillness in the body. Become aware of this general tranquillity. Use a noting word such as calm, tranquil.

Now the danger here is that we develop this state for itself. There's nothing to be gained from this on the road to liberation. So we must now bring in another quality to balance it, and that is interest. Let's raise the interest to see more clearly, more precisely, what this process of breathing entails. Let's see if we can distinguish some of the four great elements. Can we become more aware of the quality of movement, the air element, or a gentle pressure, the earth element, or maybe there are feelings of warmth or coolness, the fire element. We might even feel a certain elasticity in the movement, the water element. Use a noting word that you find most appropriate. It doesn't matter what you're aware of. Raise that interest to investigate.

Within the calmness and interest, we may have noticed a greater degree of focus and rise in our energy level. Let's reinforce this now by bringing in a deeper investigation of the Dharma. In the breath, we can become more aware of the quality of impermanence. But approach the breath in the position of don't know or not sure. This means there's no preconceptions in the mind, no prejudice, no expectations, no emotional distortions. This is the quality of equanimity. We need this to clarify our investigation.

So let's look a little more keenly, more deeply. How transient is the breath? Is the breath one thing, or is it made up of little segments? How small are these segments? To begin to see this, we need to be right there when the in-breath begins. Stay with the sensations all the way to the very end. Same with the out-breath. And in the pause, if we are still not steady, then turn our attention onto a touch point. But better if we can stay right there where we feel the breath.

It may be that as you raise the interest to see the quality of transience, the quality of calmness has diminished and you find yourself getting tight. If so, back off for a minute and feel the calmness in the breath. Go back for a while to the beginning of the exercise. Once there's tranquility re-established, restart the investigation. Remind yourself that all we have to do is to watch and observe. We're not trying to see something. We're not looking for something. We're just looking at what we are feeling and experiencing.

As we raised the desire to investigate, so the feeling of interest arose, and with it we were able to focus down, as it were, into the breath. That's another factor, focusing or concentration, being able to be still, to put the attention still on the object. And the only effort you need is to keep it still. This effort is another of the seven factors. It's a gentle but constant flow of energy supporting the interest, not the wish to become concentrated. The only effort needed is just to sharpen the looking, that's the focus, and to hold it there, steady. Let the strength of the attention grow of its own accord because of our interest to investigate the Dharma. Let our intention be simply to see, to feel the sensations, feel the feelings of the breath.

So now, let's begin again and focus in so that we can become more and more aware of the subtler feelings of the breath, the simple sensations. Get into the texture, their softness, perhaps a liquid quality, perhaps warmth, the movement, the ebb and flow, like the sway of the sea. The rise and fall of the in-breath and the out-breath.

So here we are, the body with its energized spine, everything relaxed, manifesting these two factors of effort and tranquility. The breath breathing softly, awareness, the knowing, noting, watching, feeling. The interest held in balance with tranquility rises to investigate the Dharma. Held objectively by equanimity, and the focus coming naturally, and the effort too, raised by our desire to know. So, now that all the factors are there, let's forget all the instructions and everything we've heard. Let's just note and watch, feel and observe, investigate and examine.

So now we have an inkling of this other side of the equation, opposed to all the hindrances. These are the wonderful faculties and qualities we have, even if they do need a little developing.

I want to add to these seven factors of enlightenment the spiritual faculties. The faculties, the *indriya*, are faith, energy, awareness, concentration and wisdom. And the factors of enlightenment, the *bhojanga*, are awareness, investigation of the Dharma, effort, interest, tranquility, concentration and equanimity. I'm going to try and dovetail them so that you get an overall perspective of what we need to develop.

The first and ground of all spiritual qualities is faith. Faith here is not to be confused with belief. If what we mean by belief is an unqualified certainty in a statement, for instance, if I say, I believe in the teachings of the Buddha, there's a danger that I'll never question them, never want to really find out if they're true for me. I bask in the warm comfort of my belief. It can lead to gullibility. We'll believe anything the Buddha said just because he said it. It develops an intellectual deadness, emotional blindness, blind faith, and so on to fundamentalism.

No, what the Buddha meant by *saddhā* was confidence, putting one's trust in, in the same way that we may trust a doctor or a dentist. Faith is a trust which still allows an open, enquiring mind, and that leads to commitment and then to action, to taking the necessary steps. There was the case of Sāriputta, the person whom the Buddha had called the General of the Dharma, recognising him as second only to himself in understanding. Sāriputta declared that the Buddha was the most enlightened being ever. The Buddha asked him how he knew. Now no doubt Sāriputta was taken aback a little. He then explained he had come to intuit this from his own standpoint as a fully liberated being himself.

Yesterday we spoke of sceptical doubt, how this can become an insidious spiritual disease, a mental habit that stops us trusting, stops us committing and so acting. We saw how the reasons can be varied. It may be fear of commitment. Perhaps trust has been betrayed, so that we can't even trust ourselves. Or perhaps an underlying, unacknowledged aversion to religion, or whatever. Usually the person is unaware of the reason, and they justify, rationalize their doubt. They question and discuss only to prove the other wrong, and so justify their position. But the fact is, they never commit themselves to any path. And spiritually, their lives remain arid, infertile and unproductive.

As we have seen, sceptical doubt takes three forms. Doubt in the Buddha and his teachings, doubt in the teacher and doubt in oneself. It does happen that a person begins to doubt the teachings, not only those born into the religion, but even converts. I know of someone who decided after many years that Hinduism was for her. If she had said just that, that would have been understandable. Each of us is drawn in different ways. But she went on to say that Hinduism was a more advanced religion and that

Buddhism only took you so far. That's another matter altogether. And such a statement tells us more about her practice and doubt than anything about the relationship between Buddhism and Hinduism.

It's often true that we join a spiritual path with great expectations, some conceptual idea of what enlightenment is, for instance. And if these are not fulfilled, we can presume there's something wrong with the religion. I don't know what happened to her, but I wouldn't be surprised if she hasn't moved on again. So faith is the ability to trust, but not without discrimination.

So how do we arrive at this confidence in the first place? Well, by *paññā*, wisdom, not one's own, but the wisdom of others. We come to hear the teachings of the Buddha, and we awaken, as it were, to the truth. Faith begins then with some degree of intellectual agreement. It awakens in us some desire for spiritual knowledge. Wonder arises, an honest doubt, as it were. I wonder if it's true. Such a person begins to think about it, mulling it over, until, by their own intellectual effort, they have made it their own understanding. But it's still abstract, still conceptual, still stuck in the head.

If that spiritual desire has been truly awakened, it won't just stop there, but go on to investigate in a real way, they will begin to put into practice what they've come to understand. And this leads to direct experience to true realization of the way things really are. Only then is there any real change in the person. By this time it has become the true wisdom of personal experience. So it is that through these three degrees of received understanding, to personal intellectual understanding, to experiential understanding, that a person comes to realise the way things really are, as it's put in the scriptures. And underpinning these three levels is faith, confidence, trust and commitment.

Then there's that doubt in the teacher. Again, if it's skeptical doubt, based on an habitual inability to trust people, it will be a barrier to following the instructions. When someone suffers from skeptical doubt towards teachers, they say they can't find one, or they always have good reasons for going to someone else. There's a fear of being misled, conned, worse, ending up in a pit. How do we know when to trust someone? Well, this is one of the advantages of working within a tradition. Buddhism, like all world religions, has a long history and many witnesses, both ancient and present, who testify to the validity and effectiveness of the Buddha's teachings. Secondly, the teacher in a particular meditative tradition, such as the Mahāsi tradition, will have teachers themselves who have authorised, approved or encouraged them to teach. And thirdly, because there are other teachers in that tradition, a meditator can always attend their

courses, and by way of comparison feel assured they're getting the teachings of that tradition. But we shouldn't forget that there are honest doubts, and these ought to be cleared up as quickly as possible.

There's also great danger at the other end of the scale, blind faith in a teacher, the my guru infatuation. There was a tale I heard told of Ajahn Chah, a famous Thai teacher. He went off to spend time with someone who had got the reputation of being fully enlightened. After a time, he became fairly convinced. But then one day, he happened to catch his teacher angrily giving a dog a great kick. Now, if you've been to Thai monasteries and suffered the packs of dogs, believe me, you'd have a lot of sympathy for that monk. It seems the dog had got to a choice piece of meat left by a supporter for the monks. Anyway, such anger didn't tally with the concept of *Arahat*, the fully enlightened being, liberated from greed, hatred and delusion. So it seems Ajahn Chah left.

So, be aware. It's always a disappointment to find out that your teacher is not quite the fully enlightened being you thought they were, and that occasionally they can be as stupid as yourself. Mind you, I think it's only natural to put our teachers on a pedestal and feel you have a right to some special intimacy with them. I've certainly done it. I remember I once smiled upon my teacher with that loving devotion of a devotee. To my hurt surprise, he turned away. I still didn't get the message. I placed my seat in front of his in the shrine room, and when I returned, he'd moved his to the other side of the shrine. I shall always be grateful to him for his gentle refusal to play guru.

Now there are people who form such intimate relationships of dependency that even when they're shown proof of criminality, believe it's been a set-up. Of course the guru knows what he's doing. This is not to say that the guru-teacher relationships cannot work. However, the Buddha himself discouraged any feelings of attachment to him, turning him into a guru. There was the case of a young monk who was obviously swooning of him, so he sent him off to the forest. That relationship gets in the way of the path of *gnosis*, the path of understanding. The Buddha's path is one of precise self-investigation and severe purification, as you know. The Buddha is not a guru, but an instructor. That's why in the Zen tradition, meditators are called trainees. The relationship of a trainee to the instructor is one of obedience, a word the modern self hates. Perhaps surrender is easier to understand, or perhaps to follow instructions is easier still. To follow with discrimination, that is.

In other words, all instructions are to be taken on the basis of trial and error. Any attachment to the teacher would get in the way of that clear comprehension. The opposite is true, of course, that the trainee has to see that any aversion towards the instructor is also a loss of impartiality on their part. The trainee should have no difficulty in ques-

tioning the instructions or in constructively criticizing them. The instructor should not be in authority over the trainee. That's to do with power and inspires only fear. They should be an authority for the trainee and inspire respect. A true willingness to follow the instructions given, not the instructor, should be a consequence of this respect.

Finally, there's doubt in oneself. Everyone else can do it. It's me. I just can't do it. I'm a born failure. When that emotional self-hatred, self-pity, low self-esteem, low self-confidence, when any of that arises, don't allow yourself to get caught up in it. How is it we can't believe the Buddha when he says everyone has the potential to become fully awakened and yet be happily prepared to guide our lives with such self-defeating thoughts? Okay, so we may not be spiritual geniuses. So what? There's no time limit put on this. We have as long as it will take. Slowly but surely, we'll advance, step by step. The path is gradual, and for the vast majority of us, very gradual. The Buddha warned us. So for heaven's sake, never put your faith in self-doubt. Don't believe the voices. As always, listen, feel, observe, experience and come to understand and affirm our natural human ability. I am able to become liberated. I ought to become fully awakened for my own sake and the sake of others. I want to, and I will become a fully awakened being.

So dealing with doubt is part of growing in faith. Until with that glimpse of the end of the path, we actually know for sure that the end of suffering is truly attainable. Upon reaching the first path and fruit, that of *sotapanna*, stream entry as it is called, this faith, now based upon the direct experience of *Nibbāna*, becomes unshakable and is known as a power, *bala*. That faith has become a conviction based on personal experience. No more doubt as to the efficacy of the Buddha's teaching can arise again. Nor will there be any doubt as to the path leading to the final end of all our struggles.

Now *paññā*, this faculty of wisdom, which has grown along with faith, the one supporting the other, is an active, intuitive intelligence. And it is in this mode that it is included in the factors of enlightenment, the investigation of dharma, *dhammavicaya*. Here it needs a further support, and this is equanimity, *upekkhā*. Equanimity is even-mindedness, impartiality and suggests a calmness in the heart and non-attachment to what is going on. We expect judges to have both the wisdom and the equanimity factors highly developed. They're supposed to stand above the emotions of the crowd and not be fooled by the clever arguments of the lawyers. This is the attitude we have to have to all our interior life, if *paññā*, our intuitive intelligence, is going to see things as they really are.

So equanimity produces that ability to receive, to accept, to acknowledge without fear or favour, not distorted by anger and prejudice. It is the basic quality of the open heart and clear mind.

Supporting this pair, the heart, our emotional base, has to be both tranquil and yet joyous. Tranquility, *passaddhi*, is that sense of calm and contentment, a peaceful heart. *Pīti* here is the joy of interest. Just think how happy we are when we're doing something we're really interested in. But the enemy of this spiritual joy is excitement. And excitement will immediately begin to corrupt the whole process once we've allowed some idea of getting, achieving, attaining to enter the practice. And that's what tranquility does. It keeps that joyous interest from becoming excited.

But tranquility also harbours a danger, and that's to draw us into a lovely, floaty, calm state, the land of lotus eaters. Well, it's all very beautiful, but where's it leading us? We don't realise where it's leading us till we come out of it, and we find it's leading us nowhere but to an attachment for that impermanent delight, yet another path to unsatisfactoriness. So again, it's all to do with balance. We need to develop calmness with a highly engaged interest.

Finally, there's the pair, which are both faculties and factors, effort and concentration. Concentration is a word which conjures up for us struggle, head down, knitted brow. Perhaps a better word is focus. It's the collected mind, a mind unscattered. It draws all the light in the mind into a laser beam, so to speak. The energy is simply that needed to bring this about. If we think of a camera, it can focus, concentrate on something near or far, and the motor which turns the lenses is the energy needed to get the focus we want. Once we've got the right focus, we can take the picture. We can note, feel, observe, experience and come to understand. We can't do it if the focus is fuzzy or intermittent. We've got to be able to hold that focus, and that's what this pair of concentration and effort do.

Again, they've got to be balanced. If there's more energy about than is needed, then that extra energy dissipates into restlessness. If we investigate the reasons for this, we may find the extra energy to be empowered by self-centered desire. That same old problem of wanting to achieve something. Adversely, it may be that there's a lack of energy because the self isn't getting what it wants, so it gets bored and fed up. Whatever, we'll need to spend time calming and re-centering ourselves.

If the concentration is well developed and there's not enough energy to support it, then we fall into a state of unconsciousness. This isn't the same as sleep as such. When this happens to a meditator, the body remains quite still in position. When we're suffering from sloth, as I'm sure you all know, the body bobs up and down and occasionally collapses. The other sign is that when the meditator wakes up, as it were, they're fully bright.

This combination of focus and effort is well illustrated by the story of Soṇa. He knew himself to be one of the disciples exceptional in effort but he became discouraged by the lack of progress in his practice and decided to leave, build up a family and gather lots of good *kamma*. The Buddha by his supranormal powers came to know what he was thinking and appeared next to him. He embarrassed poor Soṇa by telling him what he was thinking of doing. He then asks if he played a *vīṇā* as a layperson. When the strings of your *vīṇā* were too taut, was your *vīṇā* in tune and playable? No, Lord, Soṇa replied. And when the strings of your *vīṇā* were too loose, was your *vīṇā* in tune and playable? No, Lord, Soṇa replied again. But when the strings of your *vīṇā* were neither too taut nor too loose, but tuned at the right pitch, was your *vīṇā* in tune and playable? Yes, Lord. In the same way, Soṇa, too much energy and effort leads to restlessness. Overly slack effort and energy leads to laziness. Therefore, you should determine the right pitch of your energy and effort. This of course Soṇa did and in no longer time attained and remained in that supreme goal of the holy life.

So how do we do this? Well the trick that works for me is to let go of worrying about effort and trying to concentrate. Instead to draw my energies into raising interest and just watching. Consider, did you ever have any problems with concentration and effort when you were interested in something?

Finally there is *sati*, awareness. Now if there's one word which encapsulates the whole of the Buddha's teachings, at least in terms of the practice, it's got to be this one, *sati*, awareness. The establishing of this level of consciousness as a constant is the path to enlightenment. Indeed, to establish right awareness for one moment is to be awakened in that moment, though not fully mind. This, in fact, is all we're trying to do throughout this course, to put ourselves into *sammāsati*, helped by whatever technique possible, and to try to maintain it.

In *Vipassana Guidelines*, I've brought together various definitions that other teachers use. I can't remember now where I got them all from, but for me they come as close as you can get with words to describe what *sati* is. It is a bare attentiveness, simply watching all that arises and passes away. Now this is shorthand for the three characteristics. Impermanence is only one of them, and perhaps the most obvious to most people. But as we observe the transient nature of all phenomena we also come to see how suffering arises and passes away and how the self, the sense of self also arises and passes away.

It's a choiceless awareness. It doesn't choose what to observe, it just sits back as if in a cinema and just watches the show. It wants to understand the body, heart and mind as they really are, not as it would wish them to be, or thought they were. To do this, *sati* is an impartial observation. It's not judging, questioning, taking sides. It's not partisan.

It's not coming from a fixed position, a view, an opinion. It's not biased or prejudiced. And when consciousness can so lift itself out of the morass of the psychophysical organism, it sets something free within itself. That enormous intelligence. The intuitive intelligence which we all have and which will lead itself eventually out of all suffering.

This intelligence isn't to be confused with cleverness. The cleverest are sometimes quite unwise. This intelligence is intuitive. It sees or it doesn't see. It is immediate. Words, concepts, emotions, moods, all distort its vision. That's why the purification of the heart and mind has to go hand in hand with the process of enlightenment.

It is this power of *paññā*, intuitive intelligence, that sees things as they really are. And it does it in an environment of *sati*, awareness, which paradoxically fully experiences every physical, emotional and mental event. It would be logical to think that if we detach ourselves from our emotions, looked at them as it were from a distance, that we wouldn't be able to feel them so much. But to our surprise, when we set ourselves in the mode of *satipaññā*, we feel emotions, sensations and thoughts in a very direct, intimate way.

It's a general experience of the newcomer to *vipassanā* that they suddenly experience the sense bases more keenly. Suddenly the sky really is blue. One meditator said it was the first time they'd ever really tasted potatoes. And how strong our emotional life is felt, and how we become aware of the chattering masses in our own mind.

What the Buddha discovered then was the awakening role of pure consciousness, its ability to free itself from the body, heart and mind, once it could perch itself firmly onto the post of observation. And he came to see that this *sammāsati*, this right awareness, was a controlling factor. It acted like the lead goose in a flight of geese. As it soared ahead, so the others followed. Right on its flanks flew interest and tranquility. They were further supported by right concentration and effort. And right behind awareness sits intuitive intelligence, itself supported by faith on the one flank and equanimity on the other. At any moment, this intelligence *paññā* can dart forth, as it were, and take a momentary lead. That ability to intuit the way things really are is always there as potential whenever right awareness is established.

So now, having gone through all the five *indriya*, the spiritual faculties, and the seven *bhojanga*, the factors of enlightenment, we've come to a point where we realize it was all unnecessary. All we have to do is establish right awareness and everything follows suit. The Buddha says it is enough to establish just that mindfulness so that direct insight can arise. So in a sense we can forget virtually everything I've just said and I feel a little embarrassed having wasted your time.

We can of course use this knowledge skillfully. We should eventually be able to pinpoint whatever imbalance there is in our meditation. It may be one of the hindrances, but it could also be that there's just not enough effort, not enough concentration, too much effort, too much concentration, and so on. And here we would try to address the imbalance. This is all part of learning how to meditate, how to become more skillful in maintaining moment-to-moment mindfulness.

So let's pause here for a moment. One of the teachers in the order I belong to, who was the chief monk at the Lanka Meditation Centre in Colombo, and now has a park-like monastery near Kandaboda, which is the meditation centre I stayed in, once gave me this apt metaphor. He said that awareness was like a dewdrop on the end of a leaf, and the sun couldn't shine through it because it was all murky with dust, the dust it had collected while rolling down that leaf. If all the dirt could be removed, then the sun would shine through brightly. The dewdrop is, of course, our awareness and the sun, *Nibbāna*. So our job is to purify awareness and this is done by simply observing whatever arises within the field of that awareness. How simple!

Now I say simple, but we discover it's no easy thing to do. And that's why we've all come here for a week of hard sweatshop, to labour unceasingly at removing the dross, the accumulations of, dare we believe it, lifetimes of unskilful behaviour. But all is not darkness. We do have good qualities, wonderful qualities, and it's these we are developing at enormous speed when we undergo a special training like this. So take heart. The path is long, but there are many delights on the way. For instance, think of the ecstasy you'll feel when this course is over.

Remember Socrates, the unexamined life is not worth living. Here's the Buddha from the Dhammapada, a collection of sayings. Only foolish and ignorant people indulge mindlessness. The wise guard their mindfulness as the greatest of all treasures.

May your unflagging devotion to the development of all the faculties and factors of enlightenment bear great fruit. May you be fully awakened sooner rather than later.

The Pleasure Syndrome: Understanding Dukkha Through Paṭicca Samuppāda

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min read

In this profound evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the psychological mechanism by which pleasure becomes a source of dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness). Drawing from the Buddha's teaching of Paṭicca Samuppāda (Dependent Origination), he traces the chain from initial contact (phassa) through feeling (vedanā) and craving (taṇhā) to grasping (upādāna) and becoming (bhava).

Using the relatable example of eating toast, Bhante demonstrates how we construct elaborate mental worlds around simple sensory experiences, leading to identification, addiction, and ultimately suffering. He explains how the "pleasure syndrome" operates not just with basic sensual pleasures but extends to all worldly pursuits—fame, power, wealth—and even refined aesthetic and spiritual experiences.

The talk addresses the crucial distinction between experiencing pleasure and indulging in it, showing how Right Awareness (sammā sati) allows us to enjoy life's pleasures without falling into the vicious cycles of craving, frustration, and fear. This teaching offers practical guidance for retreat practitioners learning to observe their reactions to pleasant experiences without being enslaved by them.

Suitable for those with some meditation experience who wish to deepen their understanding of how mental formations create suffering and how vipassanā practice can reveal the path to true contentment beyond sensual happiness.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasah. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasah. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasah. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So now we've managed to get through the fourth day. The first three days were bad. Blood, sweat and tears. If you think about it, how else could it have been? In one wild axe we cut through old habits and established new ones. That's always got to be painful in itself. Never mind the difficulty of the posture and so on. It's a bit like finding yourself in the army, or worse, a prison, subjected to a new regime. Here, of course, willingly so.

We all of us have particular, perhaps peculiar habits. We get up at a certain time, sleep for a certain amount, have breakfast at this time, not that, and so on. And what we find is that if our habits are disturbed in any way, there's always the pain of dislocation. If there's a good reason, we don't mind. We take it with good heart. But if there's no reason, or rather we don't see a good reason, we get irritable and bolshie.

When we come into spiritual training, we always find there's a routine to get used to. And for the most part, it's always training with other people. It's difficult also because we're stuck in our ways. To change our habits is to loosen us up a bit. So these past three days have been a sort of spiritual boot camp. From now on, I hope, you begin to feel a relaxation, an ease with the rhythm of the course, and a lessening of gross physical pain caused by the posture. But more, I hope that you've accommodated psychologically, and no longer find yourself struggling with, or at worst against, the schedule.

So now, the other great problem arises. Up till now, we've had to deal with pain in all its variegated form. From now on, I think you'll find there will arise moments of ease, even pleasure and delight. I'm not saying to expect it, but it may just come up, and here we can fall into the grave error of negligence and indulgence. Remember, the purpose of *vipassanā* on a psychological level is to take the suffering out of pain and the indulgence out of pleasure and see if there is a relationship with the world beyond all that which is actually more satisfying indeed, rewarding.

We need then to understand the pleasure syndrome and to be convinced intellectually that happiness, true contentment is not to be found there indeed, cannot be found there. *Nibbāna* has to be something other than sensual, mental or emotional worlds that can be so enjoyable.

This brings us to the psychological paradigm that the Buddha discovered known as Dependent Origination or perhaps better Interdependent Origination, the *Paṭicca Samuppāda*. Some of you will have seen the representation of this in the Tibetan picture called The Wheel of Dependent Origination. Here, I shall only be concerned with the part that relates specifically to the problem of indulgence and suffering, and I shall indicate the Pali terms for those who are familiar with this teaching.

The Buddha begins by pointing out that at root the problem is one of ignorance. It is from this position of not knowing that we presume to know, and our presumptions become our delusions. And it is according to our deluded understanding that we live out our lives, causing distressful, occasionally anguished cycles of behaviour.

The first thing about pleasure is that it brings delight. An obvious statement, no doubt, but herein lies the whole problem. Now take toast. I've yet to meet someone who doesn't like toast. Some like it hot, some cold, some soggy. Some with marmalade, others with honey. Most with anything. But up until now, I'm of the opinion that all human beings love toast.

When delicious toast falls upon the tongue, all that happens is certain chemical and electrical signals are passed on into the brain, and the first percepts are simple and basic. At this level, known as contact, *phassa*, the mind perceives only hot and cold, sweet and sour, and so on. It's not until there's been a moment of digestion in the mind itself that definitions such as toast arise, and with them all the memories of scrumptious times and warm kitchens going back all the way to childhood, the great British breakfast. All these connections go to build up, around that initial taste, a glorious euphoria. This is the level of feeling, *vedanā*, and it includes other mental attributes, such as perception and memory.

Once this glorious state has arisen, there comes the desire to get into it. Now that's the greed, that's the *taṇhā*. But what is this *taṇhā*, this greed, this craving? It is just that wanting to indulge. The judgmental mind arises, this is good, this is wonderful. How amazing that a simple piece of toast can create such a glorious interior environment. I'm so happy. This is the life.

Now I hope that during meal times you're getting into contact very clearly with this mental state. Hold for a while a tantalizing morsel just in front of your mouth and really experience that craving, that wanting to snap at it and gobble it all up.

As soon as *taṇhā* has arisen, as soon as the craving for a pleasure has arisen, the next moment is one of identification. I am this desire. I am this delight. There's no objectivity. There's no separation between the enjoying and the enjoyer. They become unified. I, me, want toast. Now this is called *upādāna*, grasping.

What follows is the action, *bhava*, a gluttonous dance, the actual indulgence, and that's the moment when this whole process has been empowered by will, *cetanā*, and in so doing *kamma* is created and the habit is reinforced. The habit not just of indulging in toast, if that isn't bad enough, but of the whole deluded understanding that happiness, true contentment is to be found in sensual pleasure.

So let's review these kernel links on the wheel of dependent origination where the Buddha points out we continue to reinforce our delusions and so cause ourselves continuous suffering. First there is the initial contact with the object. Here, although we're just talking about the sense of taste, it doesn't simply refer to the five senses but to the

internal senses of the mind. It's the same syndrome when we're indulging in fantasies or daydreaming. This initial contact refers simply to the primary stimuli that come into consciousness, that we become aware of. As for the sense of taste, the five flavours as enumerated by the Chinese tradition seem to be apt: sweet and sour, salty, bitter and astringent. All, or some of these, are worked into a concept in the mind and there's a recognition. Toast.

Now this *phassa* refers only to initial contact. By the way, at times it is useful to know the Pali words. It is true of translation from any language that one cannot entirely grasp a foreign word with all its meanings and nuances in another language. That is why I would like to introduce you in this course to key words. But you don't have to learn Pali to make spiritual progress. Thank heavens for that, or I'd give up now myself.

This contact is very basic. With the eyes, it is simply colour and shape before it takes on any meaning. With hearing, it is the volume, pitch, tone, quality and movement of sound before any tune or recognisable speech. If you think it's not possible, just repeat a word to yourself like banana and keep doing it concentrating just on the sound. And I think you will find that soon enough, it really does become a nonsensical sound. Banana. Banana. Banana. Banana.

At the very base of this contact, *phassa*, are the four great elements. Earth, the qualities of hard and soft; water, the quality of cohesiveness, elasticity, stickiness; fire, the qualities of heat and cold; and finally air, the qualities of movement and stillness. It would seem the ancients, including the Greeks, thought that they were the building blocks of the universe. From a spiritual insight point of view, whether they are or not is not relevant. What we are experiencing is how we, the mind, contacts the world, and how from these initial stimuli, or impulses, we create a world.

And remember, how we contact the world is dependent not only on the stimuli coming at us such as light, but on the receptive sense, the I. What a person who is colorblind sees is not the same as someone with ordinary sight. The world we live in is of our own making. We construct it from this initial contact, from stimuli, from the sense base and from a primary cognition, a recognition of it.

Now what is important about this level of perception is that there is as yet no distortion by way of thought, past experience or emotional value. That's why the sensations of the breath are so important in our practice. They are neutral and so they don't have great historical, emotional or conceptual value. So we can easily see the simple qualities of movement. And to see movement in detail is to begin to experience radical transi-

ence. Radical impermanence. Everything really is arising and passing away. A sensation appears and then disappears completely. And to perceive transience at the profoundest level is to be liberated.

So although we've centered on toast, and I owe it to my teacher, Sayuru Janaka, to see the process of eating as a very wonderful opportunity to experience all this, we can take this investigation into every moment of our lives. When hearing a bird or a car passing, or the wind in the trees, when looking at a flower or the landscape or the shrine, when smelling the aromas of food or of the incense, when feeling the points of contact in movement, both in formal walking meditation and simple actions such as feeling the sheets before you pull them back and rise from the bed. We can say that this is our work, to get down to this level of perception. Bury yourself in the body. Once this level of perception is clarified, then all the steps to building a world begin to reveal themselves. And what is important to us is that we see clearly how we mess things up. Things can be so much better.

So that is the point of contact. And that brings me back to the piece of toast. As soon as this recognition, it is toast, occurs, all our memories, conceptual and emotional, around toast engender an emotional response. That interior atmosphere of pleasurable joy, an internal environment of delight, this is *vedanā*, feeling. It's not that we need to remember actual memories, though I dare say, if we set to it, we could write a book, *The Memoirs of a Toasterholic*.

Now *vedanā* refers to feeling, all feeling. We're lucky in English because the word feeling covers virtually all the meaning of *vedanā*. We say, I feel the wind on my cheeks, the sun on my face, and I'm not feeling well. All this refers to sensations in the body, physical feelings. But we also say, I feel sad, I feel happy, a great emotional feeling came over me. This obviously refers to our heart life. So *vedanā*, feeling, refers to everything we feel: sensations, feelings, moods and emotions. And unsurprisingly, they can be divided into pleasant, unpleasant and neutral feelings.

Returning again to our mystical toast, once this inner environment of pleasant feelings has arisen, then there is what might be called a movement within the mind, an attraction, a drawing towards, all of which has the flavour of wanting, desiring, craving, a desire to sink into it, to immerse. That's *taṇhā*, craving, the desire to indulge. Again, *taṇhā* is more than indulgence. It is how we react to what is pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. Towards the pleasant, there is that reaction of wanting. Towards the unpleasant, of not wanting. And towards the neutral, of ignoring it. We ignore neutral feelings because desire seeks something stimulating. We need to be very alert to catch these reactions, and that's also very much our job.

As we shall see later, if we can hold the process to this point, we are in the best position for a dharma insight, a spiritual insight. Now once this point of feeling, *vedanā*, has arisen, then there's that sudden collapse into identification. I, the self, want that. Me, I want it. That's the grasping link, *upādāna*, on the wheel of dependent origination. This is the moment we lose objectivity. From now on we are ensnared in the desire, compulsive behaviours, addictions, and so on, and nothing can stop what happens next.

Once there is that identification with want, we become two-year-olds. The whole desire is impulsed with energy. And before we know it, we empower that desire. We make a decision, often quite unintentionally, compulsively, impulsively. Will, *cetanā*, arises to bring into fruition that desire of self. I become *bhava*, I become a toast eater. How crucial that moment is. Whenever we do something, create an action, be it of a thought, word or deed, we bring an idea, a desire, out of mere potential into the actual. This is the moment of becoming, on the dependent origination. This is the moment when we create *kamma*. This is the moment when we exercise the power of will.

The toast is eaten with blind gusto, eyes shut with little low guttural gruntings. Now surely it is obvious how the simple indulgence in a harmless piece of toast can gather such emotional commitment and physical momentum that the act turns to addiction, even to self-destruction. Such can be the path of a toast devotee. However, oh the misery of it, pleasure decreases while craving increases, and we find ourselves in a spiral of famished dissatisfaction.

We have a great party of Thanksgiving to toast. We all agree to have another, but it never lives up to the promise. There's always that desire for one more, but that second piece never lives up to the promise of the first, especially as we come close to the end of our proper physical appetite, and we begin to feel we've overeaten with all the unpleasant feelings that arise. Our greed is always greater than our need. This is the inbuilt obsolescence of pleasure. Even though we adore toast, we can have too much of a good thing.

So the saying goes, why is it that the same pleasure source can't give us the same continuous buzz? Take horror movies. Many people like the thrill of being frightened. Not really frightened, of course. Pretend fright. But you can see from the vast variety of horror movies how writers have to be ever more creative and horrifying to maintain the level of buzz. When we see those old Frankenstein movies, we can't help but chuckle. Poor old Frankenstein with that bolt through his neck. We become bored so quickly and then starts the search for variety, for distraction. Variety is the spice of life. Well, it is, isn't it? If life is the pursuit of happiness in pleasure.

Until now, we've been fairly basic in our idea of pleasure, basic sensual pleasures. But this refers to all pleasure, even the most refined, artistic, aesthetic pleasures, even the most ecstatic, elevated, exalted states of spiritual bliss. It's all worldly pleasure, as far as the Buddha's concerned. And any indulgence in it will bring about that characteristic vicious cycle of delight, satisfaction, boredom, search for variety, delight, satisfaction, boredom, search for variety, and so on. And what we find is that the more we indulge desire, the greater the attachment, the greater the addiction.

Herein lies another angle on our delusive states. It is only when our addiction is fulfilled do we feel normal. Let's consider that. Taking an obvious case of the drug addict. So long as there's craving, the addict feels out of balance, in a state of suffering, agitated, ready to commit crimes. But when they're drugged up, they feel fine. It wouldn't occur to them to commit a crime. They're happy, fulfilled.

And that's what happens to us, isn't it? We open the fridge door, and there's no milk. No milk for tea. A spat of anger. We look around for someone to blame. Then the depression. The awful thought of having to drink tea without milk. No way. Better to suffer a dash to the shops. Suddenly we're rushing down the streets for a bottle of milk. Rushing. Why? Anger. Desire. And all to get that feeling of well-being, of happiness in pleasure, from a cup of tea.

Perhaps this syndrome can more easily be seen in the way humans behave sexually. When sexual happiness becomes just an end in itself, then again there is this underlying belief that happiness is to be found in raw physical pleasures of sex. The Kama Sutra, the Indian text that goes into all sorts of erotic postures, is yet another manifestation of how the human heart spins off into addiction, an insatiable desire for more. But like anything else, the same old routines become boring. The Kama Sutra is an expression of a very bored and occupied ruling caste. When ordinary sex becomes boring, there's a search for sex with a difference, kinky sex, fetishisms. This soon gets boring too, and kinkiness may turn to deviation, and the fall into crime is always possible.

It's not just compulsive tea drinkers and drug addicts and sexual obsessives, but anyone who is lost in the four great worldly pursuits: all the pleasures of life, fame, power and riches. What else does the self want? I wants to be famous, powerful, rich and have any pleasure it wants right there at its fingertips. Just think of all those people we give power to, the media barons, the multinational executives, the prime ministers. Just think of all those we adulate, the film stars, pop stars, sports stars, and pay out of our noses to satisfy. Just think of how we allow people to amass ridiculous fortunes, the Bill

Gates of this world. Why do we, as a society, allow such grossness? We need only examine ourselves and see how much our own lives are driven by these same self-driven desires.

Sometimes if we're truthful with ourselves we shall catch ourselves in some dark fantasy and then we can see how desire unchecked that has become an addiction so easily leads to crime. When desire is unsatisfied, frustration, anger and self-righteousness arise, and then into robbery, violence, murder, and what have you, sometimes on a massive national scale. It's frightening when we look back at human history to acknowledge how destructive this essential delusion has been, this delusion that we can find happiness in pleasure. Indeed, it leads to criminal insanity. What else would you call Stalin, Hitler, Pol Pot and such like, and all their myriad cronies, but criminally mad? So much of this terrible destruction comes about because of frustration. The anger we feel when we don't get what we want. That awful little vicious circle. I want, can't, will have. How easily a seemingly harmless desire can turn into a nasty aggression.

Little children are wonderful at manifesting this one. They get angry when they can't get what they want and when they really can't get what they want, they cry. If the vicious circle of desire, desire frustrated and violence fails, then there's nothing for it but to spin off into depression and self-pity.

Worse, underneath all this, is fear. Fear of loss, fear of change. The more we treasure an object, anything we become attached to, the more we fear its loss. Hence the locked door. Hence the worry that the car might be stolen. It's not that such fears aren't legitimate, there are thieves about. But even if there weren't, there'd still be the fear of the possible loss of pleasure. Remember here, pleasure refers to anything, anything at all, that brings us delight.

Take hearing and all it means in terms of human communication and the joy of sound. What a loss that would be! As soon as we have an earache, especially if we haven't had one for ages, suddenly fear arises. Could this be serious enough to make me deaf? Can you imagine the feelings of Beethoven as he began to realize that his hearing was going? What a mortification! Not that he allowed such a catastrophe in any way to diminish his work. And that's the point. Those who have lost their hearing, once accommodated, find it does not undermine the quality of their lives. Indeed, they find other treasures.

Now this fear of the loss of treasured things is so great that a huge industry of insurance is built up around it, costing billions of pounds, trillions. Why? Because the self needs to protect itself against loss, with all the anger, grief and despair that it brings. Self has created a little island unto itself and must guard its possessions against the rest

of the whole universe. It's only when you join a large community such as a monastic sangha that you realize that it need not be like that. It is through shared responsibility that so much of this emotional pain can be dissolved.

In Islam, the community is of utmost importance, the Ummah. Muhammad, after all, lived right there in the midst of community and taught people to help each other bear the unfortunate vicissitudes of life. When the Buddha established the Sangha, almost everything was to be held in community, shared. But it does mean that the self has to let go of this idea of mine and begin to move towards ours. Such behaviour leads to a lessening of that self. And remember, the less we have of self, the greater is our true happiness.

For it is happiness that we're searching for all the time. Psychologically, the whole of our life's effort is to find happiness. Think about it. Even in the most terrible circumstances, we're searching for happiness. The person in pain seeks relief. The person in prison seeks distraction, seeks release. Even if we were tied up to a chair, we'd spend our time trying to find the most comfortable position. But the whole search is a wild goose chase and we find ourselves revolving around this cycle of desire, frustration and grief. But worse, when it all gets too much, there's a downward spiral into despair and that ultimate dark desire to escape it all, suicide.

I remember the story of an Australian property tycoon not many years ago now. The bottom fell out of the property market and he committed suicide. A friend who found she was going blind began to consider suicide. I'm sure you all have similar examples. Perhaps you yourself have suffered such situations.

So the question is, is there a way out of all this? Is there something better? Well, that's the message of the Buddha. That's his good news. There is a way of relating to the world, to the world of pleasure, in a way that doesn't bring suffering, and the kernel of that understanding lies in that area of indulgence.

During this time on retreat we have an excellent opportunity to see how this whole syndrome works, how it is that indulging in pleasure brings dissatisfaction, and how it could be that without indulgence, pleasure can be enjoyed, can be appreciated, can be experienced simply as delightful. We can't live in this world as human beings without experiencing pleasure. Pleasures are a given. It's our natural heritage. It is simply how we experience some of the contact we have with our environment and our inner selves. So the teachings of the Buddha has nothing to do with getting rid of pleasure.

He himself talks in this way to Ananda, his cousin, and a close companion for the last 20 years of his life. After going on alms round he would say, let's go to a beautiful shrine. Why? Why should he ask to go to a beautiful shrine? Why not a dung heap or a desert? Or just any old shrine? Why beautiful? And he even names a few. The Buddha obviously appreciated beauty, but did he indulge in it? Did he define the measure of his happiness by it?

How can we be with pleasure in a non-indulgent way and still enjoy it? Wouldn't that be amazing? We'd have our cake and eat it. We'd be able to enjoy pleasure and not have to suffer any of the vicious cycles of frustration, grief, fear and so on. Well, we can. And what's more, we find we can enjoy things even more fully. And it's all in the magic of *satipaṇṇā*, a level of consciousness which directly experiences and yet is not caught up in that experience. That's why it's so important to discover what that level of consciousness is and how to maintain it.

Consider, when we are governed by desire, doesn't that desire define for us what is pleasurable? A friend asks you to a meal and says they'll cook spaghetti. There in your mind right away is the thought of a plate of delicious spaghetti and perhaps all the delight of a Tuscan holiday. You look forward to it. But what's offered is a plate of Heinz 57th variety. On toast. Of course, one is polite. But it would be a hard task to cover one's disappointment. Now, actually, Heinz 57th is OK. I mean, it's edible, and if you're really hungry, it's more than palatable. But as you eat it at your friend's, there's just a mild disgust with it, and the mind's full of horror stories about additives.

Isn't it the same with anything? Desire creates expectation, and that expectation cramps the real experience, blinds one to real experience. This judgmental mind, based on the skewed appreciation of what self likes and does not like, divides the whole of experience into black and white. I saw a tree expert on TV once. He was full of the glories of trees. Then he came upon a copper beech, and this disgust started pouring out of him. Words like disgusting, filthy, ugly started to come up. How can you be passionately hateful of a tree?

To get out of this pleasure-indulgence syndrome we need to exercise precise awareness and on a course of this nature we can begin to see clearly how the self traps itself if we watch carefully what happens whenever pleasure arises. To distinguish between the pleasurable feelings and the desire for them, to really catch that moment, to feel the desire to indulge, to really feel it and then to wait till it passes. And when it's passed, to taste the food. What is the experience of tasting food without previous expectation, without craving? To taste food just as it is, not as we would like it to be.

What sort of mental state arises when we are experiencing something delightful and not indulging in it? And how do we experience that state? Is there identification with it, or is it like being with someone or another person who is happy? The difference between someone who identifies with pleasure and someone who is with their experience of pleasure, as with a good friend, is aptly put by a tale told of my favourite author, Samuel Beckett.

Some of you may know his work, perhaps the most famous, *Waiting for Godot*. His work could be described as one long meditation on decay and death, but always with a wonderful, ironic humour. He was out walking with a friend in some beautiful countryside in France where he lived. His friend was overwhelmed and exclaimed, Oh, what beauty! and then asked, Doesn't it make you want to live? And Beckett, after a characteristic pause, replied, Well, I wouldn't want to go that far.

Now, as always, there are two processes we need to go through. The seeing is *sam-mādiṭṭhi* on the Eightfold Path, its correct view, right understanding. Listening to this talk, I hope you are at least partly intellectually convinced by the arguments. Later, your own thoughts about this matter may arise. But please, don't make an effort to think. That you can do after the course. But as you sit in meditation, you can begin to experience at first hand these physical and mental events. And then we realize that we can't do anything about it. To push them away would be to suppress them.

So the second process is to leave the emotions of craving alone and let them arise and pass away. This is the level of psychotherapy. If the first process of understanding and seeing is psychoanalysis, the second is psychotherapy. Both are needed. The one to clarify our understanding, and the second to allow the heart to heal itself. And it is in suffering, in bearing gladly these emotions, desire, grasping, frustration, grief, fear, that we come to realize directly for ourselves how much suffering we cause ourselves through acts of indulgence. This is the spiritual insight, the dharma insight, into the characteristic of suffering, *dukkha*.

And it's only when we suffer the consequences of our delusions and when we really see how suffering arises and passes away that we find the resolution to overcome the habitual temptations of our cravings. That's the reason spiritually for bearing with the mental distress, for developing the virtue of forbearance, of endurance. This is to allow the suffering to express itself and to remain fully conscious of it. It chisels into the understanding the consequences of unskillful behaviour, so that the fear, the dread of those consequences, outbalances the strength of any craving. There was a friend's father who said he couldn't give up smoking, that is, until he had a heart attack.

Let's pause here for a moment. So, we've looked at the process whereby we create conditionings around pleasure, the role of contact, feeling, desire and craving, grasping and identifying, and finally the act, the becoming, the creation of *kamma* of our conditioning. Now, in our meditation, we can direct our attention at the mental, emotional and physical processes within us to realize all this for ourselves. But be careful not to get caught up in thinking about it. It will take us away from the direct experience. The purpose of this talk is to convince you intellectually enough so that you really want to investigate this matter for yourself. I hope it's left you with a burning desire to maintain that moment-to-moment mindfulness. Yes, not all desire is self-based and deluded. Desires also arise out of our fundamental nature, the desire for true happiness and freedom from suffering. That sort of desire leads us to the end of wrong desires, so we should follow it. When we finally reach the end of suffering, then there will be no need for such desires.

Indeed, it is the very absence of sense desire, wrong desire, that the Buddha calls *Nibbāna*. In the Dhammapada, the Buddha says, Whoever gives up desire for sense pleasures, whoever renounces worldly ambitions, whoever abandons seeking comfort in the world, they destroy that desire for happiness in sensual pleasure and becoming. Such a one is a brahmana, a fully liberated being. I pray your incisive perceptions into the horrors of indulgence may cut asunder the delusions of craving, and that you may achieve the great liberation from all suffering, sooner rather than later.

The Characteristic of Impermanence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min read

In this profound dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines anicca (impermanence), the first of the three fundamental characteristics of existence that the Buddha identified as sources of our delusion. Drawing from cosmic scales—galaxies and stars—down to the microscopic level of moment-to-moment sensations, he reveals how everything without exception exists in constant flux.

The talk addresses our tendency to focus on the arising of new phenomena while remaining blind to their passing away, creating what he calls the "illusion of continuity." Bhante emphasizes how contemplating death, aging, and sickness serves as a spiritual protection, undermining the ego's grip and revealing the groundless fear that drives much of our suffering. He explores how this contemplation, rather than leading to despair, opens us to the preciousness of each moment.

Referencing the Dhammapada's teaching that "all conditioned things are impermanent," Bhante shows how deep insight into transience can lead to stream-entry, the first stage of awakening. The talk concludes with William Blake's mystical poetry, illustrating how an awakened being relates to the world—kissing joy as it flies rather than binding it, thus living in "eternity's sunrise." This teaching offers both philosophical depth and practical guidance for developing vipassanā insight through observing the arising and passing of phenomena in meditation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

Over the past couple of days, we've concentrated on suffering. Not simply how physical and mental pain cause suffering, but how pleasure does so. Now, see how I phrased that? It's wrong, isn't it? Nothing causes us to suffer, but the relationship we have to what we experience. In other words, it's not pain that is the primary cause of our suffering, but our aversion to it, our fear of it. Pleasures and joy do not cause suffering, but our indulgence and dependence on them does.

We have to be very careful how we use language. In what we say, how we say, is contained our view of things. So just by picking ourselves up on a simple slip such as, "this headache is unbearable," "I can't stand these people," "these politicians make me sick" – just by catching the way we talk about things and people, we can correct our view. Eventually, the penny will drop. There will be a change of heart.

Now there's an expression which tells us how things happen at the psychological and spiritual level. It's not good enough to understand the Dharma. It's not even good enough to be convinced of the Dharma. We have to work so that the correct view, the Dharma, begins to bring a change of heart. That's why in the Eightfold Path, after the number one, Right View, there comes Right Attitude. Then only does Right Speech, Right Action and Right Livelihood follow. But we need to start somewhere, and that's to correct our view.

Now the Buddha tells us that we have three fundamental delusions about the way things really are. He puts it to us directly. No fudging. This is the way it is. He declares that not seeing the three characteristics of existence clearly causes our lives to be unsatisfactory, if not downright unbearable. The first two concern everything that has existence, and one pertains only to sentient beings, and that includes us, human beings. These three characteristics are impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self or insubstantiality.

The unsatisfactoriness is this suffering we create. That's *dukkha*. Dukkha means in itself a hard place. That's life. As the comedian said, "Life's hard and then you die." Again, translating from other languages never quite makes it. And dukkha has such a breadth of meaning, books are written about it. In fact, if we take the Buddha's own pithy description of his teachings – "I teach only dukkha and the end of dukkha" – it really does become the biggest word in the Buddha Dhamma. In the past it was translated as suffering, but that's the wild end. Most now translate it as unsatisfactoriness. It's the lack of comfort, the lack of contentment, always wanting something, and as one writer puts it, just the lack. And this is what we've been pondering when we've talked of the hindrances and the problems of pleasure.

Now it's the turn to look at impermanence. Paradoxically, if there's one unchanging truth about the material and mental universes, it's that everything, without exception, is in a process of change.

I read an excellent book on the cosmos, on galaxies and super-galaxies. Astronomers estimate at least 100 billion galaxies – 100 billion! And some of these galaxies have millions, if not billions, of stars. The pictures of them are stunning. These colossi spinning in the emptiness of space. Huge vortices of unimaginable energy. Stars being formed,

others exploding. Black holes with inverted energy that sucks everything into them from light years away. It's so big, it's beyond fantasy. The mind – well, my mind – just can't grasp it. I get lost after a few stars. I look up at the night sky and I simply cannot mentally perceive what's going on. It's too vast, too overwhelming. And it's all, all of it, in a state of ferocious change.

Coming down to earth, getting my feet back on the ground, I find the same. The ever-changing seasons, the appearance of flowers in spring, their bloom in summer, their disappearance in autumn. The leaves bright yellow-green in spring, deep green in summer, mellow brown in autumn, and then just a load of litter. The tireless sun, rising and setting every day. The snow, the ice, the sleet, the slush, the rain. There's a pattern to it all, but it's hidden, as it were, within change. There are laws governing change, but there's always change.

And human society. Just look at human history. Look at human progress, or perhaps the better word is progression, throughout the comparatively short time we've been here. Constantly changing. A restlessness. War and peace. The growth and collapse of huge civilisations. Coming down to the present, the daily news with its constant flow of changes. Businesses starting, businesses flopping. Politicians doing this, undoing that. Unions, workers, voluntary bodies. The list is legion. People doing things, changing things. Sometimes unskillfully, sometimes skillfully. But nothing can be left alone. Someone's always around to change things. Everyone everywhere, it seems, has to be doing something.

Finally, we close in on ourselves. And what do we find? Change. We change our dwellings, our friends, our jobs, sometimes our spouses and partners. Children come and go. And as we progress through life, we change inside. Things happen to us that change the way we see things. Just think how much we've changed since we were born, since we were just a bundle of gurgling, screaming flesh.

And our bodies. Every seven years – some books say five – every single atom in the body has been replaced. Next time you look in the mirror, remind yourself you didn't have that face seven years ago. And the different parts of the body are changing at different rates. We'd live a long time if our longevity was measured by our bones. Sometimes the liver grows old faster than the heart, and we die of some liver disease. Sometimes it's the heart, or the lungs, or the brain. A lot depends on how we've treated the body, but for the most part it seems to depend on our genetic makeup. In my own family, we all seem to die of strokes. I only know of one case of cancer. I have a friend whose family all die of cancer, and early too. But whatever way we go, go we must, because death is the corollary of birth, and without birth and death, there's no change.

Now the upside of change is this birthing, these beginnings, the newness, the creativity. When we look at nature we learn that over the ages she has created masses of variations in plant and animal life. It's said that 99% of all species have become extinct. Now this seems a very high figure, but it gives an idea of how creative nature is. But it couldn't create anything new if the old didn't die.

We as human beings love to concentrate on the new, on the present fashion, the new song, the new celebrity. It's exciting and wonderful. We're always on the lookout for the new dish, the new film, the new clothes. The whole of our society is geared to the creation of the new. The whole of industry is about producing something new, upgrading. Whether it be a new source of energy, a new gadget, a new drug, a new computer game, a new perfume. So long as we concentrate on the new, we feel happy, for in our understanding, new seems to always mean good.

Individually, we concentrate on what we're going to do tomorrow, at the weekend, next week, next year, where I want to be in ten years' time, how I shall spend my retirement. Our delusion demands we look ahead. We plan for the future. And for the most part, it's exciting. It's so exciting that we don't see that things are disappearing, that things die out. We don't notice that to create something new, we have to get rid of something old. We become blind to the downside of change.

Now self cannot live long in the present. The present moment is death to self unless it presumes a next moment. Suddenly something happens that pulls us up short. I woke up one morning and brushed my teeth. All my teeth were there. At breakfast I bit into an apple. There was a snap, a crack, a front tooth fell out. Just like that. Where there had been a tooth, there was now no tooth.

Life can sometimes be like that, can't it? You wake up one morning feeling a little off, and after examinations and tests, you're given six weeks to live. You step out on the road, and bang, you're dead. There was an elderly woman got on the same plane as I did from Colombo, Sri Lanka, to London. We were half an hour into the flight and she began to fret. She had asthma and other complications, it seems. She was probably planning to spend Easter with her family. She was dead in an hour.

A good acquaintance of mine got drunk one night and went down to the cellar to get more booze. He slipped. He's now in Mandeville Hospital, paralysed from the neck down.

When such things happen around us, it's a shock, a real shock. When it happens to us, it's a trauma. Why? Why should we be shocked? Why should we be traumatised by events that are happening all the time? Isn't it because we don't care to look at the downside of impermanence? We don't want to look at it. It's scary. Yet with the appearance of the new, the old has died.

The Buddha tells us that this is one of the great weaknesses of self, that level of consciousness which identifies with the body and the personality. It's very frightened by death, death in all its forms. The mini-death of my tooth, the mega-death of my body. If I am that, what happens to me when that disappears? The thought is too horrible to contemplate. It's got to mean annihilation. If I am the body, then I'm nothing when it's dead. If I am the personality, and that can only exist in a body, in a brain, within a given culture, then when the body dies, everything I've come to know as me, everything I am, evaporates, dissolves. There's nothing left. Death is an utter annihilation.

Now such thoughts can definitely make us gloomy. After all, there's something utterly final about death. There's no coming back. That's it. When they asked how much the old rich woman had left, the lawyer said, "Everything." When we really absorb the fact that we take nothing material with us, it can undermine our purpose for living. Why make an effort? Why bother about what sort of house I've got? What sort of car? What does it matter? The grim reaper takes all. Not a single penny of all the billions I have are of any use to me come that moment. Why live?

What about my relationships? How much of my happiness is dependent on being loved by someone? How much on being able to love someone? Yet what love lasts? Isn't there something rather sad, perhaps a little pathetic, about continuing to love someone who has died? Yet who doesn't?

Meditating on death and all its implications is a tough one. Yet to meditate on death is known as a protection. What's it protecting us from? It's protecting us from the illusion which self loves to deceive us with – the illusion of continuity. Death doesn't come to me. Yes, I know everyone dies, but that's everyone else. And anyway, if I do have to, it won't be yet. It's too distant in the future for it to be of any importance to me, for it to have any effect on my life now. How many of us go to bed and remind ourselves that we may die in our sleep that very night? A chilling thought, yet we could. My most enduring teacher, Bhante Revatadhamma, arrived back from a long flight and complained of something in his chest. The monks massaged him and he felt better. He died that night.

Contemplating death, my death, gets me in touch with that fear. And the amount of fear I feel on the thought of death or when death approaches me or when it's my turn to die is the measure of the delusion that I live by. This fear is the ground emotion of

self. Self grasps and gathers and aggrandizes to allay the feelings of anxiety. It builds up shoring walls against the possibility of death. Self fights and battles and wars to defend its territory, its possessions. For to lose an inch is to lose an inch of self. And to lose an inch of self is to suffer a mini-death. And when the odds are stacked against it, self runs, flees, flies in a madness, lost in a paroxysm of fear.

How can we guard ourselves against such suffering? We do it by constantly chipping away at the delusions self would have us believe. And the delusion which comes because we don't care to observe and acknowledge impermanence is the illusion of continuity. Because we concentrate on the new, and the new is arising out of the old, we believe that reality is one continual flow of events happening to a static me. The I, the consciousness that knows what's happening, feels itself to be constant and utterly separate from the flow of change and therefore not part of it.

The contemplation of the ever presence of death is the most potent corrective that undermines this fundamental delusion. It brings us back into reality. This is the way it is. Sure, fear arises, but it won't make us run. We see that fear is arising out of the inability to deal with reality. So in our meditation we look straight into the terrorizing eyes of fear. We investigate fear. We feel its sickliness. We sit calmly in the nausea. Slowly we come to feel at ease with that fearful inner environment. We find we can sit still in the midst of the whirlwind. We can find the eye where all is still and untouched by the surrounding tornado.

Slowly we lose our fear of fear, our fear of anxiety. Now I ask you, if we lose our fear of fear, our fear of anxiety, what can possibly frighten us? That's the place we've got to work towards – being able to sit still amidst the icy winds of fear. Then the rest will take care of itself. As always, when we leave the heart alone, we find that she cures herself. Like any turbulence, when we stop twirling it, when we stop energizing it, it loses momentum, exhausts itself, and finally comes to a stillness.

All we have to do is to find that aloof position of the observing within us, knowing the presenting fear and the fear of fear, and slowly all will quieten. In the end all fear vanishes and all possibility of fear is extinguished. The liberated one is fearless. In Buddhist iconography, this is symbolized in the abhaya posture, the posture of fearlessness, where the Buddha holds up his right hand, the palm facing us, offering us the protection of fearlessness. This posture we can internalize. We can visualize that hand between our awareness and emotions, and so protects the knowing from being swamped and hijacked. We can even visualize that hand before our heart and it acts as a protection against the emotional bombardment of other people.

So, contemplating death is part of our practice. That's why I include it in the evening meditation. The spiritual reason is that it undermines the hold that self has over us. When the self is broken asunder, that is our liberation. And it's not only death we should contemplate, but sickness and aging. These are mini-deaths. The one protects us from the intoxication of health. That's what the Buddha calls it – intoxication, a bewilderment, an obsession with our health. And contemplating aging lifts us out of the intoxication, the bewilderment, the desire constantly to be youthful. We always want to be young, somewhere between our twenties and early thirties. But time doesn't care for that.

Now the contemplation of death should be brought into everything. Just a momentary reminder of the impermanence of things. Relationships come to an end. Children leave the nest. The car breaks down. A ring, symbol of so many treasured memories, can be lost. A precious vase broken. Everything, everything comes to an end.

But paradoxically, this doesn't make us gloomy, honestly. This doesn't lead to depression and despair. Not if we also contemplate the fact that at all times the universe is creating itself, that we will continue to recreate ourselves until we achieve liberation. This is the Buddha's teaching. He repeated over and over again to his critics and sceptics, "I do not teach eternalism or annihilationism, but dependent co-arising."

So it is that death is never an end but a beginning, be it the end of a day, or year, or life. And this won't stop till the day of our death as *arahats*, fully enlightened beings. That's why, after our little contemplation on sickness, old age and death in the evening, we go on to contemplate the enlightenment, the liberation, the awakening, the Buddha within, within us. That's what we're trying to bring into realization. And this balance of birth and death, appearance and disappearance, brings us to appreciate the preciousness of the very moment in which we live, the preciousness of that which exists and upon which our lives depend.

Each present moment is to be received as a treasured present. So never mind a Ming vase, the old market crock is treated with gentle carefulness. If we can begin to treat things with this carefulness and gentility, how much more so living beings, human beings, my own being. For underlying all this change, all this birthing and dying, is something which neither is born nor dies. The Buddha is quite clear about this. There is an unborn, an undying, an uncompounded, an uncreated. And that's where we're trying to get to, to try and reach that deathless ground which exists right in the midst of all these fleeting phenomena and yet is untouched by it.

That's the Buddha, walking about North India in the heat and the dust, going on alms rounds, talking to all sorts of people – some poor, some rich, some clever, some stupid, some powerful, high caste and low caste – all day long, mingling, a part of the world, affecting the world for the good. Yet within all that, the nirvanic peace, untouched by the exigencies of life. When he comes to die, he's still teaching. Finally, lying on his right side, he lets go of his decrepit, sick old body. Just like that. Easy-weezy-peasy. No fuss. No fear. Just letting go. Just going on.

And that's exactly what we're learning to do in our meditation. We're learning to let everything go, allowing everything to arise and pass away. And that's exactly the purpose we observe impermanence in all its aspects. This impermanence, this transience as taught by the Buddha, isn't the change of one substance from one shape into another. It's not as though there's a piece of clay and we can mould it into a cup, screw it up and mould it into a saucer. That's what happens when we concentrate on the new and we see only the new arising out of the old. We suffer from this illusion of continuity.

Just take this body. We've already said that every cell is replaced over a period of seven years. But it's all so slow that we don't perceive the process of change. But we also don't see the change so long as we are pleased by it. It's when those first wrinkles appear on the face or the hairline recedes a mite. Then, suddenly, we see change. Change in its darker aspect. That things are actually passing away. Just imagine if you got up one morning and looked in the mirror and saw someone else's face. Shock, horror, trauma. But at base, that's how discontinuous life is.

The Buddha tells us there's radical change. What has come to be must collapse before what is to come can arise. That's the sort of level of insight we'd all like to get to in our meditation. One of our first insights is to see the transient nature of our body in the breath, of our emotions ballooning and deflating, of our thoughts flitting. And if we keep our investigation right there, acknowledging the arising and the falling, we begin to balance our view. Before we come to *vipassanā*, we are aware of the new, the arising. Now we balance that with acknowledging the falling, the passing.

There comes a time when we become more and more aware of the passing. We see quite distinctly that the world does really come to an end. It just breaks up, moment after moment. And if the insight into transience is to be developed rather than the other two characteristics of unsatisfactoriness and not-self or insubstantiality, then such a profound vision of the way things arise and pass away completely, moment after moment, will launch us into the first path and fruit of stream entry, the first level of spiritual liberation.

Indeed, insight can come by observing impermanence at any level, whether at the microcosm of instants or the macrocosm of the stars. And that's what we really want, because with insight there comes a change of heart. There's a change in the deepest seat of our consciousness, a veritable turnaround. And that's what brings about not just a change of behaviour, but the purification which brings in its trail a deep sense of joy and purpose to our lives.

The constant observation of transience will eventually get that penny to drop. Whether we observe it in the stars, the seasons, in the aging of the body, in the suddenness of death, or in the microcosmic world of moment-to-moment sensations, it will eventually begin to dawn on us, really dawn on us, that nothing, absolutely nothing, is worth holding on to. Not even for a moment. Not even for a nanosecond. Why? Because there's nothing there to hold on to. Like grasping water. Like grasping water.

So it is that the contemplation of *anicca*, impermanence, in all its aspects, leads to an easy renunciation of trying to find happiness in a world of pleasure and pain. Samsāra, the world of ever unquenchable searching, is this very relationship we have to the world out there and the world in here. Once we begin to let go of that unwholesome attachment, the world with all its pain and pleasure can't make us unhappy or happy. We've found that inner spiritual solitude and contentment that nothing can disturb.

Let's pause here for a moment. So all we have to do is observe, just watch, whether it's the rising and falling of the abdomen, or the rising and falling of the foot, or any movement whatsoever. For there's always a beginning and an end. A beginning and an end, and nothing repeats itself. What has arisen has gone, has arisen and gone for good. Let us have that faith in the higher faculty within us, *satipaṇṇā*. Let that intuitive intelligence do the work, get out of the way, just watch, just observe, and all will be revealed. It's as simple as that.

The Buddha says in the Dhammapada, "All conditioned things are impermanent. When we really see this, we become disenchanted with the world. Just this is the path that liberates us from all our suffering."

Let me leave you with a more salutary note that so expresses for me the way an awakened being lives. William Blake, our homegrown mystical poet: "He who binds to himself a joy does the winged life destroy. But he who kisses the joy as it flies lives in eternity's sunrise."

May your profound insights into the characteristic of impermanence, *anicca*, allow such a depth of detachment that in an instant all *dukkha*, all unsatisfactoriness, will evaporate completely. May you all be fully liberated from the delusion of continuity and attain that unchanging *nibbāna* sooner rather than later.

Anattā — Not-Self

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min read

In this profound evening retreat talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the third and most challenging of the Three Characteristics of existence: anattā, or not-self. Unlike a philosopher seeking mere intellectual agreement, the Buddha was a mystic whose aim was for practitioners to directly experience what he had realized.

The talk explores three methods the Buddha used to deconstruct the illusion of selfhood: the five aggregates (khandhas), the six sense spheres (āyatana), and the four foundations of awareness (satipaṭṭhāna). Through practical examples—from cars and airplanes to the process of eating—Bhante shows how everything we experience as 'whole' is actually a collection of interdependent parts.

Drawing from the Anattalakkhana Sutta, the Buddha's second discourse to his five companions, the talk demonstrates how we have limited control over body and mind, undermining the self's presumed authority. The ultimate paradox is revealed: Nibbāna possesses the eternal qualities we attribute to an eternal self, yet it is not-self. Through moment-to-moment awareness in Vipassanā practice, we can glimpse this reality where 'in the seeing, there's only the seeing'—pure awareness without the observer.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

We've now discussed two of the three characteristics that the Buddha taught to be the fundamental marks of all existence. The first, *dukkha*, unsatisfactoriness, pertains to any sentient being and especially human beings, how they contact and make sense of the world, and how a delusive relationship to sensual pain and pleasure causes suffering. We manufacture our own suffering because we believe that happiness is to be found in the sensual world. Then there was the quality of *anicca*, transience, the fact that everything is in process. As we also know from our science, there isn't actually any thing as such in the universe. It's all energy changing from one shape or form into another.

Both of these two characteristics aren't difficult to grasp. The only small difficulty I think we have is to see how indulgence in pleasure always brings dissatisfaction in its wake. The third characteristic, however, *anattā*, or the doctrine of not-self, as it can be

translated literally, is more difficult for us to grasp. But nonetheless, we can begin to intellectually understand the Buddha's position that nothing in the universe has substance, and the self, this person, that I feel and experience myself to be, is but a phantasm. It doesn't really have any real, substantial, essential existence.

First of all, we need to see the Buddha was not a philosopher. He was not a philosopher if what we mean by that word is someone who is concerned to convince someone else of an idea, someone who is simply concerned to prove a given premise. For the philosopher, it is satisfying enough to have someone agree with them. For instance, if a philosopher states that happiness is the goal of life, their concern is to prove that premise by various arguments. It matters little whether the philosopher themselves actually lives a happy life or not. It's an ideal, an idea worth striving for, even if the philosopher at heart doesn't really know whether it's possible or not. What is necessary is that they are convinced by reasonable argument.

But in this sense we're all philosophers to a degree. We prefer enticing logic. There's a part of us that feels satisfied that we've understood, accepted, and have faith in a statement. Believing in something is so much easier than coming to know by one's own personal experience. That's what we mean by realization, making it real for ourselves. But this demands effort, a lot of effort.

The Buddha was well acquainted with all the philosophical viewpoints of his day. As the discussions he has with various Brahmins and wandering ascetics show, he was able to do more than hold his own. But he knew where arguments stopped. What he saw was that these Brahmins and *Samaṇa* were caught up in simply trying to win arguments. They were, he said, ensnared in a jungle of views and opinions.

The Buddha had no reason to win arguments for winning's sake. His aim was not simply to convince people that his understanding was correct, but, and here's the difference, he wanted people to experience what he had experienced. In this sense he was a mystic, not some new age spaced out psychic you understand, but someone who has understood the deeper mysteries of life, someone who has realized, actually experienced for themselves, something beyond the world of apparition, the world of things, the world of sense-data and thought, beyond the phenomenal world.

The Buddha referred to himself as the *Tathāgata*, which translated literally means thus gone, or perhaps arrived there, but it was his way of saying transcendent. The Buddha's concern was to get people to have the same supramundane experience. Hence everything he said had the purpose of getting those convinced to do the practice, to

work at the practice in order to experience what he himself had attained. Unlike the philosopher, he really did know that happiness was the goal of human endeavour because he himself lived in perfect contentment and peace.

So now we come to this difficult teaching of *anattā*, not self. The primary confusion is that this is one of those philosophical premises that we can argue about. That *anattā* means there is no self, no soul, no eternal spirit, and so on. This is quite understandable. Even people in his own day accused the Buddha of being an annihilationist, that is, someone who didn't believe in an eternal self and that the human simply vanished in total at death. There was no afterlife, and even if there were, as some annihilationists believed, in the end it would just fizzle out when *kamma* had completed its momentum.

But the Buddha insisted he was not an annihilationist, and that the only annihilation was of greed, hatred and delusion. The Buddha's position was grounded in his present state, which he referred to as *Nibbāna*. Everything was to be measured against that living experience. Perhaps he would have been on easier ground if he had used an expression as not-*Nibbāna* for everything that the unenlightened person experienced.

In fact, there is a discourse where greater and greater pleasures are described, beginning with the delicious sensual pleasures and rising to the highest bliss of *jhānic* absorption. And he says that all these states are not the highest happiness, that is, not *Nibbāna*.

Although the Buddha's choice of the word *anattā* did and still confuses, he had good reason for choosing this word instead of others. He wanted to undermine the belief that anything a person experienced, whether through the five senses or the mind with its thoughts and images, or the heart with all its emotions and moods, in any way constituted something solid or everlasting.

To do this he would deconstruct the human being, and he did this by looking at the human being in various ways. We shall look at three of them, by way of the aggregates, the spheres, and the four foundations of mindfulness. By this process of deconstruction, the idea of something, anything, being whole, entire unto itself, an integer, a one, is undermined.

It is natural for the discriminative mind to see things as individual objects, to see objects as isolated, to cut up the world into this and that, and it's necessary we do so. Can you imagine not being able to tell the difference between a cup of tea and a cup of water? Heaven forbid. There's nothing wrong with seeing the world like this so long as we also see it isn't the way things really are. This ability of the mind to create concepts is not destroyed by enlightenment. It is simply put in its proper context.

There's a good example of this in art. Artists are forever trying to show us how the world really is. The Impressionists made us see that objects can only be fully understood within the environment they stand. A tree colours into the countryside. The Expressionists showed us that what we see is coloured by our emotions.

Now let's take a car. That's an object. We see it quite distinctly as separate from its environment. We see it moving as a separate object, and we know if we get in the way it's going to hurt. At an ordinary, conventional level of understanding, a car is hard and solid and is one thing, but we know it's made up. If we laid out all the pieces of a car on the floor, we wouldn't say that's a car. We'd say they're all the parts necessary to make up a car. Then, when we put it together, something quite magical happens. It propels itself. Definitely more amazing is an aeroplane. Tons of metal and what have you just lift so easily, so gracefully into flight.

And what we come to realise is the whole is always greater than the sum of the parts, even at a basic level. Take a few bits of wood and put them together, and hey presto, a chair, a table, a bed, and so on. When we look at the universe, we see it as a collection of wholes, forming greater wholes, until we arrive at the whole which is the cosmos itself.

When we look at a human being, it's the same. If you're a materialist for whom only matter exists, then there's the wonder of consciousness. When all the bits and pieces are put together and functioning, there arises this mysterious capacity to be conscious, to be aware, and in higher primates and human beings to be self-aware. This is something extra that arises inexplicably, accidentally, incidentally. This by-product is called by philosophers an epiphenomena. Once we label something, we think we understand it.

Now it's this very by-product that confuses us. Something that's made up of lots of other things produces a new function. The car made up of bits propels itself, the plane flies. And we see it as a whole, an integer, a one. We forget it's made up of parts. It's only when the car won't start, or the plane drops out of the sky, that we're suddenly pulled up short. It's only when a part of the body hurts or becomes ill that we suddenly realize that wholes are made up of parts.

Now the most common deconstruction device in the discourses is the aggregates or collections or heaps, the *khandha*. You will notice here links with the dependent originations. The Buddha divides the human into five different aggregates: the physical base, perceptions, feelings, volitional formations and cognition.

The physical base or *rūpa* is again divided into four primary elements we've mentioned before: earth or solidity, fire or temperature, air or movement and water or cohesion. These four great elements are the way that the mind first experiences matter. At that basic percept there is only the object, the sense faculty, and cognition, a knowing. Sound, for instance, at this level, is experienced simply as pressure on the eardrum. Heaviness or lightness, that's the earth element. It's not that the other elements are not present. All the elements are present in any one given percept, but one always predominates. Fire or temperature would predominate in sight. Where there's light, there's heat, and vice versa.

So the whole experience of sense contact can be deconstructed into these elements. Now whether these elements actually exist outside the mind is not relevant, for these are simply the way the senses sense the world out there. And in our meditation, we can do it in a more obvious way by experiencing the different parts of the body from this point of view. Bones can be felt as solid, just the quality of hardness. The heat or cold we feel can be seen as just temperature. The sponginess of muscles and flesh can be experienced as elasticity, cohesiveness. The feeling of movement caused by breathing can also be isolated.

Why do this? Simply to break down the concept of wholeness. For with the concept of wholeness comes the concept of substance, real independent existence. The me, the I. Such as, I feel, therefore I am. I think, therefore I am. And of course, I suffer, therefore I am. And that's the delusion.

Then there are all the perceptions that the mind produces every moment. This is the second aggregate, *saññā*. From this basic contact we get our perceptions of taste. Whether something is salty, sweet, bitter, astringent or sour, that's why I like to stress the importance of eating, because we get in touch with this ever-present flow of perceptions and we can begin to see how they build up into the concept of a particular dish. If we were blindfolded, we'd still be able to tell it was spaghetti and not curry. But when we eat mindfully, we become aware of the different tastes that go into making up the supposed one taste, such as the hardness of spaghetti, the sweetness and saltiness in the sauce, and so on. It again breaks up for us the delusion that there's only one taste in the taste of spaghetti.

Then there's feeling, the third aggregate, *vedanā*. What is meant here is the secondary response to sensations. Feelings arise when we experience all these perceptions as likeable or unlikeable, pleasant or unpleasant. This also includes how we experience the feelings in our body caused by emotions. Again, when we concentrate inwardly, we

can see that we divide our experience of life into pleasant and unpleasant. Although we also talk about neutral feelings, if we get close up to them, we will discover some delicate shade of liking or disliking there.

These three *khandha*, aggregates, are the materials upon which the fourth *khandha* works, the *saṅkhāra*, the volitional formations. It's here that self steps in and tries to take control. A world is created out of all the percepts, perceptions and feelings. Our whole emotional and intellectual life springs out of this. And it's all manufactured by self for the pleasure of self, when we're deluded. And the creator is our will, which empowers all the intentions we make throughout our life. It's with these *saṅkhāra*, volitional formations, fabrications, creations, that we go out and do things. For the enlightened person, of course, it becomes a way of expressing wisdom into the world by way of compassionate action and service.

And finally there are the acts of cognition, *viññāṇa*. This is a discriminative consciousness. It sees everything as separate, whether it be by way of contradiction or comparison. *Viññāṇa* is the mind's ability to hold a frame up that is then understood. It's like a mirror which holds all the images together as a whole and gives us the impression that we live in a solid world. We simply couldn't function if all we were aware of was the storm of perceptions coming through the sense doors. It is the primary knowing, it is the faculty that tells us there's a bell ringing and it's lunchtime. It's not to be confused with the understanding or the intuitive intelligence, *satipaṇṇa*. That, as we shall see, is something else.

So this is one way the Buddha deconstructs our experience of the world by way of the *khandha*, the aggregates of form or matter, basic perceptions, feelings in the body caused both by the body itself and the mind, volitional formations which are all our emotional and thought life, manufactured by our power of will, and finally cognition or a primary knowing.

And we can use this in our practice. We can simply note things from this point of view. We note movement in the breath, heat or cold, a fire element, pressure, the earth element or the tightness we feel, the air element, the sheer movement, the lightness of joy, the warmth of love, and so on. Perceptions we note as images or thoughts. Feelings we feel directly, experience intimately and note. The *saṅkhāra* are all our intentions that manufacture the fantasies and thoughts, both consciously volitional or habitual, throughout the whole day. And cognition can be recognized in the act of noting of any object, no matter what it is, as the object we come to note.

The second way the Buddha deconstructs the human experience is by way of the avenues or spheres of cognition. Each avenue or sphere being distinct, exclusive and discrete. The five senses and the mind itself. When it comes to the five senses, we can't mix them. We can't smell with our eyes and we can't see with our ears and so on. They are quite different avenues of consciousness or spheres of experience and this is what the Buddha calls them, the *āyatana*, the spheres.

The mind itself is seen as the sixth sense in this case, for it makes sense of all the other incoming data. What is actually received into the mind is quite minimal. The mind has to work hard to put it all together. But it is quite discrete from the sense-bases, for if all the five senses were to disappear, the mind would have nothing to do but mess around in the library of its own images, thoughts, moods and emotions.

Now when we experience an event, it is experienced again as a whole. At the cinema or watching a video or TV, it's all one experience. We see the film, hear the dialogue, the music, we taste the popcorn or biscuits. It's all one big experience. It's only when we start concentrating on the moment that we realize there are a myriad of mental processes going on. In fact, there can only arise one act of cognition at a time. The mind can only perceive one piece of data at any one given moment, but it's all going so fast and cognition is so good at manufacturing pictures out of that data that we experience life as one continuous whole, not as a series of discrete perceptions.

Can you imagine watching TV, where at one moment you see the picture, that goes out, and then you hear the dialogue? You put a biscuit in your mouth, and on the taste you lose both the vision and the hearing of the program. It would be impossible to live like that in a sort of stroboscopic universe. Thanks to the speed of cognition, it's all magically formulated into one piece. But there lies our delusion, because we believe that's the way things really are.

The point of insight meditation is to see beyond the apparent and to see that everything is only a compendium, a collection. There's nothing real or solid about any experience whatsoever. As the Buddha says, it's all like bubbles in a stream. By noting our meditative experiences along these lines, the avenues of consciousness, and realizing how discrete they are, we get in touch with how we fabricate the world and undermine the delusion of wholeness or substance. And this, of course, rebounds upon the concept of the self, of the me. What is this me? Where is this me to be found if everything I believe to be me is nothing but a collection of sensual and mental data?

Now there is another way the Buddha deconstructs our experience by way of the elements, the *dhātu*. I want to mention it briefly here because it tells us how far this deconstruction can go. The last two of the 24 elements are called the mind object and the

mind cognition elements. These go into a moment to moment detail of how the mind manufactures a single thought. And believe it or not, this can actually be experienced. That's how profound this meditation can take us into seeing how the mind works to generate a world and ultimately how we come to be deceived by it.

Now apart from this process of deconstruction, there is another way in which we can see that the self is a false identity. The self likes to think of itself in control, the agent, to have power over. It wants to do my own thing, in my own way, in my own time.

The Buddha, after he became enlightened, sought out his five companions. He found them in Isipatana Park. There, he first talked about the Four Noble Truths, and one of the company attained the first level of enlightenment, stream entry, *Sotāpanna*. But when he gave his second discourse, they were all fully awakened. This discourse is called the discourse on the characteristic of not-self.

Here's the gist of it. Meditators, the body, form, the sense bases, are not-self. If the body was a self, it would not lead to suffering. For one could say to the body, let the body be healthy, let the body not be sick. But the body isn't like that. It is because we can't tell the body what to do that suffering arises.

We feel we have control over the body, don't we? I mean, we can make it walk and talk and eat and so on. But this is like the driver of a car who can make the car start and stop, turn left or right. But what control has the driver over the car in itself? And how much does a driver know about the workings of a car? We find ourselves in a similar position with the body. On closer inspection, we experience little of the internal workings, never mind know about them. Indeed, the body, for the most part, takes care of itself.

What do I experience of the digestive system? What control have I got over it? What about the circulatory system? I haven't a clue in terms of real experience what my blood is doing. I've read about it, but I've never experienced hemoglobin turning red when it meets with oxygen in the lungs. I feel my abdomen and chest moving when I breathe, but I've never experienced the blood exchanging carbon dioxide for oxygen. The whole thing just works altogether without me interfering. In fact, it's when I don't recognise that I'm not the body that I'm in danger of doing it harm, when I push the body too hard or overeat and drink intoxicants and so on.

In other words, although we have a certain amount of control over the body, it's quite superficial. I can make it walk and talk but I can't make it grow one way or the other. Or make it beautiful. I can't will myself to become a great athlete. I can't stop it growing old and I can't stop it dying. My control over the body is superficial. And yet I'm utterly dependent on this body for my existence on this planet. A humbling thought.

In the same way, we can go through the other *khandha*, the aggregates, and see that it's the same with the perceptions we have, the feelings, the emotions, and the thoughts we have. Eventually, we have very little control over the type of personality we have. Even when we become fully enlightened, we don't change the flavor of our personality radically. The Buddha was still recognizably Siddhartha Gautama. His five companions recognized him as such, but that personality was then purified of all malevolence.

This lack of power can be seen even in the way we perceive the world. Humans can see only a particular band within the whole spectrum of colour, and each of us has our own experience of colour. Some of us are colourblind, some of us have poor sight. Our emotional life is also conditioned, and our thought life too. For instance, certain types of music will affect us, other types won't. Our thought is bound up with the language we speak and the culture that's produced it. European people, for instance, have very different cultural values to people in the East. With insight, of course, we do begin to create a better interior life. But it will still be greatly conditioned by our culture and environment.

We've now discussed two aspects of how the Buddha undermines the self-delusion. By deconstructing a seeming whole and by questioning the power that self presumes to have. In this way, the Buddha tries to undermine the belief that the body and mind are some sort of eternal person, soul or spirit.

But our delusion doesn't stop there at the obvious, so to speak. He also wanted to undermine the belief that beneath these attributes, the body and mind as we experience them, lies any other real self whatsoever, something which is eternal. Take a hand, for instance. Let's look at it and feel it. We see it has certain colour, a certain shape. We feel it has soft parts and hard parts, and so on. Let's presume that we've seen and felt a hand to an ultimate degree. We know all its attributes. We realise it's made up of bits and pieces. But let's say this isn't the real hand. To discover the real hand, we must, as it were, slip these attributes away. Can you imagine taking off your hand as you would a glove to reveal another hand which was real, substantial, unchangeable, eternal, indestructible, and so on?

It was this sort of idea that the Buddha also wanted to undermine. For this was the more subtle meaning of the word *atta*, self, in his time, as it is today for people who believe in an afterlife, namely that there is a subtle body beneath or within the material body that is substantial, immortal, and will go on to live forever.

At the time of the Buddha, the scriptures of the Brahmins, now called Hinduism, had been developing along similar lines, but in the general understanding of things, the *Atta*, the Self, had come to mean both the empirical Self and the Eternal Self, the capital S. The empirical self is how we experience ourselves now as personalities, as persons with thoughts, emotions, sensations, relationships and so on. But the eternal self posited some self beneath or transcendent of this, like the real hand beneath the apparent hand.

Whatever later Hinduism came to believe, it was all confusion in the Buddha's time. So the Buddha simply swept that confusion aside by telling everyone that anything they conceived of, an eternal soul, spirit or self, was but wishful thinking. Put another way, anything they experienced by way of the body, heart and mind was not self, *anattā*. Whether physical, psychological or ethereal, whatever self a person experienced themselves to be, that self was a construct and had no real, substantial or essential existence.

Now let us remember that the Buddha is concerned to get us to experience this, to come to know this for ourselves. We have to have practical, direct, personal experience. Remember, to be convinced of all this by way of thought, by way of a philosophical proposition, just won't do. We might be able to write deep philosophical books about it, but that won't bring us to the end of suffering.

So the Buddha now deconstructs the human being, this psychophysical organism, into yet another division in order to lead us to an experiential understanding, a direct realization of not-self. He now teaches us to look at ourselves from the point of view of the four foundations of mindfulness, the *satipaṭṭhāna*. They can be seen as four frames of reference, whereby we can experience this psychophysical organism I call me, break down its illusion of wholeness, and discover indeed that there is no other reality beneath them, within them, above them, or anywhere around them.

You will by now be familiar with all the terminology but it's looked at in a slightly different way. This is important because up till now we've looked at ways of deconstructing the human being but they've had an intellectual bias. With the *Satipaṭṭhāna* the Buddha is being immediate and practical. This is the way we can note, observe, feel and experience and so come to understand the way we really are by the direct path of Vipassanā.

The first is *Kāyānupassanā*, investigating the body. It means we need to be mindful of all our daily actions, standing, walking and so on, and to see that no action is one thing. It's made up of a myriad of movements. This includes the action of breathing. At its most profound level is to see how the mind contacts the body. That's when we experience those four great elements of earth, fire and so on we discussed earlier.

Then there's a whole area of feeling in the body. That's *vedanānupassanā*. These feelings, remember, can be caused by the body, as when our knees hurt, or by the mind, as when an emotion comes up.

Then there's *cittānupassanā*. Here we note, feel, observe, and come to know our states of mind, all the moods and emotions, thoughts and images, whether it's concentrated or not, suffering or not, and so on.

And finally, there's *Dhammānupassanā*. This refers to certain teachings which are specific to the Buddha Dhamma. The five aggregates, the five hindrances, the six sense spheres, the seven factors of enlightenment, and the four noble truths, which include, of course, the three characteristics of existence, impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self. We have, of course, touched upon all these during the last few days.

These *satipaṭṭhāna*, establishments of awareness, are the frames of reference by which the intuitive wisdom, *paññā*, can investigate and come to see, to realize the human condition from an enlightened point of view.

In meditation, through the process of *vipassanā*, we can begin to experience directly this doctrine of *anattā*, not self. The most obvious way is through the noting technique. Whenever something comes into our attention, be it the breath, a sensation, a feeling, a thought, we mentally point to it as it were. We note it. We say, rising, falling, itching, anger, joy, and so on. This pointing at it distances us from it. What we are really saying is, there are the feelings of the breath, rising and falling. There are the feelings of itching, and so on. There, over there, not here. Not here within the knowing. We are objectifying the inner world in the same way as babies and toddlers we began to objectify the outer world by pointing. At the inner objects, the sensations, feelings, thoughts, we're distancing ourselves from them, and the noting technique helps us to do that.

As our meditation deepens, then thought disappears, the noting stops, and we learn to perceive that what we experience within ourselves is not the same as the knowing which is experiencing it. At this point, the true nature of the knowing begins to dawn upon us. What is this awareness? What is this intuitive intelligence? What is *satipaṇṇā*? Now that's the question, and this meditation is leading us directly to that answer.

Now here's the paradox. Why is it that the Buddha says that *Nibbāna* is just as we would want any eternal self to be, but it is not self? Unlike everything in the phenomenal world, which is *anicca*, transient, *Nibbāna* is *nicca*, not transient. It doesn't arise and pass away. It is the deathless, immortal, just like an eternal self. Unlike the enlightened state where everything is eventually unsatisfactory, *Nibbāna* is a state of complete contentment, perfect peace, yet it is not an eternal self.

This is expressed most clearly in the three verses we chant every morning. All conditioned things are impermanent. All conditioned things are unsatisfactory. But all conditioned things and the unconditioned are not self. When this is perceived with wisdom, one becomes disenchanted with what cannot satisfy. Just this is the path of purification.

When we think about it, is there ever a time when the idea of me doesn't come up without a self-awareness? Indeed, isn't that what we mean by a self? The feeling of a me. Is there a self in deep sleep? We just presume it, don't we? I presume that since I went to sleep feeling myself to be me, and wake up feeling the same, my self must have been there all through sleep. But it's an inference, isn't it? An assumption. How can we prove it?

In meditation we feel ourselves to be an observer. There seems always to be somebody watching, doing, experiencing. In pure *vipassanā*, this feeling vanishes entirely. Yet there is still the watching, the doing, the experiencing, but no sense of a self doing it. That's why the Buddha says, In the seeing, there's only the seeing. In the hearing, there's only the hearing. In the cognizing, there's only the cognizing.

Can we, unenlightened beings as we are, get a taste of what that selfless state might be? Yes, indeed we can, but again a paradox. We can't do it by an act of self-will. It's not within the power of self to go beyond self. All we can do is set up the conditions whereby we might have a not-self experience. And here is where the Buddha shows the depth of his gift as a teacher. He asks us only to be concerned with establishing right awareness, not to bother about experiencing *Nibbāna* or not-self, which we simply can't achieve by an act of will.

So what is right awareness? First of all, it's not intellectual knowledge. If everything said in this talk has been fairly new, you may very well be confused by the five of these and the four of those. Well, don't worry. If you're interested in it at all, then after this course you can read and study it all. But here in meditation, it's not even necessary to know it. So I go on about it because through these arguments we can at least become intellectually convinced of our insubstantiality. Being convinced intellectually, hopefully we have more faith in *vipassanā* and more eagerness to see if it's really true. In other words, it's about getting a right attitude.

Now, presumably we have it now. So we can concentrate just on the practice, which is simply to be aware of all that arises and passes away. As we begin to centre in on what we are experiencing, let's say the sensations caused by the breath, using the noting to keep the thinking mind from making us lose our focus, *sati*, awareness begins to concentrate on, gather around a smaller and smaller event, a smaller and smaller unit of time, drawing itself into the immediate present moment. And at that point there is no time to think, no time to reflect. The thinking mind has no time in which to think. The noting stops.

As the interval of time decreases, so the time interval is so small we can experience single sensations arising and passing away. This *sati* awareness doesn't even have the time to recognize its own presence, seeing itself, feeling itself mirrored within the mind like a shadow. It constructs an image of itself. That image we experience as self-awareness. But as this awareness sits simply in the presenting instant, even that feeling of self-awareness disappears.

And there is the experience of just observing, just watching. The feeling, the idea, the belief that there is a soul, a self, a spirit, disappears. For that moment, and for longer periods of time, if the practice is good, the meditator experiences pure awareness, unadulterated by the view or feeling of a self.

We can see now that the *Anattā* teaching is not saying there is nothing, but that whatever ultimate reality is, it is not a self or a feeling of a self. In ultimate reality, just as in the phenomenal world, there are no things. And the feeling of self-awareness is the feeling of a thing, but the subtlest of things, and therefore the most difficult of things to perceive as insubstantial and not self.

So how do we get a glimpse of this? By doing the practice according to the Buddha's instructions. Forget about *Nibbāna*. Forget about trying to have a spiritual experience. Forget about the *vipassanā* insights. Forget about achieving anything. Save a moment-to-moment attentiveness. Just place all our energy into observing the presenting object, be it a sensation, emotion or thought. Ultimate truth is to be experienced in the presenting event, the here and now. Hence, our whole effort is simply to be present. Ultimately, we will have that glimpse.

The Buddha says there is a consciousness which has no characteristics, no attributes, beyond the realm of scientific measurement. A consciousness that is without boundary, in all directions, lustrous, full of light, awake. Just this is the end of suffering.

Let's pause here for a moment. Whenever we look at something, that becomes an object. Being an object, it cannot be the subject. The knowing cannot be what it knows. Even the feeling of a self, when we are self-aware, self-conscious, must also be an object. It cannot be that which knows. Grasping this, at first a fear and anxiety may arise in us. Who are we if we're not this body, these emotions, these thoughts, this personality? But when we begin to see things as they really are, and where our true nature actually resides, then a real peace, a real happiness begins to flower.

And where does our true nature reside? It resides in our ability to discover a relationship to the world without and the world within, wherein we find intimacy without identity, where we are utterly engaged, utterly involved and yet detached. Such paradox can only be solved by that knowing the Buddha within. So we have to keep working

Living Life According to the Dhamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 34 min read

In this comprehensive evening retreat talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses fundamental questions about living according to the Buddha's teachings in daily life. Drawing from the Noble Eightfold Path, he explores how right understanding and right attitude naturally flow into right speech, right action, and right livelihood. The talk examines the five precepts in detail - not harming living beings, not taking what isn't given, not abusing sexuality, right speech, and avoiding intoxicants - while emphasizing their positive counterparts of generosity, loving-kindness, and service.

Bhante discusses practical applications including vegetarianism within Buddhist ethics, the distinction between being assertive versus aggressive (illustrated through personal anecdotes), and how any work can become spiritual practice through the attitude of service. He explains the ten pāramī (perfections) as ongoing virtues rather than completed attainments, and addresses the ceremony of taking refuge in the Three Jewels - Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha.

The talk emphasizes that the Buddha's teachings were given to both monastic and lay practitioners, referencing the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) being delivered to the householders of Kammāsadhamma. Bhante concludes by explaining the refuge ceremony offered the following morning, encouraging practitioners to consider a formal commitment to the path as a way of establishing clear spiritual authority and direction in life.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa

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Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

This evening I wanted to pre-empt a lot of questions over the weekend concerning daily life. Not all of them, but some of them. To look at the way the Buddha advises us to live and then to try to explain what it means to take refuge and precepts, because that's the little ceremony that I offer on Sunday morning. And why we should do it, or why you might want to do it. The ceremony is on the Sunday just after breakfast, 9:30, and I'll talk about that tomorrow in more detail.

When the Buddha started to teach, the first people who were attracted to him were people who wanted to live a similar sort of ascetic life. And many of them had already been living the ascetic life, out in the jungle or the forests, going on alms round rather. That's the preferred expression, on alms round, not begging for food.

And when they were attracted to him, he said, well, come and try. *Ehi passiko*. There is of course the story about the women who turned up from his court later on in his dispensation. I'm sure many of you know the story that when they turned up he didn't want to ordain them. He didn't think that they could take the life and he refused them three times, which is basically no. But Ananda said, can women become fully liberated? And he said, yes. So he said, well, why not give them a chance? So he did. Ever since then, he's been blamed by the men.

Now, although that story exists, it would seem now actually that that's not quite right. Research has shown something else, that these people who turned up from court were in fact his own relatives. They were his stepmother, his wife and a few other court ladies. So they were obviously people who'd been living the good life. It would be difficult to wear rag robes. They would have been probably still wearing rag robes then, collect robes from the bodies of the dead, sew them up and boil them, and that was it. Later on he made people cut them into squares so that when you look at a robe it looks like paddy fields with passages, and then he made them dye it in arakanut, which turned into a sort of colour of, as one monk said, baby shit. So it's not particularly fashionable.

But there does seem to be, especially a nun there, just the name escapes me as usual, who seems to have asked him, it's in her verse, if you look at the verses left by the *Theris*, by the enlightened women. There's one verse there where she states that when she asked the Buddha if she could join him, she'd already had *jhana* known, he said the same thing, *Ehi*, come, *Ehi Passiko*, come and try.

So that was one part of it, and slowly but surely an institution developed, and an institution basically is determined by its rules and regulations. So there were general rules and regulations of the time, but as monks and nuns misbehaved and people complained about certain behaviour, he would make a rule. One of the ones that you're all suffering from is not to eat after lunch. So that came about because lay people complained that the monks and nuns were turning up at all times and more than once with their bowls for food. They got fed up and they said no, this is not right, what are they doing all day, just sat there eating? So he made the rule that you can only go out once, it had to be in the morning and it had to be eaten before noon. And the monks com-

plained because all the best foods are cooked in the evening like in most cultures, but he was quite strict about that. He said no, if you want to join this dispensation, that's what you do.

So that was one side of his dispensation. The other side of course was that many lay people began to be attracted to his teachings, and so he began to develop a lay way of life because he had to answer their questions. And this comes out in the Eightfold Path, which we'll come to in a little bit.

But the one thing that I really like to stress is that the jewel of the collection, the *Satipatthana* discourse, in which the Buddha describes how to meditate, all the stuff you've been hearing from me is out of that discourse. Like feeling feelings in feelings and all that sort of stuff. That's all from this discourse. That is addressed to the Kurus of Kurusadhamma. That's how the discourse opens. It always opens with where he was and who he gave the talk to.

So he was in a place which was close to modern Delhi and he had been there before and he'd given teachings about mindfulness and meditation. And when he came back he was taken by how committed the village was, the little town was, to the practice. And that's where he delivered this discourse. So the discourse explaining the whole process of meditation. And it ends with, if you maintain your mindfulness for seven years, for sure you will be either a non-returner or fully liberated. Never mind seven years, seven months. Never mind seven months, seven weeks. Never mind seven weeks, seven days. That means you don't lose your attention for seven days, right? As we found out, that's a wee bit difficult. And it's good to remember that.

He didn't pull any punches. He didn't think, well, only monastics with their special form of institution and life can become liberated. Not at all. And there are examples in the scriptures of many people becoming fully liberated. One is a cobbler.

He had to, shall we say, wander through the countryside. That was his normal thing. He would go from one monastery to the next, spending so much time here, so much time there. And on the way, he would stay in little villages and towns. And in those days, the wandering ascetics seemed to be the entertainment. I mean, there was obviously folk entertainment, bands and jumping up and down, but they would have these big gatherings on full moon. And the people would go to the parks and they'd have these talks given to them by these ascetics, these spiritual seekers, and they'd be questions and all that sort of stuff.

And in fact, we know that the lay people complained to the Buddha that when we go to these teachers, they always answer our questions and these teachers also give talks, but yours sit like dumb pigs. So he said right, and he made a rule. All these rules come about because of silly things like that. So he said if a monk or nun is asked a dharma question they have to respond. It's a rule.

So he has lots of advice concerning the lay life. And this comes out, as I say, in the Eightfold Path. So it's good to look at that. It's good to look at the Eightfold Path and see what he's actually saying.

So the first is right understanding, right attitude. So that's really what we've been developing over this week. We've been developing our understanding about the way things really are, and hopefully that will in time sink down into an attitudinal base, an attitude. And then from there there's an outflow. So that outflow is into right speech, right action and right livelihood.

So now right, there's always the negative and the positive. So wrong speech of course, telling whoppers and coarse language and useless language and slander, those are your four types of wrong speech. And all those bring us problems. Right speech is kindly. It's always from a position of kindness, which you can include any positive attitude of kindness, from compassion, kindness from joy, sympathetic joy, kindness from friendliness, from *metta*. Kindness, honest. That honesty even stretches to not to exaggerate. And then finally, which is the most difficult one, at a suitable time.

So if you want to say something to somebody which you know might upset them, then you have to choose your time, say it kindly, and be upfront about it. And that's what the Buddha is saying. If you choose the wrong time, then you can expect it to completely go wrong. So this idea of choosing the right time, a suitable time, I think is rather insightful.

And that brings us all to this business of aggression and what's that other word where you're being direct, aggressive, and what's the word they use for that? Assertive, that's right. People think when you're assertive you have to stamp your foot and put your fist on your hips and say quite straightforward, I will not have this. But to be assertive is coming from a place of no fear, no aversion. That's what assertiveness is. And when it comes from that place it can be terribly kind, but they know that you mean it.

A slight example which gives you some idea of that is I remember Mother Teresa of Calcutta. She went to Lebanon when that dreadful stuff was going on and some school had been stuck in the middle of two firing lines, it seems, and the school has lots of children in the school. They'd been caught in the school and it was a dilemma as to

what to do. They were very afraid to bring the kids out. It's very strange because I saw it on television, some of you might have seen it, and she's brought to the school. So I was thinking why don't they shoot her in a crossfire? But anyway the officials and all that, they brought her to this place where she could see the school, they told her what the situation was and what to do. Well she had no problem. She just walked to the school and brought them out. Everybody else is so afraid and full of fear and all that confusion, but that's what had to be done and she was prepared to perhaps sacrifice her life to at least make the attempt.

So when you find yourself in a position of being bullied or somebody saying something which is rather nasty and all that sort of stuff and you want to talk to them, it doesn't have to be upfront straight on the nose, I will not have this sort of behaviour. Coming from that position of no fear and no hatred, no aversion, to say it very kindly, look, I won't take that sort of language anymore. And it hits much more strongly. If there's any fear, any anger, then subconsciously they'll bounce back off it. So coming from equanimity is a much better place, whatever we do, always.

It's been a regular experience of mine. I wrote in one of my little blogs on my monthly email where I came, we had to get rid of this big tree, this oak tree, because of oil tank regulations. And I came out of the house, and my neighbour was in an absolute rage. I've never seen, I mean, it was real rage. He completely lost it. And he was saying things like, I'm from Liverpool, and I'll have you shot. Doesn't say much for Liverpool. And the lumberjack who was okay by the way and quite an expert, he was standoffish. He seemed to be very cool, but that's because he had these two great big strapping young lads next to him.

And I came out into this and I thought, so I thought it was nothing to do with me, so I was really calm, cool, collected, the peacemaker. And I said, what's going on? And he raged on about this tree should have never been cut, it's not our tree, we've had all this business before, somebody was fined so many thousand pounds, on and on and on. And then he turns on me and he says, I'm going to drive my tractor up and down the side of your fence all day to disturb me, all sorts of stuff. And finally I sort of cooled him down and said well, and then he realised that I'd employed this lumberjack. He wasn't part of Satipanya. That cooled him down a bit. And very slowly over a little bit of period of time he sort of began to cool down. And this guy then approached and said, reminded him that he just threatened him with his life. A simple apology would do. And finally he just made a very quick apology. That was good. And he went out with his tail between his legs. He'd got the whole situation completely wrong.

And it was, I mean I don't know whether I would have reacted like that if I'd have been there at the beginning of the argument. It was that I entered into it thinking it was nothing to do with me. I was absolutely stable. And when he turned on me I was able to maintain that sort of stability. And that immediately gave nothing for this rage to hang on to. So that's always a little example from my own life telling me that equanimity is always the best policy.

So that's this right speech business, approaching people in a way which is always kind. And kindness undermines any form of anger. It's got nothing to hold on to. As you know, if somebody approaches you in a sort of accusatory way, as soon as you say, I'm sorry, that undermines the whole thing. And then of course you prove it was their fault. But it's just always undermining their anger is part and parcel of the good life. Which as we can see doesn't stop you from getting your point across. It's just making that little distinction there.

So it's a good thing to keep in mind the distinction between being aggressive and being assertive. And that when we're assertive it doesn't have to be done with a strict, loud voice coming from the position of righteousness. I mean, that's basically another form of aggression in a way.

So this right speech has always the negative side and the positive side with these instructions. When it comes to right action, that's normally described as these five precepts that we say in the morning. And it's the basically, that's what you don't do.

So we try not to harm any living being, not to kill any living being, not to harm any living being. Well, I mean, as soon as you take that position, then of course you move towards caring for all living beings. And of course, this takes us into that whole area of vegetarianism, which is a constant question within Buddhist circles. Should we be vegetarian?

In Buddhist culture, the only vegetarians that I know of are the Chinese monks. They can be very strict vegetarian. And I once did a wedding ceremony for a Chinese woman who was marrying an Englishman. And after the ceremony, she came up to me quite worried and said that at the banquet, at the banquet which they would have after this ceremony, they'd be eating meat. So I gave her the normal line that the Buddha didn't ban eating meat. That wasn't the problem. So it's up to a person's sensibility, really.

At the monastery I joined in Sri Lanka, one of the monks very proudly came up to me and said, we're vegetarians, because monks eat meat if they're offered meat. It's not a problem, but the message had gone out that monks at Khandaboda were vegetarians. So I'd not been there for two or three meals when fish turns up. And so I didn't say any-

thing, of course. One has to be careful. And I heard later that a rather wry Westerner had said that, well, in Sri Lanka, fish are self-propelling, automated vegetables. So that's it. So it depends where you draw the line.

As you know, in Western culture, the Benedictines were vegetarian, but they did eat fish. They had pools in which they kept fish. So fish vegetarians. The problem is not the eating of meat, of course, it's the killing of the animal. And it's up to a person to decide where they are in that sort of loop.

So of course when you buy the meat you support the butcher and so on and so forth, and it depends on really what your body needs. So I know a woman who has only got half a kidney and basically she has to eat meat, it seems. There's also this argument of blood groups. Certain blood groups are meat eaters rather than vegetarian eaters, which mirror our ancestral history. But I think it's up to every individual to decide whether they want to be vegetarian or not, or even vegan or not. It's up to you.

As a monastic, of course, because you're receiving alms, that's what you eat, because you haven't been in that loop. This is the point. You might say, well, you hold your bowl out and you get a great big chunk of beef. But the thing is that monks don't invite people to give them food. They can say, I prefer to be vegetarian. In Burma, during the rainy season, when monks and nuns gather to do special practice, often they'll take a vegetarian vow.

But if I know that you've killed an animal to feed me, I can't eat it. That's my rule. If it's a leftover or it's part of something and then I turn up at the door with my bowl and you put a leg of chicken in there, then that would be allowable. But if I'd known you'd ripped this leg off, especially for me, then the chicken was hopping around, I'd have to refuse it.

So there's this whole murky area around vegetarianism where the Buddha didn't basically make any strict laws. And you must remember that in those times there was famine. And you had to kill your livestock to keep alive. And how are you going to teach the Buddha Dhamma to Eskimos? Or Inuits rather, as they prefer these days. Or people who live in deserts. So it's like there's no, in this idea of a relative universe, everything dependent on something else, you can't make absolute laws. Even killing, you can't make an absolute law about killing.

When I was at the monastery in Burma it was regularly fumigated for mosquitoes, so nobody complained about that. So there are different degrees of moral law out there, and it's up to the individual to decide where they are, that's all. So it's very rare that something is absolutely black and white.

So the second one, of course, is not to take what is not freely given. So that's a pretty, when you think about things, you might even become sensitive to taking even a pen home from work, because it's not given for that reason. So it gets, the more you get into these rules and regulations, the more refined they become. It's not just thieving something.

In the Buddhist monk's rules, if I have a liking for that bowl, for instance, it's a singing bowl, and I think, hmm, and I'm looking around to see if I can just slip it in my bag and borrow it, then of course that's still at the thought level. So I haven't actually broken any rule. All rules to do with monks and nuns are to do with action. And then if I come in again and see that rule, and then I'm overtaken by my desire to slip it away, and my hand moves towards it, but I don't actually, to the point of touching it, that's called a *dukkata*, that's a bad thing to do. Moving towards it.

If I touch it, then that's called a heavy offence. Now if I move it a nanometre and then decide not to take it, I've still committed an act of theft and I'm no longer a monk. Yeah. So the Buddha is quite clear about what constitutes an act and what doesn't constitute an act.

So if you take that into all sorts of areas of your life, you can see so long as it's in the mind, it's not manifested outward, it's not done harm out there. It's done harm within here if you've indulged it, but it's not done harm out there. And so long as you're moving towards something, towards you're about to do something, of course, you're now into a dangerous area where you might actually find yourself doing something you didn't want to do. But once you've actually done it, even if you then decide not to do it, but once it's done, it's done. That's it. The act is complete.

Of course, the consequence is different. The consequence of, say, just moving that bowl a nanometre and then saying, whoa, no, and then walking away, well, there's going to be no consequence to that. But to actually stick it in my coat and shoot off with it and be caught at the gates, that could be, my whole reputation as a completely enlightened being might just fall apart. You can't imagine the Buddha shoplifting, can you? It wouldn't sort of fit.

So that whole business about not taking. Now, the opposite of that, of course, is generosity. Move towards generosity. And generosity was the subject that the Buddha always began his talks with when he talked to lay people, because anybody can be generous, even a thief can be generous with the stuff they've just thieved. So generosity is not, it's a sort of, it comes prior in a sense to the rule about taking and not taking. Anybody can be generous with what they have, and remember generosity is to do with both time, both wealth and time. And that's what it leads to.

Once you stop thinking about what I want. So at the worst end, it's taking something which is not ours, right? But then in the middle, it's this sort of greed of always wanting something. It's always wanting what other people have and envy and jealousy and all that sort of stuff. And when all that passes, where does that energy go? All that wanting, it moves outwards into wanting others to have it. And that's this natural transformation of the negative side of our characters and personalities towards the positive. It just happens naturally.

And I think one way that we can see that we're progressing spiritually is that we're getting far more delight in giving than in receiving. That's always a good sign, that you delight in giving. That's one of the Buddha's phrases, to delight in giving.

The third one is normally translated as around sexual activity, not to abuse our sexual activity. And of course in those days, as in previous times in the West, that would have been confined to the married life, to that type of relationship. These days of course it sort of lengthens out to a loving relationship, doesn't it? Whenever I talk about this I always say this, of course, that sex is just by itself it becomes an empty experience. And then I always quote Woody Allen, but as empty experiences go... So it's just one of those things.

But really that precept I think you can lengthen it out to any lust for anything. Lust for food, lust for getting out into the open. It's just that part of us that is overreaching. Again it always comes back to this seeking happiness in the sensual world.

The fourth one is wrong speech. Oh, wait a minute. I said wrong speech first, did I? So it should have been not to harm any living beings, wrong speech. That should have come fourth, actually. Sorry. And then there was not to take what is not freely given. And then there's this business of not to abuse the senses. And then finally, always a tricky one for a Western culture, not to take drinks and drugs that cloud the mind.

So the normal question is well what's wrong with a glass of wine? Especially if you're French. What's wrong with a glass of wine? If you're Italian I mean, how can you not have a glass of wine with your spaghetti? So really again this comes back to the individual. I mean generally speaking in our culture to have a glass of wine with food is neither here nor there. It's not. But in the scriptures, the reason for this is that under the influence of it, you do things which you would not normally do. That's the problem with specifically alcohol. And it's up to a person's refinement. I mean, some teachers would say that you mustn't ever go near alcohol, but it's up to the individual to decide what mental state arises when they take alcohol.

I remember when I first started meditating I'd come out of an evening session and I hadn't eaten and I went into a pub and I had half a bitter, just to test it actually, to test the effect of half a bitter on my mindfulness. That's true, I did. And I drank this half of bitter and I sat there and I swear I felt this curtain fall down on the brain. It just came right down. And I thought well this is it. This is what it does. It does have, even a small amount of alcohol does have an effect on your level of consciousness and what you're doing.

So considering that we're trying to develop our awareness, the last thing we want to do is do something which is undermining that development. So again it's left up to the individual. The Eastern culture is not so alcoholic based. I mean they have alcohol but as far as I know there's none of this, there's none of the culture of wine. Culture of tea, but not of wine.

And when it comes to recreational drugs, well, that's the same thing. Recreational drugs distort your consciousness, so you'd have to decide whether that's what you want to do or not. So that whole area, really, for somebody who is bent on purifying their minds and on consciousness, then of course they'd come off all that stuff.

So those are the five basic rules, you might say, of what not to do. But that doesn't cover, in a sense, all the goodnesses that we're asked to develop. So the four of them, the four illimitables, are love, compassion, joy, and peace. And I'll say more about that tomorrow when we do the loving-kindness meditation, the *metta*. But these are your basic relationships to life and they're illimitable because the development of the mind is seemingly indefinite. It's a bit like number. No matter how great a number you can conceive, you can always add one. It's like an eternity of numbers.

So it's the same with the mind, the heart. You can continue to develop it. And there are meant to be innumerable number of beings. So you can be there forever offering *metta* and an occasional lunch break.

The others are the ten *parami*. *Parami* means the other shore. And it's normally translated as perfections, which is a bit, that gives you the idea that you've come to the end of this, a perfection. But basically they're virtues. I would much prefer the word virtues. And they include a host of things. I'll just read them out. *Parami*.

The first one is this generosity. The second one is the moral law which we've discussed. The third one is renunciation. So here we have to make, I think I've said before, the distinction between self mortification and renunciation. Renunciation is giving up something to see what our attachment is to it, and in seeing our attachment we wait for that attachment to go.

So one of the things I've suggested is whatever your most enjoyable program is on the telly, to sit there with a cup of tea and a biscuit and don't turn it on. And just feel the pain. So you wait for it to pass, wait for it to pass, and keep doing that until it's all gone and you don't care about that program anymore. So then you can watch it.

Wisdom, of course. Energy, so that's this business of right energy, putting the right energy into something. Patience. The Buddha calls patience the highest form of ascetic practice, to be able to bear with, not to lose one's patience over things, to become irritable. So of course, to be patient, you have to sit in the other person's place, don't you? You have to be in the other person's side to understand why they're behaving like that. Why the train is late, all that sort of stuff.

Truthfulness, we've talked about. Resolution. You hear me go on and on about resolution. So there it is in one of the *parami*. It's a commitment. You keep making resolutions. Even if you fail, it doesn't matter. You just keep putting energy into a resolution. And eventually, it grows in energy. And it takes a hold on us.

Loving kindness, *metta*, which we'll do tomorrow. And of course equanimity.

And I'll just read out what this says in the commentary, which sort of puts them all together for us, so that you can understand that although there is this negative, what we shouldn't do, there's much more about what we should be doing to develop our hearts and develop our relationship to the world. So here's what the *Visuddhimagga* says. The *Visuddhimagga* is a later work which is considered the handbook, really, of Theravada Buddhism, and it's probably one of the greatest spiritual classics of the world, really. But this is what it says, anyway.

"As the great beings, meaning someone destined to become liberated or Buddhahood, are concerned with the welfare of living beings, not tolerating the suffering of beings, wishing long duration to the higher states of happiness of beings, and being impartial and just to all beings, therefore they give alms to all beings so that they may be happy, without investigating whether they are worthy or not. By avoiding doing them harm, they observe morality. And in order to bring morality to perfection, they train themselves in renunciation. In order to understand clearly what is beneficial and injurious to beings, they purify their wisdom. For the sake of the welfare and happiness of others, they constantly exert their energy. Though having become heroes through utmost energy, they are nevertheless full of forbearance towards the manifold failings of beings. And once they have promised to give or to do something, they do not break their promise. With unshakable resolution, they work for the welfare of beings. With unshakable kindness, they are helpful to all. And by reason of their equanimity, they do not expect anything in return."

That's nice, isn't it? Very good. So that's the positive side of what you might call right action.

Then we move on now to right livelihood. So there are those livelihoods we're not supposed to get involved in, like one of them is of course killing animals and arms trafficking, human beings. I mean, you can think of those. But the big thing about livelihood is not what you do but how you do it. This is I think the real core of the thing. Whether we're doing some of the unskilled jobs of society, like cleaning parks, cleaning, that sort of thing, or whether we're doing some of the most highly skilled work in society, in spiritual terms it's irrelevant. In spiritual terms it's the attitude with which you do it.

So if you see what you're doing as a service, then it becomes a spiritual practice. And once we've grasped that, then it makes work very worthwhile, because all the things that we might suffer at work, such as the boredom of it or the tedium of it or the fact that other people are nasty to us, all that whole area, when it becomes a service that you're giving, then it all becomes very worthwhile. And I think that's the, if we start from that, if in the morning having done your two hours meditation you sit quietly and offer *metta* to all beings and then you get round to work, where you're going to spend really the better part of our lives, eight hours a day or so, and so you sit there and you just consider what you do and you do it for the benefit of the people you're working with, for the benefit of the firm or the organisation, and through that for the benefit of all. And if we engender that within us of course then it becomes meaningful no matter what we're doing.

When I was a kid I got a job from school. I work in a cake factory. And they had this belt with the cakes coming off. And there was a group of women, and they put me on the end of the line. And the women, of course, were very used to this sort of work, and I'd just joined them. And they were very quick with their hands and could keep up quite complex conversations. My job was to stick this damn cherry on the top. And every time I missed, I had to shut the machine down. They got a bit upset with me. And I didn't quite get the hang of it. They didn't give me enough time. They'd have given me half a day to get into it. But they were very kind. He's only a lad, leave him alone.

Now you think, well, how could you do something like that and turn that into a spiritual practice? Especially on a sort of production line like that. How could you do that? Well, if you think about it, it's an enormously, if I'd have known, if I'd have been into this sort of practice, this was an enormous opportunity to develop moment-to-moment concentration. Right attitude, completely there with the cherry on the cake. Just like that, on the cake, on the cake. Instead I was, oh, bloody hell, I've been doing this all day.

And of course, if you're on the line, you're on the line for hours. Two hours, ding, the bell goes off, a cup of tea, bang, off you go again. I once had a job just punching holes in this damn thing for shot after shot, in front of my eyes.

So any situation can be seen as having potential for some sort of spiritual practice. So, yes, that is service. Service is the important thing to remember when it comes to work.

So now, if we leave it all there in terms of general guidelines about our lives, I mean, there's books written on it, lots of good books about daily life and all that. The idea of taking refuge and precepts for the people who do it is that, in a sense, you've got to have some sort of reference point in the spiritual life. It doesn't matter what it is so long as it's obviously worthwhile. But if you keep hopping from here to there, then it's like you're using different value systems which eventually can just confuse you.

So if we look at our lives and think well, is there an authority, a final authority I go to for moral problems, for actual guidance? Is there a moral authority, an ethical authority I go to whom I really trust? And from there I would be able to put into context any other information I get, any other spiritual instruction I get. If you take that position, it doesn't stop you from this authority taking in other teachings, other traditions, except that it has to make sense to this central authority. If it doesn't, you've got two authorities, and that's when your confusion starts. Like, who do I follow, what should I do?

And the idea of taking refuge and precepts is, at one level it can be a very general commitment to the spiritual life, and at others it can be quite specific.

Okay. So we take refuge in the Buddha. So the Buddha is a historical personage. We have lots of information about his life and how he lived. We have lots of information about the people around him at the time, with an enormous amount of information about his teachings and what he proposed. And to take refuge in that is to take refuge in not simply some personage but an exemplar. So this is your example. And in a sense the Buddha is mirroring some archetype within us. There's something in us that has to be liberated. And so that would, and the Buddha's path is, shall we say, specific to the Buddha.

If you were a Christian, then Jesus, Jesus Christ would be your central authority. So often I get, for instance, people who are Christians saying, can I meditate? So my answer is, I don't see a confusion, but you've got to make sense of this within the teachings of Jesus Christ. And if you can't, then it creates a contradiction. It just creates wasted energy.

So some people, of course, won't go near other practices who are more fundamentalist Christians. But there are many monks and nuns, actually, within Christianity, within the Catholic tradition, and also the Anglican tradition here in Britain, who practice some form of Buddhist meditation. And there's a nun who lives out in the Brecon Be

Mahāsi Sayādaw: Practical Vipassanā Meditation Instructions

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min read

This foundational teaching presents the complete practical instructions for Vipassanā meditation as taught by the renowned Burmese master Venerable Mahāsi Sayādaw at Sasānayeikta Meditation Center in Yangon, Myanmar. The Sayādaw provides detailed guidance on establishing the primary object of noting the rising and falling of the abdomen, which represents the vāyo-dhātu (element of motion) and serves as the anchor for developing satipaṭṭhāna.

The instructions cover the four foundations of awareness systematically: beginning with kāyānupassanā (awareness of the body) through abdominal movements, progressing to vedanānupassanā (awareness of feelings) when noting physical sensations like stiffness and pain, cittānupassanā (awareness of mind-states) when noting wandering thoughts, and dhammānupassanā (awareness of mental objects) through recognizing the arising and passing of phenomena.

Sayādaw emphasizes the crucial importance of continuous, patient noting without gaps, comparing the practice to producing fire through sustained effort. He provides specific guidance for noting during daily activities—walking, sitting, lying down, eating—and explains how this leads progressively through the vipassanā ñāṇas (insight knowledges), beginning with nāma-rūpa-pariccheda-ñāṇa (knowledge distinguishing mind and matter) and culminating in the realization of anicca, dukkha, and anattā that leads to Nibbāna. The teaching concludes with encouragement that diligent practitioners may achieve the noble attainments within days or weeks of dedicated practice.

The following is a talk given by the Venerable Mahāsi Sayādaw, Ekā Mahāpaṇḍita Ūsopanā, given to his disciples on their induction into vipassanā meditation at Sāsānāyeta Meditation Centre, Yangon, Myanmar.

Practical Vipassanā Meditational Exercises

The practice of vipassanā or insight meditation is the effort made by the meditator to understand correctly the nature of the psychophysical phenomena taking place in his own body. Physical phenomena are the things or objects which one clearly perceives around one. The whole of one's body that one clearly perceives constitutes a group of

material qualities, *rūpa*. Psychical or mental phenomena are acts of consciousness or awareness. These *nāma-rūpas* are clearly perceived to be happening whenever they are seen, heard, smelled, tasted, touched or thought of.

We must make ourselves aware of them, observing them and noting thus: seeing, seeing; hearing, hearing; smelling, smelling; tasting, tasting; touching, touching; or thinking, thinking. Every time one sees, hears, smells, tastes, touches or thinks, one should make a note of the fact. But in the beginning of one's practice one cannot make a note of every one of these happenings. One should, therefore, begin with noting those happenings which are conspicuous and easily perceivable.

With every act of breathing the abdomen rises and falls. This movement is always evident. This is the material quality known as *vāyodhātu*, the element of motion. One should begin by noting this movement, which may be done by the mind intently observing the abdomen. You will find the abdomen rising when you breathe in and falling when you breathe out. The rising should be noted mentally as "rising" and the falling as "falling."

If the movement is not evident by just noting it mentally, keep touching the abdomen with the palm of your hand. Do not alter the manner of your breathing. Neither slow it down nor make it faster. Do not breathe too vigorously either. You will tire if you change the manner of your breathing. Breathe steadily as usual and note the rising and falling of the abdomen as they occur. Note it mentally, not verbally. In *vipassanā* meditation, what you name or say doesn't matter. What really matters is to know or perceive.

While noting the rising of the abdomen, do so from the beginning to the end of the movement, just as if you are seeing with your eyes. Do the same with the falling movement. Note the rising movement in such a way that your awareness of it is concurrent with the movement itself. The movement and the mental awareness of it should coincide in the same way as a stone thrown hits the target. Similarly with the falling movement.

Your mind may wander elsewhere while you are noting the abdominal movement. This must also be noted by mentally saying "wandering, wandering." When this has been noted once or twice, the mind stops wandering, in which case you go back to noting the rising and falling of the abdomen. If the mind reaches somewhere, note as "reaching, reaching," then go back to the rising and falling of the abdomen. If you imagine meeting somebody, note as "meeting, meeting," then back to the rising and falling. If you imagine meeting and talking to somebody, note as "talking, talking."

In short, whatever thought or reflection occurs should be noted. If you imagine, note as "imagining." If you think, "thinking." If you plan, "planning." If you perceive, "perceiving." If you reflect, "reflecting." If you feel happy, "happy." If you feel bored, "bored." If you feel glad, "glad." If you feel disheartened, "disheartened." Noting all these acts of consciousness is called *cittānupassanā*.

Because we fail to note these acts of consciousness, we tend to identify them with a person or individual. We tend to think that it is I who is imagining, thinking, planning, knowing or perceiving. We think that there is a person who from childhood onwards has been living and thinking. Actually no such person exists. There are instead only these continuing and successive acts of consciousness. That is why we have to know these acts of consciousness and know them for what they are. That is why we have to note each and every act of consciousness as it arises. When so noted, it tends to disappear. We then go back to noting the rising and falling of the abdomen.

When you have sat meditating for long, sensations of stiffness and heat will arise in your body. These are to be noted carefully too. Similarly, with sensations of pain and tiredness, all of these sensations are *dukkha vedanā*, feeling of unsatisfactoriness, noting them as *vedanānupassanā*. Failure or omission to note these sensations makes you think: "I am stiff, I am feeling hot, I am in pain. I was alright a moment ago, now I am uneasy with these unpleasant sensations." The identification of these sensations with the ego is mistaken. There is really no "I" involved, only a succession of one new unpleasant sensation after another. It is just like a continuous succession of new electrical impulses that light up electric lamps. Every time unpleasant contacts are encountered in the body, unpleasant sensations arise one after another. These sensations should be carefully and intently noted, whether they are sensations of stiffness, of heat, or of pain.

In the beginning of the yogi's meditational practice, these sensations may tend to increase and lead to a desire to change his posture. This desire should be noted, after which the yogi should go back to noting the sensation of stiffness, heat, etc. "Patience leads to Nibbāna," as the saying goes. This saying is most relevant in meditational effort. One must be patient in meditation. If one shifts or changes one's posture too often because one cannot be patient with the sensation of stiffness or heat that arises, *samādhi*, good concentration, cannot develop. If *samādhi* cannot develop, insight cannot result, and there can be no attainment of *magga*, the path that leads to Nibbāna, *phala*, the fruit of that path, and Nibbāna.

That is why patience is needed in meditation. It is patience mostly with unpleasant sensations in the body, like stiffness, sensations of heat and pain, and other sensations that are hard to bear. One should not immediately give up one's meditation on the appearance of such sensations and change one's meditational posture. One should go on patiently, just noting as "stiffness, stiffness," or "heat, heat." Moderate sensations of these kinds will disappear if one goes on noting them patiently. When concentration is good and strong, even intense sensations tend to disappear. One then reverts to noting the rising and falling of the abdomen.

One will, of course, have to change one's posture if the sensations do not disappear, even after one has noted them for a long time, and if, on the other hand, they become unbearable. One should then begin noting as "wishing to change, wishing to change." If the arm rises, notice "rising, rising." If it moves, note "moving, moving." This change should be made gently. Note that it is "rising, rising," "moving, moving," and "touching, touching." If the body sways, "swaying, swaying." If the foot rises, "rising, rising." If it moves, "moving, moving." If it drops, "dropping, dropping." If there is no change but only static rest, go back to noting the rising and falling of the abdomen.

There must be no intermission in between, only continuity between a preceding act of noting and a succeeding one, between a preceding *samādhi* state of concentration and succeeding one, between the preceding act of intelligence and succeeding one. Only then will there be successive and ascending stages of maturity in the yogi's state of intelligence. *Magga* and *phala ñāṇa*, knowledge of the path and fruition, are attained only when there is this gathering momentum.

The meditative process is like that of producing fire by energetically and unremittingly rubbing two sticks of wood together so as to attain the necessary intensity of heat when the flame arises. In the same way, the noting in *vipassanā* meditation should be continual and unremitting, without any resting interval between acts of noting whatever phenomena may arise. For instance, if a sensation of itchiness intervenes and the yogi desires to scratch because it is hard to bear, both the sensations and the desire to get rid of it should be noted, without immediately getting rid of the sensations by scratching. If one goes on perseveringly noting thus, the itchiness may generally disappear, in which case one reverts to noting the rising and falling of the abdomen. If the itchiness does not disappear, one has, of course, to eliminate it by scratching. But first, the desire to do so should be noted. All the movements involved in the process of eliminating this sensation should be noted, especially the touching, pulling, pushing and scratching movements with an eventual reversion to noting the rising and falling of the abdomen.

Every time you make a change of posture, you begin with noting your intention or desire to make the change and go on to noting every movement closely, such as rising from the sitting posture, raising the arm, moving and stretching it. You should make the change at the same time as noting the movements involved. As your body sways forward, note it. As you rise, the body becomes light and rises. Concentrating your mind on this, you should gently note as "rising, rising."

The yogi should behave as if he were a weak invalid. People in normal health rise easily and quickly or abruptly. Not so with feeble invalids who do so slowly and gently. The same is the case with people suffering from backache who rise gently lest the back hurt and cause pain. So also with meditating yogis. They have to make their changes of posture gradually and gently. Only then will mindfulness, concentration and insight be good. Begin, therefore, with gentle and gradual movements. When rising, the yogi must do so gently like an invalid, at the same time noting as "rising, rising."

Not only this. Though the eye sees, the yogi must act as if he does not see. Similarly, when the ear hears, while meditating, the yogi's concern is only to note. What he sees or hears are not his concern. So whatever strange or striking things he may see or hear, he must behave as if he does not see or hear them, merely noting carefully.

When making bodily movements, the yogi should do so gradually as if he were a weak invalid, gently moving the arms and legs, bending or stretching them, bending down the head and bringing it up. All these movements should be made gently. When rising from the sitting posture, he should do so gradually, noting as "rising, rising." When straightening up, standing, note as "standing, standing." When looking here and there, note as "looking, seeing."

When walking, note the steps, whether they are taken with the right or the left foot. You must be aware of all the successive movements involved, from the raising of the foot to the dropping of it. Note each step taken, whether with the right foot or the left foot. This is the manner of noting when one walks fast. It will be enough if you note this when walking fast and walking some distance.

When walking slowly or doing the *caṅkama* walk, walking up and down, three movements should be noted in each step: when the foot is raised, when it is pushed forward, and when it is dropped. Begin with noting the raising and dropping movements. One must be properly aware of the raising of the foot. Similarly, when the foot is dropped, one should be properly aware of the heavy falling of the foot. One must walk noting as "raising, dropping" with each step. This noting will become easier after about two days. Then go on to noting the three movements as described above, as "raising,

pushing forward, dropping." In the beginning, it will suffice to note one or two movements only. Thus, "right step, left step," when walking fast, and "raising, dropping," when walking slowly.

When walking thus, if you want to sit down, note as "wanting to sit down, wanting to sit down." When actually sitting down, note concentratedly the heavy falling of your body. When you are seated, note the movements involved in arranging your legs and arms. When there are no such movements, but just a stillness, static rest of the body, note the rising and falling of the abdomen. While noting thus, if stiffness or beliefs and sensation of heat in any part of your body arise, go on to note them, then back to "rising, falling."

While noting thus, if a desire to lie down arises, note it and the movements of your legs and arms as you lie down: the raising of the arm, the moving of it, the resting of the elbow on the floor, the swaying of the body, the stretching of the legs, the listing of the body as one slowly prepares to lie down. All these movements should be noted. To note as you lie down thus is important. In the course of this movement, that is lying down, you can gain a distinctive knowledge, that is *magga ñāṇa* and *phala ñāṇa*, the knowledge of the path and its fruition. When *samādhi*, concentration, and *ñāṇa*, insight, are strong, the distinctive knowledge can come at any moment. It can come in a single bend of the arm or in a single stretch of the arm.

Thus it was that the Venerable Ānanda became an *arahant*. The Venerable Ānanda was trying strenuously to attain *arahantship* overnight on the eve of the first Buddhist council. He was practicing the whole night the form of *vipassanā* meditation known as *kāyagatāsati*, noting his steps, right and left, raising, pushing forward and dropping of the feet, noting, happening by happening, the mental desire to walk and the physical movement involved in walking. Although this went on till it was nearly dawn, he had not yet succeeded in attaining *arahantship*. Realising that he had practiced the walking meditation to excess and that in order to balance *samādhi*, concentration, and *vīriya*, effort, he should practice meditation in the lying posture for a while, he entered his chamber. He sat on the couch and then laid himself down. While doing so and noting "lying, lying," he attained *arahantship* in an instant.

The Venerable Ānanda was only a *sotāpanna*, that is, a stream-winner, or one who has attained the first stage of the path to Nibbāna, before he thus laid himself down. From *sotāpanna* he continued to meditate and reached *sakadāgāmi*, that is, the condition of the once-returner, or one who has attained the second stage on the path; *anāgāmi*, that is, the state of the non-returner or one who has attained the third stage on

the path; and *arahantship*, that is, the condition of the noble one who has attained the last stage on the path. Reaching these three successive stages of the higher path took only a little while.

Just think of this example of the Venerable Ānanda's attainment of *arahantship*. Such attainment can come at any moment and need not take long. That is why the yogi should note with diligence all the time. He should not relax in his noting, thinking "this little lapse should not matter much."

All movements involved in lying down and arranging the arms and legs should be carefully and unremittingly noted. If there is no movement but only stillness of the body, go back to noting the rising and falling of the abdomen. Even when it is getting late and time for sleep, the yogi should not go to sleep yet, dropping his noting. A really serious and energetic yogi should practice mindfulness as if he were foregoing his sleep altogether. He should go on meditating till he falls asleep. If the meditation is good and has the upper hand, he will not fall asleep. If, on the other hand, drowsiness has the upper hand, he will fall asleep.

When he feels sleepy, he should note as "sleepy, sleepy." If his eyelids droop, "drooping." If they become heavy or leaden, "heavy." If the eyes become smarting, "smarting." Noting thus, the drowsiness may pass and the eyes become clear again. The yogi should then note as "clear, clear," and go on to note the rising and falling of the abdomen.

However perseveringly the yogi may go on meditating, if real drowsiness intervenes, he does fall asleep. It is not difficult to fall asleep. In fact, it is easy. If you meditate in the lying posture, you gradually become drowsy and eventually fall asleep. That is why the beginner in meditation should not meditate too much in the lying position. He should meditate much more in the sitting and walking postures of the body. But as it grows late and becomes time for sleep, he should meditate in the lying position, noting the rising and falling movements of the abdomen. He will then naturally, automatically fall asleep.

The time he is asleep is the resting time for the yogi. But for the really serious yogi, he should limit his sleeping time to about four hours. This is the midnight period permitted by the Buddha. Four hours sleep is quite enough. If the beginner in meditation thinks that four hours sleep is not enough for health, he may extend it to five or six hours. Six hours sleep is clearly enough for health.

When a yogi awakens, he should at once resume noting. The yogi who is really bent on attaining *magga* and *phala ñāṇa* should rest from the meditational effort only when he is asleep. At other times, in his waking movements, he should be noting continually

and without rest. That is why, as soon as he awakens, he should note the awakening state of his mind as "awakening, awakening." If he cannot yet make himself aware of this, he should begin noting the rising and falling of the abdomen.

If he intends to get up from bed, he should note as "intending to get up, intending to get up." He should then go on to note the changing movements he makes as he arranges his arms and legs. When he raises his head and rises, note as "rising, rising." When he is seated, note as "sitting, sitting." If he makes any changing movements as he arranges his arms and legs, all of these movements should also be noted. If there are no such changes, but only sitting quietly, he should revert to noting the rising and falling movements of the abdomen.

One should also note when one washes one's face and when one takes a bath. As the movements involved in these acts are rather quick, as many of them should be noted as possible. There are then acts of dressing, of tidying up the bed, of opening and closing the door. All these should also be noted as closely as possible.

When the yogi has his meal and looks at the meal table, he should note "looking, seeing, looking, seeing." When he extends his arm towards the food, touches it, collects and arranges it, handles it and brings it to the mouth, bends his head and puts the morsel of food into his mouth, drops his arm and raises his head again, all these movements should be duly noted. This way of noting is in accordance with the Burmese way of taking a meal. Those who use fork and spoon or chopsticks should note the movements in an appropriate manner.

When he chews the food, he should note "chewing, chewing." When he comes to know the taste of the food, he should note "knowing, knowing." As he relishes the food and swallows it, as the food goes down his throat, he should note all these happenings. This is how the yogi should note as he takes one morsel after another of his food. As he takes his soup, all the movements involved, such as extending of the arm, handling of the spoon, and scooping with it, and so on, all these should be noted.

To note thus at meal times is rather difficult, as there are so many things to observe and note. The beginning yogi is likely to miss several things which he should note, but he should resolve to note all. He cannot, of course, help it if he overlooks and misses some, but as his *samādhi*, concentration, becomes strong, he will be able to note closely all these happenings.

I have mentioned so many things for the yogi to note. But to summarise, there are only a few things to note. When walking fast, note "right step, left step." "Raising, dropping," when walking slowly. When sitting quietly, just note the rising and falling of the

abdomen. Note the same when you are lying, if there is nothing particular to note. While noting thus, if the mind wanders, note the acts of consciousness that arise, then back to the rising and falling of the abdomen. Note also the sensation of stiffness, pain and ache and itchiness as they arise, then back to the rising and falling of the abdomen. Note also as they arise the bending and stretching and moving of the limbs, bending and raising of the head, swaying and straightening of the body, then back to the rising and falling of the abdomen.

As the yogi goes on noting thus, he will be able to note more and more of these happenings. In the beginning, as his mind wanders here and there, the yogi may miss noting many things, but he should not be disheartened. Every beginner in meditation encounters the same difficulty, but as he becomes more practiced, he becomes aware of every act of mind wandering till eventually the mind does not wander anymore. The mind is then riveted on the object of its attention, the act of mindfulness becoming almost simultaneous with the object of its attention, such as the rising and falling of the abdomen. In other words, the rising of the abdomen becomes concurrent with the act of noting it and similarly with the falling of the abdomen.

The physical object of attention and the mental act of noting are occurring as a pair. There is in this occurrence no person or individual involved. Only this physical object of attention and the mental act of noting occurring as a pair. The yogi will in time actually and personally experience these occurrences. While noting the rising and falling of the abdomen, he will come to distinguish the rising of the abdomen as physical phenomena and the mental act of noting of it as psychical phenomena. Similarly with the falling of the abdomen. Thus, the yogi will distinctly come to realise the simultaneous occurrence in pairs of these psychophysical phenomena.

Thus, with every act of noting, the yogi will come to know for himself clearly that there are only this material quality which is the object of awareness or attention and the mental quality that makes a note of it. This discriminating knowledge is called *nāma-rūpa pariccheda ñāṇa*, the beginning of the *vipassanā ñāṇa*. It is important to gain this knowledge correctly. This will be succeeded, as the yogi goes on, by a knowledge that distinguishes between the cause and its effect, which knowledge is called *pac-cayapariggaha ñāṇa*.

As the yogi goes on noting, he will see for himself that what arises passes away after a short while. Ordinary people assume that both the material and the mental phenomena go on lasting throughout life, that is, from youth to adulthood. In fact, that is not so. There is no phenomenon that lasts forever. All phenomena arise and pass away so rap-

idly that they do not last even for the twinkling of an eye. The yogi will come to know this for himself as he goes on noting. He will then become convinced of the impermanency of all such phenomena. Such conviction is called *aniccānupassanā ñāṇa*.

This knowledge will be succeeded by *dukkhānupassanā ñāṇa*, which realises that all this impermanency is suffering. The yogi is also likely to encounter all kinds of hardship in his body, which is just an aggregate of sufferings. This is also *dukkhānupassanā ñāṇa*.

Next, the yogi will become convinced that all these psychophysical phenomena are occurring of their own accord, following nobody's will and subject to nobody's control. They constitute no individual or ego entity. This realisation is *anattānupassanā ñāṇa*.

When, as he goes on meditating, the yogi comes to realise firmly that all these phenomena are *anicca*, *dukkha* and *anattā*, he will attain Nibbāna. All the former Buddhas, *arahants* and *ariyas* realised Nibbāna following this very path. All meditating yogis should recognise that they themselves are now on this *satipaṭṭhāna* path in fulfilment of their wish for attainment of *magga ñāṇa*, knowledge of the path, *phala ñāṇa*, knowledge of the fruition of the path, and *nibbāna dhamma*, and following the ripening of their *pāramī*, perfection of virtue.

They should feel glad at this and at the prospect of experiencing the noble kind of *samādhi*, tranquillity of mind, brought about by concentration and *ñāṇa*, supra-mundane knowledge or wisdom, experienced by the Buddhas, *arahants* and *ariyas*, and which they themselves have never experienced before. It will not be long before they will experience for themselves the *magga ñāṇa* and *nibbāna dhamma* experienced by the Buddhas, *arahants* and *ariyas*. As a matter of fact, these may be experienced in the space of a month or of 20 or 15 days of the meditational practice. Those whose *pāramī* is exceptional may experience these dhammas even within seven days.

The yogi should therefore rest content in the faith that he will attain these dhammas in the time specified above, that he will be freed of *sakkāyadiṭṭhi*, ego-belief, and *vicikicchā*, doubt or uncertainty, and saved from the danger of rebirth in the lower worlds. He should go on with his meditational practice in this faith.

May you all be able to practice meditation well and quickly attain that Nibbāna which the Buddhas, *arahants* and *ariyas* have experienced. *Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu*.

Vedanā: Feeling

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min read

In this foundational talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores vedanā (feeling) within the Buddhist psychological framework, making crucial distinctions between physical sensations (mahābhūta - the four elements), mental formations (saṅkhāra), and our conditioned reactions. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), he explains how contact (phassa) produces simple bodily sensations that the mind perceives as pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral - this is vedanā proper.

The talk traces how vedanā fits into paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination): from initial contact through feeling to craving (taṇhā) and the arising of ego-identity. Bhante emphasizes that our power to break the cycle lies in observing our reactions to vedanā without indulgence or suppression. He contrasts Western psychological approaches with the Buddha's method, showing how staying with pure feeling - rather than analyzing emotions - allows mental turbulence to naturally exhaust itself while liberating consciousness from identification.

Practical guidance includes recognizing worldly versus spiritual feelings in meditation, observing the arising and passing nature of all sensations, and reaching moments of bare awareness where observer and observed merge. This understanding transforms both psychotherapy and spiritual development, offering a direct path to the unshackling of consciousness that defines nibbāna.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Homage to the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

This is going to try and talk about *vedanā*, feeling. I'm going to try and make a distinction between what are known as the *mahābhūta*, the four elements, and the *saṅkhāra*, which we would translate as mental, emotional states. I'm going to see where it fits into the schema of the wheel of dependent origination, and then try and understand the way the Buddha actually wanted us to experience these through the discourse on how to establish mindfulness and become enlightened very quickly.

One thing that I think we all suffer from is confusion, perhaps that's too strong a word, between the way that the West understands psychology and the way the Buddha understood it. Just in my own little life story, there was a time when I read a lot about

this stuff, Western psychology, and I came to the conclusion that I had truly sorted myself out. Only to find in a couple of years myself in this pit. And when I got into this pit, the only thing that came to mind was to do Zen meditation. I don't have a clue why. I mean it was in the air and I'd read a book and all that. So I wrote to the Buddhist Society and said I need to go to Japan to do meditation. And they wrote back with a letter with 21 points as to why I shouldn't go.

So I gave that up, and I ended up in a very exotic town of Birmingham and started practicing Zen according to the tradition of Throble Hole Abbey, which some of you may know up in Northumberland. And I was still doing a little bit of my own therapy. I think I beat the hell out of this mattress. And I found that that got me so far. I've got rid of this whole surface stuff. But then the more I got into meditation, the more I found a way of dealing with it.

And I was lucky in this sense that by the time I came to meditation, I'd actually given up hope, both on the Christian path and psychotherapy and all that. So when I entered Zen, and they just told me to sit and watch, just sit and observe, I took it at face value. I don't remember asking any questions as to why. And Zen, of course, doesn't offer you many answers for it. Just presumes you'll discover why. But it was only when I came to Theravāda Buddhism with its psychological basis, the way that it goes to great lengths to describe how and why we end up in certain places, that things began to fall into place for me intellectually. I began to understand what had been happening to me, especially through Zen and later through this meditation.

And again, when I went to practice with these Eastern teachers, you weren't given any reasons. You were just told to watch the breath and whatever comes up. And if you asked a question, they looked at you, mystified, wondering why the hell you wanted to know anyway. It's a strange thing to have to go through. And normally the reply was just something like, watch the breath.

Slowly, through the experience of meditation, of course, these things do become clear. And what became very clear to me as I began to progress was that unless you actually see what you're doing through the eyes of the Buddha, you can waste a lot of time. Waste a lot of time trying to psychoanalyze yourself or psychotherapeutize yourself. It's wrong view. And we get caught up in it. It's very easy because it's just part of our culture. But when you actually position yourself right and you get this way of looking at it, the way the Buddha asked us to, then you'll see there's a clarity comes about as to what the practice is doing, both at the psychotherapeutic level and at that deeper level of spirituality.

So the first thing I would like to explain is the way the Buddha explained how we experience things, how we come to know something. In terms of the first contact that we have with the outside world, he actually called it contact, translates the word *phassa* for those of you who know. And this contact produces in the body a very simple sensation, extraordinarily simple sensation. At the eardrum, it's simply the tapping of the airwave on the eardrum. There's no sound to it at all. That's how basic it is. And the eye, what is it? What is it that we actually see? We know through our psychology tests that we hardly see anything. Everything that we think we see is manufactured by the mind. And in a most mysterious way, the mind takes in the information, makes it up, throws it back on the retina to give us the impression that we're actually seeing it.

In terms of the tongue, what is it that the tongue actually experiences? But very small changes in chemical touchings and pressures and heat. Very, very, very, very basic. Now, on that, the mind takes it in and begins to perceive it as a specific feeling. And that's what the Buddha means by *vedanā*. And when that perception is made, there's always a judgment made about it. And the judgment is very simple. Pleasant, unpleasant. Full stop, that's it.

So you get this sensation come in, the mind takes it in, perceives it, and decides pleasant or unpleasant. There are some pleasant, unpleasant feelings that are so fine that the Buddha then also talks about neutral feelings. But even when you get close to them, you'll find that they shade off either into pleasant or unpleasant. So there's your first distinction when it comes to feelings. Feelings are something manufactured by the mind out of data. This is coming from the outside world. It's coming from the outside world to us.

In the same way, when the mind moves in the body, the first thing that we feel are sensations. The heaviness of depression, the wobbliness of fear. We can be aware of the sensation, we can be aware of the emotion, but at base it's causing similar sensations on the physical structure. These are also relayed to the mind and in Buddhist understanding are determined, judged as pleasant or unpleasant. Now that's *vedanā*. And the *vedanā* is a conditioned thing. We can't do anything about it. It's just part of our conditioning. We're conditioned to experience pleasant or unpleasant things with that little bit in the middle which is neutral.

Now, at that base where it's first of all experienced, the Buddha calls that this contact. And he says that at that very deep level, that very first level of physical contact, either with mind, where the mind and the body meet. So when that light comes into the eye, there's that sense base. And at that point you get a meeting of the physical sensation with consciousness and at that level he says that there are only four distinctive

feelings and they're put in a metaphorical way as fire, earth, water and air but they represent heat, hot and cold, pressure, that's the earth element, hardness, softness, movement and cohesion, elasticity.

So when you're watching the breath, this is of course more obvious if you're watching it down here, sometimes you can sense just the movement, pure movement as it were, and then you can be aware of elasticity. When you put your foot on the ground and press into it, what you're primarily feeling is that earth pressure. Heat, of course, is pretty obvious. Now, from these four basic things, and every sensation, according to the Buddha, has some percentage of each of these. It's not as though the one appears purely by itself. Each sensation has some combination, and out of that, the mind has a perception of a feeling.

Of course, this stuff's coming in at pretty fast speed, and the mind gathers it into a percept, a perception. And from that, it makes this judgment about being pleasant and unpleasant.

Now, the next thing that happens is our reaction to those things. So here we have the wheel of dependent origination. We have the contact of the feeling that arises and then we have the reaction. The reaction, the *taṇhā*, is rather unfortunately translated as craving. But it's a desire for not wanting what is painful and a desire for wanting what is beautiful, what is pleasant. That is a movement, again, in our psychology, in our mind, of going towards the object in a particular way. Either to get stuck in it and really enjoy it, or to try and push it away aggressively. And if that doesn't work, you run for it. It's a form of aversion.

Now, once that has come up, you see, the next position is a form of identity. The I comes in. According to the Buddha, there's no I, there's no sense of me in all that process until that very point. When the I want comes up, I don't want. And as soon as there's that association, as soon as there's that identity, very difficult to catch the moment, this wanting and not wanting is empowered. And that's the act of will. Will is the power that takes something out of potential into the actual.

So, for instance, in your walking meditation, you can stand there for a year and a day saying intending to walk. And then something magical happens. The foot moves. See if you can catch it. See if you can find out what's the difference between intending a footstep and the footsteps moving. And what we catch in that moment is the differentiation between this grasping by the I, the *upādāna*, to the actual empowerment of it through will, which is the *bhava*. Now, *bhava* translates as becoming. That's your *kamma*.

Now, the importance of this line is to see exactly where our power actually resides. Because if we can see that, we can let go of old conditioning and restart new, more skillful one. Now, that whole business afterwards, the desire, the craving and all that, is a mental reaction to a given and constitutes the beginning of our emotional life. These are what's known as the *saṅkhāra*, the conditionings. That's the mental life. And this is all our mentation and all our emotions.

So even in the five heaps that the Buddha calls, that he deconstructs the human being into, the five *khandhas*, first of all there's the body. Then there's feelings. Then there's perception. This whole mentation business. Then there's the *saṅkhāra*, the conditioning. And finally, the act of consciousness that knows it. So he's constantly deconstructing an event. And the purpose of it is to take this sense of I out of it.

So here we have three distinctions that we feel in our meditation. We feel at base some basic sensation. Even now as you're sitting there, like just the pressure of sitting on the floor there, you see, at that base there, you're getting in contact. If you center in just on those feelings, you're getting in contact with the earth element. And because it's neither painful nor unpleasant, the mind can ignore it. So we're hardly aware of those things. That's our reaction to what we don't really feel. If the posture then moves into a bit of pain, suddenly, you see, there's pain. Then you get this reaction, got to move, got to do this, got to do that.

So what we have is this base of sensation. Then we have a feeling come up, which is a perception of that as pleasant and unpleasant, so now it's surrounded with a mental quality of being pleasant, unpleasant, and this immediately begins for the mind to start shaking and it shakes in the sense of do I want it or don't want it, and that's where we're catching it.

Now normally speaking, in our own little deluded ways, we just run the gamut. And without knowing it, we're just recreating the old sensations, the old pleasures, the old ways of acting. But in our meditation, what we ought to be doing is putting our mind right there at the feeling and seeing that movement of wanting to indulge, wanting not to indulge. And what we're catching there is how we create suffering for ourselves.

So if we have those three things quite distinct in our minds, then when we begin to meditate, we can actually go through this stage of actually perceiving the way things really are. It's an intellectual thing at first. It's an actual, although we feel these things, although we experience these things, there is a thought process going around it. Now do remember that that thought process is this very consciousness which is to be enlightened, mirroring back to itself what it's come to experience. So it's not to be pushed out of the way, but to just be acknowledged.

So, for instance, in the Mahāsi technique that I teach, you see, that is actually brought to the fore, where a word actually encapsulates, tries to encapsulate in some way, the experience that's being had. So it's an acknowledgement of it. And acknowledge means to know you know. So by deconstructing an event, by seeing that there's the primary sensations, there I'm beginning to experience it as pleasant, unpleasant, and here's my relationship to it. Wanting, not wanting.

Now, when it comes to the discourse on how to establish mindfulness, you can see that the Buddha, he actually wants us to do this. The first thing he says is, Meditators. How does a meditator abide contemplating feelings as feelings? Now, here, the word he uses is *vedanā vedanānupassī*. It translates literally as a location to see feelings in feelings, which doesn't particularly make sense in English. But it's just saying that when you feel a feeling, just feel the feeling. Don't think about it. Actually, feel the feeling. It means that you've got to go into the feeling and feel the feeling. I'm sure you all know what I mean.

And he says, and here, when a pleasant feeling arises, the meditator understands, I feel a pleasant feeling. When an unpleasant feeling arises, the meditator understands, I feel an unpleasant feeling. And when a neither pleasant nor unpleasant feeling arises, the meditator understands, I feel a neither pleasant nor unpleasant feeling. It's extraordinarily simple. And you say, oh, that is an unpleasant feeling. You actually have to make it conscious, you see.

Now, although he's actually putting it in a phrase, I feel an unpleasant feeling, it's simply pointing to a direct experience of it. Because the word he uses here for to know is *pajānāti*. And *pajānāti* is the same word as *paññā*, it's the same word as *buddho*. It's intuitive intelligence, a direct perception.

So then he goes on to say, when a pleasant worldly feeling arises, the meditator understands it. And then he goes through this bit of unpleasant and pleasant. And when a pleasant unworldly feeling. So now he's asking us to distinguish those feelings that arise out of the old ways that we are and the new feelings that are arising out of our meditation. So when, for instance, some of the seven factors of enlightenment arise, such as interest in what we're doing, which is the *pīti*, such as the sense of tranquility, the *pas-saddhi*, the sense of equanimity, we should recognize that this isn't just an ordinary worldly feeling. These are spiritual feelings. These are feelings which are supporting our meditation, which means that they can be, as it were, not too consciously developed, but definitely not pushed away because they're part of the process of enlightenment. After all, the end product is to be happy. Don't forget that. I mean, we want to try and get happy.

And when we find that we're getting happy because we're having wonderful thoughts about cream cakes and sex, drugs and rock and roll, then we have to notice how now this happiness is based. And we don't indulge those things. We don't get into those things. So he's asking us to make that distinction. Not only pleasant and unpleasant and neutral, but the fact that some feelings of meditation, even negative ones like boredom, you have to notice this boredom is because I'm doing something wrong in my meditation. It's coming out of expectancy. It's coming because I expect something wonderful to happen and it's not happening. I'm getting really bored. So by making that distinction you are helping yourself to hone the skills of meditation. If you don't make these distinctions then it's just you're wandering. You're just wandering in a wood.

So having made that statement he then goes on to say how to do it. First of all he says in this way the meditator abides contemplating feelings as feelings. He abides contemplating feelings internally. He abides contemplating feelings as feelings externally. And then both internally and externally. Now, the way the commenters explain this is that if you have a feeling in you, suppose you've got a headache, when you see somebody else and they say to you, you've got a headache, or they feel you've got a headache, you see, it's a form of inference that you're inferring. You're making some connection.

In his own experience, remember, the Buddha is said to have seen at the point of enlightenment all his past lives. And he saw through the train of his past lives how he came to be a self-enlightened Buddha. He showed the progression. And what he discovered was that there were such things as skillful and unskillful behavior, moral and immoral behavior, and that these were the kernel problems of anybody trying to become enlightened. But the next thing he saw was other beings arising and passing away from this world to that according to their skillful and unskillful behavior. So what was a personal law became a cosmic law.

So it's the same for us. Whatever we discover in ourselves we also have to relate it to the fact that everybody else is having the same experience. So this allows us to grow in empathy, to grow in compassion.

See, at fundament we're just variations on a theme, that's all. Very boring.

Then he says he abides contemplating feelings in their arising factors, he abides contemplating feelings in their vanishing factors, and he abides contemplating feelings in their arising and vanishing factors. He always does this. Splits them up into bits.

So now he's asking us to change our view of things and to actually see that all these things that we are observing and feeling are actually arising and passing away. So he's asking us to change our perspective. When you change your perspective for seeing things arising and passing away, what you're abstracting out of the equation is any sense of solidity. Because we believe in continuity, things solidify for us.

We all of us, even though we intellectually know we're changing, all of us have a feeling of you know there's something in us which is steady which hasn't moved which is always there. But supposing one morning you got up and you looked in the mirror and it was somebody else's face? You're shocked, see. It's only because we get up in the morning and we see a similar face to the one we went to bed with that we think it's the same one. It's only when you see your photographs since you were two years old that you realize something has changed. But from the moment, as we pass through the life that we experience, we don't get this feeling of great change. We don't get our feelings of going through life in this stroboscopic way.

Because that's the Buddha's teaching. Everything is arising radically and passing away radically. It's coming out of potential out of, shall we say, non-manifest into the manifest. It's not as though you're taking a piece of clay, screwing it up into making a cup out of it and then screwing it up and making a saucer and it's the same piece of clay. Everything collapses only to arise again.

Now that's what he's asking us to do. But even at this level there is still some understanding going on, some mentation, some thought pattern going on. So the first is rather gross. You're feeling feelings as they are inside yourself in a very general way, contacting them, getting used to being just at the feeling basis. Right, this is not emotion. The emotion might be buried in the feeling but you're not looking at it as emotion, just looking at it as feeling. A physical sensation. And every so often when you walk around you see somebody, there may be some connection. You don't have to go berserk on that.

And then he asks you to go more inward and to leave feelings as objects, as something that somehow has solidity, and to begin to see them in their characteristic of feelings of little things arising and passing away. So that sometimes for instance you wake up and you feel depressed, see, and it feels just like a lump on your chest. Now normally speaking that's what it is, it's just a lump on the chest. But if you actually go into it you'll see it's not a lump at all, it's all little bits and pieces, see. So you're breaking it up. You're breaking up the concept. Remember, we guide our lives through these concepts. If we undermine our concepts, we undermine our view of life.

So, at this level, he's asking us to go slightly deeper and to see their arising and changing nature. Finally, he says, or else, mindfulness, that there is feeling, is simply established in the meditator to the extent necessary for bare knowledge and mindfulness. Now, although he says there is feeling, at this point there's no words. So the concentration on feeling is taking you to a point where mentation is supposed to stop. And there arises just that mindfulness necessary for bare knowledge to arise.

It's not until we get to that level that we can expect a deep enough grasp of the way things are which is actually going to move us at the base of consciousness and change us. And these moments in the Vipassanā tradition are known as *khaṇika samādhi*, momentary concentration. They don't last. It's nothing to do with time, it's a seeing. And often a meditator doesn't really know they've seen because they're so momentary, they're so immediate.

In your meditation if you keep working, those moments where there's no I watching, where the observer collapses, where the distinction or the separation between the observer and the observed seems to disappear. And one becomes the object. We've all experienced that. That's the moment when there's true *vipassanā*. And that's the state where he wants you to get to, the Buddha. And at that level, there is a possibility of, well you have to see it, even though it may not be such a conscious thing, even though that wisdom within us is not able to fully grasp the implications of it, but there is a seeing of it.

So if we just go through that again, what we have is just the sensations of the physical base, caused either by an outside stimulus, light, heat, whatever, or caused by an emotion arising in the body to create pressure, heat, whatever. We experience that then as something we like or we don't like, and that's your *vedanā*. If you stay there, you can see the reaction that you have to that given experience. Wanting and not wanting.

And if you stay at that level, you're also able to discern that if you leave it alone, this wanting and not wanting disappears. You have to observe the wanting and not wanting. As you observe the wanting and not wanting and that reaction begins to decrease, the *vedanā* then becomes more obvious to you. And it's then that you begin to see it in its arising and passing quality. It's then that you can really absorb into it, as it were, and begin to see this quality of *anicca*, of arising and passing away, of not-self, at a level which is actually going to change the way we see things, permanently.

Now, these *saṅkhāra* that we talked about, which translate as mental states, which are emotional states, given what we would call emotions and moods. The ideation which comes up, all these images, all these thoughts, are manufactured from this base.

Nothing moves without some motive from the heart. Even the driest of philosophers, the logicians, must have interest in it. Must have a wonder. There must be a wanting to work it out, a wanting to know.

Now, this base here, you see, because of our own Western thing about being stuck in the head, we've separated thought from feeling. We don't have a word anymore. We used to have. The word was soul. Soul, there were three words. There was body, soul, and spirit. And if you look at the ancient, the more early Christian texts, which took this, of course, from the Greeks, you'll see that the body was what the Buddha means by the body. The soul is what the Buddha means by the *citta*, the mind, both thought and feeling. And spirit meant that other thing, what we euphemistically call the nirvanic element. That which is to be enlightened.

Unfortunately in our language now we split these two things, so we've now got thought and emotion and it's very difficult for us to see the connection. So if we now see what an emotion is and we can actually go into an emotion and we just in the same way as we do *vedanā*, and what we're feeling is a very much more subtle state than a physical feeling. Now how does the psychotherapy then work, you see? How does the psychotherapy of Vipassanā work?

This turbulence which is in the mind, anger, depression, excitement, whatever. This turbulence is in the mind. It's in the body. The Buddha says the mind is in the body like milk in water. It's an intimate connection. That's why in our modern biology they can prod the brain and get you to do these different things. And why in a materialistic science the distinction isn't made. It can't be made. In a sense they don't need to make it to understand how the brain works and how certain things will work. But I don't think ever they would ever be able to work out what an image is or a thought. Maybe, I don't know.

But in Buddhist understanding, that's a finer energy. It's not the same as the physical energy. To talk of it as utterly distinct, I don't think would be true. It's more of a continuum. So those of you who practice qigong and things like that will know that there's a qi, an energy there, which is, I'm not so sure it's recordable, but it's definitely there. And it's the same thing that people use for healing and stuff like that. Levitation. It's a mental energy. I haven't seen anybody levitate, mind. I'm going to put an advert in the paper. Somebody turn up who can levitate.

So this turbulence, where can it go? Where can that turbulence go? It's only got one place to go. It's got to go into the body. And there are turbulences that we know have been so suppressed into the body, so repressed into the body, that we're not even aware of them. And it's only through, often through, certain psychotherapeutic techniques and meditation that we actually begin to lift these up back into consciousness.

But when they're lifted up back into consciousness, what are they coming through, you see? They're coming through the body. So, when we're at the feeling base, which is caused by an emotion, if we stay at the feeling base, we're actually allowing this turbulence an avenue to express its turbulence and to finally expend its energy. That's how the psychotherapy works. And the reason why it's expending its energy is because the meditator is no longer empowering it through indulgence or suppressing it.

So, most of our meditation, 99.9% is burning at the stake. This stuff has to be suffered. It's got nowhere else to go. If it doesn't come up into consciousness, it's stuck in the body. If it's stuck in the body, it's going to cause illness. There's no option. You have to suffer to become enlightened. You have to go to hell before you can get to heaven. Very unfortunate.

So when you understand that, you see a search for origins is pathetic. It's absolutely irrelevant that my mother hit me across the head with a banana when I was three years old. Pathetic. It has nothing to do with anything. What I have now is a turbulence called anger or hatred or whatever. This is it. This is what I'm going to work with. This connection in the past is immaterial. It's now just like a weather system. It's a storm. All I've got to do is sit there and bear it.

Patience. A willingness to suffer it. But if I then do a psychotherapy on it, that I'm just sitting here bearing it and it will die out, I'm not going to get the gift of the meditation. It's only when I turn my perspective around to see it as something arising and passing away that I'm beginning to lift that consciousness out of this embeddedness with what it experiences. Lifting that consciousness out of its identity with, possession of, an emotion. I'm unhappy, see?

By looking at unhappiness, depression, anxiety as other, as an object, where's the I? So there's two things always going on if we're meditating correctly. The psychotherapy is happening quite normally, quite naturally. And consciousness is liberating itself. The definition of *nibbāna* is unshackled. It's an unshackling. There are ten fetters, they're unshackled. It's consciousness itself which is shackled. As soon as you make it an object and allow it to burn in consciousness, you're unshackling yourself from it because you're no longer identifying with it.

So, in the wheel of dependent origination, which is the psychological paradigm as to how we create suffering for ourselves, the Buddha points us to get right there with *vedanā* and to see what arises in our relationship to that feeling. By keeping our mind right there, we'll liberate consciousness from its attachments. And we will allow the turbulence to expend its energy and we'll be cured of it.

It's very interesting. Nowhere, as far as I can see, on that wheel of dependent origination, does he ask us to look at an emotion as a given. In other words, if I get up in the morning and I feel depressed, I never decide to get up and feel depressed, by the way. When I feel depressed, if I say I am depressed, I'm already a goner. If I say this is depression, I'm into psychotherapy. I'm trying to find out why I'm depressed. If I'm into feeling, all I feel is just a heaviness, a dullness, a stodginess of mind, an inability to do this and that. That's fine. What's the problem?

You know that book that's a bit of a bestseller, *Feel the Fear and Do It Anyway*. Well, that's it. Feel the depression and do it anyway. Feel the hatred and do it anyway. In order to do that, you have to have distanced yourself from these feelings. You have to have distanced yourself from it as an emotion. And it's very easy to do that if you just drop down a level and see it just as feeling. Feeling.

I think that's it. May you be enlightened this very lifetime.

I'd like to start before I answer the question by trying to clarify some of the stuff I said the other night about *vedanā*, especially this business of psychotherapy. A few spears hit me as I left the room. What I was on about was coming to Vipassanā with a psychodynamic model. It wasn't a criticism at all of psychotherapy as such. Things like just simple therapy like behavioral therapy is extremely good at getting rid of phobias and things like that. It's just that if you come to the meditation with a particular model in your mind then you may very well succeed in getting what that model tells you you might get but you may not succeed in becoming enlightened, that's all.

So if you come with the meditation with the Freudian idea that there's a subconscious, that there's a super ego and a need, then you'll be looking for that and thinking that it's somewhere around and you may find it. You might not become enlightened. That's the problem. That's the first thing.

And secondly that of course the whole genius you might say of the Buddha's teaching is that he left a psychological blueprint. He actually left a psychological paradigm. So that when you work with that psychology then you not only get the benefit of therapy, because you couldn't possibly have a neurotic Buddha, you also get the enlightenment, you see.

Now, when you get to be enlightened, then you can say, well, is this it, or is there more than this? He's not putting it to us, remember, as a belief factor, something that we have to experiment with and try out for ourselves. The doctrine is *ehi passiko*, come and try it, you see. Come and try it, come and see.

So my criticism is of people coming to do Vipassanā meditation with the wrong model in their minds. And that's what I get when I do interviews, you see. That's what I find. I find the person hasn't got the Buddhist model in their mind. So, you know, it creates a certain confusion. It doesn't create the results. The main confusion is concerned with this business of the relationship we have to our emotional life, our thought life. And that's really what you've got to catch to stop this round of reconditioning ourselves.

Is Awareness Enough?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 29 min read

In this profound evening teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a fundamental question in Buddhist meditation: is awareness alone sufficient for awakening? Drawing from the Buddha's own journey to enlightenment and the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), he clarifies that sammā sati (Right Awareness) must be accompanied by paññā (wisdom) and other essential factors.

Bhante explores the seven factors of enlightenment (bojjhaṅga), emphasizing that sati provides the foundation but requires dhammavicaya (investigation of dhamma), pīti (interest), passaddhi (tranquility), samādhi (concentration), and vīriya (effort) to function effectively. He demonstrates how the Buddha never separates awareness from intelligence in the scriptures, explaining why ordinary awareness differs from the awakening awareness that leads to liberation.

The teaching addresses common confusions between different meditation traditions—Vipassanā, Dzogchen, and Zen—showing how they share the same fundamental principles despite different approaches. Bhante illustrates how genuine practice requires both the effortless quality of childlike presence and the mature wisdom gained through life's challenges, all working together to see the three characteristics of existence: anicca (impermanence), dukkha (unsatisfactoriness), and anattā (not-self).

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma-Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma-Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma-Sambuddhassa.
Homage to the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

I thought I'd try and put things together to make it clear as to what the role of awareness is in the process of enlightenment and what else is necessary.

Now if we begin with the life of the Buddha himself, remember that he had practiced quite fiercely for six years. And before that he probably dabbled a bit. So in the first year or so, he attains all these very profound absorptions to the point that both teachers ask him to join them as a teacher. And these are what we now call the *jhānas*. Also during that time he's obviously keeping his mind very still because one of the factors of enlightenment, one of the factors of the *jhānas* is a still mind, a concentrated mind. Then he does mortification exercises, mainly around not eating really. And he comes to

the end of this process after six years and he's got nowhere. Nowhere in terms of his koan, in terms of his real life question, which is, is there an end to suffering? Now all that time, he had awareness.

Now he comes to that point, and in desperation, he's sitting by the roadside looking pretty ragged. And a woman comes along with a bowl of rice, meaning to offer it to a god. In the scriptures, they say that she mistook him for a deva, for an angel, for a god. But I don't think he looked like that at all. So they took pity on him and said, you'd better take some of this rice. So he had this rice, and he felt fulfilled. And he thought about what was going on and all that. And he must have been pretty miserable. His mates had left him. They said he'd gone soft because he'd eaten his rice.

And then he remembered this little time in childhood, when he is observing his father, he's watching his father doing a ploughing ceremony. Now there's something in that observation, there was something in that particular moment, which he remembered at that time, in a time of desperation, looking back over his life, wondering whether there was an end to suffering. And he remembers this particular state of mind. If you go back, can you remember a particular state of mind at the age of 8, 9, 10, 12? So it must have been something that he really remembered, something about the quality of that observation, which he then, of course, goes and sits and determines not to move until his eyes are enlightened or he drops dead. Have you tried that?

So he sat there, and luckily for him, and for us, he became enlightened. He had this insight which liberated him, liberated him from this confusion about suffering. So that's his story.

Then, of course, the whole of his life is actually talking about this moment, of how to get to this moment of liberation. And the core discourse is the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse here, the discourse on how to establish this *sati*, which we translate as mindfulness, awareness, attention, being present. All these are about being here in a particular way.

Now, if we look at this, you'll see the words he uses. He says that the meditator sits and he observes these four frames of reference. The body, feelings, the mind with its emotions, and *dhamma*, which he means to look at all this from the point of view of his teachings. The three characteristics, the four noble truths, eight of these, ten of those, and so on. And he says to do it with *ātāpī*, *sampajaññā*, *satimā*. Now *ātāpī* comes from the word *tapos*, which means mortification exercise. So in other words, it's real energy. So those people who translate the Zen effortless effort, meaning that you can just lie down and it'll happen, haven't read this particular discourse. So there's some energy here. We need some energy. We need some commitment. We need some real putting of

our effort behind something. The word *satimā* is just an adjective from *sati*. So, with awareness, translated. Mindfully. And the middle word is *sampajañña*. *Sampajañña* meaning with intelligence. Intelligence.

These core words are at a constant recurrence throughout the discourse. When we get into the discourse itself, which describes in more detail how we establish these four frames of reference, the body, feelings in the body, emotional states, mental states, and the Dhamma, we get these recurring phrases. He says to establish mindfulness on one of these four and to do it inwardly just to the point of being able to stay with it. Then the next stage is to observe the rising and falling. That's the next stage. And then finally he says to dwell upon it, to dwell upon the object of meditation just so much that *ñāṇa* and *paṭissati* can arise naturally. *Ñāṇa* is insight. *Sati* is awareness. So there's nowhere in the scripture that *sati* and *paññā* are separated. Wherever there's *sati* there's *paññā*.

So now *sati* is that awareness, general awareness. *Paññā* is intelligence. It's an intuitive intelligence. Now, if we go back to *sati*, go back to awareness, a robber, in the midst of robbing a bank, is ultra-aware, isn't he? I'd be. Very mindful. My head would be sparking. When you're crossing a road and it's busy and you've got to watch yourself, you're aware. So there's something about the awareness which is going to become enlightened, which is leading us to enlightenment, which is not ordinary awareness. That's why the Buddha calls it *sammā sati*, right awareness. A baby is aware. In fact, if anything, a child is living almost in a very present moment, but it's not *sammā sati*. So there must be something else to the *sati*.

Now, if we go now to the factors of enlightenment, then we come across those factors which are necessary to also be there against this background of *sati*. So *sati*, you can say, is like a field of awareness. It's just a being present. But there must come something into that presence which is going to spark, which is going to actually see something. And what we find in the seven factors are this *dhammavicaya*, *dhammavicaya*, which means investigation of *dhamma*. So although we have this awareness, it has to be pointed at something. It has to be aware of something. There has to be an intentionality behind it. You can't just flop, go into this wondrous, spacious state of being all things, in a state of open awareness, because nothing's going to happen. It's very nice, it's very peaceful, it's very beautiful, but it's dull, it's daft. Nothing happens.

So there has to come in this *dhammavicaya*. This *dhammavicaya*, this investigation of *dhamma*, has to be balanced with *upekkhā*, with equanimity. This suggests that this investigation must not have a question there. That's the problem. As soon as we say, let's investigate something, a question arises. Somehow we have to develop that curiosity

which is just a question mark. As soon as there's a word put to it, as soon as there's a looking for something, then it's going to be corrupted. It's going to be corrupted by that concept that you're looking for.

Now balanced with that you have *pīti* and *passaddhi*. *Pīti* here translates as interest. Interest is an attitude, isn't it? It's a mental state to have interest in something. There's an eagerness included in there, a wanting to know. It's a heart state to be interested in something. Now that has to be balanced with *passaddhi*, which is tranquility. If interest is not balanced that way, then it becomes excited. And if there's no interest there, then you enter into this lovely meditative state of tranquility. So you can see meditators when they do that. They'll be like this. And if you wake them up, they say, oh, I'm here. What's wrong? I'm aware. Put them to sleep. It's lovely. Nothing's going to happen. They're going to end up after an hour just as daft as they were before they started.

So there has to be this intelligence, this interest, this wanting to know. And subsisting all that, subsisting and helping all that, is of course concentration, which is this one pointedness of the mind, the ability of the mind to stay still. And the effort, and this is the *ātāpī*, this is the effort of mortification exercises, is just enough effort to maintain that. That's all.

So there's your seven factors of enlightenment. And you can see that in the scriptures. He never separates awareness from intelligence, awareness from intuition.

So when we meditate and we sit here, the first effort is to bring the mind to a stillness. But once you're in that stillness, once you've made the effort to, as it were, quiet down and to become aware of the object, there has to arise in us this wanting to know. Now, what is it we want to know? What is it that wanting has to be pointed to?

So here, the Buddha simply says to become aware of the three characteristics of existence. Because when we become aware of the three characteristics of existence, we're undermining this consciousness which believes itself to be a self. So as long as we are aware of transience, and that's his next step. So the first step was just to dwell upon the object. The second step is to become aware of its process. But here, to my mind, I'm not so sure this is particularly commentarial, but to my mind, this watching of *anicca*, watching of transiency, includes the other two. Which is to observe how suffering arises and to observe that quality of not me, not mine. So there are your three characteristics.

So now you can see that this intuitive intelligence which is natural to us and which is the same intelligence that works out how much we have to pay for the bills and what we have to do at work. It's all the same intelligence. There's no other intelligence than the intelligence we have. What we need to do is clarify the intelligence of thought and

clarify the intelligence of any distorting emotion. And we do that by making states of mind objects. We do that by bringing the mind into the present moment so that thought can't get in because thought is always after thought. When you're involved in something, there's no room for thought.

So the whole process of the meditation is to bring this, is to, as it were, close down the awareness into the present moment to an object arising and passing away so that there's no time but to see what there is. But that seeing is guided, is actually being primed to see the three factors, to see the three characteristics of existence. The fact that it's arising and passing away. The fact that it's not me, not mine. The distance. And the fact that any time I form a relationship with it, of wanting or not wanting, possession or identity, some dissatisfaction arises.

And it's just watching that that liberates this consciousness from wrong relationship to the body mind and heart it's in. And that's all we're doing. We're just changing our relationship to the world. And remember in Buddhist terms, in the Buddhist terms the world is how we experience the world. In other words it's within this, as he says, fathom long body. It's not outside us. It's within this bubble of our consciousness. That's what we've got to change.

So now, considering his own discovery of the role of awareness, which when you think about it, it can't only have been awareness, it must have also been the memory of this intuition that came with it, this way of looking. And the example that I always use is of a little child who's round about pre-language or around about the beginning of language where there's no conceptual thinking as such. They might have a word, car, whatever, but there's nothing built up around it conceptually.

And you'll often see them see something like a bug which they've never seen before. And you see them just lock onto it. They just lock onto it. There's no time as far as they're concerned. There's just this thing crawling away. And you'll see their mouths drop. Now when the mouth drops and the tongue relaxes, there's no thought. So there they are, just in that moment. And they're just stuck there. And then some well-meaning parent will tell them to shut their mouth and kill it.

But if you leave the kid alone, then of course it comes out of it and says, what is it? Now once the parent says, oh that's a beetle, that's it, it doesn't look anymore. It knows it. And we've lost that direct contact with beetles. When was the last time you really looked at a beetle?

So that's what concepts do. They make us presume that in seeing a thing through the vision or through the prism of a concept, we actually experience it. So somehow we've got to go beyond that, and we do that by constantly bringing this attention into the present moment. And as it locks into the present moment, there can't be room for thought. And we're right there with that childlike mind. Except this time, it actually has some intelligence, some stored wisdom behind it, which the child doesn't have. If the child had that, it'd become enlightened at the age of three. But we have to go through the horror of our lives in order to build up the wisdom of how to develop this way of looking. Remember, it's suffering which leads us to the enlightenment. So we've got to go through the pain, or else there's no gain. Everybody knows that.

So in this scripture, you see, he's very clear about that.

So now we come to this confusion as to how we can be confused with the different traditions. So as far as my understanding is, and you're welcome to correct me after the talk, there are two major traditions. There's the Vipassana tradition and there's the Dzogchen Zazen tradition. And just on the outside of that, there's the Koan tradition.

So now, what is the difference between those two approaches which can cause confusion to meditators? In the *vipassanā* process, we want to get to that *satipaṇṇā*, we want to get to that *sampajaṇṇā satimā*. And we do it by way of using an object within the body, the breath itself. By turning inward and going into the breath, we pull out that singular object and we begin to, as it were, bury our awareness and that intuitive intelligence just into a single sensation. All the world is in a grain of sand.

In that moment, when we, as it were, open up to the field of awareness, so that we're not just concentrated into the breath, but able to observe anything which draws our attention, we're not looking for anything. So I'm sitting watching the breath and there's a bird song. And it's the bird song which is drawing my attention. I'm not looking for bird songs. And as I go to the ear, as I go to the ear base, I'm interested in the process of hearing. I'm not interested in the bird. I'll see the image of the bird in my mind. I hear and I feel my response to it. So I can see this whole connection I have with the outside world. I can see that when the bird stops, there's a longing for it to go on a little bit more. So there's my attachment. So that's what I'm interested in. I'm interested in the way that this mind is constantly wandering between wanting and not wanting. How things arise and pass away. Creating that distance, recognizing it's not me, not mine. And it's all come from this center in the breath where I've honed the seven factors of enlightenment.

Now, if you go to the Dzogchen school, or the Zazen school, the Zazen school I know personally, as soon as you sit, you're supposed to be there. Like that. Boom, boom. You made it. That's it. You're right there. Just where you were, it took these poor *Vipassanā* guys weeks to get there. These Dzogchen guys, boom, that's it, they're there.

Now it can't be so, can it? There must be something going on. So that somebody who throws themselves into a Zazen position, Shikantaza. So now when you look at their training, you can see how they get there and are able to hold it. Remember that in most, like, something like Sogyal Rinpoche, as far as I know, you sit in Dzogchen for ten minutes. That's all they can expect from somebody who's doing their practice at an ordinary level.

Now remember that insight in the Enlightenment doesn't take any time. You either see it or you don't. It's a flash, that's it, it's finished. But if we look at the whole tradition, then we see how they can just sit there for ten minutes, or maybe an hour, or whatever. Hundred thousand bows. Om Mani Padme Hum. Days on end. What are those practices? Visualizations, purifying the heart. It's only when you've been through all that can you throw yourself on the cushion and enter into Dzogchen. There's the balance of the practice.

Dzogchen masters and Zazen masters will tell you that the error of somebody in Dzogchen and Zazen is that they fall into the same error as *Vipassanā* people, to move into that state of clear awareness, absolute body, straight, perfect energy, no intelligence. Perfect peace and happiness until they wake up.

If you look at the Zazen school, you've only got to go up to Throstle Hole. It's been years since I went there. But when I used to go up there, you'd work three hours at a shop. You'd never stop. And you worked fast. I remember once I was saying to the work chiefs today, the abbot wanted soil moved from one end to the other end to build a little garden. So I was stood at one end with a spade, and there was another guy stood at the other end, and there was this Dominican priest with a wheelbarrow, belting up and down. He shoved it in and down, he chucked it out and back up. Three hours! Weeding for three hours.

The whole idea of that Zazen meditation is not something separate from what you do. It's a common mistake, especially in the *Vipassanā*, because we have these special practices, special occasions, but in Zen they always talk about ordinary daily life. So there you are weeding, and you're weeding. You're putting your mind in it. When you wash, you've heard these Zen sayings, when you wash the pots, just wash the pots. So when you weed, you weed. And you're weeding, and you get into the rhythm of weeding, and you don't want to leave the weeding. And the bell goes, and you want to keep

weeding. And then you go back, and you're full of this energy. And you go, boom, something's going to go, and you're there. It's not that the mind doesn't wander, but at least you've got some concentration because of the hard work, you've got the energy, and so you can sit in zazen, just sitting.

Now the koan is an interesting one, because the koan actually has its roots, all these things have its roots in the fundamental schools of Theravada and for the Mahayana, what became known as the Sarvastavadin school. If you have a look at this very dry tome called the Path of Purification by Buddha Gosar, a scholar of the medieval ages, the driest book in the world, bag of bones, but probably the most brilliant piece of, most brilliant compendium of spiritual exercises you'll come across. And one of them is how to become enlightened by repeating the word death. How to become enlightened by repeating the word death.

So now, how are we supposed to do that? Well, the idea is that you sit, you be silent, and you use the word death to contact your feelings about death. Every time you say death, images may come, feelings may come. It's an internalised practice of what's in the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, known as looking at dead bodies in cemeteries. It's the *asubhā*, it's the horrible meditations. And you're supposed to go to a cemetery and a charnel ground where the bodies were just left, and eaten by vultures and rotting and all that, rats around. And you're supposed to sit there and just watch bodies rotting. Come back, see them in different states and keep saying to yourself, just as this body is, so mine will be. The commentary warns you not to sit windward. Very detailed.

So there you are sitting, repeating this word death, and it's bringing up all your emotions about it, all your feelings about death. And just like in *Vipassanā* you observe in part one. And who is it? What is it that's afraid of death? It's the self, isn't it? So once you've cut through the fear of death, what is it to be afraid of? Hence the Enlightenment.

Now from that you can see how the koans came. The koans now, the regular koan in somewhere like Korea is who am I or what is it. Now, a person in the old days would have been given a koan, and they would have been caught up in this intellectual answer. The Rinzai school was meant for, was supposed to be for samurais, right, and for the intellectuals. So, the yogi would come along, and the master would say, would ask him the koan, and he'd wait for the answer, and the guy would give him some sort of explanation, well, I'm not this, I'm not, and he'd get a clout across the ear. And he'd keep coming, getting bonked on the head, until finally he stopped thinking. That's the point. That's the point of the koan, to stop thinking.

So the idea in the koan when we say something like, who am I? And remember, these koans come up naturally in your meditation. Just feeling a feeling and hearing a little question like, what is this? That's your koan. Is turning on that intelligence. That's what the koan is doing. It's turning on that intelligence, making that intelligence look in a certain way, but beyond thought.

So the meditator, just like one would say, death, and just feel what comes up, you might say, who am I? And just rest in that moment and let the intelligence take over. Our problem is we keep getting in the way. After all, we keep trying to manipulate that intelligence to see what we want it to see and become enlightened.

So you can see how the koan is just an extension, is just a more obvious way of exciting this *paññā*, this intuitive intelligence we have within us.

So now you can see, if you come from the Zen tradition, and you meet a Theravadin, and the Theravada says, all you need is awareness. They'll say, oh, no, no, no, that won't do at all. But in the Theravada understanding, whenever you say right awareness, the intelligence is included. It's not right awareness unless the intelligence is being activated, the intuitive intelligence. And that's where the confusion lies often when you meet these schools, because they're coming from slightly different traditions. But it's always the same. It's always the same.

And in his book, which is still considered to be a classic of meditation, *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation* by Nyanaponika Thera, a very famous German monk who died not so long ago, he said that there was a time when people thought that Theravada meditation, *Vipassanā*, and Zen were two opposites, belonged to two different worlds. But in fact, when these teachers came together, and when people who had practiced both actually began to realize that in fact it's all one and the same thing. And when you think about it, how else could it be? How else could it be?

So there we have it. The Buddha's own remembrance in childhood of a particular level of consciousness. It's not a state of mind. It's not an emotional state. It's not a thought state. It's a way of seeing things. Because of his own practice, he has that concentration of mind. He has the effort. And he has the rice pudding. And he sits under the tree and he becomes enlightened. And then he realizes what the factors are that made him get there. And the main factor is this *sati*. Behind it there are all the faculties.

Why does he put *sati* first? Because that's your main disposition, awareness. To begin with the awareness of the object is your disposition. And then once the awareness is there, the concentration and effort will come to rise to support it. And once the awareness and concentration is there, and it's coming more and more into the present mo-

ment, the intuitive wisdom, supported by faith, if there's any scepticism you've had it, supported by faith, uses those qualities to see clearly what's going on. And just that seeing is its own liberation.

So the liberation is consciousness liberating itself from wrong view. And the whole process of the enlightenment is simply to get out of the way. The effortless effort. That's it.

Is there any questions? Observations? Criticism? Additions? Editorials?

There are many stories about people who follow the teachers and then are severely treated in order to get rid of this ego which you mentioned is one of the biggest barriers to being able to have these states come together in the right portions and go forward. How does it terrify you, doing that, scourging yourself on weekends?

I don't think Buddhist teachers were particularly cruel. I mean, the only real stories come from the Zen tradition where they chop your hand off or something, or chop your finger off if you happen to. Well, remember that the way teachers teach their students is very much dependent upon the culture. I mean, I can't imagine a Westerner taking that sort of business. I mean, they'd probably smack the guy, smack the person back. It's not within our culture to be battered towards the Enlightenment. I mean, the Buddha himself wasn't. Nobody gave him a whack or two.

As Buddhism spreads, remember, it does pick up the culture. In the West, we're in very early days, very early days, and I can well imagine within two or three generations, four generations, that the Buddhism in the West is remarkably different from the Buddhism elsewhere. Because that's what's happened everywhere else. Chinese Buddhism is remarkably different from Japanese, from Thai, from Tibetan. So it changes.

But your core question is in fact how to get rid of ego and the self. One of the things that is very difficult for us is the word obedience, is the word submission. We can't handle that. It goes against the whole post-modern idea that I do my own thing in my own way in my own time. But before the Buddha became enlightened, so it is said, he put his bowl into the river and it flowed upwards against the stream. Only dead fish go with the flow. So this was symbolic of the fact that whatever we do towards enlightenment is always going to go against the self. Always. Always.

So the self remember is caught up in a game, it's caught up in a game with the world of wanting and not wanting and it finds a certain pleasure there, it finds a certain comfort. It doesn't want to let go of it because it always thinks if it can get it right it will definitely be perfectly happy.

So that's one of the things about bowing. People hate to bow. But in fact bowing is the physical, it's the bodily expression of that submission. That's one reason, it's the physical expression of submitting yourself to the dictates of the Dharma. So if the Dharma says you shouldn't indulge in this then you have to bow to that. If you can't bow to it, if you can't take the teaching, if you can't do it, then you just end up with a very stiff back. An arthritic back.

And this is one of the fundamental attitudes of any spiritual life. It's not just Buddhism. Humility goes all the way through. This word humility, which has now been downgraded into slavery. But humility is that ability to be obedient. Who uses the word obedient these days? You don't hear parents use it with kids. Be obedient. It's all gone out of the language. It's too painful for the ego. The word discipline. The word discipline. I mean, it actually means, if I remember rightly, study, isn't it? Disciplina. Does anybody know? Disciplina. It means learning. Learning. So in a university you have a discipline. We talk about a discipline, because to study, to advance in knowledge, there has to be this commitment, this order, this discipline. But these days, education is much more concerned with entertainment.

So, in answer to your question about the way teachers teach, it's often to humble, to humble the student. I remember when I was in Burma, and I was being the westerner, and frankly, I just got fed up of bowing to this monk. I mean, he was my teacher, but I just got fed up with him. And he was so conceited, as far as I could see. Arrogant. I wasn't going to bow to him. And I remember approaching him and just sitting there. And he went... And if I hadn't have bowed, I'd have been out. That's it. Forget it. And what he's teaching me is, look, if you're going to take my message, then you'd better have the right attitude. One of the most painful times of my life.

Is the awareness with interest and energy, what exactly do you mean by energy?

Energy is just the effort to maintain it. I mean as a physical thing the only energy you need to become enlightened, if we could hold it there the Buddha says for seven years if you're unlucky, for seven days if you're really with it, it's just the energy to keep you upright. Just the energy in the spine. So all the energy you need is the resolution, the energy to just keep observing the object.

So that's why I mentioned to those of you here for the meditation that if we are serial meditators, then every time we come to sit, you really have to remind yourself what you're going to do. And so you make that resolution. This period of time, I'm going to commit myself to establishing mindfulness. Unless you forget, and you just sit there, it becomes habitual, and the mind wanders, and sure, you've planned your holiday down to America, but I mean, what's the point?

But if you sit and you make this resolution right at the beginning of your sit, then I think you'll find that when you wander, you'll come back to that same resolution. Because remember, that resolution is conditioning your mind, it's conditioning you to be present. It's an attitude, it's an attitudinal change to be present. And I would say that every time you lose it on a dream side, you come back, you stop for a moment, you recognize what's happened, right? And you recommit yourself with real resolution. Resolute resolution.

But don't you need like a free flow of energy so no tension? Say that again? A free flow of energy so... In the whole body, not just a resolution.

Well, the thing is once you're in this posture and you're lifting the energy up the spine just by sitting tall, then you're actually correcting all the energy in your body. You will feel, I'm sure many of you have felt, all the chakras fire. Pain in your stomach, pain in your chest, around your neck, it's all blocked. That's it. You don't have to do any yoga posture to become enlightened. You don't need astrology.

You seem to be saying in the talk that awareness is necessary but not enough?

That's right.

It seems that people can have quite deep insights into those three experiences, but not have a final cessation in suffering. Maybe some change in ways that can happen, so they can bring wisdom and intelligence, but there's still a sufferer and still suffering can take place.

Yeah. The insights into these things are like little corrections of view. Little corrections. Until the whole thing becomes properly corrected and then you're enlightened. They're just little adjustments. And they show up in little changes in the way you behave, in the way you react to similar situations, in the way you don't react to similar situations. Little changes within you. It's a very slow process. I mean, the Buddha often warns us this is a slow process.

And then there are kernel points when we can talk about a shift in perception. And these are what we call the stream entrant, the non-returner, and the *arahat*. I liken it to a stick. You keep bending the stick. Now you'll notice that when you first start bending a stick, it's easy, isn't it? So when you first sit, it's easy. But as you keep going, you get the resistance. You get the resistance. And you get the resistance, and that's the ego, it's pulling away. And you've just got to keep working. And sometimes you relax, and you back up again. But remember that every time you flex it, you are getting stronger. You all do these exercises, I'm sure. And then one day, crack! Two sticks. Different state.

My question was going to be that once the stick is broken, is there no going back?

Definitely not. And who'd want to go back? If you think of the shift of consciousness, this very great shift that we go through between six and eight, where we get real. When we're six, believing Father Christmas comes down the chimney is not a problem, because what I can imagine is true, it's fact. Eight is a bit difficult. And then this morality comes in. It's not as though that young children don't feel shame and guilt, but it becomes much more clear around the age of seven, right and wrong. The tree of the fruit of good and evil. Now you wouldn't want to go back to three years old. I don't think so. So once you've moved, once you've become a *sotāpanna*, once you've become a stream entrant or an *arahat*, you don't want to go down again.

Is enlightenment a one thing from which there is no going back or is it also a temporary insight?

Now actually, it's a good question because this is also very confusing from the different traditions. In Theravada we have things like *ñāṇas*, these insights of *vipassanā*. In the Japanese tradition we hear about satori and kensho and now they're actually all the same thing. You'll find that when you read the literature and you go through all the traditions and all that, you'll find they're always talking about the same thing. They're always talking about little insights concerning the three facts, concerning the three characteristics. Transience, how suffering arises, and not self. It's always that. And then you'll see that they often have a special word for what we would call stream entrance, etc., etc.

Now, up until that stick snaps, you can always go back. And it's very difficult. It really is. Oh, it's soul destroying to have got the stick there and to have given up. It's like climbing up the mountain and you're almost at the peak and you tumble all the way down. So it

Eroticism, Romance, Love, Distraction and Boredom

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 27 min read

In this evening retreat talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma continues his examination of the hindrances by investigating what he calls 'deliciousness' - the erotic, romantic, and love experiences that can both bring joy and serve as escapism. He distinguishes between the natural beauty of erotic and romantic feelings versus our lustful relationship to them, explaining how these experiences often mask deeper emotions like loneliness and anxiety.

Bhante discusses practical meditation techniques for working skillfully with sexual thoughts and romantic fantasies, including the practice of sublimation - transforming unskillful impulses into wholesome energy for compassion and spiritual growth. He addresses the role of celibacy in spiritual practice, clarifying misconceptions about Buddhism being life-negative, and explores the difference between attachment and genuine love.

The talk also covers the challenge of boredom in meditation, distinguishing it from spiritual weariness, and explains how our constant seeking of distraction prevents deeper purification. Drawing on the Brahminical life stages and the Buddha's own encounters with Māra's daughters (sensual desire, pleasure, and boredom), Bhante offers a balanced perspective on integrating spiritual practice with natural human experiences.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

So I wanted to just continue for another session the hindrances, just to go into perhaps a little bit more detail. And this evening I wanted to investigate deliciousness. And the two areas, the three areas, that you can look at particularly is the erotic, the romantic and love. I call it the erotic, not lust. Lust is our relationship to the erotic. The erotic and the romantic are just part and parcel of the loveliness of our lives, occasionally.

And the erotic, just to think about that for a minute. So that's really to do with some sort of physical attraction towards another person. And it only happens between certain people. You don't feel normally erotic to everybody you meet. It would be exhausting. So there's that case of something very particular and... As you know, it's said that, generally speaking, if you abstract, if you separate out the erotic from the romantic

from love, then it becomes a bit like eating. And in itself, it's a sort of empty experience. It loses meaning when you just do it by itself. Whenever I say this, I'm always reminded of Woody Allen's little crack, where he said... Just sex is an empty experience. But as empty experiences go...

So, as usual, when you look at anything which is delightful, it's either because we like it, quite obviously, we like to indulge in it, it brings immediate sense of happiness. That's the point. It brings happiness. The whole point about the erotic, the romantic, and love in the general sense, not the true *mettā*, I mean love as attachment, is that it brings joy. It brings joy to the heart. It's a lovely experience.

But the other side of it is, as usual, that we may also be using it to escape something. That's the point. So that we are seeking entertainment to escape something that we don't like. So things like such a very obvious and loud sensual experience, such as sex, is something that you can get lost in and forget the worries of your life.

So there's always this duality with anything that we enjoy in terms of the self, in terms of how we relate to it. Part of it is just sheer indulgence. We like it. And it creates a lovely feeling in the heart. And the other side is that we may be running away from something. So once we have that clear in mind, with anything that we indulge in, in those two parts, then as you watch that indulgence, as it fades away, don't be surprised that underneath it there lies maybe grief, anxiety, anything that you're pushing away. So that these pleasant things can be used to suppress just as anything else. So we talked about sleep, as a lovely way to suppress things. So here, anything which is enjoyable can be used just to push it away, just gently push it away, to ignore it, for it not to be there.

And because the sexual energy is so related to life, to the life force, any time that death appears or anything like that, there's a great desire to run that way and to reinforce the fact that there is life. Interestingly enough, I picked up a quote from William Blake. The road of excess leads to the palace of wisdom. You see? So remember that in the Buddha's life, we saw how all that loveliness that he was experiencing with his dancing girls and all that, and presumably his drinking, and having a good time, that in the end, it's like squeezing blood from a stone. It loses its buzz, basically. And there comes that weariness with it.

And remember we, and I'll mention again towards the end, there is a distinction to be made between weariness and boredom. Weariness is that coming to the end of seeking happiness in that place. Boredom is just that you're fed up with it for a while, you

need a break, you need a fast, you need a diet, and then you can get back to it again refreshed. So boredom is just coming from overindulgence and then but then you still want to get back to it once the hunger for it arises.

So in our meditation, of course, it can be, if you don't watch it, these thoughts around lust can be really obsessive. And we have to be extraordinarily patient with that and just keep coming off them and back into the body and just feel the excitement, feel what's actually happening there. And that business of really acknowledging what's going on, sometimes you might think, well, we're too old for this, we shouldn't be thinking these things. But you're never too old. I think it was Pope John XXIII. I just remember a quote from him where he said the loveliness of being, I think he was 85 or something, was that the flesh had finally quietened. So you can expect to be harassed by this until who knows when.

So it's a case of being very quick with that because remember that when a thought arises and carries on, there's some force behind it which the Buddha called *cetanā*. And that force, remember, is not the intention. Force is just a force. It's just an energy form. It's the same as when you throw a stone up into the air. As far as I know, they still don't quite know what it is. That makes the stone keep going. But we call it force.

So there is something which takes... That which is a thought in the head, just an idea, a wish, a desire, an intention. See, that's why we're also being very careful to note intentions and it suddenly flips and you're away. It's gone. You're either doing something or you're thinking something or you're saying something. And remember, at that point, it's become an action. That's a *kamma*. And therefore, you are reinforcing your conditioning. So here, if we're not very quick with these delicious thoughts, then they just run away and you've had it. And then it takes a time, then it takes time because you've re-empowered that.

A good metaphor for that are people who suffer from drink problems, alcoholics. They can be off for so long and then maybe just out of weakness or a little bit of hubris, a little bit of pride, thinking they're now above it. And it's just that one drink and off they go. Because it's re-empowering an old habit. Of course, in that case, there's a physical element, but it's the same with smoking. Even though there's a physical element too that people can be off smoking for a long time. And then just when they feel a bit down or when they're in the wrong company, they just take that one cigarette and then they're surprised how difficult it is, how suddenly that whole engine is restarted.

So if you see these thoughts coming up, to be very quick with them and come back and just think about what that thought is doing and bring yourself back to the body.

Now, there is an exercise that you can do, which we did partly, for those of you who were here for my New Age Healing session. And there you actually take the image that you've got towards which you find erotic, you see. So it's not lust yet, it's only lust when you indulge it. So as soon as you see an image which is erotic, to actually begin to take the skin off. Look at the parts, just see that in fact, we say beauty is only skin deep. And when you do that, then if you do it to parts which naturally raise a sense of disgust, you don't have to make yourself vomit, you understand. When you just raise that little bit of disgust then you'll see the mind balances itself and what we're trying to do with that exercise is to get the mind to be conditioned so that as soon as a lustful thought comes up the mind itself will change it for you. You can make that a habit in the mind to do that.

And by doing that, you're undermining that process of spinning off onto these thoughts. If you end up being disgusted all the time, then you have to stop it. Because that's not the point. The point isn't to end up with disgust for the human body. It's just a little trick that we can play to make the mind flip, you see. And, I mean, I've practiced this myself, and it definitely works, I can assure you of that.

And you have to be slightly careful with it too because you can be slightly unwittingly you can be suppressing see that's another point that we have to be careful of. All we're thinking about is thoughts and then we have to get down to the root feeling which is that desire to be at that place which gives us so much pleasure. So you have to be quite careful with the old suppression which we know from Freud becomes twisted and ends up in all sorts of peculiar behaviour.

So the thing is that what we want to do with sexual energy, or what we want to do in terms of the spiritual life, is to withdraw the unnecessary energy that we ought to have around sex. And there's a word that, I don't know, you never hear it these days. It's got a bad name because I think it was confused with suppression. And that word is sublimation, to sublimate. In science, I looked it up, I don't know anything about science. In science, it means when a solid evaporates immediately into air, into a gas. There's a special word, sublimate.

And to sublimate means, in terms of your energy, is to divert unskillful impulses or unskillful desires into something which is skillful. So if we have an image of the way the mind works as just an energy system which coagulates, forms a tightness around a particular idea and spins around it like a whirlwind, and that's all we're talking about. We just talk about energy. And if I can draw that energy away to something which is more

useful or even expresses that in a sublimated form, then what I get is poetry, art, music. I don't have to go that way. I can draw that energy away and put it into some loving energy, some compassionate energy.

Now, you just have to be slightly careful with that because you've also got to acknowledge that whirlwind. So if you don't acknowledge the whirlwind, then you think you might be putting your thoughts in better places, but you're not acknowledging this turbulence. So that turbulence remains. So you have to acknowledge the turbulence, feel the turbulence, and then cajole yourself to draw the energy into something which is more skillful. And there's that transformation going on.

Now this of course became the root understanding of Tantra. That's all that Tantra is. It's just the transformation of that energy. It's just that understanding that all you're playing around with is some sort of energy force and that therefore through certain imagery and even through certain actions you can sublimate it, you can draw it out and take away that habit. And what we want to do is get rid of that obsessiveness around these things. So I'm sure you all know that if lust gets hold of us in a meditation retreat, it's got a tight hold, so you have to be very sharp on that. And remember that it can be an escape from something, a usual escape from anxiety, from loneliness, from all sorts of things.

And romance, that delicious feeling that we get when we fall in love with somebody. And the dreams and the books written, my goodness, and the films, I mean, it's just never ending. It's always the same plot, which is really annoying. But somehow, we still wring juice out of it. It doesn't matter how many romantic films people see, they love them. So it's that sheer deliciousness of being in love with somebody.

And again, I'm talking now about being in a meditation retreat, when the mind is wandering that day and it's fantasizing about some enchanted evening. And you're out there with old Frank Sinatra in the background. And you have to see that immediately and go into it.

Now there'll be that deliciousness there because of the memory of the wanting to be at that place in that special way with another person. I mean, it is pure deliciousness. I can't think of anything more delicious myself. Apart from maybe the *jhānas* and that's why you have to be slightly careful. So remember that again there's always these two things: it's delicious, we like to indulge in but it's also an escape. It may be an escape, it doesn't have to be an escape, may be an escape.

So when we're sitting here and we're beginning to be assailed by these romantic feelings and romantic dreams and you come back and you allow that feeling. Remember that feeling emotions all these things are all seeking metaphor. They're all seeking metaphor. They're all seeking a way in which to express themselves. But when you just note romance, falling in love, and you note that and you turn away into the body and you feel the delicious feelings, as they begin to dissipate, don't be surprised if underneath it what you come across is a deep loneliness. Because that's what we're running from.

So it's a case of remembering that. So that when the loneliness comes up then there should be this little aha—that's why I'm so obsessive about these romantic films and stuff. It's because of this loneliness. And of course you have to go into the loneliness, you have to let the loneliness express itself. You know, you are unlovable, nobody loves you, you're alone in this world, kill yourself. So you have to stay within those awful feelings, don't get caught up in those words. And then again, don't be surprised that as you sink into that loneliness, allow it, allow it to express itself and let it dissipate. Suddenly you're just sitting there in this really lovely state of solitude. Just being at one with oneself.

It's a sense of lack. There's a writer called David Loy. He can be a bit heavy because he's a very good philosopher. He's American. Works in Japan. And if you haven't come across his books, do look him up, David Loy. And he likes this word lack for *dukkha*. Not suffering, not unsatisfactoriness, but lack. There's a lack there. And when you think about it, that's just another way of saying desire, a wanting for something.

And remember that the self is an empty thing. Not empty in the old Mahāyāna, the great emptiness. Emptiness ends up, there's nothing there. It's got to fill itself with something. Sex, drugs and rock and roll.

So, again, it's a case of being very clear about what's happening there, and to stop the mind. When I say stop the mind, you have to be careful not to back these things away. You're not trying to destroy the mind, you're not trying to kill it, you just note it. Now, as soon as you note what's going on, that which has been going on, the thought, the romance, it has to stop, because you can't think two thoughts at the same time. It's as simple as that. So if you keep saying, romance, romance, as soon as you've said that, the romance is gone.

So what that means is that we've stopped with that noting, the acknowledgement, we've stopped the escape of this emotional energy from slipping up into these higher faculties to create this imaginary world, a virtual reality. That's what it is, eh? And if you get lost in that, then of course you tend to throw it out into the world. So by coming off those very patiently, just know that you come back into the heart and you just feel,

feel what's going on there. And don't be surprised if suddenly, as it dissipates, some rather nasty feeling turns on. And of course, as those nasty feelings disappear, then there's nothing impelling this search for escape, happiness in romance and all these things, and therefore the obsessiveness begins to grow.

And remember, as I keep saying, that all the energy we have, nothing is lost in this process. It is actually being slowly transformed. And all these things are transformed into love, compassion, joy, or peace. That's what we're doing.

Now, you know, whenever I talk about this, especially as a monk, everybody thinks, well, he's just a monk. He's against the erotic and the romantic. He's taken about celibacy, so he's bitter. But it's not true. And if you think about the ordinary passage, I personally like the Brahminical path, because I think it's a bit, as usual, a bit male-dominated, but it is the way that you can see how the relationship between two people can lead to ultimate renunciation and then finally a true love and then finally renunciation.

So the idea is that you're a student until you're 25, thereabouts. Then you get married and you live the lay life. You live an involved life. And if possible you have a family, that's not necessary in this particular, in the spiritual sense. And during that time you go through a relationship and go through these particular moments where there's a block to be, there's a contradiction to be solved, a conflict to be solved, and in so doing the relationship gets closer and closer until there's what you might call a real union.

And then around about the age of 65 or thereabouts, they're supposed to leave family. They're supposed to go away and live like hermits. And then at the age of 75, the man, and presumably the woman, we never talked about, the man disappears completely. He goes away, tries to lose his caste name. He's supposed to become a beggar. You're not supposed to approach him as an uncle or a father or anybody.

And when you think about that, isn't that just the natural way of life? I mean, here you've got the leaves, and you can see it, the early buds, the full blossom, the slow dying, and then the disappearance. And so here you have the idea of a full life, if possible, you've got to have a bit of luck there, where, through meeting somebody, you form this very close, intimate relationship, which is very supportive, and we all know how difficult it is to get that. And then you work through that until it becomes utterly mature. Then there comes a time when you realize that even that has to be let go of.

So remember, the spiritual path, whether we like it or not, eventually, at some point, is a path of renunciation. It's like, whether you like it or not, it's got to come that way. I heard Joseph Campbell, some of you might know, the mythologist who wrote the book called *Hero of a Thousand Faces*, and a very well-known writer. And he was inter-

viewed on this and he was talking about two relationships that people sometimes go through. The first one being the worldly relationship and then a change in midlife. And then you finally find your spiritual partner and off you go and he reckoned that this was a regular thing. So there is within a relationship a real possibility of true spiritual friendship, true spiritual growth and eventual, the eventual path of renunciation which has to come at the end.

And talking about this, it's very interesting how people get a very negative view about marriage and things like that. I'm surprised how many Buddhists think that, for instance, it's not worth having children and bringing them into this life of suffering. And once a young man came to see me while I was in London, and he said that he was having problems with his relationship, which had been absolutely fine, but now she wanted kids, and he said he couldn't see the point because life is suffering, and he gave me all this stuff about suffering and pain. I thought, why bring a child into this? So I slowly argued that this was a very special place. That in fact it was right here that all the conditions are where a being can actually make very good, very quick spiritual progress.

So I explained this to him. And then I said... Apart from becoming an Arahant, apart from becoming perhaps an Anāgāmi, a non-returner, I can't see in the world anything more compassionate than to bring another being into this world and to give it that basic moral and spiritual teaching for its own growth. So he thanked me very much and I never saw him again. Which goes to show that he just didn't want kids.

So I think we have to correct some of that because Buddhism has come to the West through the eyes of Christianity and it's still there as a life-negative religion. As a life-negating religion. And that's just not true. It's just not true.

And then just finally within this area is of course celibacy. And I'd like to coin a phrase from dear old Sir Winston Churchill. Some are born celibate. Some choose to be celibate. And some have celibacy thrust upon them. And we have to say that in the ordinary run of life we do find ourselves in celibate situations. Now for us as you know on the spiritual path those are times to get in contact with all the stuff around relationship around this sort of relationship. Yes, and that's an opportunity. Remember, in daily life, here you see there's no point in getting into all these fantasies because it's really just taking out energy somewhere else. But in daily life, when we enter into daily life and these energies come up, and you can see there's no point in indulging them, then this idea of sublimation, of recognising that energy and then cajoling it into some other area of activity.

If one, of course, makes the decision that one wants a relationship, then have the faith, go with it, hope for the best. Just one last thing that I had slightly forgotten to mention is that I was very surprised once I did a talk at a marriage ceremony. Well, two things actually. A talk at a marriage ceremony, not for Buddhists. I was just a friend of this. Well, he was a Buddhist. Yeah, that's right. And everybody else wasn't. And I gave a talk. And in the talk, I simply mentioned the distinction between romantic feelings and real love. And I said that romantic feelings towards your partner just come and go. Sometimes you feel them and sometimes you don't. Often you feel hate, disgust, fed up, could get rid of the person, all that sort of stuff. And I said, but love, love has nothing to do with the emotional life. I said, love is to do with a commitment coming from a deeper centre that you have devoted your life to sharing your life with somebody else. And that is the underlying motivation. And if that goes, then definitely get a divorce. So I was surprised how many people came up to me afterwards and thanked me for that distinction. And I could only presume that in their own relationships they'd been utterly confused because they woke up in the morning and said, well, I don't love you. You turn over and you see this person and you think, oh, God, 10 years, what am I doing? And you think, I can't live, I've got to get out, I've got to find somebody else. And it's just that confusion about things.

And the other thing that I might say just on this little level is how I've conducted marriage ceremonies for people who've been in partnership for years. I mean, 10, 15, 15 years. And all of them, and they tell me of friends who actually go through a marriage ceremony, that there is a distinctive difference once it moves into a state of vowing. Because when we make a public statement about our intentions, that really roots us very deeply in something. And that's why we take public oaths. That's why when the president is elected, he makes a public oath. And that is a public commitment, and the whole of society is meant to be supportive, to support you with that. That's the idea of it. But that extra commitment... It just deepened the whole relationship. Which means that in the partnership, there was always something holding back. Just something holding back. Just in case, after 10, 15 years, this is the wrong person to be with. Which would be very disappointing. After 15 years you suddenly decide this is not the person I ought to have been with.

So just remembering all that and remembering that here in our meditation to be very quick with those thoughts because they are, they're delicious. Yes, celibacy. So the idea of when we find ourselves in a celibate situation is that this is a time to allow those things to pass away. And again, this sublimation so that we can see that times of celibacy and for monastics, the idea is to refine that energy, to take it away from there and to actually refine it. That's the idea of that. And it's displaced into the spiritual path.

I think I've just got a bit of time, I think, to talk about attachment. So this is also a love with a little kink in it. And just think of all the people whom we are attached to. Children... family, friends, even animals. You can love an animal as much as you can love a human being. And there's an attachment to it. And the unfortunate thing is that we don't know the depth of the attachment until the beloved disappears. You don't know how attached you are to your cat until it dies. You don't know how attached you are to your mother until she dies. I can tell you that. And this is one of those things that we don't really know.

Now, the only distinction I like to make is that we're not here talking about something evil. We're not talking about something evil. We're talking about something unskillful. When the Buddha uses the word *akusala*, see there's two words in the Pāli, *pāpa*, which means evil, and *akusala*, which just simply means unskillful, unwholesome, not virtuous. And in terms of the path we're just trying to shift all our conditionings towards the virtuous. So it's not a case of feeling guilty about attachment. It's a case of knowing that there is some attachment there, that there has to be some attachment there. And within parents you see that's the rebellious teenager. They just want to get away from that grip, that hold.

And of course the root reason for that is that we're seeking happiness in human beings. Now that's ridiculous. Anything in the world to depend upon for happiness is definitely not a human being. I mean, that's really awful. I mean, they leave you, then they hate you. And then they die on you, for heaven's sake. I mean, there's no way that when you think about it, you'd want your happiness to be dependent on a human being. I mean, rather a rock. That will stay there for a while. I mean, you should outlive you. You can keep hugging the rock. Or a tree. Love a tree. That's much better. But a human being is very, very fickle.

So once we see that, and we take the attachment away, and then the confusion disappears between what attachment is and what love is. And just to be aware of that. And of course the downside of attachment is that the person becomes an object. They become something to satisfy your lack. That's what an attachment does. I want you to be like this, I want you to grow up like this.

And you can see in certain behaviours, for instance, supposing somebody was told that the doctor said to them that they had terminal cancer. And when the doctor told them that, they begin to break down and weep and cry, gnash their teeth, bang the table, how terrible it is and all that. You think, well, that's very unprofessional. I don't expect the doctor to do that. And you expect them to be compassionate, kind, softly spoken, but just with you in that quiet way. And when you go home and you say to your

partner, I've got terminal cancer, and they reply, well, what do you want to wear in the coffin? And you think, my goodness, don't you love me? I expect you to weep gnashing of teeth and all that sort of stuff. And so you can see how behaviours change when that attachment comes. And it's a case of just recognising that.

With children, you can see parents, if the child hurts itself... And it's just a scratch and the parent knows it's just a little thing. But the kid's screaming. The parent's very calm, very quiet, hugs the child, everything's all right, all that sort of stuff. But if the parent sees that the child has actually broken a leg or really banged his head and, oh my goodness, then the fear comes out and all that. And of course that feeds right into the child and the child becomes the object of fear. The poor kid's trying to handle all this pain and the mother or father's berserkness. But it's just part and parcel of that relationship.

So, if we find ourselves here in the meditation wanting to phone somebody, expecting somebody to phone them, wanting to get in touch with some family member, some friend. If you see that, that's a product of attachment. Just let it pass, let it pass. And then there might be that feeling of guilt, of some sort of loss of love. Because there's that confusion between what love is and what that attachment is.

I've got time just for one more thing I wanted to... Oh, yeah. And just to take the deliciousness to that other area of distraction. So be careful, especially on a retreat. We might think to ourselves, oh, it would be nice to go for a walk now. I think I feel I need a walk. But actually, if you sit with that... actually just fed up with being inside. You're just trying to escape being inside. Or you don't want to walk up and down the same walking path anymore. You want to have a distraction, do it somewhere else. And if you can really let that go, and draw the space around you closer, making your boundary less and less, you'll see it has a great force on your meditation and your stillness. Because every time you wander off on a walk, you're in a different place. You're exciting something. Something's arising. And it's very difficult. I'm sure you've all experienced, even doing quick walking as an exercise, how suddenly the mind will start wandering. And you've walked up and down for ten minutes and you've been everywhere and anywhere.

So all these desires for distraction. So remember that if we really want to get to know the mind and to really get into its turbulences, if we really want to squeeze the pimple, then you've got to stop the input. That's the point. You've got to stop the input. You've got to stop looking, stop listening. Hearing is different from listening. And as soon as you stop the input, then there's no way these turbulences can find a way to express themselves. And the mind starts going berserk, but you keep playing with it. And when

that's cut off, what can they do? All these griefs, guilt, fear, the whole gamut of human suffering. It booms out as it comes out. It comes out as these awful, awful, terrible feelings. But that's the purification. That's purgatory. Just hang on in there. And just keep saying to yourself, there is an end to suffering. There is. There's got to be.

So that's why in meditation we're always encouraged to go inward, to stay with what's happening within ourselves. And just as an addenda to all that, of course, is the problem of boredom. So remember, boredom is that frustration, is that getting fed up with distraction and pleasure. So be very careful with boredom, because boredom will tell you to seek distraction, to do something else. Remember that the whole point of the pleasure syndrome is that there's an inbuilt obsolescence. You can't keep chewing the same sweet. It gets boring. You've got to go for the raspberry flavour or the coffee flavour. You've got to move a little bit to get that same sense of pleasure or joy out of it.

So whenever boredom comes up, you feel the boredom, you don't get confused by boredom on the breath, boredom on this, boredom on that, boredom with food. You stay with the boredom. And the way to overcome boredom is to keep doing what you're doing, repetition. Just repetition and keeping that boredom within your attentiveness. And then don't be surprised. If the boredom suddenly disappears and what arises is its opposite which is interest only this time because you've let the boredom go some wrong purpose has been got rid of. That's the point. Boredom has come because we're seeking happiness in whatever it is we're experiencing.

I mean, our society is really bad with that because pleasure is so easy at hand and we expect to be distracted, we expect to be entertained all the time, TV, radio, the whole thing. And to enter into a place where there's nothing, then you get this boredom arising. And going back to the Buddha's own experience, remember, after he had become enlightened for seven years, Māra stalked him with his three daughters. Sexual desire, pleasure and boredom. So there's little boys saying, this is really boring just sitting here, why don't you get on with it?

So, with that in mind, be careful of these delicious areas. So I think there's just some time to complete some of these questions. Now, unfortunately, I lost the list. I brought the wrong list that I was working with last week, but I shall answer a few more next week. Let me just give some indications to these.

Can you please discuss the differences in practices and goals in the Theravāda, Zen, Dzogchen and Vajrayāna tradition? Well the way that I think you'll find eventually people who have practiced two, three or four of these is that the only difference is skillful means, that's all. We're just using always skillful means, some different ways in order to achieve the same end. What is that end? It's *sati*, right awareness and *paññā*,

insight. That's all it is. And either you get it by observing the phenomena of the mind, in other words, which is more Theravāda-based, or you become aware more of the space within which this is happening, which is that consciousness. And just that begins to separate consciousness out from the contents that it sees within itself. So it doesn't matter. Even in Theravāda one becomes aware of the knowing as a different faculty from everything it knows.

So remember that all these traditions arose as they passed through cultures and even in our culture now you can see the effect of western psychotherapy on the practice of the Dhamma and it's bound to happen and it's a good thing because that's the way we are.

Please discuss the pros and cons of being in the breath of the nostrils as opposed to the abdomen. The general or the usual instruction is you watch the breath where you feel it most and that's the important thing because it's your primary object. It's something you want to go back to. It's something that you want to develop a certain stillness with because I don't use the word concentration. And it's something which, when everything quietens down, the still mind, the peaceful heart, and the quiet body, or the quiet mind, still body, there is only the breath, and that becomes the object which you are looking at. So, keeping that in mind, that the primary object is supposed to be the breath, and at the point where you feel it most.

I think you generally agree with me those of you who've tried both is that when you watch the breath of the nostrils you tend to lose the body. It's a very good technique for concentration meditations because you don't have to worry about the body. You become concentrated up here. Whereas when you stay down at the abdomen you're buried in the body. You tend to feel more in contact with the body.

The other thing is that in the Mahāsi tradition, of course, the rising and falling of the abdomen is then carried into the rising and falling of the footst

The Pāramī Turned Inward

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 28 min read

In this evening retreat talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines how the ten pāramī (perfections) that the Bodhisattva cultivated over countless lifetimes can be turned inward as practices of wise self-care during meditation retreats. Drawing from the Jātaka stories of the Buddha's past lives, he explores how dāna (generosity) begins with nourishing ourselves properly, including mindful eating that distinguishes between healthy enjoyment and indulgence.

The talk addresses practical retreat challenges through the lens of the pāramī: developing mettā (loving-kindness) toward ourselves, practicing truthful self-assessment without harsh self-criticism, and cultivating the renunciation (nekkhamma) needed for sustained practice. Bhante emphasizes how proper sīla (ethical conduct) includes not harming ourselves through oversleeping or mental proliferation, while upekkhā (equanimity) allows complete receptivity to whatever arises in meditation.

With characteristic wisdom and humor, including stories from monastic life, this teaching offers a compassionate framework for retreat practice that balances effort with kindness, helping practitioners avoid both indulgence and self-mortification while cultivating the same qualities that led to the Buddha's Awakening.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

Last week we talked about what's known as the distant epoch. This is the story of Gautama Buddha and it's in the collection of the Jātakas. We talked about what he was doing before he was born as a bodhisattva. I was going to go on to the process of his life and what he did during his life, but then it occurred to me that this was a good time to look at the pāramī, because herein our Bodhisattva spent four asaṅkhyeya, measureless times, and a hundred thousand eons, making his resolutions under twenty-four Buddhas, commencing with Dīpaṅkara. No Buddha other than this perfectly enlightened one appeared after the Blessed One, Kassapa. And in this manner, the Buddha received his assurance under the twenty-four Buddhas, beginning with Dīpaṅkara.

So what was he doing during that hell of a long time? My goodness, what was he playing at? That took him so long. It was the development of these *pāramī*. They're usually described as perfections, which is a little bit over the top, really. It's more virtues or those qualities that you need to get to the other shore, because that's what *pāramī* means, the other shore. But he needs a little bit more than that, and I just want to read this out of interest to you. He actually needs, for it is said, the resolution which consists of a combination of eight conditions. You can't just become a Buddha because you've got the perfections right.

Birth as a human being. The advantage of sex—we'll come to that in a minute. No throwing stones yet, please. The good fortune. The meeting with a teacher. Ordination. Endowment of inherent capabilities to higher knowledge. The dedication of one's life and resolute will. So there are one or two things there. The idea that you have to be a human being to be a buddha. You can't do it in the other realms. I think we know why. The hell realms are too painful and the heavenly realms are just too joyful. The wonderful thing about the human realm is it has this lovely mixture of joy and woe. And of course we have the intelligence to work our way out of it.

The advantage of sex. If you remember last time we were talking about conceptions of time and the idea of circular time. Obviously if you believe in circular time, time constantly repeating itself, then once you've got a Buddha who is a male, all the rest of them have to be males. That's what you call a *diṭṭhi*, that's what you call holding on to a belief. And the Buddha rails about this. If he knew what was being said about him now, I'm sure he'd turn over in his grave if he was still there. The whole idea of extending something present into the past to make a law of it is one of those things that we constantly do. Precedence. In our law-making we call it precedence. So that's how you end up with the idea that only men can become Buddhas.

The meeting with a teacher or ordination, endowment of inherent capabilities to higher knowledge. Hopefully we've all got that, but there's something perhaps special about somebody who's made that dedication to become fully self-enlightened. And a dedication of one's life and resolute will. Don't forget that. This endowment of inherent capabilities to the higher knowledge. Remember, we've all got that, but we talk about the self-enlightened Buddha. For a Westerner, this does conjure up the idea of the self-made man, the self-made woman. And of course, when you look into the history of anybody who is self-made in terms of their success in society, you find that they've been helped along by their workers, by the system, by their birth, by good fortune, and so on and so forth. So the idea of somebody being self-made is one of these lovely Western myths. And we deposit that on the Buddha, thinking that he did it all by himself.

Of course, he didn't. He started off by going to teachers, tried various methods, as you know, and eventually, in that despair, suddenly found a way out of the problem. But we'll come to that perhaps at another time.

What I want to talk around, really, just allow ourselves to contemplate a little, are these *pāramī*. But I want to do it specifically for a retreat situation. The first two I'll stick together are *dāna*, generosity, and *mettā*. We say that charity begins at home. So where's home? It's here, isn't it? It's how I treat myself. If I can discover and develop a way of treating myself which is virtuous and which does me good, then let's presume that I'm going to treat others in the same way.

We have this teaching called the *āhāra* or nutriments. And they go like this: food for the body, that's pretty straightforward. Sense impression for feeling. Volition for *saṅkhāra*, for mental formations or becoming, *kamma*. And consciousness for the body-mind. That one specifically has to do with the process of rebirth, so we won't bother ourselves here so much. But it's this concept of nourishing, nourishing ourselves.

When we go for food, that's a real opportunity to develop this nourishment, *dāna*, this generosity, this nourishment towards ourselves. You have to, as it were, get in contact with the body and you have to recognise that the feelings of hunger partly are coming from the body itself needing nourishment and partly from greed which also needs nourishment. We have to be able to recognise that that's there whether we like it or not and it's a case of approaching the food with that consciousness of the body, with that awareness of the feelings in the body, and then reminding ourselves that we can always go for seconds. We take what we feel we need and we place it in front of us, and again to remind ourselves that this is nourishment for the body, that it's just going to cause us the sufferings of greed if we indulge. So we begin to eat.

Now, at this point, especially with this teaching around *dukkha* and suffering and all that, and the dangers of pleasure, we often fall into the wrong thinking that pleasurable feelings are somehow evil. You have to be very careful with pleasant feelings. They're Māra in disguise, and they're going to drag you down to an eternal hell. In which case, you fall into the error of self-mortification, because now you don't let yourself enjoy anything. Because if you enjoy something, well, surely that's the same as greed.

This distinction between enjoying what is given to us and indulging is obviously very subtle. And we fall into the error of one or the other. In the monastic life, which I've come to know a little bit about, the horror sometimes comes out in people's practice, the horror of any sort of sense pleasure. Monks will ride on buses and trains and keep their eyes constantly on their knees, daring not to look out in case they're distracted by whatever passes by.

There was one lovely example I remember of a monk who, if you saw him, you would definitely feel that he was an ascetic of tremendous stature. He had that gaunt look about him of somebody who had been through hell and survived, and he was a couple of years older than me in the order, so he would sit to my left. The food came by and it happened to be a very lovely meal. It was somebody's birthday so it was one of these times when we got fruit salad with ice cream. This was served to us and we began eating it, the robed monks, and I noticed that he was actually staring at this object on the table. And I could feel the energy of his stare, because right there in front of him was Māra.

As we ate it and we got close to finishing our dessert, he very mindfully went towards it, picked it up very gently, raised it to his lips, and disappeared within a couple of seconds, just in case it touched the tongue, just in case there arose anywhere some sort of pleasurable feeling. Now you can imagine that this sort of life is pretty dire if you can't enjoy what life gives us.

We're very familiar with the *jhānas* and the idea that we can sail into *jhānas* and that the Buddha said that this was wonderful. But there is a point in the scriptures where the Buddha coming back from alms round actually says to Ānanda, why don't we find a beautiful shrine where we can eat this? A park—remember shrines in those days were really like parks—and he names a couple of shrines. The Cāpāla shrine is the one I remember. The question arises, why should he be bothered about eating his food in a beautiful shrine? Why not on a dung heap? Or in a desert place, or just where he is?

There's something about beauty, there's something about the loveliness of life, which is not to be confused with indulgence and wrong relationship, which causes us problems. Now, it seems to me that food is just one of these lovely places where we can develop this right attitude because we have to eat. And most of us do it two, three times a day and probably a lot more often as well with the cups of teas and coffees and what have you.

Every time we approach something to nourish the body, there's an opportunity to make this distinction between enjoying what is lovely, what is beautiful, and indulging in it. Now it seems to me that if we can crack this problem of enjoying something without indulgence, of experiencing essential pleasure in a lovely way without indulgence, then we have perhaps a way of translating that into every part of our lives.

There's of course all the joys of relationship. How can you enjoy the joys of relationship without becoming attached? There's got to be a way of doing it, surely. How can you enjoy all the aesthetic beauty of life and not depend upon it for personal happiness? That's what indulgence does, doesn't it? You depend upon. Your happiness de-

pend upon something being there. And when it comes even to the spiritual joys, one of the warnings that they always tell you about *jhāna* practice is that you get stuck with it. You become indulgent and you can't let it go. And it just becomes another path to hell.

It seems to me that this *dāna*, this generosity that we can practice towards ourselves, this loving kindness, this caring towards ourselves, if we start just with the basic body. What does the body need and how can I give it to the body in a way which is lovely, which is beautiful?

When it comes to meditation, keeping the mind calm, keeping the mind still. Remember that you have to nourish that. You have to nourish that by giving it those things to absorb into, as it were. So just the softness of the breath. Instead of looking at it as some sort of painful exercise that one has to do, to watch the breath in order to make insight, feel the actual gentle feelings of the breath. Feel that lovely quality of the breath and just those calm gentle feelings around it and just begin to sense that as something which is worthy of appreciation. The body does have lovely feelings.

Going always with this idea of giving oneself something is, of course, the opposite, which is to renounce. You've got to renounce something. And that's where you get these two particular *pāramī*. They come together, the idea of generosity, the idea of giving, and the idea of renunciation. In ordinary daily life, when we give something to somebody with no hope of return, it means we have to give something up, which we would have normally used for our own personal enjoyment. If you make a donation to these terrible things that happen in nature, and you make a donation to help people, then you've obviously given something up, which you might have had before. You might have gone on holiday somewhere, but you've decided to give that up for the benefit of others.

The idea of renunciation and generosity and care always balance each other. They come together. When we nourish the mind, when we want to nourish our calmness within us, remember that it also means that we have to renounce sense pleasure. Now it's up to you how far you want to take that. Reading can excite the mind. Writing can excite the mind. Phone calls and definitely getting onto the web. So all these things have to be renounced for the benefit of spiritual development.

You can even get more refined and, of course, not look around, not look around at nature, which is around us here, and just keep the eyes, as it were, still. This feels like a sort of sensory deprivation. But the purpose, of course, is to completely calm the mind. And the more we stop that sense impression, the more the mind will calm. It's just a

fact. These sense impressions, remember, are what feelings are made out of. As soon as a sense impression comes in, we immediately perceive it as either being pleasant or unpleasant. And as soon as that happens, you get your reaction, wanting, not wanting.

To keep the mind very calm and to restrict your sense perception at all the doors, hearing, whatever, is going to help us to just calm the mind. It's sort of feeding the calmness, nourishing the calmness. And calmness, remember, *passaddhi*, is one of the seven factors of enlightenment. So it's all linked. Everything's linked.

This lovely word, attention. It has this double meaning, doesn't it? To attend to somebody, to look after them, to tend to something. And by paying attention to the object, by giving it a feeling of care towards what you're looking at, giving a flavour of loving kindness to your practice, looking down upon something with compassion. We have this Buddha, Avalokiteśvara, from the Mahāyāna tradition, to look down upon, to look down upon with compassion.

When these great pains arise in the body, which, remember, are only trying to express themselves, one looks down upon them with great compassion. As it were, one embraces them, opens up to them, but rather than always this sort of very sharp investigation, which is fine, I mean, there's nothing wrong with that, but sometimes just to, as it were, flavour the investigation with just that little bit of kindness. And what that tends to do is it just softens a bit. It just softens the process, that's all.

Of course, the danger there is that you try and zap what it is that's hurting you with enormous compassion and try and do a bit of New Age healing. And of course, that can be a disaster, especially if it fails.

It's a case of also recognising that the attention that we pay, the attention can be an attending, an attending to. And if we think of the body with its pains coming either from the physical base, from the posture, say from the knees and things like that, or from the turbulences that are caught up, these mental turbulences that are caught up in the body that come out as neck ache, back ache, stomach ache, the whole load of aches. And to, as it were, look down upon them with that sort of gentleness.

This is a generosity, this is a kindness, isn't it? This is a kindness towards ourselves. There's also to nourish that sense of enthusiasm. It doesn't come, I mean, sometimes it just arises of itself, but enthusiasm, urgency—a sense of urgency. You have to feed it. Sometimes when you find yourself not putting in the practice, it's sometimes because we haven't lifted that enthusiasm. If you think of people in the business world or the political world, how they're constantly telling themselves to get on with it. These sports people that shout at themselves to make the game. Well, I'm not suggesting that you do

that. But one has to, as it were, bring up what were the reasons that we came to meditation for in the first place. You have to keep reminding yourself. You have to cajole yourself sometimes to build up that dedication.

This is all to do with not being hard upon ourselves, but just to develop this sense of generosity towards ourselves. It's the same with concentration. When you don't have concentration, then you can get very down and you start blaming yourself and you think, oh dear, this is terrible and all this sort of stuff. And it's a case of just resting and just asking yourself, well, why isn't it coming? Then if you put too much energy into it, of course, then it corrupts it even further. So it has to be a gentle energy, a cajoling. Have some sort of image, like training a puppy dog to sit. If you give it a kick, it just runs away. So you've got to pat it down and give it something to suck. And very slowly, it'll sit down for you.

That sense of being kind to oneself, being generous to oneself. In all the forms of our practice, we can find a little way of bringing that generosity towards it. Of course, there is always going to be the danger of indulgence, but sometimes give yourself the benefit of the doubt. You are actually being caring and not indulging. I think the trick is to really look at your attitude. Why am I doing it? And be very clear about that.

That brings us really to this whole business of honesty. Honesty is, I mean, nobody would say, you know, I'm telling lies or anything. It's not a case of that. It's a case more of exaggeration or not really facing up to why you're doing something. So you feel a bit sleepy and, you know, a little power nap, take a bit of time out, all this sort of stuff. You know, I'm being kind to myself. But actually, when you really quiz yourself, and you recognise that you've actually had a very good night's sleep, and really there's no reason at all to fall asleep at this present time, then one has to be kind to oneself by not going to sleep. Or else one simply begins to develop that idea of little naps all over the place. And if you've ever tried that, it does undermine your meditation. It begins to actually sap your energy. So you have to be slightly careful about that.

And that truthfulness, even small things. What we want to do, don't we, is to build up this, to build up the power of our meditation. We want to maintain a constant effort, a constant effort. I personally like to think in three hour blocks, I can handle that. If it gets longer than that, I get headaches and stuff like that. So a three-hour block. If I've been sitting, say, for one hour, and then I get up, well, there's that little idea comes, you know, have a cup of tea. And off I go, and half an hour goes having this cup of tea which I never needed anyway, and of course it ruins, it ruins that little special effort, it ruins the building up of that energy that we need to really make some good insight.

When you get these feelings to have a little drink or take a little break or go for a little walk, you have to be really truthful. You have to sit there and say now come on, and then you go to the walking place and do your walking meditation. Very slowly, by renouncing those desires, they're all nicely interwoven, these things. By renouncing those desires, one is being kind to oneself and one is building up this other *pāramī*, this other virtue of determination, *adhiṭṭhāna*. Goodwill, strong will.

One of those things is when you feel restless and you think, oh well, I'll go for a walk. The mind is not still. And off you go, you go into the forest or something. And really, you're just escaping. We're just wandering off to get away from restlessness for a little bit. And of course, if you do feel restless and we walk fast up and down, it does give us a sense of relief. But it's not dealing with the mental factor of restlessness at all. And often we can use that to suppress. So you have to be careful.

It's the same with *thīna-middha*. I prefer the words dullness and lethargy, frankly. Dullness and lethargy, you can make the mistake of thinking, right, well I'll go for a run and really shake this off. And of course what you're doing is you're suppressing those feelings which are an energy force, which is drawing us down. There's energy, remember, which bursts us out like stars, and there's energy which draws us down like black holes. So it's all within us, and if we think that we're going to overcome feelings of *thīna*, dullness and lethargy by giving ourselves a kick and running about. That's just another way of actually suppressing it and building over it this energy. But actually we're not dealing with this energy which is experienced as a dullness in the mind or a heaviness in the body.

How do we do that? Well again you have to let go of the idea of trying to do something about it. And as it were, be gentle to these things. Be generous to these things. Be open to these things. And allow them to express themselves. You have to find a way of allowing dullness and lethargy to express itself. And usually the best way is to walk up and down gently. But you keep your mind, you keep your attention on those feelings. And in that way, these mental states are given the space and the time just to exhaust themselves.

Often, when we do that we can feel that transformation. Remember that there's nothing lost in this process. Everything is simply transformed. We might just suddenly feel having worked with these feelings of dullness and lethargy a sudden very gentle energy. Sometimes it flips because it's just the other side of the coin of restlessness.

It's a case of being careful to really be truthful with ourselves, not to kid ourselves. Of course, the opposite is, or the danger, of course, is you get into self-criticism, self-judgment, this business of I'm no good, everybody else can do it but not me, I'm special

that way. And it's a case of recognising that you have to make a separation between the action and the person. The person is a figment of the imagination. We can say that this action was unskillful. Lying down in the afternoon was unskillful. I didn't wake up till seven o'clock and it broke my sleep pattern. We can say that was unskillful. But if I then say to myself, well, you're an absolutely useless person. This is obvious. What the hell are you doing here? Then I get into this awful negativity about myself, which is a fiction anyway.

It's a case of recognising that the act can be unskillful, but the person need not be criticised. If those things come up, of course, you can't deny them there. You can't, just like in feelings of heaviness and these dullness, you can't say, oh, the self's not there, go away. No, you have to pay attention to that and let it go. You have to pay attention to it, but you don't indulge it by identifying with it. You recognise it now, that's the self. And remember that to keep off thought, to come into the body, to stay with the body, because there we're actually experiencing the mind in its rawness as emotion, what we call emotion, feeling, *vedanā*.

Every time the mind wanders, remember, it's indulging itself, whether we like it or not. Whether we made a decision to do so or not, there's still an impulsion there. That's why even though we don't mean to get angry, because we let the mind wander, we get more angry and more angry and more angry. You end up with Prozac.

It's a case of recognising that, coming back, coming to the feelings of guilt, feelings of shame, and just staying there with them. Just allowing them to rise and pass away. Because you'll never satisfy self-criticism. I mean, if you hear that voice saying, you really are the most unloveable of people. I don't know how anybody could love you. And then you say, well, I'll make up, I'll give something to somebody. And I'll practice generosity. And so you do this wonderful gift and give it to somebody. And then the little voice says, yes, that was a very wonderful thing. You did a really wonderful thing. But you are still horrible.

You can't get out of that definition of being horrible by doing something about it because it's there as a conditioning. So all we can do is allow that statement to come, note it as self-criticism, and go into the feel of it, go into the feel of it, and give it time to dissipate, give it time to dissipate.

When it comes to coming back to this renunciation, just one or two things that you might like to try. The idea of renunciation, of course, is not to create suffering for ourselves, as if we didn't have enough. The idea of renunciation is to see where the attachment is. So one stops doing something to feel that attachment towards what you would normally indulge in. Just try missing a meal as an experiment, seeing what hap-

pens. And just stay with the feelings of fear. The body may disappear if I don't eat. Things like that. And just stay with it and just feel the fear of it. That's what you're trying to do. You're trying to feel the fear. Remember that underlying all attachment is this anxiety, this fear.

One of the things is to find out what we feel about time. That can be interesting, just to find a clock which has a finger going round, and just watch it. Watch it for an hour, two hours, and just see what happens in your mind. It can be quite something to listen to yourself, just watching time passing. Because all this business about trying to achieve something, trying to do something, and I'm wasting my time, that all comes up in great gullops. So just watching the clock go round, or watching a watch, just tick, tick, tick, going round.

When it comes to this intuitive intelligence, I'll only say a little bit about that because I'll go into that more deeply later. This intelligence we have, the Buddha nature within us, this something in us wants to know, where's that come from? And it's a case of developing that as an intuition, knowing the difference between thought. Thought is not intuition. Intuition has to use thought to express itself. Intuition doesn't know what it knows until it says it to itself. That's why in your meditation sometimes you might hear these little phrases come up. Oh, everything's arising and passing away or something like that. And that's this intuition talking to itself. And it's one of these peculiarities that it doesn't know what it knows until it tells itself. And the only way it can tell itself is through words. Or one way it can tell itself is through words.

Intuition is not feeling. Don't confuse what people would normally talk about as I have a feeling or intuition with feeling. Feelings can also be just as delusive as thoughts can be. But again, this intuitive intelligence expresses itself through feeling. Just take a very simple thing. Intuitively, in terms of the intellect, expressing through the intellect, we may understand this idea of interconnection, interdependency. But when it expresses itself through the heart, how does that express itself? Through love, isn't it? Compassion. So compassion, love, sympathetic joy, these are all expressions of interdependency from the heart's point of view.

And, of course, it's not the body, but it expresses itself through the body. You've only got to see sports people and see how they react to things to see how the intuitive, just that intuitive intelligence expressing itself. Same with people who perform, actors and musicians. So the body, heart, mind, the body, all that are avenues in which this intuition expresses itself.

Somehow, we have to abstract it. We have to find a way of lifting it out of that embeddedness, that confusion with the psychophysical organism. And that really is what our meditation is about. That's why we turn everything into an object. That's why we look at it. That's why we look at something. As soon as you look at it, you can't be it. If you got into a car and said, well, this is me, they'd take you away. But here we are in this body and we say, this is me.

It's the same sort of idea of detachment. That's what the detachment is. Lifting this awareness, this intuitive intelligence, this *paññā*, out of its embeddedness to look at what's going on inside us. And to do that, I always find anyway, personally, that the best motivation is curiosity. What Zen calls the great doubt, or wanting to know, to excite that interest in our psychology and our bodies, and to see these three characteristics, see how it works.

This is the sort of thing the Bodhisattva was doing, for eons, for lifetimes. Trying to get it right.

The other thing is, the other quality is *sīla*, right conduct. Normally speaking, of course, when we talk about *sīla* or right conduct, it's usually referred to as just what we say and what we do. But also, you know, for our purposes, we can extend it into the mind because every time we think it's an action, it's an act of *kamma*. It is a form of *sīla*, you might say.

And, you know, you can look at just not to harm oneself through our thinking. Not to harm oneself by overeating. Not to harm the body. Oversleeping. All these wonderful researches into sleep. And people who sleep five hours are better off than people who sleep nine hours. It's better for you. There's a sort of good period between five and seven hours which is good for sleep. Anything over that is doing harm to the body. They did these exercises with rats, these poor animals, in which they half-starved one set and overfed the other. Not surprisingly, the ones who were half-starved lived the longest. The ones who overfed died of overweight.

One of the things that often troubles us in our meditation is erotic, romantic desires. It's a very strong pull within us. So be careful of that. Because as I say, once the mind trips, you're off. You've created enormously wonderful good films. If you'd only written them down, you'd have probably made a fortune by now. It's a case of as soon as you see the mind beginning to indulge, be very quick. And I can set you a little exercise if you haven't heard of it or done it before, but to look to the disgusting nature of the body. I have to be careful here because you don't want to end up being equally disgusted as you were lusted. But the idea is that as the figure towards which you feel either erotic or romantic feelings come towards, you either see the body in its more unpleas-

ant parts and positions and see the process of aging in that person and this undermines it and the idea is that we train the mind to actually turn the image for us so it'll do it naturally once you've done it a few times it'll just do it naturally for you and as the lust arises and presents its image it'll change in your mind just like that it'll do it.

This is only while, for most of you, you're undertaking the *brahmacariya*, you understand. I wouldn't want to suggest that there isn't a place for the erotic and the romantic in our lives. I remember it somewhere in my life. Somewhere in the past. And that, of course, is a renunciation. That's part of renunciation. Renouncing that sense pleasure.

We have to speak to ourselves properly. We have to understand why we're doing it, or else you get into a battle with yourself. And if you do things unwillingly, it creates a wrong attitude within us.

It's the same with drugs and drink, even at the level of just relying on tea. That's also, you can look at that as, you know, conduct.

Of course with all this you have to just be careful of not getting too tight a conscience. One of the great mistakes of the monastic life is presuming that if you keep the rule absolutely perfect then you're bound to move forward. Or worse, if you're practicing very hard and you don't move forward it means that you're not really keeping the rule properly. And I shall end this little tale, I shall end this little discourse with a tale of a particular monk just to show you the error of our ways. And of course it easily translates into lay life where you get the feeling that everything you're doing is wrong and that just because you're doing something wrong you can't move forward. You're always slipping into old habits, old negative habits.

There was a particular monk I knew who was an excellent meditator. Very fierce, up at four o'clock in the morning, all that sort of stuff. And seemingly after some period, not getting anywhere, began to lose confidence. So he presumed that it must be the Vinaya. So he began to study the Vinaya and he found, to his horror, that all monks weren't keeping the Vinaya at all. On two counts specifically. The upper robe was far too big. According to the original measurements, it was at least half the size. It was a little cape that you threw over yourself when you went into the village. And the bowl was definitely not the depth of, I think it's called a cubit.

At a particular ceremony, the Kaṭhina, which is the time when you have a feast after the rainy season retreat, where people come to make offerings for the *saṅgha*, he turned up with a very natty little cape tied around his neck. And then began doing little alms round, we went on a little alms round, with a proper sized object, which was actually a biscuit tin. And the general feeling was that he'd gone mad.

Now, as far as he was concerned, he was following the Vinaya strictly. Unfortunately, he then began to decide that, in fact, Buddha never taught Vipassanā. He only taught Samatha. And he went to Thailand, and he got shifted from one monastery to the next. That's what happens. You just get shifted. They just tell you to leave. And he eventually ended up in Australia, where I think he finally disrobed. And it's a sort of bit of a sadness, really, because he was very keen and very devoted to the practice. And then just this wrong thought around *sīla*, around conduct, and making that distinction between moral law and rules and regulations.

Remember that even when two people, well, even by yourself, but especially when two people live in the same place, you have a veneer. You have your own little rules and regulations, like you leave your shoes in a certain place and you don't leave them anywhere else and you have to close the door and you don't pull the chain of the toilet at certain times during the night and things like that. So all these little rules and regulations begin to build up whenever two people live together. And of course, even when you live on your own, you end up having little rules and regulations which you're not aware of until somebody comes and lives with you. And then you realise that you don't want them to wash the pots like that. You do it like this. And it causes enormous anger and all sorts of silly stuff.

Again, this business of right conduct. We can look at our actions from the point of view of not doing harm to ourselves. That's the main point.

There are

Faith (Saddhā)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 26 min read

In this evening retreat talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma offers a comprehensive exploration of faith (saddhā) as one of the five spiritual faculties (indriya) in Buddhism. Drawing from the Abhidhamma and commentary literature, he distinguishes faith from mere belief, explaining that faith involves trust and confidence rather than acceptance of statements.

The talk examines faith through three essential components of consciousness: intellectual understanding (cognitive), emotional involvement (affective), and commitment (conative). Using practical examples like climbing Everest or starting relationships, Bhante illustrates how these elements must work together. He traces the development of faith from initial hearing of the Dhamma, through personal reflection, to direct experiential understanding through meditation practice.

Addressing common obstacles to faith—including confusion between faith and belief, imbalanced development, self-doubt, and unrealistic expectations—Bhante emphasizes that faith becomes unshakeable only upon reaching stream-entry (sotāpanna). He concludes with practical guidance on nurturing faith through spiritual friendship (kalyāṇamittā), ethical conduct (sīla), energetic practice, and understanding impermanence (anicca). The talk offers both newcomers and experienced practitioners essential insights into this foundational aspect of Buddhist spiritual development.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So I thought I'd give a little talk around faith, which in the Buddha's understanding is fundamental. Nothing happens without faith. And I read a rather nice little essay on it by Ñāṇaponika, whom some of you might know—a very famous German monk who started the Buddhist Publication Society up in Kandy. Didn't write all that much himself, but what he wrote was influential. And his main book, *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation*, still remains a classic really on meditation.

The way I would like to tackle it is from these three constituents of an act of consciousness. I'm getting this from the Abhidhamma, but actually it should be pretty obvious to us. Not being too specific about one act of consciousness, but in a series of consciousnesses. You always have the intellectual part, the cognitive part, the understand-

ing. There's always some affective part, your emotional involvement. And for an action, there has to be what's known as an act of will. And you will notice that in my explanation there, I use my hand to point to three centres. So they're your basic chakras, the one in the middle of your head signifying your understanding, the heart in the middle of your chest, and the one in your belly.

And it's interesting that, just a little aside, that if you look at the way Buddhism grew, it was very much a cognitive effort. The Buddha's teaching is very much about, first of all, understanding and everything takes place, everything flows. But that became too rigid, too dry perhaps, so that the next wave through Mahāyāna was raising up *karuṇā*, raising up the heart to the level of *paññā*, wisdom. So *karuṇā* and *paññā* became equal. And if you go over to the Far East, to Japan, their centre is very much in the hara, the will. A samurai. Just a little aside, you understand. Nothing to do with faith.

So these three things I want to just look at from the point of view of faith. And before we do that, I have to make one big distinction between faith and belief. So a belief is faith in a statement. So if you say, there is no God, or there is a God, then that's a statement which, in effect, you can't prove either one way or the other. But if you believe it, then it would come under a belief rather than faith. So when we're talking about faith this evening, it's concerned with an attitude, trust, confidence. That's what we're talking about.

To give us some idea as to what we mean by that, we can take a few ordinary things that we do which demand faith. If you take, for instance, supposing now you decided to climb Everest. So there would have to be these three things, wouldn't there? You'd have to have understood what the actual path of Everest means and what it might take. It has to be that understanding. There has to be the desire to get up there, doesn't there? You might read about it and think that's very interesting but there's no desire to go up Everest. And you might of course have a good understanding as to what it's going to take, you might have an incredible desire, but somehow you just can't get your boots on and that's the lack of will. Lots of times like that in our lives, isn't there?

So somebody came and she was in quite an upset state because she was convinced that she had throat cancer, this particular person. And she had no trust in her doctors. So she wouldn't even go for a biopsy—not an autopsy, she wasn't dead yet—a little biopsy on the grounds that she didn't trust the doctors. And as we were discussing it and seeing what other options were open, it finally of course began to show that what was really undermining her faith wasn't at all to do with the doctors or the profession, it was the fear that in fact she may have throat cancer. So that underlying fear was as it were translated into a lack of faith. I think in this case she actually did eventually go.

But if you think of anything you have to do with doctors, you have to have a primary faith that their diagnosis is correct and that the medicine they prescribe is correct. Now in the old days you would have just had blind faith, the doctor. My parents wouldn't have ever argued with a doctor. If the doctor said this pimple on your nose is a dreadful cancer they would have believed it. It wouldn't have occurred to them to question the diagnosis. These days we're a bit more argumentative. And you want to know why and what happens. Recently I went in to the doctor with a tinnitus which had just arrived out of nowhere. And she said, I'll send you for a blood test. I said, a blood test? I had to squeeze out of her why she was sending me for a blood test.

So this whole business of even taking medicine, even going for an operation, you've got to have that trust in the surgeon. You take another thing that we do in our lives, a job. So if you're taking on a job, especially a job which you know will stretch you, then there has to be these three elements. There has to be, first of all, that you've understood what the job is asking you to do. There has to be that attraction to the job, there has to be a desire to do it. And then finally you've got to sign on the dotted line, or else it just doesn't happen. And that's the act, that's the commitment, the act of will. And there, sometimes what stops us is that doubt, can I do it. So you can see that the opposite of faith is doubt. There's something that stops you from that commitment.

And if we take another one, it's forming a relationship or getting married. This takes us into the realm of a more intimate human relationship where actually your trust is in this other person. They're not going to abuse you or take advantage of you. Take all your money. There's got to be that trust. And again, there is that knowledge that comes of knowing the other person long enough, the confidence that arises with that. Then, of course, that special love that one has with that sort of relationship. And then, eventually, there's got to be that movement towards yes, yes.

So these things are just little examples which we now translate into the spiritual life. So when it comes to the spiritual life, and specifically around Buddhism, faith, the Buddha calls the spiritual faculty. Interestingly enough, he doesn't put it in with the factors of enlightenment. And the presumption is, at least I presume, is that by the time you're actually meditating, the faith must be there, at least some level of faith. Because the factors of enlightenment are put into the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the discourse on how to establish mindfulness or this awareness which leads us to the awakening. But the five faculties are not there. They're talked about in other places. What's in that particular scripture are the seven factors of enlightenment. So when it comes to the faculty, it seems to me faith seems to me presumed.

So all of you here now, whatever commitment you have towards the Buddha's teaching, the fact is you wouldn't be here were it not that there was some faith. And if we now go back to what faith entails, the cognitive part, the actual part of understanding, so that's pointed out as three different stages. The first one is you hear the doctrine, you hear the teaching, and that immediately, as it were, arouses interest. There's also something that's stirring in the heart, that this is the truth, an attraction. There must be some sort of an attraction. And then after you've heard it and you read about it, there are, shall we say, reflections about it. So that the knowledge which was given, hearsay, read, now becomes your own personal understanding by way of your own reflections. And the more that happens, the more confidence arises, the more faith happens, the more faith arises in us about the doctrine, because now in a sense it's becoming our way of thinking, our way of understanding. So it's my way, not the Buddha's way. I'm slowly turning towards that.

But there's still that missing link between an understanding which is intellectual and the actual experience. So it's all right saying that everything arises and passes away, and I mean, there are very few people in the world who wouldn't grasp that. And when we turn inward and we just look around a little bit, we can see that thoughts arise and pass away, emotions arise and pass away, feelings arise. I mean, it's not a brain twister to actually go into that, but it's actually coming to the point where this I, this me, which feels so solid, is also arising and passing away. So turning inward and really coming to terms with what transience actually means at a deeper level through our meditation, that now becomes a knowledge which is also carrying into experience. But we would never have got there, really, without that initial confidence. That initial confidence.

When it comes to the heart itself, there's that feeling of trust which comes in, to trust somebody, to have confidence in, faith in somebody. And then there's a desire to devote oneself. A sort of loyal service to the Dharma, for as much as it feeds you personally. So if you're devoted to somebody, then you're there to actually help, please, make them happy. A mother and father devoted to their children. So that act of devotion is not just a lovey-dovey thing. It's part of that movement of the heart to give of oneself. A votary offering. It's an offering. And running along with that, there's love, which translates as a sort of lightness, a sort of joy in faith.

And then once those two are there, there comes this point of a commitment. And the commitment is at all different levels. So it might be just the commitment to practice a bit of meditation. And eventually it's a commitment to actually follow the Buddha's path as your centre line. And a total life's devotion to it. So, for instance, when people

take refuges, refuges and precepts, I mean, that's the normal way in all forms of Buddhism. So the refuges are the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Sangha. And then you take the five precepts, which is just your basic morality, not to kill anybody, steal, etc.

But the first part, the taking of refuge in the Buddha Dhamma Sangha, is an act of commitment dependent on the person. So it might be that they are committed to it, just on a level of, a rather superficial level of, the Buddha's teaching is good, and it's part of my spiritual smorgasbord. I've got all this other stuff, and here's the Buddha's teaching over here, and I do a bit of that. That's fine. As the teaching takes a more central position in your life, then of course the commitment comes for more, to give oneself more to that teaching. But there still might be a holding back.

So it takes a long time to actually commit yourself to something, especially if you are converted to it. If you're born into a religion, if you're born into a spiritual way of life, then it's just natural to you because ever since you woke up, you've been cajoled to make that sort of devotion, to make that sort of act of devotion. But for those who have come from other forms and come into Buddhism, then it takes quite a long time before you ever get to that point of actually, if ever of course, that you actually commit yourself in terms of this life.

Now, you only get back what you give. So if you give a bit of commitment, then you get a little bit back. If you give a bit more, you get a bit more back. And if you give the whole thing, then eventually you get the whole thing. It's like in a relationship, if you say, well, I love you a bit, and the other person says, well, I love you a bit. And it slowly builds up until finally there's some sort of connection, which one can call a marriage in one form or another. So that's the same with our relationship to the spiritual path. And that commitment can't be forced, you can't say, oh well, I'm fed up with messing around now, I'm going to devote myself to the Buddha Dhamma Sangha. Not at all, because it's a movement within the heart. And there just comes a time in a person's life when they make these little commitments, so it grows, it grows, it grows.

Now when that happens, or as that happens, then one gets the satisfaction of acts of commitment based on faith. So here's one way of putting it. This is taken from the commentary, but it also turns up in what's known as the Questions of King Milinda, which was written quite a while after the Buddha. And it says, as a water purifying gem of the universal monarch—he has seven of these by the way—thrown into water causes solids, alluvia, water weeds and mud to subside and makes the water clear, transparent and undisturbed. So faith arising discards the hindrances, causes the corruptions to subside, purifies the mind and makes it undisturbed. The mind being purified, and the

aspirant of the noble family gives gifts, observes the precepts, performs the duties of the Uposatha and commences *Bhāvanā*. Thus, faith should be known to have purifying as its characteristic.

So these performs the duties of the Uposatha is in Buddhist countries, the full moon and the new moon and the quarters are times when lay people go to the monastery and make a special day of it, especially the full moon. And commencing *Bhāvanā*, *Bhāvanā* is meditation.

So here we have the purifying of water, transparency. Now all you've got to think about is those times when your life has been full of doubt. Either should you move house, should you go for this job or that job, should you go into this relationship or that relationship. In those times of doubt, as soon as there's a commitment, as soon as there's a decision and a commitment, all the stuff around that disappears, doesn't it? All that disturbance, all the doubt, all the fear, it just clarifies, it just disappears. So that's what this is pointing to, that an act of faith is, or an act of taking refuge in Buddhist language, to take the refuge in, a refuge, is that point where all doubts, finally, about how one should lead one's spiritual life begin to fade away. And one is clear, one is clear. So that's its effect on us.

Talking again just a little bit about the intellect and the affective the emotional thing, if something is only intellective if it's only an understanding coming from the mind and it doesn't have the force of the heart behind it then it remains brittle, it remains quite brittle and it can easily be cracked by another argument. Somebody coming along like for instance later on there's a question on rebirth so if a person thinks well you have to believe in rebirth to be a Buddhist and I can't really believe that then the whole thing shatters. So if faith is only at that sort of intellectual understanding that this is okay I understand it and all that but without the heart behind it it's not going to really penetrate it's not really going to have the effect of true devotion.

If on the other hand it's only the heart, so sometimes one is drawn, a type of person might be drawn simply by seeing, seeing a statue of the Buddha. I know people as soon as they've seen a statue of Buddha they sort of fall in love with it. Something in their memory has clicked and there's this heart connection. And there's that leap of faith. But if that's not balanced with, of course, some sort of intellectual understanding about what they're doing, then we would call that blind faith. And what happens then is an easy falling into belief systems so I believe the Buddha is right whatever the Buddha says it's got to be right and what that does to the practitioner is it undermines their commitment to practice I mean if you have a belief that oh yeah the Buddha is right then why prove it.

The whole point of the practice that we do the *Bhāvanā*, the *Vipassanā* is that question: Is the Buddha correct? Has he got it right? I mean, you're not saying that to yourself when you sit, I hope. But that's the underlying basis of the great doubt. This is not doubt as a sceptical thing. This is not coming from fear. It's coming from a desire to really know personally, as a personal experience, whether the Buddha's liberation is true. And whether once one gets to this point of nibbāna, whether there isn't in fact more. We might get there and we think, no, this isn't it. I've got to keep going. You don't know, do you? And it's that sort of doubt which is better translated as a wonder, a philosopher's wonder, which drives our meditation.

So in your meditation, if you're just sitting there watching, looking, that won't do. It won't do. That's called being lazy. There has to also be that sense of curiosity. If the curiosity is not there, just that simple question mark in the mind, a way of looking, then insight can't arise. So the Buddha is quite clear. Awareness. Without awareness, without placing that attention on something, insight can't arise. So you can't have insight without the awareness. But on the other hand, that insight won't arise unless there is that curiosity in the mind, that wanting to know.

So those two, you have to have them in balance and of course when you say balance there's not some objective balance you can't go on a weighing scale and say well I've got a bit of this and I've got a bit of that it's to do with the individual so that every individual has to have that balance within themselves of an intellectual understanding and a commitment in terms of their devotion in terms of what their heart wants to do.

And that will, it's just like we were saying about not getting your boots on. So there can be always this lovely intellectual understanding. Some people read so much and they can splurge it all out and quote ad infinitum. And sometimes they've got a good feeling behind it, but they don't practice. No practice at all. Don't do any meditation. Now what stops them doing that? What stops them making that little effort to actually climb the mountain? And that's the lack of will, the lack of commitment. So unless there's that too, there can't be progress on the path.

And it's interesting that the Buddha puts faith opposite, or he balances faith in the five faculties, he balances it with insight. So if there's no faith, if there's not that act of devotion to the practice, then insight can't come up. So these two things are intimately linked. And eventually when we have an insight which is an insight into the final goal, which is known as entering the stream, the *Sotāpanna*, at that point this faith becomes unshakeable. It's then known not so much as an *indriya*, which we translate as faculty, it becomes a *bala*, which means a strength. So now that faith now is unshakeable because that person has actually seen the top of the mountain. They know where it is. It's

no longer clouded. It's not that they can't see it because they've actually touched it. And now that faith, which is a strength, of course, must necessarily draw them to the end of the path through the next few stages.

So until, it's understood that until we have intuited this nirvanic moment, faith will always have a little shake in it. There'll always be a little shake in it. And that really brings us to what undermines our faith, what undermines your commitment to the practice.

The first one we've already talked about, this confusion between faith and belief. So you can very easily slip into that lazy place where you say, well, I believe the Buddha, what's the point? And it undermines that practice. So you've got to keep up that sense of curiosity, that sense of wanting to know. And the Buddha laid that out very clearly when he visited the Kalamas. It's a very famous discourse. Everybody quotes it, so I may as well quote it myself.

So he ended up at the village of the Kalamas, and the Kalamas said to him, we're in a state of perplexity. And he said, everybody who comes here tells us that this is what it's all about, this is the truth, and everybody else is wrong. So who are we to believe? Where are we to go? And he says, do not believe anything simply because you've heard it. Simply because it is tradition handed down for many generations. Simply because it is spoken and rumoured by the many. Simply because it is found written in your religious books. And simply on the authority of your teachers and elders. In other words, don't believe anything. And then he says, only when it works for you, only when you've tried it out, only when it's something which is of benefit to you, would you then commit yourself to it. So belief is something which would be contrary to the Buddha's path as such.

The other thing is that we talked about was this balance between devotion or the heart and the understanding. And this is from the commentaries. And it says, for one strong in faith and weak in understanding has confidence uncritically and groundlessly. So that's your blind faith. That's your gullibility. That's believing something. For one strong in understanding and weak in faith errs on the side of cunning and is as hard to cure as one sick of a disease caused by medicine. Interesting, isn't it? We know about the side effects of drugs. One strong in understanding and weak in faith.

So what they're saying here, what he's saying here is that you can have such a good intellectual grasp of Buddhism that you actually believe you've experienced it. And there's a total confusion between something that has been so clearly understood and something which has been directly experienced. And I knew of a monk who actually believed that himself. He did, he had an enormous, wonderful, deep grasp of the

Dharma. And he was convinced that he must be a reborn stream entrant. In other words, he was already, he'd already somewhere in his past life, I mean he had to believe that, he had intuited Nibbāna. Or else how could he have this amazing, wonderful understanding of the Buddha's teaching? And that is such an easy confusion, related to those who have a very strong intellect.

And so it then goes on to say, with the balancing of the two, a person has confidence where there are grounds for it. In other words, it's the balance that we're looking for.

The other one is more to do with self-expectation. The big one about self-doubt. Everybody can do it but not me. That sort of thing. And that can be a real barrier to progress. There's a particular monk in the scriptures who becomes despairing of his practice and commits suicide. Fortunately, when the Buddha comes along and is asked, well, what happened to this monk? Where's he gone? He says, oh, he became enlightened in the process of committing suicide. Now, I'm not suggesting, of course, that. In this case, it was a happy outcome.

But I don't think there's a deeper despair than spiritual despair. To despair of somebody, to despair of your ability to have a relationship, to despair of your ability to earn money and live a good life. All these things that throw people into suicide and jump off bridges. I'm thinking particularly of a young man in Australia who made, and remember this is a piece of news, who made an enormous amount of wealth on property. And when that thing crashed in the mid-90s, he committed suicide.

But when we're talking about spiritual despair, that digs at the deepest level of our being, doesn't it? Because that's what the spiritual life is about. It's about being. It's about who are we at fundament. And to have entered the spiritual path and to have seen the possibility of spiritual advancement and spiritual attainment and that end of suffering and then to despair that one could ever achieve that. I don't think you can get worse than that when it comes to despair.

So don't despair. So that when self-doubt comes up like that, it can often be caused by an over-expectation. You know, you thought you'd be further along the path than this, than you are now. And there's pride involved in that and a loss of self-esteem. I met a man and he said to me, when he first came to meditation, he went to a course, this was back in the 70s, he went to a course of meditation and he went to it as you would go to any old course of calligraphy or basket making or French or something. And he went along and the idea was you got a Nibbāna, you got a certificate and then you left. It was a week on how to attain Nibbāna. He entered the course thinking he'd have a go and at the end he'd know Nibbāna and that was it. That's what he'd come for. Well, of course,

as the course began to end, the despair entered into the heart and it took him a while to realize that it wasn't that sort of course. And that's why you don't get certificates after meditation courses. Nobody hands you a certificate. So this expectation.

So here's the Buddha. He says, I do not say that the attainment of profound knowledge comes straight away. Nevertheless, the attainment of profound knowledge comes by a gradual training, a gradual doing, a gradual course. How does the attainment of profound knowledge come? By means of gradual training, gradual doing and gradual course. As it is, one who has faith draws near. Drawing close, they sit down nearby. Sitting nearby, they lend an ear. Lending an ear, they hear the Dharma. Having heard the Dharma, they remember it. They test the meaning of things they have borne in mind. Whilst testing the meaning, things are approved of. Things being approved of, desire is born. When desire is born, they make an effort. Having made the effort, they weigh it up. Having weighed it up, they strive. Being self-resolute, they realize for themselves the highest truth itself. Penetrating by means of wisdom. Stages.

And you also have to be careful that, so the whole point is that when we practise to abandon all expectation. This is the point. So abandon all expectation. And if you don't, if you don't then you'll get into that failure success. And that's where the trouble starts. And when you get a lack of success, it can be a sort of misunderstanding really. Remember that all spiritual traditions warn us that the spiritual path is full of deserts. Dry places, empty places. And it's surprising how many people when they enter into that place just begin to slag off and disappear and then they reappear about 20 years later.

But those periods when you think you are not advancing are more important than those periods when you think you are. That's the slog, that's the dryness, that's the desert. You've just got to keep one foot in front of the other. And I use the image before the mountain. So mountains are used often in the spiritual literature because they're so close to the experience of the spiritual life. The idea of having this constant... The actual practice is extremely simple. To climb a mountain, all you've got to remember is you put one foot in front of the other and, generally speaking, go up. That's it, isn't it? I mean, you don't need any more instructions than that. Then, of course, there comes all sorts of techniques and ways of handling certain situations. Stamina, commitment.

And the worst thing you can do on a mountain, especially the high you get, is to sit down and have a break which is just a wee bit too long and you start getting cold. And you drink your last cup of tea. And that's it. You're on the way down then. So it's a case of that commitment, especially during those periods where you feel that nothing is happening. It doesn't matter how long nothing is happening. You just keep going. Just keep going. And it's a testing time. You're just looking at the fact of the loss of self-esteem, the

feeling that you're not going anywhere, as if there was anywhere to go, a lack of success. All comes up, and it's the ego. So the dryness, the aridity of practice, is one of the most potential parts to get rid of the ego. And usually it's a time when we give up, which is a sorrow, because it takes a bit to get up there.

So don't worry about lack of success, just keep doing the job. Then of course there are the more obvious things, doubt in the Buddha, doubt in the teaching. The doubt in the Buddha always has felt to me, in a sense, slightly unnecessary. Because as you go along, there are side posts there. You don't have to believe in Nibbāna. You don't have to believe at all in any of that stuff. The whole point about the Dharma is that it's immediate. You either benefit from it now or you don't. That's the point.

But when we're practising we might not see an immediate benefit from it right here and now in this present moment, but when we look back on our practice over a period of years we can see that it's helped us to progress and it's part of our progression and it might even be the fundamental reason for our progression. So it's that ability to see that the doubt that we have in the practice is undermined by not looking too far ahead. It's right here and now. So if we can look back and think a little bit, oh, this is a benefit, then we don't lose that sense of faith in what we're doing.

When it comes to the Sangha, that's really an extension of faith in the Buddha because the Sangha is simply other people who've said that they've actually attained the same thing. And the more people who say that, the more of course it gives other people confidence.

Now these three things have to be, or at least two of them, have to be internal. Even at the end when the Buddha actually becomes enlightened as that doubt appears is this it or is there more and that's when Mara attacks him with all the armies that's how it's put in the mythology and the Buddha touches the earth you've seen the posture the *Bhūmisparśa* posture where he's touching the earth and that was the point where he touched the earth as a witness as it were that he had attained the end of suffering. And the earth quaked and the earth goddess rose, wringing from her hair the water poured as libation to her by the Buddha in previous lives. That's nice, isn't it?

But when we actually take the refuge, it's not simply in that historical Buddha, it's the presumption that there's a Buddha within us, that there's something within us which is to be liberated. And that's what you're taking your faith in. So when the Buddha is dying, Ananda wants to know who's going to take his place. Because Ananda has this overflowing faith in the Buddha. And the Buddha's answer is that he mustn't take faith in him as a person, but take faith in the Dharma, the teaching itself, the practice itself, and in himself: be a light unto yourself, take the Dharma as your light, take

the Dharma as your guide, take the Dharma as your teacher, take yourself as your guide, yourself as your teacher. So eventually this is our journey, that's all the Buddha is saying, and the usual quote is the Buddha's only point the way.

So eventually when we take these when we take these refuges when we make that commitment it's always a commitment to ourselves. And there was only one period in Buddhist history that I know of where there was a collapse of where there was a doubt that there were some human beings who couldn't make it and it's a heresy of course. And these people who couldn't make it were labeled the *icchantikas*. And *icchantika* means forever going on in the world of *saṃsāra*. There was no ending to their rebirth because they were so stupid. But luckily that didn't take on. It remains there as one of these little side schools that believe that. Some sentient beings were really thick. They couldn't make it, even if they tried.

I must tell you, in Sri Lanka it's very strange to us. But they can tell by the shape of somebody's head, or some monks can tell, and nuns I presume, can tell by the shape of somebody's head whether they're going to make it or not. And the teacher at my own monastery, who was an excellent teacher, a direct disciple of the *Mahāsi*, very strict, very demanding, and often wouldn't take on students, but he wouldn't take on certain students whose head wasn't quite right. I say no more. Maybe there are ways of telling things that we're not privy to, that's all there is to it.

So I think I've just about covered all the bits that I wanted to cover. I suppose one thing I might just say is how to make faith grow. We haven't done that really. So first of all, there's the spiritual friendship. That's very important, to be with the right people. To be with people of like mind who are supporting you is obviously I mean the Buddha Ananda says to the Buddha I believe that right relationship good relationship is only half of the spiritual livelihood and the Buddha says oh no he says it's the whole of spiritual livelihood.

When a meditator has a good friend, a good companion, a good comrade, it is to be expected that they will develop and cultivate the Eightfold Noble Path. Also to be clear about one's training. If you're sloppy with your virtue, then it also slips. It undermines your commitment to the path because you cannot separate insight from virtue. You can't have a Buddha who goes around robbing. Wisdom is also an act, when it expresses itself, is virtuous. You have to be careful of your speech especially, it says.

You must be energetic in abandoning what is unprofitable. Remember that every time you attend to something, there's an act of intention. Therefore, it's conditioning. You have to be careful what programs you watch on the telly. And finally, the understanding of impermanence. The more we understand impermanence, the more we get

what's known as *Samvega*, that enthusiasm. I mean, we haven't got that long, have we? And visits to the teacher or to a centre where you get teaching. And also, just as an aside, the group, the evening group, your local group. That's always a nice fillip.

I always remember making that effort every week to go across town in order to join a group had an effect of raising the effort for the whole practice for the week. And if I missed it, I could feel the lack of energy during the week. So remember that the effort you put into a practice is an attitude and the attitude stays with you.

So I think that sort of brings me to an end of my little homily. I'll just leave you with a little final refrain taken from the Sutta Nipāta. Faith, in the way that we've been describing it, is the best wealth to a person of this world. Well-practised Dharma brings the most happiness. Truth is the sweetest of all tastes, and living with wisdom is said to be of the noblest kind.

Revising the Principles of Vipassanā

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min read

In this comprehensive evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma revisits the fundamental principles of vipassanā practice, focusing on how our conditioned responses create dukkha (unsatisfactoriness) and the path to liberation. He explores how our thoughts and imaginings shape our experience of the world, creating cycles of anxiety, depression, and dissatisfaction that mirror back to us our internal conditioning.

Drawing on the Four Noble Truths, Bhante explains how we become trapped in patterns of wanting and not-wanting, constantly seeking happiness in an impermanent world over which we have minimal control. The talk emphasizes finding the 'observation post' within ourselves - a transcendent position where we can witness thoughts, emotions, and sensations as objects rather than identifying with them as 'me' or 'mine'.

Practical guidance is offered for working with difficult mental states like anger, depression, and sloth-and-torpor (thīna-middha), emphasizing the importance of feeling emotions in the body rather than developing them through thought. Bhante stresses that we don't need to change our conditioning - simply maintaining awareness allows these states to exhaust themselves naturally. The talk concludes with instructions for maintaining wakefulness in meditation and the understanding that liberation comes through changing our relationship to experience, not trying to control it.

Namo tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma-sambuddhasa. Namō tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma-sambuddhasa. Namō tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma-sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So it's just an opportunity to revise the principles of meditation and go over the problems that we come across in terms of dealing with certain mental states. One of the core words of the Buddhist teachings is this word *dukkha*, which translates as a hard place. So we're in a hard place. And the idea is that if we get it right, it'll become *sukha*, it'll be a happy place, an easy place. And the process whereby we bring that about is a dual process, both of allowing old conditionings based on wrong understandings to exhaust themselves and developing new conditionings.

So from an ordinary relative phenomenal point of view, the Buddha Siddhartha Gautama when he was fully self-enlightened, the personality, the character, was still conditioned by the situation he found himself in. But according to him, he was always happy or calm, equanimous. "The world argues with me; I don't argue with the world."

Now if we investigate how we create these conditionings then hopefully we can go back on that process. One of the things we do is to use our intellect and our imagination to create within ourselves and to develop within ourselves a particular conditioning. So if for instance we have already a disposition within us which is anxious, then through our thoughts and through our imaginings we'll create an anxious world around us. We'll worry about this, worry about that. And with all these things there's a presumption that the more you worry the less you'll have to worry about, but the opposite tends to be true: the more you worry the more you worry. And then you suddenly begin to wake up that you begin to perhaps ask the question, well am I the one who's creating the worry?

If you have a disposition which is depressive, always looking at the negative side of things, we tend to find more and more things to be depressed about. And there's a relief in that because you're always proving yourself right: I am depressed. The world is depressing me. Everywhere I look, it is depressing. And what we get ourselves into is a lock situation where you don't see the end of that spiral. You try to break out of it. You try to buy some ice cream or something. But then you worry whether the ice cream is doing you any good. And you get depressed about it.

So when we realize that it's thought which is actually creating the world for us—thought and imaginings—information comes in and we play with it inside the mind. And we play with it from a particular disposition, of a particular position that we've taken in life, and then we project it, we deposit it on the world. And the world funnily enough mirrors it back to us. So if you go around feeling depressed, looking depressed, everybody else around you gets depressed. And if they don't want to get depressed they don't want to see you, so you end up getting more depressed because now the world is truly depressing.

Now, all the Buddha is saying is, if you stop for a minute and try to take a position within ourselves to observe the mind, to observe what it's actually doing, then we'll come very quickly to understand that all we have to do is stop this form of indulgence. And that's really the training of *vipassanā*.

So we're discovering a place in ourselves, rediscovering a place in ourselves, and constantly trying to re-establish it—a place where we can observe what's going on. And we start with placing the attention on the body itself, because that's the most obvious.

You can sense the body, you can feel the body, it's not that difficult to get in contact with it. And one of the main reasons for doing that is to try and release this intelligence, to draw it out of its confusion with thought.

That's the first thing you see: this intelligence we have, this intuitive intelligence, generally speaking defines itself as thought, as imagining. "I think therefore I am," that sort of statement. But when we take this position in ourselves of the observer, of this observation post, we can actually see the images in the mind; they can become very clear to us. Thoughts are often too quick for us and we wake up after a sequence of thoughts and then reflect on it as some form of thinking or worrying or whatever. But in some good states of concentration, when the mind is really steady, when this attention is really clarified, you might even see a thought passing in front of you like a neon sign. And these sorts of experiences are telling us that there is something prior to or beyond the thinking process.

When we go into emotions normally or often, we find ourselves hijacked by a particular mental state. Suddenly you're angry, suddenly you're anxious, whatever. But when you actually sit like this and find that observation post, when a mental state arises you can feel it as an object. You can investigate it as if it were something you had in your hands, a piece of putty, a dough. You can actually begin to investigate the feelings, the sensations that we would normally call anger or depression or anxiety. So you're becoming intimate with your psychic life in a way that you wouldn't normally be.

Normally, the ordinary person wouldn't make a distinction between that knowing and what they're experiencing. They are what they feel, they are what they're experiencing, they are their thoughts, they are the body. If the body hurts, it's me, it's me that's hurting. But here, by taking that observation post, when we find pain in the body, discomfort in the knee, whatever, it becomes an object. We've distanced ourselves from it. That's our first position.

As soon as you do that, as soon as we make any of this stuff an object, whether it's the thoughts or imaginings, emotions, feelings, sensations, we've created a very different relationship to it. Before I would have said "my knee hurts," but when I'm sitting in meditation here like this and the pain comes and I say "pain is there," it's not mine. There's a break in my relationship with it and I can begin to see it as just sensation.

When I can begin to distance myself from these things like this, I become aware of this other relationship that I've had, which at the moment I'm not indulging. And here we're coming to this second noble truth. So the first one is that there is this unsatisfactoriness, the suffering that we've created. And the second one is the role of desire.

Now I have to be careful with this English word "desire" because it doesn't hit the nail on the head. It's really a relationship we have with the world where we're constantly trying to be happy with it. We're constantly trying to find a way of being in the world which makes us happy, so that this happiness is dependent on the world. When I say the world here I mean what we experience.

So how does that manifest within us? Well, whenever I get something pleasant, a pleasant feeling in the body, say a nice joy comes up or a calmness, I immediately want to disappear into it, absorb into it, I may want to indulge it, I want to maintain it there. Sometimes we're sitting here and finally we can say we've got some sort of steady attention and we feel that we're calm and peaceful and we're really watching. And then somebody comes in and bangs the door off, sneezes into the back of our necks. And all hell's let loose inside. You want to kill somebody.

And what that shows us is that we've entered into this beautiful space and unwittingly we've tried to hold it, we've tried to contain it, we've tried to not let it move. And in that way, whether we like it or not, we find ourselves in conflict with the world. So when somebody sneezes, we feel irritated by it. But if we were in that easy state of open awareness, there would just be the sneeze and the sneeze would disappear. It would just be like a bird flying across your sight. Just one thing happening after another.

Now when we are maintaining that, we'll also see that whenever something unpleasant arises, there's always this resistance to it. You just don't want that. And that resistance is a relationship of wanting to get rid of, destroy, annihilate anything which I am experiencing as undermining my comfort, undermining my particular state. So again I find myself in conflict. I'm always in conflict with what's happening. Either I'm trying to hold on to something and stop something entering into that experience because this is the way I want to be, or I'm trying to get rid of something which I find upsetting, exhausting.

And if this pain or whatever that comes up begins to get a bit too much for me, then the anxiety comes, the fear comes. So those are our three basic positions in the world: we're either holding on to something, we're either being greedy, we're either trying to maintain a particular situation, or we're trying to get rid of it. We're trying to get rid of a situation. And if that situation is too much for us, we run for it. That's it.

If we observe ourselves, even if you're just sitting watching TV, if you watch yourself, you're constantly shifting your position, moving around the armchair. You just can't maintain any place which is slightly uncomfortable. Now that wouldn't be so bad in itself, I suppose, were it not that it was based on a wrong understanding as to where we're going to find happiness. I mean, if happiness could be found by playing this want-

ing-not-wanting game, then we ought to keep playing it. Because, well, we want to be happy. Very simple. But it's when we realize it's not going to deliver that, and we look at our fundamental position...

There's an unspoken presumption that happiness is based upon the sensual world. In other words, I've got to find happiness within this mortal frame, within this body, within this mind. And all the time, the messages I'm getting from the world is, it's not possible. And it's not possible because things are changing anyway. I can't maintain anything. As soon as I try to hold on to something, I just find that it slips out of my grasp. It's like holding water. And then I find I've not got that much control.

So to define myself, to define a self, surely it's about—if this is me, I should be able to control it. If this is my body, if my body is me, then I should be able to do what I want with it. I should be able to make it grow a bit more. Hopefully. I should be able to eat as much as I want and not grow fat. I should be able to do whatever I want with it, but I can't. I find myself in a peculiar situation of being in a body over which I've got minimal control. I mean, I can wave my arms about and all that. I can't stop it aging. I can't stop it dropping dead. That's the important thing, isn't it? I don't mind the aging bit, I just don't want to drop dead. I don't mind the body as it is, it's great, I just don't want it to fall ill.

So here we have we're in this peculiar state where there's a drive within us to be happy in the world and the world just isn't playing ball. It's just not responding in a way that it ought to really. So maybe I've got it wrong, and this is the Buddha—remember, the Buddha's own life story mirrors this same path. The Buddha isn't just simply the exemplar, the one who actually sets an example. He's the archetype. All of us have to follow this particular path if we want to find this liberation.

And what we begin with through this meditation is this process of renunciation. Now renunciation is not self-mortification. We're not trying to make ourselves suffer. There's no point in that at all. And this is also something that the Buddha discovered, wasn't it? He went through a period of self-mortification. And he ended up by saying it was just suffering, more suffering, unprofitable, and well, ignoble really, beating yourself up.

So whatever renunciation is, it's not a case of putting ourselves into painful situations just for the sake of it. Renunciation is that process of beginning to let go of those things that we find ourselves attached to, those things that we are depending on for happiness, because we begin to realize that that isn't true happiness. Any happiness which is dependent on something is fragile. If my happiness in the evening is depend-

ent on watching Coronation Street, it can be very upsetting if the TV isn't working. I then get quite excited. I have to phone friends and ask to put it on a DVD and stuff like that.

So the idea of renunciation is to find out where the attachments are. You don't have to go the whole hog, drop everything and live under a tree. But you can do it in simple ways. You can find out where you're getting stuck, where you're holding on to something, where you find yourself getting upset over what is logically a rather silly thing, and you can begin to withdraw your indulgence in that and just feel the pain, the pain of letting go.

And that pain of letting go isn't something which is bad. It's something which is good because it's releasing us from that attachment. That process of experiencing the pain of release is central to spiritual growth, because what is it that we're releasing? We're releasing not simply that attachment to an object. That would be just very restricted. We're actually releasing ourselves from a wrong view, a wrong understanding. That whatever happiness is to be found, it can't be found in an ephemeral, transient, unpredictable world.

So by letting go of things as best we can, we're actually repositioning ourselves in the world, finding a different relationship with it. And it's beginning to discover that which has the effect on us of developing a sense of calmness with it, of developing a sense of patience, just bearing with things without irritation, not seeing that as a suffering.

Now that's really one of the main things that we're learning when we sit in this meditation posture. Finding that observation post within us, we've already discovered a transcendent position. What we mean here by transcendent is that it is no longer involved or drawn into any confusion with any identity, with any possession of whatever is being experienced.

So at a very simple level, if I'm sitting here and pain comes to my knee, in normal daily life I'd say "my knee is hurting" and I would try and do something about it. But here, this is an opportunity to release myself from this relationship of "my knee." If you were walking along the road and your leg fell off, you'd look at that leg, wouldn't you, and you'd say, well, is that my leg? It was my leg, but now it's on the road. How can I say it's my leg? That's a fiction, isn't it? If somebody says, "whose leg is that?" "That's my leg. That's my leg. It's just fallen off."

Now because you've reached this perfect equanimity, you would simply note that your leg had fallen off. And then you would hop merrily into Costa's for a coffee. It would be of little concern. But that's not what would happen really, would it? I mean, one would be in a state of shock. And that's really the problem with this identity. If it's me, if it's me we're talking about, then I lose a piece of me. That goes deep.

That's why anything which happens to the body—we might be glib about it, we might say oh it's only the body and all that—but when something serious moves in the body then you come across this huge fear, this shock, and that's the measure of our delusion about who we are.

But it doesn't take that much reflection to realise that we can't be the body, even on a simple level. Well, have you any idea what's going on in your liver at the moment? Do you know where it is? Do you experience your toenails growing? Do you lose a part of yourself when you cut them off? So just reflecting on the body as body, as an actual physical piece of mechanism, an organism, you begin to realize, actually, you don't know it. We can't even see our own faces, for heaven's sake. When you look in the mirror, you think everybody sees you that way. But actually, have you done the double mirror thing? It comes as a shock. You never thought your ear was that big.

Have you done that? Get two mirrors and look into the one that's looking into the mirror, that's catching your face. And that's how people see you. It's always the other way around. Don't get too depressed when you see it. Even when you see yourself in the mirror, even in that way, it's only a representation. We can't see our own face as we can see other people's faces.

So this definition of who I am, you draw yourself into yourself with emotional states. And we find that there's not much control over that either. These emotions arise and pass away by themselves. And they're often attached to certain things like meeting people and Coronation Street and things like that. To say to myself now, at this moment, "I will be happy," to command happiness—can't do it. You can pretend, you can jump up and down and be happy, but the heart won't respond on a command. You don't go to bed thinking, well, tomorrow I'll wake up depressed. You go to bed with the expectation that you wake up refreshed, but you're not. Sometimes you're depressed.

Thoughts. There we seem to have some sort of ability to guide our thoughts, to put our thoughts in a particular way and guide them. But often it's the thoughts that overtake us. We find ourselves dominated, compulsive thinking. We can't escape the little boxes that we've created for ourselves.

So what the meditation is trying to make us do is to form a different relationship with it. And what we find to our joy is that actually we don't have to do anything. We don't have to change anything of the conditioning that we have. And this is quite a relief. You don't have to do anything about our depressions and our guilts and our feelings of embarrassments and all that. You don't have to do anything about it. All we have to do in that sense is this passive ability, this ability to stay with what's arising and give them the time, give them just that time and that inner space to express themselves.

And we find that when you just watch it like that it evaporates. It begins to expend its energy and in so doing it'll eventually draw those things to an end, because it's only when they creep up into this thinking mind, into the imagining mind, that they develop themselves. It's only through thought that an emotion develops itself. And that's a real important insight to make into our psyche. That if you stop thinking depressing thoughts, the depression cannot develop. On the other hand, if you don't feel the depression, then the depression stays in the body as a turbulence, as an energy which isn't doing us any good, creating discomfort, illness, headaches, and all that sort of stuff.

So it's not as though we can get rid of these conditionings overnight, but we now know that we don't want to indulge them through thought. And so we're left with just this situation of sitting with them and allowing them to express themselves.

Now when you contact an emotional state—say anger, you feel irritated about something—and you've cut off this avenue of constantly going over what it was that upset you and you come into the body and you feel the anger within your body and you're saying to yourself "this is anger, this is anger," not "I am angry." You've separated. "This is anger." As you drop into that emotional state, so you're getting intimate with it, you want to find out what constitutes the emotion of anger. As you go into it, you may be surprised to find that all there is is heat and movement. There's nothing there. The only thing that made it substantial was your positioning of saying "I am angry." As soon as you say "I," "me," it becomes solid, it becomes something. Whereas when you experience it as just an emotional state, as just a sensation state, you find there's absolutely nothing there. And eventually that little flowering of anger begins to just fade away, it fades out.

Now it's not as though that's the end of it, because there are these deeper dispositions which take their own time to purify. And that purification of the heart goes on automatically as soon as you're in this position of observing or feeling or experiencing. That's automatic. You don't have to work at it. You don't have to do anything.

And to maintain that objectivity, to maintain that position where you're not going to identify with this stuff, you're not concerned with the therapy of it. As soon as you do that, you become your own therapist. And that's always a danger, isn't it? Because it's the deluded trying to fix the deluded. So abandon that as absolutely hopeless. Instead, the Buddha says, don't worry about that. Just let that burn itself out. We don't have to worry about that. That'll happen naturally. What we need to do is to correct our relationship to it.

And he points to these three positions. So the first one is this impermanence. We begin to see that this solid thing that we used to call depression, anxiety and all that is actually nothing but just an amorphous blob of sensations. There's actually nothing there, there's no substance to it. And you begin to see that clearly when you experience it just as arising and passing away of sensations—heat, pressure and so on.

And by doing that you come to the second understanding that if that's so then there's no substance to it. It is insubstantial. It has no entity of itself. It's not an integer. It doesn't have any being. It doesn't have any existence. It's just energy. And in fact, I tend to look upon my own emotional life as just weather patterns. I mean, what's a storm? It's just a couple of clouds coming over and a couple of bangs and flashes and then it moves on. It just blows itself out.

And the third thing is this position that we have caused by that wrong relationship of wanting and not wanting, wanting and not wanting. So we're trying to access this transcendent point. We're at the apex of a triangle and we're looking down upon what is happening beneath us. And on one side we're getting all those things that we've defined as pleasurable and on the other side as unpleasurable, just a longer continuum. And that's your baseline, that's the given of human life. You can't not be alive and not know that things are pleasant or unpleasant. That's never the problem. Things are always going to be pleasant or unpleasant.

Then you get this line that runs parallel to it, which is our reaction to it, which is wanting what is pleasant, not wanting what is unpleasant. And that reaction to it is causing the conflict. And when that reaction passes, there is only the pleasant and the unpleasant. And having abstracted ourselves, having uprooted ourselves from an identity with the pleasant and unpleasant, we find ourselves in this transcendent position where there is just experience.

So the Buddha when he died of a stomach disease, even right towards the end, he's asking, "Are there any more questions?" I mean, the man's dying. He's got gastroenteritis. And he's lying there and he knows he's dying. He knows he's dying and he says, "Is

there any more questions before I go?" And then just before he goes, he gives that salutary command. He says, "All compounded things are transient. Work diligently for your liberation." And then he dies. Peacefully.

What will be our last words? "Why me?" "Why not?" Just the arising and passing away of the human body. And then when he died there were those younger monks around who weren't so trained and they began to cry. And the elderly monks and the monks who were more advanced said, "What are you crying for? Didn't you know that everything arises and passes away?" And their attachment to the Buddha was based upon that wrong view.

So that's all we're doing in a sense through our meditation: discovering a new relationship with the world. And the core practice of just being able to turn inward and to this introspection, just to be able to observe ourselves. So this intelligence that we have, this intuitive intelligence, it just begins to understand. And that understanding then begins to change our attitudes. And that attitude then begins to express itself in the way we speak, what we do, how we act, and through our livelihoods. And that's how this thing flows. It's a systemic effect on our lives.

So that's what you might say the more passive side of the practice. The active side is what we'll come to this afternoon, which is developing the beautiful mind. Developing love, compassion, joy, peacefulness, and then through that to move into the world.

So just to recap that: when we're sitting and the mind is wandering, the mind is thinking, unwittingly we're developing the old conditioning, we're making things worse. So we've got to be really right there with it as soon as we wake up and we have to acknowledge what the mind is doing. If the mind's worrying, we're not worried about content, right? Just don't give an ounce of interest to content. Just worry about the attitude.

So if you see that you're worrying about something—worry. When you come into the body, see if you can feel the worry as an emotional state within the body. And if you can't find it, you go back to the breath. And if you can find it, if it's there quite obvious to you, then stay with it. Wait for it to die out and you'll see the thoughts die out, and then that connection between thought and emotion becomes more apparent to us.

If you're sitting there and you feel a disturbance in the body, a tension in the stomach, something like that, don't guess. Don't say to yourself, "this is anxiety," or "this is worry," or "this is grief" or something. Just feel it as feeling. That feeling which may very well be an emotional state caught up in that part of the body may rise to the point in the heart, into the heart center where you can recognize it as an emotion, or it may

dissipate itself through the body so that when that tension goes that particular mental state has also been exhausted. This is also true of illnesses that are caused by the mind, psychosomatic illnesses. Not all illnesses are caused by that, of course.

And the only other thing that I'll mention just towards the end is the other side, which is this disappearing into sleep. So remember, the mind needs rest, sure, the body needs rest. But if you've had a good night's sleep and you feel generally rested, then in your meditation, if this dullness comes and this feeling of lethargy, don't fool yourself, don't say, "well, I must be tired." Because this is sloth and torpor. And the instruction there is to remain awake at all costs. So whether you open your eyes or stand up or if it gets really bad, do some walking meditation. But be absolutely steadfast in your commitment and refuse to be annihilated.

And when you do the walking meditation or you're standing, don't try and get rid of it. This is the thing that we tend to do. You feel a bit lazy until you're jumping up and down. But actually all you're doing is suppressing that conditioning which is drawing us into oblivion. So when you feel the heaviness and the dullness, stay with it. Make that your object. Allow that energy to dissipate itself. We don't see it as energy because it's drawing us down into something. But it's like black holes. You get drawn into the inner black hole. So it's a real energy, it's a force that wants us to move towards oblivion.

And we teach ourselves that every time the alarm goes and you turn over and wait for the snooze button. Every time you do that, there's another little weight just drawing us down into oblivion. And of course the attraction of oblivion is that there is no suffering. There's no suffering in oblivion. Wonderful. But unfortunately we keep waking up. So that's our problem.

So when we come across this other side, the bit that is lacking energy, when we feel that heaviness and the dullness of the mind, just open your eyes, stand up, stretch yourself. But you're not trying to get rid of it. Don't get into a battle with these conditionings. Just give them the space and time to just burn themselves out.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Fear

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min read

In this profound evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma offers practical guidance on working with fear in both meditation practice and daily life. He explains how fear manifests before we conceptualise it - as uncomfortable bodily sensations that we immediately categorise and react to, creating layers of 'fear of fear' that keep us trapped in reactive patterns.

The teaching emphasises the importance of developing bravery through meditation - the ability to remain steady in the midst of fear without moving or reacting. Bhante guides us to investigate fear not as an emotion with a story, but as arising and passing sensations in the body. He warns against getting caught in psychological analysis, noting that 'it's the deluded trying to find out how they're deluded.'

Key insights include understanding fear as 'mental-physical turbulence' - like weather passing through the organism - and recognising that suffering comes not from the fear itself, but from our reactions to it. The talk explores how to maintain Right Awareness (sammā sati) when fear arises in daily life, distinguishing between appropriate caution and irrational projection.

Bhante concludes with practical advice for maintaining mindfulness outside retreat conditions, emphasising the importance of regular sitting practice, stopping when rushing, and cultivating wide, relaxed awareness. The ultimate goal is losing our fear of fear itself, which naturally leads to fear's complete dissolution.

Fear. What the meditation is trying to do is get you in contact with fear before you call it fear. What's fear before you recognize it as fear? What is it? It's a bit nauseating. It's an uncomfortable feeling in the body. As soon as the mind recognises it as fear, it categorises it, blocks it. And as soon as it's done that, it'll react. It'll start being afraid of fear. And that's how we suppress stuff. We just push it away with fear. Don't want to see it. So you can't get right down there, you've got to go through those little barriers.

So when fear arises, this is in your meditation now, when fear arises, you first of all have to hold steady and just feel that panic. See, the panic's the fear of the fear, which is making you run. You just hang on in there, you wait for it to die down. And then what you're building up is bravery, isn't it? Bravery is being able to stand in the midst of fear, not move. So you stand there. And then as your reaction goes away, you're still shaking

from the fear. So then you get interested in it, not as an emotion. Because that immediately brings up all sorts of concepts and ideas. You can even get into a wild goose chase of trying to find out why you're afraid. Get into a personal therapy.

When you get into a personal therapy, just remind yourself that it's the deluded trying to find out how they're deluded. And the definition of delusion is, you don't know where the delusion is, so you wouldn't be deluded. So when fear comes up and you try and chase some historical moment when all this fear was gathered, then actually all you're doing is not facing the fear. You're trying to get behind it or before it. And even if you did remember the occasion, would it help? So okay, it was when your mother hit you with a banana across the ear when you were three years old. So what? You're still stuck with the fear. You're still stuck with the aftermath.

So one has to get into the feel of it. So then you point your attention to the quality of its feeling, its sensations, the sensations it's calling. And as you go into it, you taste it. You get a feel for fear. And you just sit in the midst of that. And when you sit in the midst of fear, what's happening? It's just a mental, physical turbulence, isn't it? It's like a bit of bad weather running through the organism, isn't it? You're just sat there just with this nausea or something pitting your stomach or you might have it in your chest. You're just sitting there, that's it. You babysit. Just sit with it.

And as you're sitting with it, you might notice that it's a process. You might notice that there's no such thing as, this is fear. It's just a set of arising and passing away of sensations. They're just little sensations. And you might get that feeling that actually, to be in the midst of that isn't suffering. It's only suffering when you start reacting to it. It's only suffering when the fear of fear arises. And then when you get comfortable with the fear, it's okay, you want more of it. You just sat there with it and said, well, come on, let's show your face. It's like a snake, show your face. So we just let it come up, let it come up.

Now, when you let things come up like that, because you're not identifying with it, I am afraid, because you're not pushing it away, feeding the system with fear, with more fear, because you're not turning away in aversion, because you're not trying to seek its origin, because you're not trying to do anything with it, you're therefore not empowering it at all. In which case, like any energy form, it has entropy. It will die away. It dies away. And then you recognize that actually all you have to do with fear is sit with it. Hug it. I don't want to sound too New Agey there, but just sit with it. And then it passes. It passes.

And that's where your confidence comes. And then you translate that to all your negative states. Depression, stress, whatever it is. And you realize you don't have to do anything at all. You just have to sit in the midst of the flames. That's all. And it arises and passes away. And that's it. End of fear. Guaranteed forty years, if you're lucky, because there's a lot down there. It's not as though you're going to get rid of it. So any ideas of getting rid of fear is also subtle aversion. You mustn't have any opinion about it. What you're really trying to discover is just how to be with it in a non-reactive way.

In so doing, you find, as it were, a place within yourself which is aloof. It's up above. Even though you're in it, you're not of it. So that's what the Buddha's teaching. That's the position we have to take. In the body and mind, in the heart, but not of it. So that sense of being aloof, of being an observer, an experiencer, a witness. You can get there by just an act of will, by saying, this is an object. You can point to it and say fear. As soon as you point to something, it's an object. So it can't be you, it can't be me. You're already creating a distance just by recognizing it's there.

That's not the end point to be an observer. The end point is pure observing. Even that sense of somebody observing disappears. But that just arises naturally. You don't have to work at that. So that's fear. I wouldn't worry about it. There's nothing around that in terms of how you meditate with it, how you actually sit with it. The good thing about strong emotions is that you've, generally speaking, got no problems with concentration.

"Can I ask? Would you say that then if you feel fear in a situation which isn't sitting on the cushion in the situation, that that would be the best approach to adopt?"

I'm coming to that in a minute. Fear in action, as it were. Are you all pretty clear about fear when you're sitting? You're getting to know it intimately. So you have to be aware of your reactions to it too. Come off all head stuff. As soon as you start thinking, imaging something, cut. Come down to the body. Because that's how an emotion develops itself, through thought. It's through the technique of imaginative thinking that emotions develop themselves.

You all know that from when somebody says some little thing that upsets you in the morning and then quite unwittingly you keep thinking about it and thinking about it and thinking about it. By the evening you're chucking them out of the window and doing all sorts of nasty things and all day you've made them insult you. And they only did it once. And it's just because that little irritation has grown and grown through the force of our imagination. So imagination, any thought around fear, you just recognize it as fear and then you come back into the body. So doing you stop it. So now that feeling

of fear has only one place to come out, which is through the body as a feeling. So if you think of the mind as an energy system like the weather, this is just a bit of a storm coming up, let it come and let it pass away.

So now, in daily life, of course, it's a different position. When you're meditating, you're at the interface, you might say, between consciousness and thoughts, consciousness and emotions, consciousness and sensations in the body. When you're meditating like that, ask yourself, where's the personality? It's only when you get up and speak and do that suddenly a personality appears, a personal writing. When you're looking inside yourself, what do you see? A thought? An emotion? So this becoming of a personality is a different position. You're in now the flow of your actions and your speech.

So now, when fear comes up, or anxiety comes up in action, then, as it were, we've still got to try to maintain just that sense of knowing it's there. Knowing it's there. And because of that knowing it's there, you've lifted yourself out of it. Even though this is saying, run, run, run, run, you keep walking. Because you've not fallen into the delusion of the fear. So even though the fear is tearing at you and they're saying, run, run, run, run, you keep walking, you keep walking. Because you're above it. And if you feel it's the same thing, when the panic comes, you say, just stop, hang on in there. You can't handle it, run. It's alright. And then when it passes, just reflect on that. Hmm, that's interesting.

And so in other words, you've got to take your meditation, this insight, into daily life. And don't worry if you so-called don't succeed, because all that's shown is the strength of our conditioning. So that takes a little humility. This is the way it is at the moment. But you work gently against it.

Even if you have a very strong fear, like obsessional stuff. One person who worked with me had problems with contamination. Couldn't go near certain areas that had been contaminated with certain substances. And I was just trying really to, through the meditation, to get her to have enough confidence that she could stay within that fear, and then to try to get the person to walk into that contaminated area. So, in this case it didn't work that way. If you take that as an example, so we all have fear, we all have anxieties and this and that, so it's a case of knowing that it can't kill you, it's only an emotion that comes out. And then just building up through your own self, through your own reflection to move towards that area which is dangerous. Hang on in there. Stay there, just keep moving towards it.

Now ultimately, what's the ultimate point? The ultimate point is the loss of fear of fear. And when you've lost your fear of fear, what's going to frighten you? It's at that point that fear drops away. And that's why, through your meditation, you should see that there's a possibility of the end of fear, the complete ending of fear.

"But when is there a situation when you should worry about fear? When you project fear onto a situation which isn't really fearful, it feels so real. So how really to distinguish between real fear and be sensible about it, and what you've projected from your own mind, it's quite hard."

Yes, of course that's difficult. I mean, you can take an absolutist stance and say that all fear is false projection, but obviously there is a level where it becomes inappropriate, shall we say. It's not fixed to the actual situation. As the case that I've just pointed out, this particular person, if some substance or other, if she thought that some substance or other was in this room, she couldn't go into it. And it was irrational. She was irrational. It wasn't as though she was crazy. But she couldn't go into that room.

So often you can perceive that your fear is irrational. For instance, if you have, on holiday, a fear of jumping off the high board at the swimming pool. Fear is irrational, isn't it? So, if you have that fear, you go up there and do it. You keep doing it until the fear, until you've actually, until you've no fear of it. But in so doing it with meditation, you're actually learning how to be with fear and not to let it hijack you.

Now, there comes that shady area where you don't know whether it's fear or not, whether it's appropriate fear or not. In which case, what can you do? You have to test it. You can only investigate a situation and find out whether in fact your fear was correct or not. How else? You don't know. That's the problem with delusion. You just don't know. You have to keep testing things.

"In its biological origin, I mean, I think it's like a... You'd think that it would be programmed to have fear of something, a self-protection, and that you'd actually be quite heightened perception. So it's that you'd have the fear in order to be able to... We're so used to running away from emotions, but you can imagine that the fear was actually a heightened sense in order to deal with something, so that you're actually in a state where you can think all your senses are alert, which is what you should be anyway, but we're so used to negative emotions, like, you've got to run away from the emotion, rather than it has a function or it has, whether its function is present or past, that you're just to use it or stay with it or go through it."

Yeah, absolutely. I mean, there should be, shall we say, that background fear, for want of a better word, whenever we're crossing a busy road, isn't it? It's just that the fear then becomes a guardian, where you never actually feel the fear, but the fear is running as it were in the background because you know if you make a mistake you're going to get run over.

This is much the same as shame, dread, guilt. When we do something which is unskillful, unwholesome, then these emotions arise, these states of mind arise. But what the Buddha calls them, guardians of society. Not in the sense that they are wholesome because we've done something wrong, but when we've done something wrong and we've felt the inner reaction of shame, dread and guilt, then as it were, it's just like that background program. So the Buddha says, you can get sensitive enough so that as soon as an unskillful, unwholesome idea arises in the mind, it recoils, it recoils like a feather from the flame. And that's that inner conditioning about, well if I do this, this is what's going to happen.

And I dare say that there are inbuilt fear mechanisms just in the mind itself, which is self-protective. But that's not the same as what we're talking about, in a sense, because that just arises and passes away when it's pure. Oops, don't go there. That's it, it's gone. It's like the heart telling you there's danger there. That's totally different from the normal fears and anxieties that we feel ordinarily.

"I just think that that would have a different function, a different feel even to the fear. Don't we rush it up by the use of the word fear when it's actually lower than anxiety?"

Oh, well, that's what I meant about as soon as you label it, you categorize it and then all your history comes in and before you know it, you're stuck with an ogre, where in fact it was just a little tickling in the stomach. A little tickle in the solar plexus. Yeah, definitely. That's the problem with history.

I mean, my own personal opinion is that the fully liberated person wouldn't feel fear at all, apart from that fear of just knowing something is dangerous, as a background understanding, you might say. Just on the grounds that there's no association at all anymore, there's no identity or wrong understanding of what this body, mind and heart is. Once it's not you, it's not a big problem, is it? You can intellectualize, you can rationalize and say, well, I know my body's not me, it's going to die, etc., etc. But then when the doctor tells you you've got six weeks to go, you freak out. So there's a difference between intellectual grasp of something, an understanding of something, and actually moving to that level of consciousness which no longer identifies with the body.

But I dare say it's root stuff. I mean, the place where these emotions are kept, the amygdala or something, I think that's what they call it, comes from reptilian life, doesn't it? I mean, it's part of that whole evolution of basic life. The reason that our emotions, it seems, are civilized is because they're all channeled through the front part of the brain, which is new to human beings, it seems. But when they escape, that's when you get the road rage, computer rage, things like that.

"I had the experience last week of leaving the barn for a week and travelling around and staying in different houses and I found it very difficult to keep my meditation practice going and the mindfulness in a sense and I'm wondering if you had any pointers towards maintaining practice on the road."

Yeah, well, that's the big difficulty, isn't it? First of all, you just have to recognize that a place like this, a meditation centre, there are special conditions. People try not to disturb you for a start. Generally speaking, people try to respect your silence and respect what you're doing, which isn't so in the outside world, so to speak. So, you'll never get the same quality in ordinary daily life from what you do in the centre until there's been a real, I would say, a real purge of the heart. So I think it's unrealistic to think that you're just going to walk out of a meditation centre or the barn like this and take it with you.

So it's a case of recognizing that you have to put in some coping mechanisms. So it's very much a case of keeping up the practice morning and evening. The morning is a time when you remind yourself what level of consciousness you want to be at during the day. And the evening, I don't mean just figure a bed, just fall asleep. In the evening, say, after work or before you eat, to sit and just let whatever you've accumulated during the day just arise and pass away. Then, of course, you have a very pleasant meal and a more pleasant evening.

The other thing is just simple things like if you find yourself rushing, stop. Stop. One thing at a time. Breathe. When you're talking to somebody, remind yourself to listen. If you've got the answer ready before they finish, you're not listening. You can't listen and answer at the same time. The brain can't do that. So you're presuming what they're going to say and you've already given them an answer. So it's just relaxing into what's happening. And of course what you find is that when you do that, the other person does it.

Yesterday it was rather funny really. I'd gone to a cafe with somebody to have a little coffee and then we were walking back because we were trying to open another bank account for this trust we had. As we were walking there, the pace lifted and halfway through, Anne, and some of you know Anne Ashton, she said to me, God, you're walk-

ing fast. And I said, I thought you were walking fast. And we were just firing off each other without knowing it. So, by the end of it, I was running to this damn bank. So, it's a case of just recognizing that, you know, perhaps the coffee was too strong. Maybe that's what did it.

If we're sharp enough, if we can maintain that sharp mindfulness and recognize that mindfulness or awareness, it doesn't have to be trapped into one single object. It can be quite wide. Even now, as you're listening to me, and that's where, as you would say, the point of your attention is, you can still be slightly aware of the bird chirping out there, and just the colours in the room. It's like that wide awareness. And to get that, you have to be very relaxed. As soon as you get tight, the whole thing... And so it's that effort just to keep relaxing, feel your shoulders and... just let the breath go for a little while. Then you just have to keep doing it and keep doing it and keep doing it. And just very slowly you... Try to take life easy.

And then little reflections like, does it help to rush? Does it help to get irritated? What does it do? What's the point of it? It doesn't mean that we don't get irritated and we don't rush. It's just that we're trying to slowly work against these old habits which are deeply ingrained and are reinforced by society. This is the problem. I mean, if you were to stay here for, I don't know, a year or so, then it would begin to undermine a certain conditioning. But the effort has to be made because the one feeds into the other. If you meditate, say, for a week or something and then go out and have sex, drugs and rock and roll, then you've had it. You come back and you've still got these headaches and backaches and it's as though you've got to take it into daily life. And don't expect great change, very slow. It comes over a long period of time.

I remember once when I came back from... I'd been out in the east meditating and a very old friend of mine came up who's a long-time meditator and his first question was, is there a quicker way? That was the only thing he was actually concerned with. Is there a quicker way than this? I'm afraid that... Well, I mean, if you find one, come and tell me about it.

Stopping is a very strong technique. If you leave a room, for instance, and you've picked up a bit of irritation there. If you just open the door, close the door, just mindfully, and then just stand for a moment and just recognize what's happening. And then just wait for it to die out a little, then you find it doesn't snowball. You don't take it with you into the next room and off it goes. So you ratchet things up all the time.

"Just a question about right effort, that balance between too much effort and not enough, the technique to find the best way to concentrate too much, but not put too much pressure on it. But, you know, hanging in an easy... Just in particular meditation."

Ah. Well, I've always thought that's pretty easy, actually, to get over that one. Because we are Westerners, we have to achieve. Okay? So, make your achievement just being aware. That is the achievement, to be aware. That's it. You don't have to worry about insights. Just be aware of what's happening. Put the whole of your effort in just knowing what's actually happening now. As soon as you put any expectation to it, as soon as you put an idea to it, then of course you are bringing some extra to that present moment-to-moment awareness. So you're not looking for anything, you're just looking at what's coming up. And to do that, you have to relax. So your posture should be held up to the spine and everything else will happen. So relax on it. You relax on the object.

And to keep the attention there, don't worry about concentration. Raise the interest. Just ask yourself, when did you ever lose concentration if you were interested in something? It comes naturally. If the interest isn't there, if there's boredom, then you have to ask yourself. Well, now that's interesting. Any object which comes, you have to raise that question mark. And it's childlike curiosity. And it's questioning, do I really know? Do I really know?

So I sit there and I think, well, as we were discussing, fear. Do I really, really know what fear is before I name it? Do I really, really know what an emotion is before I conceptualize it? Because that's the process in the mind. First there's a sensation or a feeling, then there's some labeling or perceptual process, and then the history comes in, and that's it.

Even in very simple things like, you might see one of these flowers. So you might name it a rose or something. But do you know it? Do you know that particular rose? Or have you just looked at it and it's just fitted into a pattern of a rose so then you've seen it. But have you gone up and really looked at the colour, looked at the veins in the petals, seen the shape of the petals, have you actually smelt it? But we're happy just to say that's a rose and then we think we know it.

So it's raising that curiosity as to what is actually happening now and recognizing that that is the achievement. That's it. That's all the Buddha's teaching. *Satipaṭṭhāna*, awareness and intuitive intelligence. It's just the establishment of that. And it comes when you have right attitude. You just want to know what's happening now. So you just rest your eye on it.

So you can practice this on ordinary things. So the next time you're just out in the garden there and a flower, just rest your eye on it. So you don't look for anything, just rest your eye on it and see what the perceptual faculty is doing. Observe how the mind observes the flower. Just be aware of where the eyes are going. And that's it.

And when you catch yourself with wrong effort and you know that because you get tight I mean the other side of course is that you lose energy and you fall asleep. That's not so painful. But the other side when you get tight and you start feeling nasty about yourself and all that, then just go into the feelings of it, the sensations of it. There's something crept in there about achieving it, that's all.

So, as you know, the mind's very subtle, it's very... you think you're doing it right, and then you find out afterwards you weren't doing it right. But that's alright. Just to find out that you weren't doing it right is a step forward. And sometimes you find out you didn't do it right, and now you think, well, from now on I will do it right. And a little bit later you realise you've done it wrong again. So, that's alright. That's how slippery the mind is.

"Is it time for tea then?"

Forgiveness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 30 min read

Drawing inspiration from the story of Aṅgulimāla, the murderer who achieved Awakening in one lifetime, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents a profound exploration of forgiveness through Buddhist psychology. Using the framework of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), he demonstrates how we create our own suffering through our reactions to harm, whether as victims or perpetrators.

The talk examines the crucial insight that others cannot directly cause our psychological suffering - our pain arises from our own internal reactions and conditioning. Through guided contemplations, Bhante shows how understanding this process becomes the key to liberation. He addresses the role of shame, dread, and remorse as natural guardians that can lead to healing when properly understood.

Central to the teaching is recognizing our fundamental innocence - that all harmful actions stem from the primordial mistake of avijjā (ignorance/nescience) rather than inherent evil. This understanding opens the possibility for complete forgiveness of self and others. Bhante provides practical steps for releasing victim consciousness and perpetrator guilt, emphasizing that true forgiveness doesn't mean forgetting or excusing harm, but rather transforming our relationship to painful experiences through vipassanā practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sambha sambuddassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sambha sambuddassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sambha sambuddassa — Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

This talk came about because a friend of mine, who's a musician, wanted to write music around the theme of Angulimala, as some of you may know. The story of Angulimala is a murdering thief. But he meets the Buddha and undertakes the training and before he dies becomes fully enlightened. So there's hope for us all. And he wanted me to write something which he could attach his music to. Having done that, I wanted to add something to it to explain the psychology as to how somebody so steeped in evil might arrive at the enlightenment even within this very lifetime. So the first part I'll ask you to do some imaginative work and then we'll do some explanation. And then at the end you can try and have a go at practising forgiving all those people whom you've murdered and forgiving yourself, rather, and forgiving all those people who've done you harm.

Just try this one for size, shall we say. You can close your eyes and just, what I want you to try and do, and just catch the process of your psychology. Just imagine now, if you can think of an actual occasion in your life, that might be even better, but just think of an occasion now where somebody says something which hurts you. It might be just a flippant thing, like you're an idiot or something. So if you can imagine that, and just let the insult come. Now, just catch your reaction. So I wonder what the reaction might have been. Irritation? Anger? Indignation? And what might it lead you to once you've left that person? What might it lead you to? A slander? A knife in the back?

So now just try something else on a similar line. Instead of somebody saying something awful to you, they actually do something to you. Perhaps they push you, or they stick their finger into you, or at worst they bop you on the nose. Can you imagine that? Can you see what your reaction might be? I would suggest it's much the same unless they're much bigger than you then you'd probably get a bit fearful. So the question we have to ask ourselves is did that person cause us suffering? Do you think they were the direct cause of your suffering?

So now turn that one around now and just take somebody whom you're going to insult. It might be the same person of course. So as you just make that scene in your mind, offer them your insult and just see how you feel about that. I would suggest that maybe you feel a little satisfied by it. A job well done. Pleased. Supposing they pushed in front of you in a queue or something. You got rather angry about it and you pushed them out. You used a bit of physical force there. Can you imagine yourself doing that? So I would suggest it's much the same as above, only a little more stronger.

Now take that person and let them come back to you and say that they're really upset and you've seen that you've been the cause of their being upset. Now how do you feel about that? A little remorseful, a bit guilty, shame. Let's take an occasion which is much worse. Supposing you've unfortunately had one or two drinks and you knock somebody over on the road. Now what's your first reaction there? Just play it through your mind. Shock, fear, dread of consequences when other people find out, shame when you realize what you've done to the person, remorse.

That's the end of our little escapade of trying to imagine things, just to get you in touch, as it were, with all those emotions, all those states of mind that revolve around those actions where we're hurting somebody or somebody's hurting us.

So now, if we just take the process of that psychology, what we have, of course, is the Wheel of Dependent Origination. And what the Buddha is teaching us there is that whatever, just taking the first instance, whatever somebody does to us, has to stop at the point of reception, at the point where we perceive something. So if somebody called

me, you know, you fathead, that's not very nice, is it? They call me fathead, so what actually happens is that I've just heard these words, fathead. If somebody, then having heard those words, I take them into myself. I take them into myself and I define them as unpleasant. They are, aren't they? So they're unpleasant. So this person hasn't actually made me think they're unpleasant. I'm just defining them as unpleasant within myself. If I didn't speak English I'd probably smile.

So there's something I've done there whereby I've defined this as unpleasant. Now I've taught myself that when something unpleasant arises I have to get rid of it. I want to push it away. So that's my reaction to something unpleasant and again it's done by me within me because of my past conditioning.

So we can see if we look at our psychology very carefully, the person who's called us fathead hasn't actually caused me to suffer. It's the way I've responded to it. If the person who's just called me fathead is reckoned by everybody just to be a bit loopy, then I wouldn't have that reaction. I'd probably just say, oh, well, they're a bit daft or something.

So everything, all the hurt that I get when somebody insults me or somebody says something cruel to me is my own inner reaction. I can't blame them for making me suffer.

If somebody now pulls my nose, or tugs my ears, or gives me a shove, where does that stop? It stops at the physical body, doesn't it? It stops at a sensation on the body. But then, inwardly, I see what the person's done, I feel what the person's done to me, and again, I define it as unpleasant. Again, I respond to it with irritation, with anger, with hurt. But that's all happening in me as a response to what this person has done. I can't say that this person has made me suffer. They've given me severe sensations on the nose, which I've defined as pain, but pain isn't suffering. Pain as such is just sensation, no matter how severe it is. What makes us suffer, what makes it hard to stay with, is our reaction to it, our inability to be patient with it.

So it's the internal reaction we have to these things which is actually causing us to suffer. So those are your links on this wheel of dependent origination which remember is the Buddha's paradigm as to how we cause suffering for ourselves. How we cause suffering for ourselves.

So now you can widen that out and you begin to recognize that nobody in the world can cause you psychological pain, which is hard to accept because until now we've been very happy blaming everybody else. Parents, society, Tony Blair, all these people have made me suffer. But now when I look into my psychology, I can't say that anymore.

If we now turn it the other way, I now say to somebody, you fathead. Now, the same process is happening within them. I can't say that I've caused them to suffer, but I have to recognize what's happening in me. What's happening in me is that I am developing a conditioning of hate, a conditioning of cruelty. Now I might get immediate satisfaction by watching somebody cringe when I call them you fathead, but inside me I have this turbulence, this desire to be cruel, this desire to get my own back, the hatred within me. And of course the effect of that is that, not surprisingly, people start staying away. They don't hang about. They don't want to talk to me. So my cruelty, my hatred, goes into the world and the world moves away from me. And it causes me to be lonely, and if I don't see that, I then blame others for not being friendly, for not being open-hearted to me, and I begin to hate them the more. I'm in a whirlwind, taking me downwards into a perpetual state of hatred and grumbling and whinging, which can keep you awake.

Worse still, if I actually hit somebody or push somebody, then that's a more violent act. And therefore the inner violence is even worse. So here we have a situation where I think I'm hurting somebody, but in fact I'm only hurting myself.

So you might ask, well, what stops you from hurting somebody anyway? Well, when we've contacted the hurt that I feel when somebody insults me or somebody harms me, then even though I recognize that I'm the cause of it, it's out of compassion for the other that you don't, that you are not the catalyst whereby they cause themselves to suffer. So you begin to take responsibility not to enter into situations, not to confront people in such a way that you know you're just pressing their buttons.

So, the whole psychology around doing harm is always centred on us. We ourselves create an inner turbulence when we do harm, and when somebody does harm to us, it's we that create within us our own suffering.

Now, although that may seem at first to land us in a load of suffering, it's the very fact that we create our own suffering that will allow us to escape it in the end. That's the purpose of meditation. That's the purpose of *vipassanā*. So you can see these mechanisms that are causing us to suffer. And then you realize that you must stop behaving like that, which means that in your daily life you have to maintain that sense of sharp mindfulness, knowing your own habits. Even if you respond in an old way, you don't indulge it. Even though somebody says to you, you fathead, it stays right there at the point of hurt. You're prepared to let the hurt hurt because you know that is your own personal response to such a thing. But you don't allow yourself to begin to fantasize to get your own back.

So if somebody insults you once, as you know, by the end of the day, they've insulted you a thousand times. And the punishment for their insult has got worse. At first, you just shouted at them in your mind. But by the time you go to bed, you're hanging them. You're chucking them out of the window. So remember, it's through the process of thinking and fantasizing that we are developing these states of mind. This is how we develop our states of mind, through fantasy, through this process of thinking. And it's not a great distance between thinking about doing something and actually doing it.

So what the *vipassanā* or the insight meditation is teaching us to do is to stay right there with the hurt, to let the hurt die away. Now, when the hurt dies away, first of all, we're stopping it developing, but more important, we're actually undercutting that old conditioning of being hurt when somebody calls us a name or does something which insults us, but actually going underneath it so that there will come a time when somebody might say something which in the past you would have felt to be hurtful but actually it just stops at the sense door. You just hear the word. There isn't that reaction.

So you can see that taking full responsibility for our inner suffering, using the *vipassanā* to allow things to burn out and to heal, is actually the process of psychotherapy, healing the heart, purifying the heart. That would be impossible to do if you think the other person is making you suffer, in which case you'd have to change everybody in the world because a lot of people go around calling other people fatheads.

So even though it's difficult sometimes for us to recognize that nobody can hurt us, actually, that's our salvation. That's the healing. That's the liberation from suffering. Once we've actually realized that.

With that, there's the other side where we hurt people. So it's recognizing that even though we can't cause somebody to suffer, by actually wanting to hurt people, we're creating a turbulence within our mind, which is suffering, and we're creating a habit which eventually begins to push people away from us. So once we recognize that the serpent bites back, the serpent is biting its own tail, then you realize that that behaviour has to stop.

So again the purpose of the *vipassanā* is to sit with it in silence, to allow it to burn away, but then we have to maintain that sense of sharp mindfulness in daily life so that we don't fall into those old habits. And what we discover is that very slowly, over a period of time, those habits of trying to do harm to everybody just fade away. And the opposite, of course, takes its place. Nature abhors a vacuum. We're talking here about transformation. So where there was cruelty, now there's compassion. Where there's hate, now there's love. There's openness. There's open-heartedness. Warm-heartedness.

Just as a little aside, just talking about these things that we suffer. So for instance, we have within us a mechanism that decides whether something is good or bad, skilful or unskilful. We call it our conscience. Now, just because our conscience which is the judge, remember judging us, just because our conscience says something is wrong or something is bad doesn't mean to say we have to accept it, because sometimes this judge is a tyrant, sometimes the conscience is too tight and it creates a life of dread, creates a life of unnecessary shame. On the other hand this conscience can sometimes be very loose so that we don't feel appropriate shame, appropriate dread when we do things. So we haven't got to trust our conscience. There has to be reflection about it and talking to other people whom you trust so that there's a balance in the mind knowing what is good, what is bad, at a basic moral level, but remember that at a more refined level, it's what's skilful and unskilful. And when the Buddha talks about what is skilful and unskilful, he's always talking about that which leads to the liberation and that which leads to suffering.

Those two emotions that we feel, dread and shame. Shame is that feeling of loss of self-esteem we haven't lived up to our own standards, that's why we blush, and dread is the fear of consequences, the fear of consequences.

Now when we do something harmful and we feel shame and dread, in a sense that is not to be seen as a punishment. That's how people would look upon it. It's not to be seen as a punishment, but as warnings. When we accept the factors of shame and dread, and they become part and parcel of our psychology, they prevent us from doing things. Because as soon as you think, well, I'll do that, there comes just that little bite of shame, just that little bite of dread, and it stops you. And it's when shame and dread are behaving like this that the Buddha calls them guardians of society.

You can see from the way, for instance, a lot of the youth behave, that the line they draw about shame and dread is pretty low. They can do certain things which they're not ashamed of, nor do they dread any consequence. So you can see that once these reactions are lowered, you're going to get behaviour which is unsociable. When there's no shame and dread there, then we're talking about psychopaths, we're talking about sociopaths. It's an actual psychological disease.

Remorse, on the other side, is suddenly feeling that compunction, that desire to be rid of all the guilt and the shame and to want to be reconciled with the person whom you've hurt or indeed who's hurt you. So remorse is a natural feeling which comes after we accept that we've done wrong. And in our meditation, we have to sit with that. If

you try and block it out, you'll just harden your heart. You must respond to that desire to be reconciled. To go to the person, if necessary. But in some way, that remorse has to be answered.

And it's going through that cycle of guilt, shame, feeling bad about oneself, fearful of consequences, feeling remorse, and bringing that remorse to an end by reconciliation, that there's not only a process of healing at that particular event, but also undermining that whole conditioning. So eventually we don't get ourselves into those corners.

Now what helps us is that our conditioning is always fairly much the same. This is what we mean by *kamma*. We're always doing the same thing. We're always making the same mistake. If you look back on your life, you'll always see that there's a trait within us which is always popping up, given the occasion it comes up. And it's catching that right before it comes up and letting it go, not responding to it, that undermines that whole trait. And why do we do it? Because we've recognised it leads nowhere but to suffering, to our discomfort.

So now we have to go a little deeper because, in a sense, that tells us how we cause ourselves to suffer, and it tells us how to get rid of it. But the next point on the wheel of dependent origination to investigate is that whole point at the beginning of it, which is *avijjā*. Now, *avijjā* is translated as ignorance. That's how it's normally translated. But in English, ignorance has a feeling of stupidity about it. But that's not really the meaning. The meaning, I came across this word, nescience, which fits it more beautifully. And nescience just means don't know. I just don't know.

Now, in the Buddha's understanding, when consciousness arises, it arises from a base of don't know. And it moves into this body and mind, body mind and heart, and it simply presumes this is what it is. Therefore you form eventually a concept of yourself. I am who I am. I'm here. I'm my personality, my character. I'm my body. I'm my emotions. That little mistake is actually the fundamental cause for all the bit that we've just discussed.

Now if we go back on that and we recognize that right at the very beginning there's been a mistake, it was a mistake, that if it weren't for that mistake we would never have done any harm, then you begin to understand that at fundament we're innocent. It's only because of a mistake, not because of something culpable, not because of something blameworthy. We just made a mistake.

Now, I'll give you an example of that just from one of my experiences when I was in Sri Lanka. They had these very nasty little flies called Ohopatua. They're just little gnats, they fly in the air, and they have a nasty habit of biting you and leaving you with a very

itchy pimple for about three days. And sometimes they even can creep through a mosquito net. So here I am with these little pimples and scratching them, and I'm wondering what to do, and I suddenly realize that a spider has built a web in the hut. So I say to myself, that's it, I've got to get spiders in and that'll get rid of them. So I have little signs up saying, this way please. Well, within a few days, there were hundreds of them. They were everywhere, all around the room. And I thought, well, this is really crazy. And it was getting to a point where I was so bitten and miserable that I decided I've just got to leave. I've got to go up country somewhere. Just get out of these flies.

Happily, just at that time, a friend of mine, a Canadian monk came and I told him, looking really grim that this was it. And I showed him my pimples and I said, look at this. And he looked around and he said, these spiders webs, don't you get rid of spiders, the webs out of your room? I said, no. He said, well, they breed on those.

So here's a wonderful occasion where innocent ignorance leads me into suffering. Now, at fundament, that's all the Buddha's saying. All he's saying is that we've made a mistake. We're never meant to do any harm. And so at fundament, we are innocent. If we weren't, if it was actually part of our essential nature not to be innocent, then how could we ever become enlightened?

Just one reflection on existential guilt. This really refers to people who have been brought up in Christianity or a religion which has a god. Because according to those religions, we are born evil. In Buddhism, evil and all that is a secondary thing, which means that Western people can suffer from what you might call an existential guilt. In other words, they feel themselves to be essentially evil. In so doing, you can see the necessity of having someone to intercede, somebody who can save, can take away that essential evil, and thereby find some reconciliation with God.

Now, if you're a Westerner and you're brought up on that, then that will probably be somewhere in your psyche. So that also has to be suffered and allowed to pass away. And sometimes that goes very deep. And when you couple it with the idea of eternal damnation, then that's bad news. So what we have to do is go underneath that and really accept those sorts of feelings. And they can be extraordinarily nasty, like fear, and dread and all that. But you have to stay there, you have to feel it, you have to investigate it and recognize your reaction to it, which is of course that we don't want to feel that. And eventually as that evaporates, that essential innocence arises.

Now, there is a movement in Christianity where they don't talk about original sin. Most of you will know the myth of Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden. But you'll also find that there are movements in Christianity that, instead of talking about that, talk about the original blessing. In other words, the fact was that Adam and Eve were born in innocent happiness. So in that sense they come closer to a Buddhist understanding.

So there is an end to guilt, there is an end to shame, and there is therefore an end to forgiveness.

Just two things that always come up whenever I discuss this. First of all, why is it that some people get away with it? I mean, they seem to die. I mean, take Stalin, for instance. He died fairly happily in bed, having murdered 40 million people. And it seems to have got everything he wanted, although he must have been in a dreadful state of mind in a way, because he only worked at night and I think on one trip he had five trains going, all giving the impression that he was on one of them, constantly in dread of being assassinated. But take that to one side and just say, well, some people seem to get away with it.

Well, here, of course, we have to open towards the acceptance of the idea of rebirth, the idea that perhaps this isn't the only life we've ever lived, and it's not the only life we're going to live, and that there is some sort of justice in the process of the world in which individual consciousnesses work their way up towards the enlightenment through a process of being born and being reborn.

However, if a person finds that difficult to accept, it's not actually necessary in order to get the benefits of the psychology that we've just been explaining, because the benefits of that are immediate. Through the practice of insight meditation, to seeing that we cause ourselves suffering, and to see that we cause ourselves suffering when we cause others, when we press other people's buttons, is immediate. We immediately stop behaving in certain ways and we feel happier for it. But in a cosmic sense, this was one of the insights of the Buddha. It was part of his enlightenment, when he saw that people were dying and going elsewhere, and that a great deal of the reason for their going where they were going was because of their bodily behaviour, which creates these dispositions within us.

And finally, there's a real difficult one, which is very hard for people to accept, who haven't come across this psychology before. And that's, of course, the suffering of innocence, especially the suffering of a child. But it is the same. It is the same psychology. What is horrific to us about a child's situation is of course its absolute vulnerability and its inability through language or conceptual reasoning to find any distance or objectivity to the suffering that it's undergoing. But still, the child ends up with a trauma and in

a sense the rest of its life is working out that psychological trauma within itself. And it's very rare, I think, for a person not to have a childhood trauma somewhere. These childhood traumas are not only caused by people who actually mean to do them harm. The very process of birth is a trauma, for heaven's sake.

So, the suffering in the child follows the same psychology, and that's why eventually, as adults, we can empty ourselves of this suffering.

Now, for the person who harms a child, well, now that's something else, because they have to now bear the awful responsibility for that child's suffering. They might not be the direct cause of that suffering, but they were the catalyst that caused it. And just to give you two wonderful examples that bring that home to us, the Moors murderer, Brady, was asked if he ever thought about the child victims that he tortured and murdered up here just in Lancashire. And he said, if I did that, it would drive me mad.

Now, some of you may have come across a book called *The Man Who Mistook His Wife for a Hat*. It's written by a psychologist called Oliver Sacks. And he's interested in brain damage and the way people are. The particular title refers to a man who couldn't distinguish objects. And as he was leaving the office after a talk, he simply grabbed his wife's head, thinking it was his hat.

In that same book there's a very interesting tale which definitely says something to Buddhists. There's a man who murders his daughter in such a vicious way that the facts of the case are not brought out in public in the court, they're just too horrific. This man could not remember a thing. So eventually they had to convict him as insane and they sent him to a secure prison for the mentally insane. This is in America. So they couldn't convict him as a straight criminal. While he was there he acted seemingly quite normal and within a few years the staff had such confidence in him that they let him go out on bicycle rides. On one of these bicycle rides, a car hit him and he fell over and banged his head on the road. This had the effect of awakening, when he woke up from the concussion, of awakening in him what he'd actually done. And so the story goes, it took six months for the staff to restrain and stop him from committing suicide.

So eventually the harm that we do catches up on us and to harm innocence would leave us with an enormous sense of guilt and remorse.

So now we come to, well I'll just give you a final reflection on that concerning harm. There's a very famous simile of the saw which the Buddha gives. And he says, oh monks, even if bandits were to sever you savagely, limb by limb with a two-handed saw, he who gave rise to hatred towards them would not be carrying out my teaching. That's heavy, isn't it?

So now what I'd like to do is ask you to do another contemplation exercise. And the first one is, how do we free ourselves from a victim's suffering? So from the suffering that we feel when we've been victimized or when we've been a victim. And the second one is, how do we liberate ourselves from the suffering of being a victimizer? So I just want to go through these steps and you can close your eyes and just go through them. And then you'll get an idea of how it might work for you.

So the first one is how to let go of the suffering we feel when we've been hurt. So the first thing to recognize is that to forgive is not to forget. You have to be very careful. If you try and forget the hurt that's been given to you, then all you're doing is suppressing it and it's just working underground and it works as grudges and it just sabotages our lives. When we forgive somebody, we're not excusing them either. And sometimes we feel that if we forgive somebody, somehow in a secret way we're condoning what they're doing. So that's not forgiveness either. Forgiveness is just a change of attitude, a letting go of that hurt, letting go of revenge, and establishing within us that sense of compassion and forgiveness towards the person.

So the first thing, if you now take somebody who's hurt you, it can be somebody real, but not the big one. The first thing you have to recognize is that there's no need for us to punish them. They themselves will suffer the consequences of their own actions. That's the karmic law. So there's no need for us to seek revenge. And a Chinese proverb warns us, those who seek revenge should dig two graves.

The second thing is to remind ourselves that that person originally has made a mistake. It's by way of delusion that they've come to behave in this unskillful way. That fundamentally they are actually innocent and they didn't mean to do any harm. Sometimes it's good to have a dialogue with the person in your mind. Having done that, having corrected our relationship to that person, we can then turn inward.

And just get in contact with the hurt we feel. You can run through the occasion. You can bring up the occasion when you were hurt. Now here you've got to be very careful not to be taken away by fantasy. So you've got to keep that attention as much as you can right at the physical base. The feelings around hurt. The anger that may still come up. The desire for revenge. Try and stay as close as you can to the body, to sensation, to feeling.

Now as those feelings begin to decrease, the next step would be to contemplate the other person's better nature. When all the hurt and the desire for revenge begins to decrease you can then begin to reform your relationship to that person. Try and see their

better nature. Give them the benefit of the doubt. Send them good wishes from the heart. And if that's too difficult, well at least an attitude of no harm. That's the base, isn't it? No harm.

So that sets our right relationship with the person, right attitude. Now, in the future, we can resolve not to approach that person concerning this occasion unless we're absolutely equanimous, which means we have to wait for the right time. And then when we decide that we are going to approach them, to almost talk as if you're a mediator. You'll be very careful not to put blame, not to lay it on them, but just to be clear about the feelings we felt. We have to take responsibility for our part in the incident. Takes two to tango. And the next thing is not to expect an apology. That's a presumption on our part. If they do so, well, of course, it's very healing. But it's not important to us that they should express an apology. The healing comes by this inner process.

Now sometimes of course we can't do anything because the person's moved on or they may have died. So we have to work with this process of reconciliation inward. Until all the emotional pain around the memory is just slowly drained away. Don't solidify around it, don't get hard around it, just see it as a process. You can often just sit with an emotion and just say gently, not me, not mine. It's there, I'm looking at it. I'm experiencing it, so I can't be it.

So that's one way that you might try in the future to deal with suffering which comes because somebody has victimized you.

If we now go to the other side and consider some of the suffering that we've been a catalyst to in other people, where we've been the victimizer, then it might be a good start to just reflect on the fact that we are fundamentally deluded, that we've acted primordially out of a mistake, and that we are fundamentally innocent and therefore utter forgiveness of ourselves by ourselves is possible. Then we have to convince ourselves that of course we do have a responsibility. We did play a role in causing that person harm, we were a catalyst. A catalyst in chemistry is something which causes a change, causes a change between two chemicals, but itself doesn't change. So the word I might have said to somebody doesn't change, or it just hits the same space, but it creates within the other a whole sequence of psychological events that causes them suffering. We have to take responsibility for that. Sometimes we know how to press somebody's buttons too. We enjoy doing it. But when we do this we have to be careful not to take on false guilt. We're taking on false guilt if we take on their personal suffering.

So now we make resolutions not to do that again. So I was very careful about resolutions because you know the old phrase that the path to hell is paved with good resolutions. So it has to be realistic. These behaviour patterns are deeply ingrained. They've

come to us over a long time. So we shouldn't be surprised if we keep making the mistake over and over again. So we have to accept that this process is going to be repeated and repeated and repeated. And what we're hoping is that given a length of time, the behaviour lessens, eventually dies away. But we still have to make these resolutions, these determinations. And that determination has to be one of being really awake, really mindful. The alarm bell should go off whenever we enter a situation where we know we normally do something stupid, something silly, something unskillful.

Then there's the usual business of sitting with the remorse, the shame, the guilt which is in our hearts. So that's part of the process of *vipassanā* insight meditation. We can do that. And we can watch them as a process. We can see that if we push guilt away, push shame away, or push remorse away, that causes us more suffering. So there we're catching this process of how we cause ourselves to suffer. We can so distance ourselves from those emotions within us that they become very objective. There's shame. There's the feelings of shame. There's the feelings of guilt. And just watch them as a process. Don't get involved by way of identity or possessing them. They're not me, not mine. These are the things that insight meditation teaches us.

Two of our most powerful reasons for hurting people is jealousy and hatred. All forms of hatred. So jealousy isn't just a simple covetousness. It's not just wanting what the other person has. It's wanting what the other person has and hating them for having it. So the antidote to that is having sat with that for a while to begin to rejoice in the other person's good fortune. This is what we mean by sympathetic joy. And that's a contemplation. When somebody wins the lottery, you rejoice for them. You're happy that a bit of the pound you spent went to their fortune. When your friend who went with you for the same job gets the job, you rejoice for them. This undermines jealousy.

Hatred is undermined by seeing the other person in a different light. As we said before, to actually bring to mind their good qualities, so there's a balance of attitude towards them. And then finally, if it's possible, to meet with the person and express our remorse, express our sorrow. In the *Visuddhimagga* it also suggests that we offer them a gift when it's appropriate.

Now supposing at work you'd had a bit of an upset with somebody and you'd gone through this exercise, when you go to work and you're walking through that door of a corridor and they see you at the end of it. Our ability to tell where people are at is very refined. We know from a person's body language, we know from what's on their face, even at quite a distance, whether they're friend or foe. And this person may be feeling themselves still hardened by what they did, or they may feel remorse themselves, or they may feel a desire to be reconciled rather. Just by having that attitude, it'll show on

our face, it'll show on the way that we walk. So that they know there's a desire in us to be reconciled. So these things are really very important preparatory exercises, so that when we actually meet up with people whom we've hurt, they're open to our apology.

Now the fact is that, generally speaking, unless they've been fortunate enough to come to the Buddha's teaching about pain, they will definitely blame you for

The Gratification, the Danger and the Escape

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min read

In this profound evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents one of the Buddha's most essential teachings—the three aspects of existence that the Awakened One said he had to fully understand before attaining perfect enlightenment: gratification (assāda), danger (ādīnava), and escape (nissaraṇa). Drawing from key discourses, he explains how beings become enamored with worldly pleasures precisely because there is real gratification to be found, yet this very gratification contains inherent dangers that lead to suffering.

The talk traces the psychological development from childhood's natural seeking of pleasure and comfort, through the complex web of attachment, identity, and possession that creates our suffering. Bhante examines how this pattern extends beyond sensual pleasures into spiritual materialism and the pursuit of power, wealth, fame, and sensual gratification. He explores the danger (ādīnava) inherent in this approach—the inevitable arising and passing away of all conditioned phenomena, leading to frustration, fear, grief, and the entire spectrum of dukkha.

Most importantly, the talk illuminates the escape (nissaraṇa)—not as annihilation or destruction of the world, but as a fundamental shift in our relationship to experience. Through mindfulness practice, we can access the observer consciousness that remains unattached, finding equanimity with pain, emotions, and mental states rather than identifying with them. This practical teaching shows how both samatha (peaceful abiding) and vipassanā (insight) meditation work together to reveal this ancient path to liberation.

Namotassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma-Sambuddhassa Namotassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma-Sambuddhassa Namotassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma-Sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I wanted to bring all the teachings a little bit together for you using a schema that the Buddha himself seems to have liked very much. In fact, he said until he'd understood the world this way he hadn't attained the unsurpassed perfect enlightenment, so these three moments are important. They're translated as gratification, danger and escape.

I'll read the discourse. It's only a little thing: "O monks, I set out seeking the gratification in the world. Whatever gratification there is in the world, that I have found. I have clearly seen with wisdom just how far the gratification in the world extends. I set out

seeking the danger in the world. Whatever danger there is in the world, that I found. I have clearly seen with wisdom just how far the danger in the world extends. I set out seeking an escape from the world. Whatever escape there is from the world, that I have found. I have clearly seen with wisdom how far the escape from the world extends."

And then to complement that, in another discourse he says: "If monks, there were no gratification in the world, beings would not become enamoured with the world. But it is because there is gratification in the world, beings become enamoured with it. If there were no danger in the world, beings would not become disenchanted with the world. But because there is danger in the world, beings become disenchanted with it. And if there were no escape from the world, beings could not escape from it. But as there is an escape from the world, beings can escape from it."

So this little schema — gratification, danger and escape — none of this will come to you as a surprise. It's what you've been listening to all the time you've been here.

This word gratification — I looked it up because I think it's a good translation. I tended to use the word satisfaction, but Bhikkhu Bodhi uses this word gratification. I think it's actually a better word in some ways than satisfaction. I looked it up in the dictionary and it gave two examples: "She was gratified to see the shock in Jim's face" and one that shouldn't surprise us, "a thirst for sexual gratification." This word gratification has a slightly stronger meaning than satisfaction. It suggests that compulsive behaviour or a demanding nature about the desire that we have. So I think it's probably a slightly better word for us than satisfaction.

Now if we go back to the Buddha's own particular life story, there is that time when he's having a good time — sex, drugs and rock and roll — and he's just had a party, and he wakes up in the middle of the night and he sees all these men and women, all disheveled and saliva dripping from their mouths. He goes into great detail of how disgusting it was. It's then when he wakes up from the gratification that he's had from the party before.

So there's something about the search for gratification in the sensual world. Now why is it that we seek happiness there? See, there's no denial on the Buddha's part that there is gratification in the world. There is gratification in ice cream and Costa coffee and all those things that we enjoy. So there is gratification. It's not that he denies that. It would be foolish of him to do so. What is it that draws us to that then? Why is it that we seek it there?

If we go back a little bit into the sequence of our psychology, remember that we're born into this frame, we're born into this body. Right from the beginning we're seeking milk because it's nice to taste and it comforts us. We seek the touch of our mothers. So there's an immediate connection right there, even in the womb they say, with the voice of your mother and things like that, where that unborn and the born child finds pleasure. This pleasure isn't just physical, is it? It's actually an emotional wellbeing, a wellbeing of being protected and of being close to some other being.

So it's right there at the beginning of our experience. Now, it shouldn't be strange for us to realize or to accept that right there, even though it's not an intellectual thing, there's an immediate, there's a total identity with that experience. There's an identity with it. Obviously the child's not saying "this is me," it's just the way they experience life. It's a total identity with what they are experiencing. And I think that goes on. I would say an ordinary person would say that they are what they experience in that total identity way.

What we tend to do, isn't it, is to try and develop comfort around us. We want to be comfortable. Even in our sitting posture, if it gets a bit uncomfortable, there's that urge to move. If you watch yourself watching TV sometimes, there's a shuffle here and there. As soon as it becomes slightly uncomfortable, we move the body. Even at that very basic physical level, we're always trying to be comfortable. And when it comes to the more delightful things — what we eat and our friendships and all that — then of course there's an added factor of a real delight. There's loveliness in life, there's beauty in life, there's all the things that we enjoy. All these things the Buddha wouldn't have denied. There is gratification. There is gratification.

If you go through the whole gamut of your experiences in life where you've been happy — from just ordinary basic things like eating to lovely times in relationships and being out in the country and listening to beautiful music, and in the meditation sometimes these beautiful states of mind arise — all that is given. They're going to come hopefully till we die. It's not that we're going to disappear because we meditate, I hope not. So there's always that part of life which gives us comfort, pleasure, joy, all those things.

Even in our meditation we're trying to develop these factors of enlightenment to the point where they are just the way we are. So there is that calmness and there is that equanimity and openness. And what that means, of course, is there's no fear. It's fear that stops us being open, isn't it? And there's just an attention, a quiet attention to

things. And then there's the four great *Brahmavihāras*, the dwelling place of the Brahmas, the great gods — perhaps better understood as the illimitables: love, compassion, joy and peace.

So that's the Buddha mind, or the Buddha heart, shall we say, is always in that sort of state. I think sometimes we get the impression through the coolness of *vipassanā* meditation that you end up being soulless or emotionless, a little bit like a dried prune, I suppose, but very wise. Well, it isn't like that, is it? The Buddha says he feels joyful, he feels happy, he feels compassionate. So his experience of life at the emotional level is always in these lovely, beautiful states — always in these beautiful states. But somehow he's not fooled by it. He's not, in this sense, he's not gratified. He's not gratified.

So what is it that makes this gratification in the joys and pleasures of life gratifying, unsatisfactory, not in the end gratifying? Basically very simple, isn't it — the fact they arise and pass away. Just when you think you've got everything sorted, it chucks a spanner and that's the end of it. You try and build up a life which is meaningful and fulfilling — good job and relationship and all that — and then your partner dies or they leave, or the job suddenly disappears. So you can't — there's nowhere you can rest.

I love the sayings of Jesus on that: "The birds have their nests and the foxes their holes, but the Son of man has nowhere to put his head." I think that's it, isn't it? There's nowhere in this world that a human being is going to be comfortable in that total way.

And then when we come to investigate the psychology around pleasure, then we see all these downsides — the frustration, because of the attachment that you've built to it, because of the dependency on what's giving you happiness, there comes that frustration when you can't get it. And there's the fear of losing it, all the insurance that we have to buy just in case we do lose it, we can buy another one. And then there's the grief, of course, when you do lose it.

So there's a whole messy psychology in the aftermath of having indulged in something that's very pleasurable or joyful. And that connection, that identity, you see, is the root cause, isn't it? It's because I'm saying "I am," you know, "I am" or "I have." There's that peculiar connection with things that we have, which is very subtle, but it manifests mainly in these negative emotions and that indulgence, right? So it's catching that, it's understanding that, that we begin to see the danger.

See, there's the danger of it. In fact, these things hurt. And then, having seen that danger, one seeks for the escape. So that's the Buddha. He saw the danger of the emptiness, the vacuity of sensual pleasure. It wasn't going anywhere. That's when he leaves and he's prepared even to leave his wife and his kid, his child that was just born. Those

sorts of decisions wouldn't have been taken lightly, would they? People are called away from their families for various reasons — for war — and in this case the Buddha felt, or the Bodhisattva he would have been then, just compelled to go and try and work out what was at the core of his deep-seated unhappiness.

And I think when you get to that level, you're really at the sort of an existential level of suffering. And what I mean by that is questions of "Why am I alive?" and "Why am I conscious?" And in the Buddha's more immediate experiential question: "Why am I suffering? Why am I suffering?" Couldn't work it out.

When we do in the evening when we go through these recollections on sickness, old age and death, which refer back to the mythical way that they explain that the Buddha slowly came to awoke, really, to these factors of life — seeing somebody who was sick, old and dying while he was out in his chariot, remember? — he also sees an ascetic. He also sees this ascetic sitting under a tree, and that awakens in him: "Is there an escape? Is there a possibility of an escape?"

Now just going back a little bit on the psychology of this, remember that because of this deep identity that we have with this life form, with being a human being, there isn't just that side of greed, there isn't just that side of lust and seeking happiness in the sensual world, and indulgence — you can put it all as indulgence or acquisitiveness. As soon as we've done that, remember, as soon as we hold on to something, we put a fence around it. We put a barrier around it, and that defines what our pleasures are. So anything beyond that boundary becomes unpleasant. It becomes something that we don't want or we don't need. So our attitude to something which is unpleasant but which is neither here nor there is to ignore it. That's what we mean by neutral feelings. We don't get particularly angry about it, we just don't notice it.

But as soon as these things outside this fence, outside this boundary, begin to look a bit dangerous to us, look as though it's undermining what we own and what we identify with, then you start getting these negative things — aversion, the pushing away and the anger and the hatred and the spite and all that sort of stuff. And that all comes under this, there's been some aversion. And in our meditation, it's boredom. That's an averse state. Be bored.

And included in that, remember, is that when these things that seem to be undermining us, seem to be overpowering us, then we start getting this other side of anxiety and fear. And it all comes down to this basic position of seeking gratification in the world.

And then once we've established in childhood this way of behaving, then you can see how it moves into another layer of psychology when we hit the whole problem of good and evil. So when we do good and we attach to it, then of course you get into the business, the downside of really using compassion, using love, using sympathetic joy in order to make yourself happy. So when the other person, for instance, doesn't appreciate what you've done, then you feel hurt, you feel broken, you feel angry. Things like that: "What I've done for you" and all that.

And on the other side you've got the evil — evil in the sense of doing what is harmful. It can be something rather unskillful, which is neither here nor there, but we're capable of doing great evil — really doing something which is tremendously harmful both to ourselves and to other beings. And then you get into all that other psychology of guilt and shame and remorse and all that. And you can see how all this builds up, up and up and up until you get this massive human suffering stuck in this fathom-long body, as the Buddha would call his fathom-long body.

And it all begins from this mistake, this unfortunate mistake we make at the beginning of seeking gratification in the world, in the sensual world. So all those things are all linked, they're all there. And of course when you suppress them, when you push them away, when you don't want to look at these turbulences, these negative turbulences within us, well that's when they manifest as feelings of depression. See, depression and tiredness and lethargy and all that — all those are, you know, "I push them away. I don't want to see them. Keep them away."

So when you're meditating, of course, all this starts to come up, doesn't it? It's like, I think I say on one of the tapes, like lifting a lid off a dustbin. Suddenly it all comes up. So suddenly the depression comes up now, and you've got to see it as a consequence of past conditioning. You've got to see that actually we've manufactured this. This isn't come because your mother hit you around the ear with a banana when you were three years old or something, as you might have done, but it's how you reacted to this banana which is causing all this problem.

Now that doesn't mean to say that childhood is fraught with both ecstatic joy and disaster. It needn't be that any parent has actually physically or purposefully done you harm. You can just fall off a bed and it would be a catastrophe which remains as a trauma inside you. But even so, that is how the child has reacted, and there's that continuation of all those things that we learn in childhood throughout life, until we get really bad and then we look and we try and find an answer. We come to meditation.

So when we are meditating, we're opening the gates. We're opening ourselves up to all the stuff that's been suppressed and all that. But also from this understanding we're beginning to see the danger of this wrong relationship we have to the world. And it's seeing that danger, you see, which is painful. It's hard to sit with it. It's hard to bear with some of the stuff that comes up. But there's no other way. There doesn't seem to be any other way of curing our psychology except in this conscious way.

Drugs don't help. They just suppress. They just suppress the physical frame, don't they? And then you feel good, but when the drug passes, oh, it's even worse. There doesn't seem to be — I don't know of any spiritual practice whereby you don't have to go through this purging, purgatory, the process of purification. It's just a matter of fact.

But if you understand it as a growth in consciousness, as a growth in wisdom, then you see there's no other way. Because how else would you know that the gratification is wrong? How else would you know that there is danger? How else would you seek the end of suffering?

So if you see your life as more to do with an evolution of wisdom — or an evolution of consciousness, perhaps the word wisdom is far better actually — an evolution of wisdom, and not to confuse wisdom with knowledge. Wisdom is a relationship. It's how you relate to the world you're in. That's your wisdom.

And if you see that that's what you're doing through your meditation is to discover a wiser way of being with the world, then in a sense you're prepared to go through the purgatory. And also I think when you actually go through the purgatory, when you actually see that it is a process of healing, you're more and more open to actually going through it. And that's important. It's important that you actually see that there is gratification and that somehow something goes wrong with that.

And this is what we mean by indulgence, whether it's indulgence in something which is pleasant or indulgence in something which is outwardly unpleasant, like anger. But it is pleasing to let go of your anger and bang the door and bump somebody on the nose. That's gratification — to finally get your own back. But it's not particularly skillful, it's not really wise.

So it's actually beginning to see that, that we begin to see the path out, you see, and that's the next business of it, the *nisaraṇa*, the escape.

If there were no escape in the world, then boy, we'd be miserable, wouldn't we? And people who get themselves into these dead ends, these dead ends of the meaninglessness of life. Or a religious person — I've met a few people who think they're damned. What do you do? They're damned. Now, in Buddhist terms, that's to really believe that

there's no escape from *saṃsāra*. That whether you like it or not, you'll be reborn and reborn and reborn — first as a shrew in a meditation room and then you get chucked out with a bit of cheese out in a paddock, and then you're reborn as a human being picking up a shrew and chucking it out, and there's this constant *saṃsāra*, this onward going. And in the Buddha's day, that was the horror. It wasn't ecological disaster. It was this thing about having to be reborn and reborn and reborn again.

And there's a lovely conversation in one of the scriptures, I can't remember the details now, where two of the Buddha's cousins, if I remember rightly, decide that, discussing whether to go, whether to actually take up, whether to follow Gautama and take up the robe and bowls. And the argument goes something like: "Look, what is life? You've got to go out there, you've got to plow the ground, you've got to harvest the seed, you've got to eat it, and then you do it again next year, and it's really boring." And one of them gets really into this and says, "Yeah, you're right," and he goes off. With the other fellow he says, "No, it's for you. I'm still enjoying this." So he doesn't leave, you see. He's still getting something out of the life form. But it was this fellow who was pointing out to this man who finally leaves how terrible life is in this boring, repetitious way, which I think would have been perhaps more obvious to people in those days, in some ways anyway, because there wasn't this huge entertainment industry.

Reminds me of an old prewar comedian — he's going to jump, he's on London Bridge, and he's going to jump in, and the policeman sees him and he calls him over, you see, and they start having this big discussion about life, as to why suicide. And the policeman's arguing that life's worth it, and the comedian is arguing how useless it is. And the conversation goes on and on, and they finally jump — both of them jump off the bridge. That's brilliant. "Yeah, you're right."

So this finding of the escape — so that's the Buddha's great thing, isn't it? And he says that what he's discovered, he's not invented it. He says this is an ancient path. He's just rediscovered it. It's not as though he's the first human being that's ever done it. He doesn't claim to be that. In fact, in the mythology of Buddhism, there are Buddhas previous to him. Going back, I don't know how many times, there are twenty-eight previous Buddhas named in previous huge eons of world systems. It was just the way that you begin to think when you think of time being cyclic. I think I mentioned it this morning, that the years just roll over, just keep going, and the whole universe is expanding and then it'll collapse, and then it expands again and collapses. So there's that idea that this has been going on ever since. He says that he doesn't see the beginning of *kamma*. He doesn't see that there is a beginning. It's always been like this. And presumably in that sense he doesn't see the end of that process, but as an individual he found an escape.

Now this escape is — be careful here — because this escape, as hopefully you've all come to realize in your meditation, is not the destruction of the world. There's a very interesting discourse in which somebody asks him, "Where do the four *Mahābhūtas* come to an end?" Now the four *Mahābhūtas*, the four elements, the four great elements, they are earth, fire, water and air. And they constitute the physical universe. So what the person is asking is, "Where does all this come to an end?" And he says, "It's the wrong question." He says, "Where do they not find a footing?" It's very interesting. "Where do they not find a footing?" In other words, is there an experience, is there something experiential where you will not find these, but it doesn't deny their existence or destroy them or annihilate them?

And then he goes on to say there is a consciousness which is not touched by the five or six senses. So there is a consciousness which is not coloured by the six senses. So there's no hearing and there's no seeing and there's nothing there, there's no thought, there's nothing. And yet it is without boundary, and the reason it's without boundary is because there's no phenomena. You've got to have something to create a boundary. If there's nothing in this universe, then it's empty space, there's no boundary in it. It's what we have, it's the things we have that create boundaries for us. And he says there is this consciousness which is without boundary, and in all directions full of light.

So he's pointing there to an experience which is a total escape from the world. Now remember that when we say an escape, he's still there. It's not as though he's disappeared in a puff of smoke and there's just this mystical voice arising from nowhere. So this escape is not the destruction of anything.

So again, when they ask him, "Does he believe in any form of annihilation?" He says, "No." He says, "Everything arises depending on something else and there's no annihilation." He says, "The only things that are annihilated are greed, hatred and delusion." And greed, hatred and delusion are this way of expressing this wrong relationship we have to the world, which in a psychological sense is this seeking gratification. And that's what he means by this desire. When we chant in the morning this *taṇhā*, that's what he's referring to.

But remember that there's a completely different psychology, and that's the psychology of the Buddha. That's the psychology of the enlightened beings, which doesn't have that downer, it doesn't have that gratification, it doesn't have all the downers of gratification — the grief, the fear, the anger, the frustration, all that stuff. It doesn't have that. It doesn't have any anger, it doesn't have any fear. The fearless one — that's one of the epithets of the Buddha. He's fearless. What's he afraid of? There's no connection to the

world whereby suffering could arise. How does suffering arise? It arises through the connection of attachment, identity, possession. If that's all gone, what then is our relationship to the world? What might it be?

So that escape is suggestive of all the teachings of the Buddha concerning the practice which leads us to this point of liberation. It's an escape. It's like escaping from prison. It's like you're finally released.

So now this is where our practice comes in, because it's a fundamental practice. And what we're learning is not only to see that gratification is wrong because it has these dangers, but we're seeing this escape. And that's all we're doing. We're just seeing where the escape is. And the more the escape becomes clearer to us, then the more we'll practice, because it's like when you see the finishing line, you really want to go for it.

So even in our practice when we're confused or when we don't think we're getting anywhere or we don't think we're progressing — that's a regular one for meditators, because you still keep doing these pratfalls and you think, "Well, I'm still as I was before," you see — so if you have those feelings, those ideas about yourself, remember that all those come from this gratification. You're now seeking gratification, as it were, in the spiritual life, meaning you're seeking a certain type of comfort there. And that comfort usually comes from the sense of achieving.

But if you abandon those ideas of trying to achieve anything and draw that word simply into moment-to-moment mindfulness, then you're always achieving, as long as you're mindful. You're always here. And that mindfulness, that sharp mindfulness, is a guard, because as we begin to realize, the problem begins or starts with these intentions. So when we see these intentions and we're awake, we're bright with it, we're not caught up in it, we're not suddenly dashing off and doing something, then that gives us that moment of choice. And then we begin to see, "Oh, here's the escape, here's the escape."

And when we access that point within us, which is the observer — so that's not the fullest escape because there's still a sense of me there — but we can see that that's an escape from all the pain that the body might offer us, because from there we can feel the pain, we can see the reaction to pain, we can allow the reaction of fear and aversion, all that, to die away, and we can find this equanimity, this peacefulness with pain, just this patient forbearance. And that's an escape. It's an escape from all the fear and the anxiety that we have around the body.

It's the same with these emotions. When you distance them, when you can feel them there, rather than being them, it's an escape, isn't it? You've transcended them. You're in a different position. You're not identifying with them. You're not possessing them. You're saying, "Oh, look, there, there's anger." See, there's grief. There's depression. And it's seeing that clearly that we begin to say, "Oh, here's the escape. Here's the escape."

That doesn't mean to say at all, does it, that it's easy. It's very difficult, in fact, to stay with these mental states as they arise. But the more we see that this is the escape, the more we'd be happy to stay there. The more we see it actually as a place where there's healing going on.

And then finally, all this takes a long time. So there's always going to be that little bit of self left right to the bitter end. It's not going to let go. So there's always going to be these pratfalls on the way. There's always going to be moments when we feel we've slipped back and we're not moving forward and all that. But we have to keep reminding ourselves that this is an onward going. This is a long-term commitment. In the Buddhist sense we're talking lifetime — not just talking this life. So it's a whole process that we're going through.

So there we have it — these three ways of looking at our practice: to be aware of where we're seeking comfort, where we're seeking gratification; to see that greed, that lust, the avarice — we've got lovely, great big words for all that — all centering around the four great lusts: power, riches, fame, and sensual pleasure. To be famous, powerful and rich — everybody wants to do that. That's pretty simple. "And what do you want to be?" "I want to be famous, powerful and rich." They're your four main areas, aren't they?

And it's just to see how the mind is constantly moving that way. It's always trying to achieve that particular state. And that renunciation is the point where we allow that desire to just fade away, to just begin to release itself. And as I've pointed out in the morning, to let any desire fade away and then just to stay with it long enough to see what the mind is, what the heart is when there's no desire there. See that lovely contentment, and then with it comes the peace.

And hopefully you're beginning to experience that even during these times of quiet abiding where we're trying to develop the more passive side of the factors of enlightenment — the calmness, calmness of the body, just being still; calmness of the heart, stillness of the silence of the mind. All that comes under calmness in a way. And the attentiveness, just the ability to just be attentive, focused — not particularly focused on any

one thing, but just to be here, and to focus on whatever arises and passes away, that very spacious, open awareness. And the equanimity, just that ability, just the openness to what's coming into our field of awareness.

And just every so often to be like that and just to rest within the present moment, you see, relaxing into the present moment wide awake. And then as you do that, when it passes, to ask yourself, "Now what was that like? Was that a pleasant place to be?" Now fair enough, we can get attached to that too, and then it becomes — and our practice becomes a sort of quietism, that we're just seeking this lovely quiet place: "Leave me alone. Get out of my way."

But then, of course, that's balanced because we then bring in these other factors, the more active factors of the process, which is that interest — the interest of wanting to see — the effort to begin to see things, and the effort to remain at that point of interest, and the investigation of the Dhamma.

So, during your day, try to balance those things. Just go through your day and say, "Well, this is when I'm practicing this *samatha*-type meditation, peaceful abiding, and this is when I'm doing *vipassanā*." And get to know yourself. Know where your weak points are during the day. Say, "Well, now here I've got to, I mustn't fall asleep again," or "Here I just let my mind go, I give up effort at this particular point in the day." And just catch your rhythm. They're probably also to do with just the natural rhythms of our bodies, the circadian rhythms, as they call them. So there's all those rhythms going on too, you see. So once we've attained, once we've got to this point of observation, then we can see all this happening.

Let's just pause for a moment and just whatever thoughts come up, let them come up and pass away.

So, let me encourage you to keep putting in that little bit of effort. For Nick and Sarah have been here now for two weeks, you see. It's coming to the end, so you have to be careful that your energy level doesn't drop. More like the long-distance runner, when you see that wire. You've got to put on that little extra spurt to get there. So that's important.

And this is about your fourth day, isn't it, Haji? So in a sense, hopefully, you'll be more at ease with the schedule, with the regime. So with that, there's a danger of, "Well, this is now easier now," and there's a drop of commitment, a drop of energy.

So you've got to keep lifting it. You've got to keep seeing where the effort begins to drop and you just very gently push yourself. That's what one of my teachers says: push gently. And then you'll see the energy comes. The energy comes. So keep going. That's all there is to it.

May you be liberated sooner rather than later.

Kamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 27 min read

In this profound evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the Buddha's nuanced understanding of kamma (Sanskrit: karma) as the fundamental law of conditionality underlying all existence. Moving beyond popular misconceptions, he clarifies that true kamma is not fate but rather the will (cetanā) that empowers our intentions into actions.

The teaching distinguishes between five universal laws affecting our lives: physical laws of nature, biological inheritance, mental formations, societal conditioning, and the Dhamma itself. Through vivid imagery of interconnected waves in puddles, pools, lakes, and oceans, Bhante illustrates how multiple karmic streams converge to create each moment's experience.

Central to the discourse is the distinction between moral behavior and spiritual skillfulness (kusala) - actions that lead toward Nibbāna. The talk emphasizes that while external circumstances arise from countless causes, our inner response to any situation constitutes our true kamma. This understanding places complete responsibility for our psychological conditioning and spiritual development in our own hands.

Drawing from the Dhammapada and core Buddhist principles, Bhante explains how renunciation differs from self-mortification, serving as reconditioning of the will toward Dhamma-cetanā - the awakened intention bent on liberation. The teaching concludes with practical guidance for maintaining moment-to-moment awareness as the foundation for transforming unwholesome habits into wholesome ones, ultimately leading to the 'warm, still waters of Nibbāna.'

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

Now we've come to the end of the seventh day. We're well into the course, well adjusted, in fact, having a great time. How else could it be? I'm sure that those who will leave tomorrow will now regret bitterly that they will not be staying or have not stayed for the full eight weeks. The fact is that once you've got through the first seven days, you can actually keep going with very little effort.

It's also true that those staying for three weeks or more can train themselves to sleep less, down to three and a half or four hours a night. When a meditator does that, they experience the next three days similar to when they started, going through the healing

torture of raising energy one more notch. If after five days they still feel exhausted during the day, then it's okay to go back to five and a half hours. The fact we can do with less sleep during a meditation course is because of the purifying effect and the transformative effect of the practice. The practice lets mental turbulences release themselves and transforms that violent energy into a pure calm flow as when water having bubbled and boiled over rapids transforms into a deep and powerful gentle river.

But why do this? Why do we have to lift energy? Because in so doing, we squeeze the hidden turbulence out of the system. Remember, this turbulence also turns inwards. It drags us down and causes us to feel that dullness and lethargy, as when water trapped is overgrown with weeds and often turns fetid and rank. But when we refuse to go down but stay awake, that deeper layer of turbulence begins to manifest as some form of mental turbulence. And so we can work with that deeper layer of our psychology. So though staying on for three weeks or more, let's see if we can lift our energy.

Now all this week we've been looking inward and trying to understand how suffering arises and how it passes away. Indeed, that is what we mean by *kamma*. You will notice, by the way, I am using the more common Sanskrit form of the word with the R, karma, which is now in the Oxford English Dictionary. In the Theravāda Pali script it doesn't have an R, kamma. But that aside, we need to understand the Buddha's teaching around karma so that we can take our practice into ordinary daily life.

First, it's important to understand the underlying philosophy of causality, cause and effect. As we all know, and as our science understands, nothing comes into existence without a cause. Nothing happens without causes. What happens is the effect, the consequence, of some past action or event. That's our usual understanding. Remembering our iconic toast, once that lever is pressed, we know the bread will be transformed. Equally, when one of those terrible diseases hits the animal population, mad cow disease or foot and mouth, scientists set about searching for the cause. We sometimes go far back in time to understand the cause of present day events, such as an earthquake. We try to see our present psychological problems in terms of what happened to us in childhood, and so on.

The Buddha stated this in a very simple way. Literally, the Pali translates as, "Because that arose, this is now arising. Because that did not arise, this does not arise now." Here we have a more subtle understanding. We tend to look at karma only in the positive. This happened to me because that happened previously. I got my wages at the end of the week because I worked. But the negative is also true. I didn't make any money this week because I was sick and couldn't work. Because we do support a worthy cause, some benefit arises. Because we fail to do so, some benefit fails to materialize.

Now if everything that happens now is indeed caused by some past event, that suggests everything is set, predetermined, everything is fate. Where then would choice and free will figure? What's more, if indeed everything is determined by past events, where does creativity come in? Surely we'd be looking at a universe constantly repeating set patterns. The same cause and effect spinning around each other. A monotonous dance.

The Buddha points out that things also happen because of a conjunction, a meeting of various lines of actions that come from various past causes to create a single new event. Jung, the psychologist, called this synchronicity. Again, the Pali translates literally as "because this is, so that is, because this is not, so that is not." For a person to receive their wages either in hand or in the bank account takes a lot of things to come together from various sources. There's the amount of work done, the registering of it, which implies all the office work, the transfer of money, which implies all the banking system, and so on. I shall spare you the details of how a piece of toast ends up succulent on the tongue.

Here we have an understanding that is reflected in modern chaos theory. Dependent on supporting conditions, it may be that a flap of a butterfly wing in the tropics could eventually develop into a tornado in little old UK. That is, supporting conditions of weather patterns may come from different sources to conspire, as it were, to use that little flapping as a catalyst to create a catastrophe. By the way, I find it typical of our present-day gloom and doom that a positive spin could not be given to it. Conditions creating a great summer, for instance.

It is also important to take this understanding into our moral behaviour. A small act of kindness whirled by supporting conditions may bring an end to an age-old quarrel, an age-old war.

Now if it were true that the universe was only a confluence of unrelated events, different events totally unconnected with each other in the present and arising with no connection to the past, then we can imagine only chaos, real chaos. How could there be any coherence? Or if there were, it would be by mere chance, and then only for the occasional moment. Yet without these haphazard meetings, there can be no creativity. We may unexpectedly meet a friend and suddenly a choice arises whether to do something with our friend or carry on doing what we'd set out to do. I set out looking for work. Others are looking for workers. Opportunities arise. Some improbable, some just up my street. Hopefully.

So to understand the picture fully, we need to blend these two positions together. Something happens now because the different parts of that event come from a structured past and because they happen to all come together at one and the same time.

Even in this statement we do not catch the boggling complexity of the situation because what the term "structured past" fails to get across is the idea that every moment in that structured past was a similar confluence of various karmic lines.

There is the story of the boy who was drowning in a bog and the local poor farmer who saved him. The rich father of that boy wanted to give the farmer some money. The farmer would have nothing to do with it. So the rich man offered to give the poor man's son an education. As things turned out, the rich man's son was Winston Churchill and the poor man's son was Alexander Fleming, the discoverer of penicillin. When Winston Churchill fell ill with pneumonia, it was Fleming's penicillin that saved him, saved twice by the same family.

Here we see a graphic example of the interaction of two differing lines of past karma meeting to create unexpected results. What possible connection could there have been originally between the poor and the rich boy? There will be those who argue that this was the product of karma coming from a past life, and there may be some truth in that. But I tend to lean on the side of chance. Our general disposition is to try to make sense of everything, even if it does not solve the problem. To be sick and not know what is wrong with you is worse than finding out what is wrong but can't be cured. One learns to bear with it. Even if it's terminal, one can come to terms with it. But not knowing is an anxious and frustrating place for us to be. And as we shall see, there are other laws that really do bring that element of chance into our lives.

So here we have the basic law underlying the teachings of karma, the law of conditionality. Everything arises in the present moment dependent on past and present conditions. Nothing arises spontaneously of its own cause. There is nothing causeless in the relative universe simply because everything is related. You can see though that this is not a mechanical law, we don't live in a simple one-and-one-makes-two logical universe. There's something quite unpredictable about the universe and indeed about our lives as human beings. In fact, the Buddha said, if you were to try to work out your karma, it would drive you mad.

To give you a sense of what it's all about, I'd like to ask you to practice a little visualization with me. You'll have to close your eyes for this one, and imagine. Imagine there's a little puddle, and a tiny stone lands in the center of it. See how the waves expand outwards, hit the edge and flow back to the centre. And how this continues until the momentum slowly dies away. Now see that puddle showered with little stones of various sizes. Can you see the turmoil? And yet there's that underlying pattern. As waves criss-cross, there are new meetings, each wave affecting the other. Everything is interconnected.

Now take a large pool and place that puddle in some quiet little corner. Again see how the stone creates a wave that flows out to the edge and back again and also flows against that little puddle and affects all the wavelets there. Now shower that pool with stones of various sizes and again see the apparent turmoil and the underlying structure.

Now take a large lake and place that pool with its puddle in a hidden corner and again watch that first wave splash out from the centre and make its way to the bank and back, again affecting all the waves in the pool with its little puddle. Again shower the lake with rocks and boulders. Oh, what a creation!

Now take a sea and again place that lake with its pond and puddle in some quiet corner. Again, see that first splash and the wave launching out to the surrounding beach, crossing over the lake, the pool and the puddle. And now again the sea is bombarded with pebbles, rocks and boulders. What mayhem!

And finally the vast ocean. Hidden somewhere is that sea containing the lake, the pool and the puddle. Again a great wave. Watch it flow outward and as it lifts the pool and the puddle it hardly affects them, so great is it. Both are simply lifted up in the great swell. And again so many swells.

And one last little thing. Focus again on that little puddle and notice that the turbulent which hits it does not penetrate. It only causes the inner water to vibrate as when we strike a balloon. And as you slowly zoom away, you notice it's intimately surrounded by lots of other little puddles. And one final observation. Waves are not water moving. It is simply a force that runs through the mass, causing it to rise and fall.

So now there's our image. It's a way of symbolizing how each of us are at a crossroads of lesser or greater confluences. And what we need to be very clear about is what constitutes karma, personal karma. That karma that has to be cleared up, purified and refined as a part of the process of becoming liberated.

We can take these images in various ways to see how intricately complicated the universe is. On the grand scale we can see the puddles as human beings, the pool, the society we create, the lake, the earth we live on, the sea, our galaxy and the ocean, the vast cosmos. Alternatively, we can take it on a more interactive human level, making the puddle stand for individuals, the pool for the family and relatives, the lake for our society, the sea for our culture, and the ocean for mankind.

Here we have used the word karma in a more popular way to describe how all things come to be, all cause and effect, but the teachings make a finer distinction. They point to five different laws. They equate with our own modern understandings.

The first are the physical laws of nature. Luckily, we live in a fairly benevolent climate. Some parts of the world suffer greatly from floods and droughts, and perhaps most dramatic of all in recent times, earthquakes, hurricanes and tsunamis. Yet even we in temperate climes are affected in all sorts of ways by the weather. How the cold and dark of winter keeps us indoors. At an extreme level some people suffer from depression because of light deprivation. It's the time we prefer to catch colds and flus. And then summer with its flowers and sun, more than occasional these days, happily. How we love to bask in the warmth. How a sunny day lays us out on beaches like pancakes, and so on. But it's much bigger than that, how dependent we are on that very sun, how inexorably tied up we are with the laws that govern the physical universe. Who knows what distant galactic explosion might not blast this puny little planet out of existence. Not to talk of black holes. Now there I go being gloomy and doomy. Alternatively, it may remain a favoured place for the evolution of consciousness and simply die away gracefully with the rest of the universe.

In popular Buddhism, there is much confusion over this. Much like the monotheistic religions, people believe that storms and earthquakes and tsunamis are sent to us by our past karma, our sins. Not because there is some judging God doing it, but because of the lord of cause and effect, karma. There's a telling story, a later attachment to one of the verses of the Dhammapada, the collection of the Buddha's sayings. A ship suddenly stops in the middle of the sea. The wind suddenly drops. The captain and crew are mystified. Luckily, there's a group of monks on board who have supranormal powers. They sit in meditation and announce to all that the reason the ship has stopped is because of the bad karma of the captain's wife. It seems that in a past life she drowned many dogs, and there would be no sailing until she left the ship. Can you imagine how she felt? Worse was to come. How could she leave the ship in the middle of the sea? There was only one way for it, so they chucked her overboard. The wind blew, the ship quickly caught sail, and soon made harbour.

The next is concerned with the law of seeds, as it translates. This is anything to do with life, with biology. As for humans, that refers to our DNA. And here lies another regular misconception. It does say clearly in the discourses that the way we behave morally has an effect on the way we look. Hatred leads to an ugliness, love and joy to a beauty. But our dispositions are only one in a number of factors. The overriding factor must be our genetic makeup, which comes to us from a long history of evolution. So we should hardly feel that we're undergoing the consequences of a hateful heart in the past life, if we happen in this life to look like the back of a bus. So what is our actual true karma in terms of the process of awakening? It is how we deal with being plain or plain ugly. Even though ugliness and beauty are all to do with human convention, non-

etheless they affect us. In the same way as ugliness, for instance, might lead to low self-esteem, beauty can lead to conceit, both unskillful, unwholesome. Ultimately, of course, how we look should not be of any consequence to us. But the fact remains, however, that the way we feel does have an effect on our looks. Not simply body language, but even the shape the face grows into can express a constant underlying mood. Depression or joy, for instance. Even so, the body we have is not something we have directly caused by our actions.

The third law is the law concerning the mind. Again, this tends to focus on how the mind works, how consciousness arises and contacts the world and so on, and especially the psychology of dependent origination we've covered. But implied, of course, is our relationship to the world around us. Was it a conscious choice to be born into the family we were brought up in? Did we make a decision to be born in this country and not another? How all overpowering on our minds and hearts, our personality and character is the family and society we are born into. The way we see things, talk about things, our opinions, even the very language we use has been pre-set, pre-determined for us. We are born into a set of values, a history, a culture and a civilization. We are profoundly conditioned by them. Indeed, how else can we be human beings if not as members of a family and a country with all that that implies? Has it all been the result of my own personal past actions? Hardly. Yet here I am with an identity that firmly locks me into time and place. Again, there is some connection, but not necessarily because of a personal action, moral or otherwise. It may be just the way things came together.

Then there's the Dharma, often translated as the law or the norm, the truth as to the way things really are. Penetrating the world within, our feelings, thoughts and emotions, and the world without, living organisms and the material universe, are the spiritual truths that teach us about our relationship to this interior and exterior life. And within these teachings, that are only concerned to liberate us from suffering, lies the law of karma itself.

So what did the Buddha mean by karma, specific to the process of liberation? Karma here means action, what we do. It's not to be confused with the result of action, which is properly termed *vipāka*. But what is it that actually creates an action? Is it not will? Just consider what happens when we do walking meditation, or indeed anything on an intensive course like this. We first try to become aware of our intentions before we actually act them out. This has been a very important part of our training because usually we don't distinguish between the two. In ordinary daily life we rarely stop to consider an intention. As soon as the desire arises we tend to act upon it. Who would want to

pause and note the intention to open a door once they've decided to leave a room? It's normally when we're in a state of doubt or conflict do we consider whether to respond to an intention or not. Usually we just react.

But until we've begun to meditate, we may not have realized the crucial role of will. For will is that power that brings something out of potential into the actual, within ourselves and into the world. If a thought comes to mind, I need not necessarily follow it. To cause it to continue means something has been added to the original impetus, the original stimulus. Perhaps an image of someone I dislike arises. I could just stop it there. Something must empower it to develop. Perhaps an idea comes to take a holiday in an exotic place. It could stop there, or I may end up right where I had imagined. What is it that empowered that desire in my mind to throw it into the world out there? That empowering is what the Buddha meant by will. And he goes so far as to say, "Disciples, it is the will, *cetanā*, that I call karma." So will is the power that brings potential into actual. It is that which conditions.

It is the will that has created this inner environment that we live in. It is the will that has created and is developing right now all our emotions and thoughts, and it is our will, our will to live, that keeps this body alive. It is activated in a conscious way when we deliberate, but it is active also in an unconscious way out of habit for the will itself is also conditioned. That's why we can teach ourselves to do something even when we're not watching. I'm sure you've experienced coming back from a daydream to find the mind happily noting rising, falling.

Now from an intention there arises through the empowering of will an action. Many actions form a habit. Many habits form a personality and character, and once you've got that, well, you've also got your destiny. The crucial link in the chain is the movement out of intention into action, be it a thought, word, or deed.

So how does this psychology link in with the end of suffering? First let us remember that will does not have understanding, it's just a power. What guides our will is the way we see things. It is our understanding, deluded or wise, that commands the will to empower a desire. Although there are many times we perform neutral actions, such as tying up our shoelaces, a lot of the time we could ask ourselves whether something is skillful or not.

Now here, we must make a distinction between the moral and the skillful, the immoral and the unskillful. All of us have given up gross, immoral behaviour. Have we not? I mean, we're not about to kill or steal or tell whoppers. No doubt we infringe the moral law in some small aspects, little piccadillos, but nothing to get us in serious trouble with the police. But when it comes to skilfulness, well, we've a long way to go.

By *kusala*, skillful, wholesome, virtuous... The Buddha meant all those actions that lead us to the end of suffering, *Nibbāna*. The path leading to that liberation is always against the flow self would have us follow. Before the Buddha took his seat beneath the Bodhi tree, where he was to become enlightened, he put his bowl in the river and it flowed upstream. It's a metaphorical way to show that the path of enlightenment is against our self-conditioned will. There's a verse in the Dhammapada which says that those who are not mindful, not skillful, are as if dead. So beware, only dead fish go with the flow.

To turn that self-conditioning around and to follow the desires of the Dharma is what spiritual training is all about. The whole of spiritual training could be said to be the reconditioning of the will. For once the will is behind the desire to become enlightened, awakened, then it becomes known as *Dhammacetanā*, the will that follows the true law. What in Mahāyāna is called *Bodhicitta*, the mind bent on enlightenment. Now when that happens, the path is straightened up. No more side alleys, no more diversions, no more wanderings in the garden of lotus eaters. And this is when we come to understand the importance of renunciation in our spiritual practice.

Renunciation must not be confused with self-mortification if what we mean by self-mortification is to make ourselves suffer in order to get rid of suffering. The Buddha discovered that to be simply painful, ignoble and unprofitable. It gets you nowhere but into more suffering. Renunciation, on the other hand, is the practice of confronting unskillful will, unskillful conditioning. It's the process whereby we undo self-conditioning and create a dharma conditioning.

Today, lots of people diet. Why? Is it not to contain their greed? Say, for the few who truly have a weight problem, the reason most do it is to get back their youthful shape or to rein in their insatiable appetite. Such people are forever in that exhausting tug of war only the self can invent, at one time feasting as if there's no tomorrow, and then bloated and obese, dieting because there might very well not be. In olden days, when our society was more spiritually bound, dieting was called fasting. But the reason for fasting was not for worldly gains of health and beauty, but to tame the will to undo conditionings forged by greed.

The Buddha instituted for his order members and any lay member who wanted to increase their spiritual effort the rule not to take food after midday. We don't have to stop eating altogether to practice renunciation. For the reason is to let go of all conditioning of eating for greed and not for nourishment. Not to let go of food itself. This is

the difference between renunciation and self-mortification. The self-mortifier blames his body for his greed and so denies the body what it needs. The renunciator blames attitude.

Take the bad habit of snacking. Rather than blame the body and go on long punitive diets, better to sit quietly with the craving and wait for it to pass. Or if that's difficult, put the mind onto something more skillful such as taking a walk. And that's the main reason for not eating after midday on this course, to investigate greed and to let it go. Remember, every time we let go of an unskillful conditioning, we also strengthen our will to follow the Dharma, our *Dhammacetanā*. And as I'm sure you've all experienced, there's the added advantage of being a little more awake in the evening.

The same practice can decondition any unwholesome habit we have. Just think how addicted we become to the TV. Now how to tackle that? Well, if you want to hit it head on, just sit in front of the box with a cup of tea and biscuit, and when your favourite programme comes on, don't switch the TV on. Just sit there and watch the inner programme. Now that's spiritual training.

And this is where our free choice really lies. Free choice here is not some anarchic behaviour, do as I want to do, when I want to do and how I want to do. That's how the self would have it. But we don't live in our own universe. We aren't creator gods. Choice arises when the possibility of two or more actions arise in a given situation. Most of our lives we have little choice. We have to get up to work, we have to go to bed to rest and so on. But there are many sorts of choices we do have to make. Some are trivial, to have tea or coffee, walk this way around the park. Some are practical, pragmatic, the best way to buy a house. But for the trainee, choices become important when there is an ethical or spiritual value to them. Ethics is concerned with the way we treat ourselves and other human beings, or living beings and the earth. Spiritual decisions are more personal and concern our own inner growth.

Once we've made a decision and empowered it, we've created an act of thought, word or deed. And whether we like it or not, there will be a result. So what we come to understand is that there is no absolutely free will and that ultimately our choices are whether to empower those thoughts, desires, intentions that lead to suffering or those that lead to the end of suffering. So that we can say that the process of awakening, of liberation as it shapes our characters and personalities is simply the switch from unwholesome habits to wholesome ones.

Here we come to the other core teaching of the Buddha concerning karma. Many people these days don't believe that. That's why there's an attitude of, well, if you can get away with it, all the better. Even in the Buddha's day, there was a famous teacher

who said it was irrelevant what you did by way of good or bad deeds. Your karma, meaning your destiny here, was set. He said if you went down one side of the Ganges and murdered, pillaged and created mayhem, or whether you came up the other side performing immense deeds of compassion, it would not make a blind bit of difference.

Now two of the great insights the Buddha had upon enlightenment were concerned with this sort of karma. The first was that he saw all his past lives and saw clearly how all the ethical and spiritual decisions he had made had led to his becoming a fully self-enlightened Buddha. And then he also saw beings moving from one realm to another according to their ethical and spiritual decisions. What had been seen first of all as a personal individual law was now understood to be a cosmic law. It was true for all beings.

Now here we seem to have a contradiction. At one time we are saying that the situation we find ourselves is not entirely of our own making. And you hear the Buddha seems to be saying as much. To clarify this situation we must understand that although the world out there has its own relative existence and reality it remains even when we are not here what we experience of it and how we relate to that experience is all of our own creation.

When we came here to join this course we all saw this building. No one will deny this building exists and has some objective reality yet did we see the same building? Is it not true that each of us had a different image, a different feeling, a different understanding of the place, even if only in delicate shades? In other words, Buddhism teaches that even if the world out there has some objective reality of its own, we only know it from our own subjective perspectives. What seems to have great beauty or meaning to one person strikes another as indifferent. Think of the arguments of modern art. Is it art or isn't it? Who knows? Well, we could say only the judges know. But then they only know for themselves. And if anyone has an opinion, well, that's their judgment. In this way, there can be no absolute objective standard in art existing out there in the universe that are only agreed conventions among human beings.

So it's not the situation we find ourselves in but the way we are in any given situation that is our karma proper, that karma that pertains to the process of liberation. Take one of those earthquakes. There will be some who go through the experience with utter horror and yet others with calmness. There was the case of a mother and child trapped beneath concrete. To keep her child alive, the mother cut her fingers and had the child suck her blood. Right there in the midst of that horror there can arise such selflessness and heroism, whereas no doubt others scream themselves to death.

There are people you meet who have to suffer terrible diseases and misfortune. Some are emotionally gnarled by the experience, embittered, self-piteous, humourless. A while back I remember there was a policeman who was shot and lost the power of his legs. It seems he made a valiant attempt to make sense of his life but eventually committed suicide. Yet we have the heroic example of many people cruelly paralysed in all limbs and yet still find life meaningful. I met someone who was so paralysed after a car crash, though happily he did recover. While lying there it came to him that his life was still, as he put it, authentic.

In other words, how we experience our lives is the way we have conditioned ourselves to experience our lives. Of course, our parents, family, culture and so on have had enormous influence in the way we see things. But, and it's hard for us to accept this, they actually only have influence. Yes, even as utterly vulnerable children, it is still our own decisions that make our conditionings. Ultimately, it is we who have made the internal decisions that have brought about our particular way of relating to the world. In the final analysis, then, we must take on the entire responsibility of our own perspectives and attitudes. And it is because of these perspectives and attitudes that we have created the inner environment in which we continue to live.

So when we feel unhappy, it's an utter waste of time to seek the solution out there, for the fundamental reason lies within our own hearts and minds. It is futile to seek someone to blame. At first this may seem unfair. How could I have known as a baby, as a child, or even as an adult? But what if it were not so? If indeed other people can make willful decisions that actually condition my inner attitudes? Then how could I ever change without having to change them also? Everybody whom I think has conditioned me, rather than influence my conditioning, and by implication all those who conditioned them and so on to all people, everybody would have to be liberated before I myself could attain that liberation. But when we see that others can only influence our decisions and that we alone are the sole creators of our deeds, then firstly we stop empowering people to dominate us and secondly we take full responsibility for our decisions and our own psychological conditioning. Now once we do that, we are on the noble path to liberation from all suffering, for we can purify our hearts and clarify our understanding, both necessary preconditions for the attainment of *Nibbāna*.

So now we've talked about the fundamental laws of conditioning how we live in uncertain times all the time for we do not know what lines of events will come together for us in any given moment that's indeed why the Buddha told us not to try to work out our karma it would drive us mad We talk to the many laws that affect us from nature to genetics, from psychology to family to society. We discuss the difference between morality and skillfulness, how the former is included in the latter, how skillfulness is the

whole noble path that leads to liberation. We saw how the Buddha puts his finger so firmly on the role of will in our conditioning. And finally, how there is an underlying moral law within the universe that dictates that unwholesome actions will have negative effects and wholesome actions positive effects within our own psyches.

And it is upon this final note that we need to concentrate, especially in our daily lives. Why is it that so many people seem to get away with it and so many people don't seem to get their just reward? It is only when we look inwardly that we see there is a justice based on this moral law. Remember, the effects of one's actions outwardly can never be determined. There are too many variables. But inwardly, all our decisions are going towards creating an ugly or a beautiful environment. And just because a person may be good at suppressing their guilt, anger, fear and so on, doesn't mean they've escaped them. These turbulences, as our meditation makes so obvious to us, are always there, lurking in the depths, causing slow havoc in the body. But worse, they are secretly skewing our perspective of the world, as Freud understood so well, so that we find ourselves falling again and again into the same old situations, the same old problems, the same old traps, the same old unsatisfactoriness. And it could all be so different. And it will be different once we take hold of this wild bull and begin to train it in the ways of the true law.

The Buddha warned us that the way is gradual. It's going to take some time. Think in terms of decades, not years. But although the path is hard, it should not be laborious. Think of the drudgery or training for an Olympic sport. Every day, for instance, rowers can train for six hours, and most of it rowing, that monotonous movement, forward, backward, forward, backward. They probably go through days of sheer boredom, I don't know, but they are fired with the will to win. That same drive to become awakened is called *saṃvega*, translated as a sense of urgency about our task, an enthusiasm. That's the feeling of *Dhammacetanā*, the will of the true law.

Though the path ahead of us is hard, tough, demanding real determination and stamina, yet there is a joy to it, a subtle joy, that suffuses the spiritual life, and that joy is hope. Hope is not expectation, rather expectation is hope with a date put on it. No, hope is the heart's secret delight when it is informed through faith and insight that there will be a time when we shall enter into that blissful peace and contentment of *Nibbāna*. It is this hope we should savour and from that heartfelt base we should express our wisdom, little though it may be, into the world. And in this way everything we do will be perfumed with love, compassion, joy or peace.

Let's pause here for a moment.

And so the connection is made between our training here on an intensive course and our training in ordinary daily life. If in our understanding there's a hair's breadth of difference between the two, that gap is a chasm that will greatly undermine our progress. The Mahāsi Sayadaw, reinforcing the words of the Buddha, moment-to-moment mindfulness is the secret of success, points to the essence of our practice, and that practice is full-time. Six hours a day just won't do. Save for the hours of sleep, not a moment should pass when we are not making that effort to be aware, a calm, bright attentiveness. That's all we have to do to become fully awakened. It's as easy as that and as hard as that. But do we have a choice in the matter? Is there any free will to be exerc

Rebirth

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min read

In this comprehensive exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses the complex topic of rebirth in Buddhist understanding, examining what happens at death and how one's mental state determines the next rebirth. Drawing on insights from terminal illness research and the five stages of dying, he explains how the death moment (chutti) is influenced by our mental state at passing.

The talk covers the six realms of existence - hell beings, animals, hungry ghosts, humans, angry gods, and devas - both as literal destinations and as psychological states we experience in daily life. Bhante distinguishes between Hindu reincarnation (with a continuing self) and Buddhist rebirth (like billiard balls touching), emphasizing the radical transience of all phenomena.

Examining evidence for rebirth including children's memories and past-life research, he also presents alternative explanations like cryptomnesia and genetic memory. The talk addresses potential drawbacks of rebirth belief, including how it can delay liberation by encouraging ego-building "karma banking." Concluding with the Kālāma Sutta's wisdom, Bhante emphasizes that whether rebirth exists or not, the Dharma's effectiveness lies in its immediate benefits for purifying the heart and ending suffering here and now.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa three times. Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I want to try and collect my thoughts around all the problems around rebirth. What I've done is put it in question form, which are the normal questions that people ask. Then after each question, I'll make sure that everybody's got the idea.

The first one that is interesting is: what happens at death in Buddhist understanding? Actually the process - what produces your next rebirth? I'm now presuming that there is such a thing. What's going to affect your next rebirth? It's said that when you die, some image as to where you're going to go appears in the mind, and it's a product of your actions during your life. Sometimes they say it can be a strong image, an actual memory which takes you into your next life. So if you, for instance, just as you died, there came this image of you squashing a fly against the window, this may take you into the deepest hells. On the other hand, catching a fly gently with the hands and showing it the window may produce a very happy realm.

One thing that's interesting for us as Westerners is what has been studied about the process of terminal illness. There are five states that people go through, it seems. It's been well documented. The first book written on it was called *Death and Dying* by Elizabeth Kubler-Ross. Some of them you'll recognise. So when you're told, for instance, that you only have so long to live, the first thing - it's a bit of a shock, isn't it? So that's your first reaction: the shock, the horror of it. And the measure of that is the measure of our self, the measure of our ego, the measure of how attached we are to life.

Once the shock is over, we tend to go into a more hopeful state, a magic stage where we think if I do the right thing, it'll pass away. They call it bargaining. So if I eat a thousand carrots, the cancer will definitely disappear. If I pray very, very hard, God will take this disease away from me. Then you visit the doctor and he says, no, it's getting worse. You are going to die. Then the next thing is you rage: why me? I saw this lovely cartoon once - there's a woman in bed with a few friends around her, and she's saying, "Why me? Why not one of you?" And then after the anger passes, there's this coming up with the reality of it. So you can't - there's no way around it now. So it's very depressing. Life's going to come to an end. And if the person gets through that, then they come to that state of equanimity, acceptance.

Now just look at those: shock, abject fear. A weird mind state where you're trying to bargain your way out of the problem using magic, running all over the world, taking this herb, that herb. Anger because it's just not working, nobody's helping you, there's no way out of the situation, frustration. Deep depression, deep sadness. Equanimity, peace. Fear, elation, excitement, anger, depression, peace. Now, if there is a rebirth, you can see if you die in any of those states, that's the one that's going to carry you.

That's why in every religion they make this big effort when somebody's dying to get around them the images of their religion, which is going to make them peaceful, joyful, people giving them permission to go so the sadness disappears, singing hymns, being with them in the last moments - just to give them that aura of equanimity, of peace, so that they themselves can die gently, can let go. So all that the Buddhist literature would say is that the image which comes to mind as you leave the body will be determined by that state you're in. And it determines where you go. If you want a full explanation of that, you can always look up the *Comprehensive Manual of Abhidhamma* on page 124, and that will give you the details.

So that's the process - it's called the death *chutti*, the death moment when you leave the body. It is going to be determined by the state of mind you're in. In Buddhist understanding, it may not particularly be that business around the illness. It could just be some big past regret that comes up.

The next question is: what happens when you die? Here, unfortunately, the Buddhist tradition gives us an option. It depends what tradition you're in as to what's going to happen to you, it seems. The *Theravāda* understanding, and so I'm told, Zen and those Chinese forms of Buddhism simply say that you're reborn immediately into another space, another realm, another place. But the Tibetans have this idea of a *bardo*, where you stay for up to 49 days. In that state, you seem to be bombarded, or you seem to come in contact with, some forms of light, figures who emanate light, who all represent the six realms. The big one being the light of the enlightenment, of the dharmakaya, the body of the true law. And normally speaking, the person can't handle it, and they go for these softer lights for a different rebirth. And eventually they take rebirth wherever this soft light is. So the human realm, as I remember, was yellow - I'm not absolutely sure. You have to look it up. So then one goes towards that light and manifests through that light.

A more interesting explanation of *bardo*, in terms of our life here and now, is they talk about the in-between point between one thought and the next. Just catching that moment is meant to be symbolic of *bardo*. So it's that moment of that emptiness, when the mind stops. So that's what happens at death in these two major traditions.

The next one is: what are the realms of existence and how do they match what humans can experience? In other words, how they relate to us. Well, the six realms are hell, the animal realm, the hungry ghosts, the human realm, the angry gods, and the *devas*, the gods.

The hell realm, the worst of the hell realms, is reserved especially for those who've been cruel and horrible. But it really refers to, in terms of our experience, those states of mind that we ourselves would consider pretty hellish - really delusive states, schizophrenia, deep profound depression. The big thing about a hell state, when we experience it, and all of us have experienced it in some way or other, is when we're in a bad state and just for a moment, or maybe even more than a moment, we don't think there's a way out. That's hell. If you're so depressed, if you're caught in a job and you just don't see a way out - that's really the quality of hell.

The animal realm is the realm of the dull mind. So you get drunk or something like that. The problem with these two realms is that they're not very good places for enlightenment because they're too heavy. So the hell realm is obviously too painful, too deluded. And the animal realm, you don't have the intelligence. It's not possible.

The hungry ghost realm really refers to obsession, addiction, and these days we know all about them. That's really what it refers to - an addictive nature. So next time you serve yourself soup, especially when a huge desire to devour it arises, you have to warn yourself: oops, if I die now, I'll be a hungry ghost. I won't be able to leave this pot forever. No, nothing's forever.

The human realm is characterised by what we know as joy and woe - in Buddhist terms, remember, everything we say is always about the liberation, always about the enlightenment. It's characterised by joy and woe, suffering and joy. And we have this intelligence. We can make our way out of it. And that's the process - *Vipassanā* is a technique we use, or in other traditions, Dzogchen, Zen, is a technique we use to access that intelligence which is going to lead us out of this suffering. So that's specific to the human realm.

The angry gods are always fighting, always at each other. So it's obviously a place where we're angry, frustrated. And finally the *devas* is for the rich, the powerful and the famous. So you're just too happy, you just can't be bothered with practice. When you're lying on the beach in Acapulco, why bother?

So they don't particularly relate directly to these five points of terminal illness, but it shows you that there's some relationship. This isn't the fullness of it. If you look at a book called *The Psychological Attitude of Early Buddhist Philosophy* - a hell of a title - by Anagarika Govinda, the later scholastics went and divided all these realms into myriad realms depending on the particular state you were in, especially the particular absorption you were in, the particular *jhānic* state. And all these different stages, these different paths, have a particular place to go to.

I don't know whether these things exist or not. Who knows? I've got this awful feeling that they're all here. They're all here around us. Just like the human realm is a jumble of hellish people, ghostly, these hungry ghosts - they're all around us here now. I can feel them. So there we have this whole thing about the way you die, the way you're reborn. Everything that we talk about the afterlife is actually a mirror in Buddhist understanding of what you can experience in the human life.

So you can say it's just a creative imagination. You can take the position of believing it. Or you can take it that in fact it is a holographic universe. Everything is virtually the same. Everything contains everything else. This would go back to the idea of the Indra's net, where each jewel at the joining of each of these little ropes of a net mirrors the whole universe. So why should any other realm be really outside what we can experience here in this realm?

The next question is: what is the difference between rebirth and reincarnation? This whole thing is worked out in the Indian culture. You don't get much of this at all, as far as I know, in the Chinese culture. Of course, they believe in ancestors and rebirth. But in the old Confucian culture, the old ancient Chinese culture, there was obviously some idea of onward going like Christians have, but it was never worked out in any great detail.

But the main difference between reincarnation and rebirth, between the Hindu system and the Buddhist system - there's a nice image. The Hindu system would suggest a string of beads. So all the beads are different, but there's this string that goes through it, a continuity, a self that continues, which is steady throughout the whole of these little apparitions. Whereas the Buddhist idea would be more a line of billiard balls that touch each other. So they're all quite distinct. All arising dependent on conditions. Not entirely the same, not entirely different. But always arising, one after the other. So it's a radical transience.

So the Hindu idea might give you the impression of a lump of clay which you mould into a saucer, screw it up again, mould it into a cup - the same substance that's moving around. Whereas the Buddhist idea is that there is nothing that actually moves. It is more like - well, the great example is the body. The body itself completely changes every atom. Every atom is supposed to be changed within seven years. So next time you look in a mirror, just remind yourself: this face wasn't here seven years ago. So get back to reality. So that's the difference.

So the next thing is: what are the proofs for rebirth, for reincarnation? There's a man called Stevenson who's spent his whole life going around, interviewing people, finding out about their recalls and rebirths. And some of it is, in a sense, pretty convincing. Usually the most sharp ones come from children. Children suddenly around about the age of three to four or five suddenly remember things. There are stark examples where they've actually demanded to go and see their mother who lives in this next village. When they take them off, they describe everybody, and they even tell how they died. And it's pretty heady stuff.

The other one is adult past life experiences where a person remembers something that happened in a past life and they can sometimes prove it, sometimes prove that it actually happened. And the other small thing is birthmarks caused by death. Often how you died is mirrored in the next body you get. So you get moles - and the next time you look at your moles, just say: these must have been where I was stabbed in my previous

life. And birthmarks. So there are things like that which are supposed to relate. Again, proven by people with past life recall, who then said that they were shot, and there's a mole, an ugly birthmark, where the bullet went in.

The mark of a true past life experience, according to Stevenson and according to my understanding, is that the person remembers this past experience, re-experiences it as that person. So they're not this person. They're not actually this personality. It's as though for a moment you've become somebody else. And that can happen to us in a re-birth situation in this life where a childhood memory comes up as a trauma and you remember it as that child. So that's the difference. So if somebody says, "I suddenly remember being Napoleon at the Battle of Waterloo," then you can ask them: were you really Napoleon? Or just a memory?

There are other reasons as to why somebody might have past life recall. The first one, and this relates to Napoleon, is called Cryptomnesia. The biggest example that most books use is concerning a woman called Virginia Tighe. She certainly had these very vivid, clear memories of being Bridie Murphy in the south of Ireland in her past life. Described it absolutely perfectly. And from everybody's understanding - this is under hypnosis, so it wasn't something conscious - it seemed to be a real proof that past life exists. Because they went there and it was there. Everything was as she said it was.

Then through an intrepid investigator they came across a certain Bridie Murphy who actually lived opposite Virginia Tighe and told her all these stories. And they'd obviously sunk into the subconscious, had taken on emotional meanings and came up as a whole story of vivid images. So that unfortunately was the end of this amazing proof that there was a past life. And now that's given the whole thing a bad name, because now it's just Cryptomnesia - hidden forgetfulness, an unknown forgetfulness.

The other explanation from a materialist point of view, something like Dawkins, is genetic memory. So our genes not only carry just the physical nature of our bodies, but also they bring with it what Dawkins calls memes - genes and memes. So the idea is that just as you get pieces of information in your genes which make up your body, you get pieces of information which are cultural. He doesn't refer to that in the genetic structure as far as I know. It's more in the sense that that's what we do to each other. We keep giving each other these little blocks of information which we then pass on and it builds up and builds up into a culture.

The other one is just the power of retrocognition. The opposite of retrocognition is clairvoyance, where you can think - in clairvoyance, some people really do see what's going to happen. Sometimes they don't, but sometimes they really do. So this retrocog-

nitition may be real, maybe it did happen, but it's more like a mystical ability to see into the past. So there are your arguments against it. It depends where you are on the scale of things, as to which one attracts you.

The bad thing about the whole rebirth, reincarnation theory is that for the self it becomes a comforting thought. So I won't die after all. I'll keep going. Even though I might have to go through this little gate and it's painful, I will arise. And to actually turn around and just face for a moment that in fact there is no re-arising of this person, which is true - this person will not re-arise. It's a bit of a challenge. So to actually turn around and face the annihilation of this personality is a bit of a challenge. And it's sometimes easier to believe: well yes, the personality changes, but when I die, the changing will go on and I'll recognise me as I am, as I've always done.

And the other awful thing about the whole rebirth understanding is that people delay the process of their liberation, thinking: well now I'll just collect a bit of good *kamma*, build up a good bank account, and I'll die in this lovely place, and off I go. So it's like you're delaying it. And the whole idea of building up a bank account is based on a big ego. That you're going to get more and more ability to liberate yourself the more good things you do. But the very fact that you're doing good things for that ego reason undermines the whole process. In other words, you're not facing the process of liberation.

And for born Buddhists, for traditional Buddhists, most of them will delay it. It's not only the way, I would say, the vast majority of lay people - it's the way the vast majority of monks and nuns think. They're all building up good *kamma* for the next life. So these are drawbacks of the belief in rebirth.

The other thing that comes across when you talk about rebirth is: how do you square it up with evolution? Evolutionary theory. Now if you look at the Buddhist scripture, they live in this ancient time of cyclic time. And this goes back to earlier times when, if you think about it, every year was virtually the same. And you did the same thing. And the society was static. For as long as you can remember and for as far as you can see, people will be doing the same thing over and over again. There was no idea of progress at all. Progress as such didn't really come into the Western mind - and it's a modern idea - until fairly recently, although it was started off by this cleric somewhere around the 12th century, if I remember rightly, who, having now been 12 centuries since the birth of Christ and he hadn't returned, began to say that the time before Christ's birth was the time of the Father. The time we're going through now is the time of Christ. And we're leading up to the time of the Spirit, when all will be resurrected.

So this idea of actually going somewhere, of an aim, of an end to life, suddenly appears before us as an evolutionary process. This was reinforced by Darwin and all that we know these days. Although they say you can pick holes in the theory, I don't know enough about it to give you that. The fact is it's pretty convincing stuff that there's a process of evolution going on.

Whereas if you read the scriptures, what you get is the name of the past 28 Buddhas. And every Buddha has a Pali name, they have two main disciples, they go through this and it's this repetition, repetition. If you lived in those times and all you thought - considering you were, say, a farmer, working with your ox on a field day after day, no TV, no holidays, except in winter when it's dry season. You go through this, and then you have these horrible old days because there's no medicine, and there may be some palliatives for pain, and people have died, their teeth are falling out. And leprosy. And the whole thing is there. When you're going to die, you think: I don't want to come back here.

So this idea of being reborn was really quite the big thing in the Buddha's time. Everybody wanted the end of rebirth. They wanted not to be brought back as a human being, to be born into a god realm, not to fall down from the gods to be a human being. And it was pretty obsessive. And it actually ends up in the three great insights of the Buddha's enlightenment. That's where it's put. It's called the *Te Vidyā*, the three knowledges.

The first knowledge is that he sees that the process of his rebirth has been very much according to his moral life. So whereas before the Buddha, the idea was that it was more a chaotic reason - you just got reborn. The only way you could get out of this rebirth was through ritual, through appeasing the gods. There wasn't a close relationship with rebirth and your moral life, your ethical life. So this was an insight into the fact that it's our morality - morality here means what is skillful. It's not just to do with killing and whatnot. It's to do with all that stuff around neurotic patterns. It's the purification of the heart.

And then through his vision, he saw that this was true of all beings. So what was a personal law became a cosmic law. And the third understanding was that he'd actually completely purified his heart. Now, to be an *arahat*, to be a fully enlightened being, it's the third one you have to do. You don't have to have these other insights. So there's a small suggestion that these crept in as part of the whole teaching around *kamma*. Part of the whole teaching around how we create *kamma*, the process of *kamma*, how it's guided by what is skillful and unskillful.

In terms of these days, does rebirth make sense? Well, I suppose if you think of it as an evolutionary process, that you're actually moving towards a liberated consciousness, a liberated *chitta*, then it is some sort of an evolutionary process. It still seems to work. It's the evolution of consciousness.

The other thing that comes across is the question about seeming inequality. People seem to die who've been absolute villains and they seem to die in bed and fairly happy. And others who've been wonderful and good end up on the gibbet and get themselves hanged. How does that work? Well, there are all sorts of ways of trying to explain that. But one thing you have to understand about *kamma* is that our moral life is only to do with our internal, our interior life. Of course it affects others. If I'm into stealing, that's going to affect people. If I'm into good works, it's going to affect people. But morality, my ethical life, has a direct effect upon my inner life and eventually should clear it up, should move it towards a purification.

But things that happen to me on the outside are coming from other sources. It might be that I steal something and I get caught and put in jail. So that's a fairly straightforward sequence of events that I can understand. It may be that I do some little good for somebody and they turn out to be a billionaire and they give me a million pounds. But unfortunately, suddenly you win the lottery. Suddenly you find yourself caught up in a terrorist ordeal. All these people getting kidnapped in Iraq.

So obviously we live in a fairly chaotic universe in the sense that we don't know what's going to happen to us. Because there are various forces. There is the force of nature. There's the force of other people's decision-making and actions towards us. So you have to take all that into account when you think about: well, why did that happen to that person? Why did they die in this way? Because we're not in control of the situation we're in.

But one little example that I like to give around that is that in one of the great earthquakes, I think it was in Mexico, they found this mother and her child after something like 10 days trapped just between two blocks. And the mother had, over the period of 10 days, constantly cut her fingers in order to feed the child her blood. So presumably they were fairly comfortable down there for the time being. But it's like, she didn't freak out.

Finally, I suppose, a big question: is the concept of rebirth necessary to become enlightened or to get the best out of the Buddha Dhamma? And I think you'll find amongst Western people, Western scholars and Western Buddhists - and if you look up the Journal of Buddhist Ethics on the web, you'll get some very good essays about it - the

general opinion is that you don't need to believe it at all. The *Dhamma* itself either works now or it doesn't work at all. One sees the benefit now, here and now, *sandiṭṭhiko*, here and now, or what's the point of it?

And worries about whether there is a future life or not really don't pertain to the direct practice. So the wheel of dependent origination, which is this whole process of mentation, which brings about the purification, or which upon seeing of it - the seeing of it, seeing how we cause ourselves suffering - is the process of liberation, is happening right here and now. So the escape is here and now from that. So it's not actually necessary for the *Dhamma* to work.

And just to leave you with one little understanding that the Buddha gives in this Kālāma Sutta, which is a discourse where he really talks about freedom of thought, he says: well, if you live with the idea that there will be a rebirth and that your good actions here and now will produce a better life, if there is rebirth, all well and good. If there isn't rebirth, all well and good. In other words, the reason for our practice has nothing to do with whether there's rebirth or not.

So, in terms of your practice now, here, at Gaia House, this whole talk has been a waste of time. Because it's irrelevant. But it's a pleasant three-quarters of an hour. I think that's about it.

The Illimitables

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min read

In this comprehensive evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the four brahmavihāra or 'illimitables' - mettā (goodwill), karuṇā (compassion), muditā (sympathetic joy), and upekkhā (equanimity). He explains how these heart practices complement vipassanā meditation, creating a balanced approach to spiritual development that includes both purification through insight and cultivation of positive mental qualities.

The talk examines each brahmavihāra in detail, identifying both the 'near enemy' (obvious opposite) and 'far enemy' (subtle corruption) of each quality. For mettā, he distinguishes between genuine goodwill and attachment-based love, emphasizing how true love must be non-dependent on its object. He addresses the difference between compassion and pity, sympathetic joy versus attachment to others' happiness, and equanimity as balanced awareness rather than detached indifference.

Bhante Bodhidhamma emphasizes the practical importance of right intention in all actions, explaining how conditioning patterns (anusaya) can be transformed through skillful awareness rather than suppression. He discusses the role of responsibility versus culpability in spiritual development, and how these heart qualities can be developed illimitably - both horizontally (toward all beings) and vertically (in depth of cultivation). The talk offers practical guidance for integrating these qualities into daily life while maintaining the clarity of vipassanā awareness.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

You can see how that exercise we've just done, loving kindness, *mettā*, it's normally put under this word *mettā*, but goodwill, developing goodwill, I prefer that to loving kindness. It sounds a bit mawkish to me. And you can see how it complements the *vipassanā*, I hope.

There's one side of our practice which is to do with purifying, the purgatory. And that includes also this insight, these insights into how we're creating suffering for ourselves. And that goes deep, remember. And on the other side, there's developing the

heart, developing the heart of goodwill. And these are expressed as the illimitables, the four illimitables: love, compassion, joy, peace. And they're illimitable in what you might say is a horizontal and a vertical sense.

Horizontally, they're meant to be innumerable beings. So there's no limit to the amount of beings that you can offer your goodwill to. Illimitable. We don't say infinite. And vertically, there's no end to the depth that you can develop that attitude. It's indefinite. You can keep on developing love until you become this enormous film star charismatic. People hang on to your every word and want to be hugged. And it's the same force that you'll see this afternoon that can be used to heal because it's also a very strong relationship to the body. Just remember that the mental force and the physical force, mental and physical energy in Buddhism is just a continuum. It's not as though they're completely separate. The one saturates the other. The mind saturates the body.

When it comes to the first one, love, the commentaries always talk about a near and a far enemy. An obvious one and a subtle one, that's what it means. So the obvious enemy of love is hate. That's pretty straightforward. You can't hate and love at the same time. Not exactly at the same time. You can hate somebody and love them in a sequence. You can't do it exactly at the same time. And hate of course closes the heart, it shuts it off. And remember, hatred and fear are flip sides. So it's said, I don't know how true this is, but the paranoid is afraid because they project their hatred into the other person's eyes.

That's what we do often, isn't it? You might see a friend walking down the other side of the road and they don't acknowledge you. So you go away thinking I've said something wrong or they hate me now. But actually they just didn't notice you. So we undermine that hate by again allowing it to arise. Remember you can't kill a conditioning. You've really got to really accept that. You can't kill, you can't annihilate a conditioning. If there's hatred in the heart there's only one way it's going to be cured and that is to allow it to express itself and you have to be very careful not to fall into the fantasies.

Even when we do it unwittingly there's a little development there. You've all had the experience of being slightly annoyed with somebody in the morning. They've said something at work or something. And quite unmindfully you've allowed this to generate a little story. And it gets worse and worse and by the evening you've strangled them and written poison letters and all that. And that's what the mind does. It'll generate, it'll proliferate. So stopping that, recognizing that, and just staying with the pain, staying with the hurt, you see, you're allowing it to die out. So that's what you've got to really grasp if we want to come to the end of hatred.

And remember that all these negative things are not dependent on an object. A disposition is not dependent on an object. The object is the button which when pressed allows this disposition to manifest. So the Buddha talks about two things, he talks about *anusaya* and *kilesa*. *Anusaya* is latent tendencies, latent tendencies. The fact is we don't know how much hatred we've got in the system. We don't know how much fear there is. That's just a fact, it's buried within the psyche somewhere, it's buried in the body. And suddenly when something happens, this hatred comes out, this fear comes out. And often it's entirely inappropriate to the situation, isn't it?

Road rage, for instance. It might be that just on this occasion somebody cut you up. And suddenly you're full of this rage. You see, if they'd have done it and your business was good and you had a happy relationship, you'd just swear a bit. But because you're in a bad mood, this rage comes out and you go out and stab them. It happens, doesn't it? It's terrible. Computer rage. How many of you have smashed up your computer? Totally inappropriate response. And sometimes we can get this inappropriate response, especially with objects or people whom, of course, we feel can't come back at us. The child. The dog. They can't bite you back, so there's permission to let go of it.

So what we have is this disposition and I liken it to a balloon and it's being held there with just this membrane being held there. Something happens and it's just that little pinprick and all of it tries to get out through that little hole. So this disposition, all the anger we have and the anxiety and all that, it's all there as a programming. It's a good way to really see it. It's just there as a latent programming. And you don't know how big it is until something allows it to manifest. And then it becomes this obvious thing, and that's what the Buddha refers to as a *kilesa*. I can't remember how they translate that now. Can you? *Kilesa*? Neurosis, that'll do.

So that's part of our practice is to know what to do when something negative arises. That's part of our practice. And the real insight in this is to know that you can't do anything about this stuff except to allow it to burn out. And that's it. So in the scriptures the Buddha always talks about going from hatred to non-hatred, cruelty to non-cruelty, see this neutral state. Then there's the transformation. It's all the same energy, remember? So that which we hated, through the practice, through a generous practice, through these sorts of meditations like *mettā*, become transformed. So the amount of hate we had eventually turns out to be the amount of love we have. And then of course we can develop love. So nothing is wasted in the universe. Nothing is wasted in the heart anyway. Everything eventually through this sort of practice becomes transformed. And you end up with the Buddha heart, the Buddha mind.

Now the subtle enemy of love, of course, is attachment. And that's a difficult one. Because we have all sorts of attachments. Romantic attachments, erotic attachments, attachments to parents, attachments to their children, attachments to friends, attachments to cars. God, there's all sorts of attachments. And that attachment turns the person whom you love into an object. That's what you're doing. Because what an attachment does is it is seeking from that person that which I need to be happy. That's what an attachment does.

So when we have an attachment to something, I only want from that person what makes me happy. As soon as they do something which doesn't come into that little circle of what I like and want, then I get that rejection, I get the hatred, I get the pushing away. So that isn't love. Now, you have to be very careful here. Not to think that therefore this is somehow immoral. You can't say that a parent's attachment to their child is immoral. But it's not skillful. That's all. It's just not skillful.

So we see it in things like when a child gets hurt, you see. If a child is hurt and the parent sees that it's just a scratch or something, then of course they have this comfort, hugging, all that, it'll be alright, etc., etc. But if the parent sees that the child is really hurt, then there comes this enormous fear. And that doesn't help the situation, does it? So that's a real subtle one, that. You have to really work with it. And again, you can't kill the attachment. You can't get rid of it. You can't pretend it isn't there and develop this open-heartedness. It's just the gentle working with it.

Now, in the discourse on that loving-kindness that I chant, the Buddha likens love to a mother. And he says that, are these four illimitables to a mother? So, with the youngest child, I think it's in this sequence, can't be exact. With the youngest child, she's a friend. A friendly relationship. With the child who's sick, she's compassionate, looks after the child. With the child who's successful, she's full of sympathetic joy. And with the child that leaves home, she's equanimous. Being able to let somebody go. So that's the sign of a detached love. Because what you're saying to the person is, you're utterly free to be as you are. You're utterly free to be as you are. I don't need you.

So we think that part of our love contract is need. But that need is neurotic. That need is coming because we're not looking into ourselves for the fullness. So that's why the Buddha says the spiritual person, seek solitude. Be as lonely as a rhinoceros. I don't know anything about rhinoceros, but whatever the habits of a rhinoceros are, they're definitely to be alone. And that distinction between being alone, being solitudinous, and loneliness. See, you know the difference, eh? See, when you're lonely, there's that hole. You want somebody to fill it. So you go and get this person and fill it. There's your attachment. You call it love.

But actually, when that loneliness comes, we should seek that solitude. We should stay by ourselves. And instead of calling up that friend, turning on the TV, making a cup of tea, we should do the *vipassanā*. We should stay with that sense of loneliness. As that begins to dissipate, what comes in its stead? We have love to hatred, cruelty to compassion. Loneliness to what? To solitude. Solitude is being at peace, at one with oneself. Occasionally you feel it. But these things have to be developed.

And you have to not be confused by those things that are negative in us. They'll always give you a good excuse. You might not, for instance, recognize the loneliness. You say to yourself, ah, Mary, yeah, I'll give her a ring. I'm sure she'd like to hear from me. You displace it onto this poor person. And in fact, you haven't recognized, you haven't locked into your own sense of loneliness.

So all you can do is, and this is the whole point of *vipassanā*, is to lift that awareness, that intelligence, so that during the day one is with the mind, one is with the heart, one doesn't get caught up in it. That's the whole point of developing the *vipassanā* mind. During the day you see, ah, lonely, you see. Then you see that desire to seek this, seek that. You just stay still, wait for it to pass. And eventually, you develop a love which is non-attached.

What does that mean? Does it mean that sometimes there's a detached love? It sounds cold, it sounds horrible, detached love. But all it means is a love which is not dependent on the object. So it doesn't matter who stands before me, they get the same treatment. They get the same generosity, open-heartedness, etc. Now I'm not talking personally, understand me, but that's what we're trying to develop we're trying to develop that open hearted love not dependent on the object.

When it comes to compassion you can see the same thing. The obvious enemy of compassion, of course, is cruelty. It's completely the opposite. Compassion is a desire, this is how it's stated, is a desire to alleviate somebody's suffering. It's as simple as that. You want to help somebody who's in some sort of pain or suffering. Cruelty is the opposite. You want to enjoy it. The worst hell in Buddhism is reserved to those who are cruel, because it's obviously the complete opposite of the Buddhist teaching. I mean, here it is going around telling everybody how to alleviate suffering, and there are people going around purposely trying to make people suffer. In Buddhist understanding, there's nothing worse.

So again, when we feel that cruelty, that very subtle desire to put somebody down, slander them, stand on their toe when they're not looking, things like that, give them a push. When you feel that, when you don't like somebody and you hear that they've got a serious illness and you can hear yourself saying, good. There are all these little cruel-

ties stuck inside us, you see. So one mustn't feel guilty about that. See, that's something else. We're not supposed to feel guilty about conditioning. Conditionings that we end up with are being manufactured, rather, out of ignorance, out of delusion.

So now we're coming out of that. We're coming to a point of wisdom where we recognize, that wasn't very nice. One doesn't blame oneself. One just recognizes, that's a conditioning I don't want to develop. It's as simple as that. I just don't want to develop that conditioning anymore. So we know that conditioning will come up again and will fall again. But our attitude now is we don't want to develop it anymore. So we get more skillful. We don't feed it anymore. And eventually it dies away. Or at least it doesn't hijack us. That's what we don't want.

Guilt and shame in Buddhism, the Buddha calls them the two guardians of society. But he's not referring here to the guilt we feel when we do something wrong, the dread of consequences. And he's not referring to the shame we feel when there's a gaffe, a social gaffe or something, or we hurt somebody. He's not talking about the consequence of unskillful action. He's talking about that little memory, that little warning that comes up when we are tempted to fiddle the taxes, which is highly topical, when we're tempted, as soon as the temptation comes, you see, the fear of consequence arises, just as a memory, the shame, you see, and immediately they guard us from doing that.

If that's not internalized, that's not internalized, well, that's a psychopath, isn't it? A psychopath has no sense, a sociopath, they've no sense of right and wrong. You see these kids, no sense of right and wrong. No sense of shame. There was that incredible thing I heard on the radio or television, I can't remember, where that little black boy was killed in London. Damilola Taylor, that's right. And they interviewed all the young people, the police interviewed. And one of the young kids, we're talking 10, 12 years old, so the policeman's asking this question, and he nuts him, broke his nose. It's amazing, isn't it? It wasn't within my generation to do that. There's just absolutely no fear of consequence. It can't be touched. And it just produces anarchy, doesn't it? It produces terrible stuff.

So those two things, fear of consequence, I'm not talking about now the guilt which arises from a feeling of being evil. That's something else. That's a sort of existential guilt, you might say. That goes deeper in a definition of self. I am evil. So when that comes up, just note it and let it pass. No, I'm just talking about those feelings of dread, like you didn't, you shouldn't have done that, something's going to happen at work, that sort of thing. And they become your guardians, see? So that's a sensitivity.

So cruelty is the opposite of compassion. The subtle enemy is grief. Grief. It's interesting, isn't it? Grief. Subtle enemy is grief. So often people grieve for somebody, pity, pity their state. So what's that? What's happening there when you do that? Where's that coming from? I mean, the desire, if somebody's sick or somebody, whatever, and you want to help them, the desire should be a joyful desire, a desire to help, a desire to help them in their situation, lend them some money, whatever. But if you slip into pity, pity them, what's happening there, you see?

Can you agree with some of these thoughts? I mean, you haven't said anything. Well, the question is, is it necessary? I mean, we do it. We do it, but does it help? Does it help to pity somebody? I mean, how do we feel when somebody pities us? It's coming from a conceit, isn't it? It's coming from some place, almost, I always feel it's coming from some place of displaced fear, actually, and anxiety might happen to me. And it gets in the way, of course, because then you overdo. You overdo. You get into that do-gooder thing. Because you're compensating. Oh, let me help you. Let me help you. Go away.

And the other subtle one of compassionate action is that when we do something out of compassion, when we help somebody, we do get a pleasant feeling. But when we make that pleasant feeling the purpose for doing, then of course we end up as a real do-gooder then. So I always think, supposing now you went along to your friend and said, you heard they were sick. So you said, you go along and help them. I'll come over and help you. So you go over there with this idea of cooking them chicken soup or something. When you get there, they say, can you clean the toilet? I didn't come here to do that. See what I mean?

Whenever we're acting out of compassion and very subtly we're doing it in order to feel happy, we don't want to do what another person wants us to do. We want to do what I want to do for you. That's really oppressive. So again, you can't kill that conditioning. You've really got to accept that that's the way it is, that's the conditioning arising. And then, having acknowledged that, you may be doing it in order to feel happy. You see, you just acknowledge it, it's there within the heart. But there's also the true compassionate desire to alleviate somebody's suffering. So you make that your conscious desire. And the conscious desire that you empower is your new conditioning. So the more you empower a positive thought to help somebody in whatever way they want to be helped. See, that is developing the upper part of the egg, that's developing the compassion. It doesn't mean to say that there won't be all that disgust coming up, fancy asking me to clean the toilet, all that. So that still comes up, but it's an afterthought, it's a leftover. One hasn't empowered that.

So it's the same with generosity. When we give something, a present or a donation or whatever, you see, as you give, there may be some feeling of goodness about it for the benefit of others. So you might be doing it for that reason. You might be doing it for guilt, I've got too much money. Not too many of those, but... But what you do is, before you give, before you actually commit the action, you have to suffuse your heart and mind with the right intention. So I'm giving this for the benefit of others. And when it's there, there's a real purposeful giving. That's when you give. As soon as you act, that's your *kamma*, that's your action, that's your conditioning.

So there's an intention, there's an action, and those actions produce a conditioning, which grow depending on how you keep on supporting that intention. So there you are, and you've given, and you've said, I give for the benefit of others. Really suffuse that and you give it, you see. And you hear this little voice, you see. You are so wonderful. Now you see, that's old conditioning. That's coming up from the old thing about wanting to be somebody's pet, wanting to be somebody's friend. So you just recognize that. That's the old conditioning. You haven't empowered that. And eventually that would die away.

Or you might get the other side, Too much, get some back. So you just let it go, pass away. If you feel guilty about that, you know the guilt, because it's inappropriate. He didn't mean, that wasn't what was empowered, that's just an old conditioning coming through. So again, you can see the purpose of mindfulness. You don't just give. So you have to stop for a minute and really get your heart right. You don't just go out and do good. You really get your heart right.

When somebody says, can you help me? You don't say yes. A lot of us suffer from that, don't we? I mean, I do. Can you do yes? And then you think, I don't want to do that. If you just stop a minute, you see. There's all these little tricks of language. Well, I might be busy. I'll have to look that up in my diary. And then so long as you've got the good reason for doing it, then you do it. If you don't want to do it, you shouldn't feel guilty about that. If you feel guilty about that, then one should note that, one should see, ah, guilt. Feel it, allow it to pass away.

So you can see that this, what we're doing here as a sitting practice, is specifically important every day, every moment of our lives, to keep that awareness going, so that when you're talking to somebody, there is that more spacious awareness, that you're aware of what they're saying, but you're also aware of your reaction here. Not to always be going outward. A balanced awareness. Even now as you're listening to me you can be aware.

Joy. The enemy of joy is jealousy. Envy. It really cuts through, doesn't it? You can't feel joyful for somebody if you're jealous of them. So when jealousy comes up, and it's one of those things that we never, we don't like to acknowledge about ourselves at all, the fact that we're envious or jealous, because what it's suggesting is that somebody's better than us. Nobody wants to believe that. And I just make an arbitrary distinction between envy and jealousy all over it. Maybe it's not quite like that. But envy is wanting what they have and jealousy is wanting what they have and hating them for having it. Which is an added twist.

So again, all you can do is accept that that's there and let it burn, pass away. And of course the joy that comes up is then that much more joyful. You can feel great joy, can't you, for people whom you love. That's not a problem. Parent for their children, it comes naturally. Sympathetic joy, reciprocal joy. And the subtle thing is again that attachment. Wanting to be joyful in order to feel always joyful. So you're not joyful for somebody, you're only joyful for them because it makes you joyful. So again, you're turning that person into an object and you want them to do things that are joyful for you. So again, you make people do things that make you happy.

I mean, that's also a parental thing sometimes, isn't it? The parent wants the child to be in a way that they foresee would be good for the child, which would make them feel happy about their child, getting a degree and stuff like that. Pushing them. And it's done under the guise of it's good for you. But often it's this business of, I want to feel happy about you. But that's not a sympathetic joy. Not reciprocal joy.

And that's something you can develop, you know. You can develop joy every time you hear of somebody who has won the lottery and stuff like that. To say to yourself, how wonderful. May they be happy. The person who got the job that you wanted, may they be happy.

And then finally there's equanimity. So now equanimity is a funny one. It's a funny word, equanimity. It's balance of mind. A balance of mind. So you expect a judge to be equanimous. No matter what the emotional state is in the court, you expect them to be above it. You expect them not to get caught up in that. Not to be judgmental.

So obviously there's your main enemy. Be judgmental, to lose that balance of mind, to take sides. You lose it. And the subtle enemy is just again seeking to be calm for calm's sake. See, as soon as you make these virtues their purpose, it immediately corrupts it. If you want to be generous to get the joy of generosity, then it corrupts your generosity, because often you're asked to be generous with exactly that which you don't want to give.

Some people are very generous with their time, others with their money, some with neither. It's just a fact. So some people might be very generous with their time, but if you ask them for a penny for a cup of tea, they don't want to see you. And that's them drawing a circle around their idea of generosity. So as soon as you start practicing a virtue for the virtue's sake, then you'll find yourself in this, you'll find yourself drawing a line, you'll find yourself being unable to develop it illimitably. Illimitably.

So that, these are the four principles. Illimitables. And you can see that their development is equally important to developing this *vipassanā*, this insight. Yeah? Any questions about that? Anything that's come up about that? Clarifications? Observations? Criticism?

What did you say earlier in the interview? Doing it for itself. Yeah, always making it its own object. To be joyful in order to be joyful.

It took me a second when you were referring back, when you were saying about, guys are in the basement. It took me two seconds to say, who's putting up on you? In this case, it was the kid. But in relation to the last one, equanimity, which you were saying there, and you've made an earlier reference to kids, or these young people, and... It sort of came across to me that it was a general criticism of people who would be in a certain condition and would only know how to react one way.

Oh, yeah. Oh, no, that's presumed. They've not been taught. They're in a vicious circle. Family and social circumstance, definitely. But they, you see, these children, if they move into the spiritual life, they can't blame. They can't put blame on that social circumstance and parents and all that. So this is the point. If you keep doing that, then you're unable to come out of the vicious circle within yourself, because you presume that this conditioning has been caused by others, whereas what we've discovered is that it's actually produced by ourselves.

Now, you've got to make a distinction between responsibility and culpability. You're not to be blamed because we've ended up with cruelty in our hearts, but we are responsible for it. That's a subtle difference. In other words, unwittingly, at an early age, because of circumstances, I have created within myself a lot of cruelty. Now, I can't be blamed for that because at that time I was unaware, deluded. Now I end up, through the meditation, all through ordinary life, realizing how much cruelty is in my system. So it's my responsibility now to get rid of it. See? That's a relief, isn't it, when we think like that?

We're not looking to blame anybody or to put the finger on somebody. All we've done is that we've ended up with this personality, with this conditioning. And now that we've woken up to it, the job is to clear it out. And here's a system that can help. If we start blaming or looking for somebody to blame, then that creates another negativity in the heart, doesn't it? Revenge and all that. Yes, sure.

So it is in the nature of the being then that we have a constant battle, even if we go to a certain level of cruelty and compassion and try and keep on moving forward. Is it a part of being human?

Well, you see, at some point in existence, as consciousness grows, we simply make this mistake of thinking that this is what we are. That's the big problem. So therefore, you get into this contradiction with the world. The contradiction is, this is me, and I want to be happy, so I'll accumulate around me things that make me happy. And that moves to greed, it moves to crime, etc., etc., yeah? Anything that touches me, which makes me feel unhappy, then I want to push away. So it moves to hatred, cruelty, all that. So I'm caught in that contradiction all the time. I'm always in a state of contradiction.

And the only way I can overcome that is by seeing that contradiction and stop playing that game. So the image I have is of a triangle. So the bottom part of the triangle is this aversion, accumulation, aversion, greed. And we're constantly running up and down this base of a triangle, completely caught up in it. When we lift ourselves up out of that in meditation, we're at the apex of a triangle. We can see this game. So that's why I say in that exercise on forgiving somebody, you bring up the memory and you can see how you want to get your own back. You don't want to forgive them. You can see that. And that's the game of the base of the triangle. When you stand up at the top and you just watch this game, because you're not in it, you're not empowering it. So it has to die away.

And that's the role of will in Buddhism. The will is what empowers the game. So as soon as you withdraw your attention from it, withdraw your awareness from that level, that's a level of self. And you come to the level of observing that, then of course you've withdrawn the energy from it. So it goes on and on, but eventually it dies away.

But that's a very important distinction to make between responsibility and blame, and blaming somebody. And remember that in Buddhist understanding, nobody eventually escapes their problems. So if somebody's being cruel, they themselves will suffer the consequence of that. So the idea of punishment is untenable in Buddhism. That

doesn't mean to say you can't put somebody away if they're a danger or put them somewhere they can be re-educated or something. But you can't have the attitude of punishing them. It's a form of revenge.

Which doesn't mean to say that in Buddhist countries people don't punish each other. But it's untenable. Because it's just understood. As soon as somebody does harm, they will suffer the consequence of that. And that's what we're doing. Every time you sit, I mean, all that restlessness and all that stuff, what is it? Where's that coming from? Some of it's coming from deluded decisions at a time when we weren't aware. But some of them are coming from active wrongdoing. Yeah?

When is it appropriate to intervene in a situation which is really not in your business, even though it's obviously obvious?

Yeah, there was... This comes up, I had with a friend of mine out in Thailand and he had this idea of detachment. He was developing detachment. So when he saw a cat playing around with a mouse, he didn't do anything. He was completely detached. Whereas I've seen also in monasteries where a cat has got hold of a bird, the monk has run out and given the cat a kick. And then just held the bird up. It was actually quite beautiful. The bird had been killed. Its lungs had been punctured. And he just held it up, with its wings. All compounded things arise and pass away.

I should think those decisions really, it's up to a person's own sensitivity to that, whether they're open to advice. Sometimes you give advice or you want to help, but actually you're making things worse because they don't want to know. But our attitude should be, of course, yes, to undermine suffering wherever we see it. I mean, this is what's come up with all this business of these wars on terrorists, the massacre in Rwanda, for instance. If we'd have been a more advanced international society, we probably wouldn't have let that happen. Just got in there and pulled them apart.

Yeah, sometimes it's wise not to say anything, huh? Time, place and suitability. Right speech, the Buddha says. When you want to say something, make sure it's suitable. Make sure it's the right time and the right place.

The Ten Fetters

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 11 min read

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the ten saṁyojana (fetters) that bind beings to the cycle of saṁsāra and their progressive elimination through the four stages of noble attainment. He begins by outlining the four paths and fruits: Sotāpanna (Stream-entrant), Sakadāgāmi (Once-returner), Anāgāmi (Non-returner), and Arahant (Fully Awakened being), using vivid imagery from lightning flashes to noonday sun to illustrate deepening insight.

The talk explores how understanding the three characteristics of existence—anicca (impermanence), dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness), and anattā (not-self)—leads to the dropping away of specific fetters at each stage. The first three fetters eliminated by the Stream-entrant are sakkāyadiṭṭhi (belief in self), vicikicchā (doubt in the Dharma), and sīlabbataparāmāsa (attachment to rites and rituals). Bhante explains how the Once-returner additionally weakens kāmarāga (sensual desire) and vyāpāda (aversion), while the Non-returner completely eliminates these.

The remaining five fetters—attachment to form and formless realms, conceit, restlessness, and ignorance—persist until full Awakening. Throughout, Bhante emphasizes that Nibbāna is fundamentally about 'unbinding' and that meditation practice, rather than ritual observance, is the direct path to liberation. This teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical encouragement for serious practitioners committed to the path of insight meditation.

What are the ten fetters? To understand the ten fetters you've got to have understood or know about the different paths and fruits. The way the Buddha said that people develop spiritually, there are four levels of deep insight, four levels of consciousness, meaning four levels in a change in the way we see things. According to his understanding, when we begin to see things through the three characteristics of existence, when we see things are transient, when we see things are not substantial, not self, and when we see how we cause ourselves suffering by having a wrong relationship of indulging in pleasure and running away from pain, when we see that, then there's a shift in the way that we relate to the world. And these three shifts are called the *magga phala*, path and fruit.

The first one is called *sotāpanna*, which means stream entrance. The second one is known as *sakadāgāmi*, once returner. The third one is *anāgāmi*, a non-returner. And finally there's *arahant*, a fully enlightened being.

The Buddha gives us some images to work with. He says that when somebody has the first insight into *Nibbāna*, the stream entrant, the one who enters into the spiritual stream and is coming out of *saṃsāra*, they've found the way out basically. When you have the first insight, it's like a flash of lightning. The flash of lightning means that you see everything but you've only seen it for a moment. So you actually know what the truth is, what *Nibbāna* is, but it's just been that very sharp insight.

The second one, the once-returner, is the one who sees things in a full starry night. The non-returner sees things, he says, as if it's a full moon. Even here the full moon can be bright, but those of you who've been to the East know that you can really see colours. It's very bright. But you don't get to see things like the noonday sun until you're fully enlightened.

There's also a teaching about what happens to a person and how long the training is after they've had these insights. A *sotāpanna*, a stream entrant, is said to have to come back as a human being seven times before they get out of the problem. A once returner is exactly that, comes back once. And the non-returner is someone who achieves that third level here, but doesn't have to come back to this realm of existence and works out the rest of their problems in a much better place. So those are your four levels of noble insight.

I'll give you one more image that he talks about which is rather interesting. He says that people who don't know the Dhamma, who are stuck in delusion, are like people who are swimming underwater and have no clue where they're going. The trainee is someone who keeps bobbing up and just getting their head above water so they've got some idea as to where they might be going. The *sotāpanna*, the stream entrant, is one who's treading water. That's rather interesting. Treading water. The *sakadāgāmi* is swimming, hell-bent for the shore. The *anāgāmi*, the non-returner, is actually standing on the shore, on the shoreline. And the *arahant* has found his seat on the island. That's another little image that he tells us.

There's another one which comes from the general tradition of spirituality about the mountain. If you think about it, the higher you go, the more you see. But you don't get to see the full thing until you get to the top. You never get to see what's on the other side of the mountain until you're at the top. So something happens at the state of full enlightenment which is obviously quite a quantum leap. And that's the suggestion between a full moon and the noonday sun.

So what is it that these people see to make them ennobled? They have insights into these three characteristics. The more you see transience, the more you see impermanence, then the less attached you are, the less suffering there is. The more you see how

the psychology of seeking happiness in this world, real happiness, leads only to dissatisfaction, then, of course, you come off that drug. You come off the addiction of sensual pleasure. Stop running away from just the pain of living – sickness, old age and death. And the more you see that this body, this personality, is not me. It's not a me. It's not a person. It's just a conditioned state. It's just an energy form.

Looking at those flowers we know that matter itself is just energy. It's just a swirl of subatomic activity. They don't even talk about atoms these days, they just talk about energy forms. So that even though at our level of perception they are real things – they're real colour and they've got a feel about them – when you drop down to a deeper reality about the way the material world is, then all that disappears. It's just a fuzz of energy. So it's the same with this body. It feels real enough when you get your finger trapped in the door. And the same with the personality. It feels real enough when you're depressed or when you're happy. But it's just energy.

Now, there are two parts to becoming one of these noble people. The first part is called *magga* and the second part is called *phala*. *Magga* is entering into it. So the insight is what makes you enter into that level of consciousness. But the fruit of it is the falling away of fetters. Falling away of the fetters. And *samyojana*, which is the word that fetter is describing, we get the word yoke from it, yoga, yoja, that which binds, that which holds. And *sam* is just a strengthener. So it's something that really binds you. And there are ten of these. And as you go up the different paths, the fetters drop away. And the definition of *nibbāna* is unbinding. Unbinding. It's a process of unbinding.

So what are the fetters? The first one is *sakkāyadiṭṭhi*. It's the belief in the body or the personality as me and mine. So there's something about an experience of *anicca dukkha anattā*, transience, suffering or dissatisfaction and not-self, which allows that person to see that they are not this body, they are not this personality, they're not emotions, they're not thoughts. So they've experienced something beyond that, beyond something phenomenal. So that goes, but don't think that it's thereby entirely destroyed. What's happened is that the belief in it has gone.

I liken it to the leaving of mother. Some psychologists say up until about the fourth month there's no differentiation between the baby and mother, it's all one thing. In fact there's a baby in the world, but specifically a baby and mother, and then suddenly or at some point mother becomes other. It looms out of this me as something other than me. And that's your first what's known as object relations. So that's the first leave-taking. Now how long it takes to get rid of mother? My God. Our binding to our mother is very deep. So letting go of this body, letting go of this mind, letting go of these emotions is a very long process of leave-taking. But what the *sotāpanna* has seen, at least, is that they

are not that. That's a very important little insight. We get hints of that when, in our meditation, we experience an emotion as something objective within us. When you become the observer and you feel you're looking at an emotion, experiencing an emotion as if it's not me, not mine. So that's the *sakkāyadiṭṭhi*, that's destroying or taking away the fundamental belief that this personality, this body is me. That's the first thing that goes.

The next one is *vicikicchā*, doubt. Obviously, if someone has experienced the ultimate truth, *Nibbāna*, then obviously all doubt in the Buddha's teaching goes, because now they know for themselves by their own personal experience. And having done so, they also know the way. I liken it to somebody wandering around in a swamp and suddenly through the trees through the swamp they see the top of the mountain. Now they've still got a load of swamp to go through but at least they know where they're going and there's no doubt that there is a mountain and there's no doubt that there's a way out of this problem. So doubt in the Buddha's teaching disappears.

The third one is rather interesting. *Sīlabbataparāmāsa*. It's the recognition of wrong rites and rituals. It's understanding that the path to become enlightened has virtually nothing to do with rites and rituals. No matter how many times you bow to the Buddha, light candles, repeat your Om Mani Padme Hums. Nothing to do with it. If we could just hold the line of pure meditation that's enough.

There's an interesting scripture where some young monks go to the elders and they say how did you become enlightened, and the split even then is between those monks and nuns who like to live completely by themselves in the forest and those who were much more into towns and the study and all that, remembering, in those days, rote learning. So Kassapa, the very great ascetic, said that you have to keep the rule very fiercely. You must keep the rule about renunciation. You must live out in the forest and you must meditate. And Sāriputta, who was considered to be the general of the Dhamma, second only to the Buddha in understanding, said you must understand, you must learn what the Buddha's teaching is and you must meditate.

So this troop of young monks went off to the Buddha and they said to him we've asked so and so this, we've asked so and so that, and we get these answers, what do you think? And he says well all teachers will bring you the way they came, they'll bring you the way they came. So they said, Lord, what is your teaching? And his reply was, Meditate, meditate, meditate. So if we can bear the horror of sitting and walking and continuing to meditate all the time, then that would be the most direct way.

However, that doesn't mean to say we can't have rituals. It doesn't mean to say you can't have other practices. But there's an understanding in the stream entrant that they are not material, directly material to the path of enlightenment. I mean they're skilful means. It's a skilful thing to say, repeat a phrase, say a loving kindness phrase, may all beings be happy, than it is to let the mind wander off to Machu Picchu or Gold Coast or something. At least it's a skilful means. So that's what drops.

Now in the Buddha's day, remember, there were all sorts of very strange things. Remember, we're talking about medieval and pre-medieval times. And a lot of people, even these days, believe that ritual has some sort of efficacy about it in itself which brings about some form of enlightenment. For instance there were times in those times people thought that if you stood in the Ganges, just stood there, the purifying water of the Ganges would take all your bad *kamma* away. There was understanding that somehow you had to go through enormous suffering to get rid of suffering, mortification. Like if you, on a very hot day, you'd build a fire and sit next to the fire. And somehow that had this purifying effect. The purifying nature of fire. You can see it's around superstition and around wrong beliefs, things like that. So that's the third thing that goes.

In other words, for the *sotāpanna*, the stream entrant, their practice is very direct. They know where they're going. They don't get pulled off here and there with all sorts of stuff. I Ching, astrology, I don't know.

Then the next movement is to the once returner. And what these people break, or they undermine the two next things, which are *kāmarāga*, which translates as indulgence in pleasure, and *vyāpāda*, hatred, aversion. So those two things go. Now, if you think about it, from an ego point of view, from this ego level, from this self level, which believes that this is what it is, you've got to make the most of this now. There's only two ways to behave. Wherever happiness seems to come to you, whether it's pleasure, straightforward pleasure, bangers and mash and beans, or whether it's something, a relationship or music or even spiritual delight, from the self point of view, if that's what happiness is going to be, there's going to be a clinging to it, a wanting it, a holding on to it, a wanting to develop it. And if anything is in any way oppressive or seems to undermine happiness, any form of dissatisfaction, then there's going to be an effort to push it away. So that's the only way a real self can behave. You don't have an option when you're down at the level of me and mine.

But now, when somebody has so broken the idea of me and mine, they're not playing that game anymore. That game is undermined. It doesn't mean to say that they won't indulge and they won't get angry and all that, but the heaviness has gone. And it's only at the third stage that these two are completely undermined. And that's why there's a non-returner. They don't come back because there's nothing here attracting them anymore.

However, there's still attachment. And the attachment now is to the more finer mental states and more finer realms. And these are to do with the absorptions that we practice. Or you can practice. These are the rūpa and the arūpa. What do we mean by that? We mean that when somebody practices absorption meditations, ecstatic meditations, what they come to understand, what they realize is that they can create beautiful mental states independent of the world. So when we practice loving kindness, for instance, and we just put that phrase in our hearts, may all beings be happy, may all beings be happy, and we begin to feel the joy. That's just created by us, within us. So this releases you from dependence on sausage and mash. Beans. You don't need the world out there. You can just engender this loveliness within yourself.

And the progress of that gets very fine until you come to a very fine place of absolute equanimity where there's not even an object. And those who experience these things always say that this is the highest happiness, not something else. All the way up that chain, all the way up those degrees of ecstasy to pure equanimity. Those people who have experienced these things always say, well, this is the highest happiness. Not the other one. Everything begins to feel more and more gross. So that attachment doesn't go. Those two attachments don't go until you're fully enlightened.

The other thing that doesn't go is conceit. So the I, the me stays right to the bitter end. So don't think at any moment that you will not suffer from conceit and arrogance. It will stay with you to the bitter end. The other thing is restlessness, which is interesting. Restlessness. And although it doesn't say so, in my own personal understanding, it must also include sloth. Because they're just two energy forms, one going out, one coming in. So, so long as there's an impurity in the heart, there's going to be that shaking, that restlessness. So our struggle with sloth, torpor and restlessness must also be carried on to the bitter end.

And finally, of course, what is completely undercut is ignorance. That's the last fetter. Ignorance here means don't know. So the *arahant* now knows that... What does that person know? They know they are not the body, mind and heart. There's no confusion about that anymore. No confusion.

So the fetters are those things that drop away as we enter into the different paths and fruits. Which are the fruits. That's the fruit. That's the benefit. That's the return for all this hard work we have to put in. So therefore we must work hard. The fruit is there for the taking.

The Awakening

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 35 min read

In this profound dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's awakening beneath the Bodhi tree and its practical implications for our meditation practice. He explores the Buddha's three key insights: knowledge of past lives, understanding of karmic rebirth, and the complete destruction of the āsavas (mental floods) of sensual desire, becoming, and ignorance.

The talk delves deeply into the Four Noble Truths and the three characteristics of existence - anicca (impermanence), dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness), and anattā (not-self). Bhante explains how these insights arise through cultivating satipaṇṇā (awareness and wisdom) and taking the position of objective observer in meditation. He illuminates the Wheel of Dependent Origination (paṭicca samuppāda) as the psychology of suffering, showing how wrong view creates the cycle of craving, grasping, and becoming.

Drawing from various meditation traditions, including intensive practices from Thai forest monasteries, Bhante demonstrates how direct observation of our reactions to pleasant and unpleasant experiences can break the delusion of self. He concludes by describing the transcendent sphere of Nibbāna as beyond all dualistic experience - a state with "no coming, no going, and no standing still" that represents the complete end of suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So for those of you who listened to my earlier talks, I'm following the life of the Buddha and we got as far as his enlightenment and then we went into details about Mara, the evil one, and I had only meant to take one talk over the hindrances, but I ended up taking two, and I haven't finished them yet, so I don't want to overplay that, so I'm going to leave the other ones, aversion, doubt and all that, which I'm sure you know anyway. So I wanted to move on to the question of, so what was his awakening? What was it that he discovered? And how did that translate into practice? I'm not going to say anything which is going to surprise you, but at least it's just an occasion to reflect on what his awakening was all about.

So if we go back to that point where he's sitting by the roadside and the rice pudding turns up and this enlivens him and fills him with great glee, as rice pudding does, and he went off to make the great determination to sit beneath the tree saying that he would not rise from this posture even if he were to die. And so he sat there and he went to sit, remember, with that memory of the child, the child who was watching his father doing the ploughing ceremony.

The ability of the child just to receive, especially around about the age of one onwards to about six, just that ability to let the jaw drop and the eyes wide open. And just that entire receptivity with no mentation at all. There's nothing guarding anything coming in because there's not enough history, there's not enough experience to block or to play around with. So seeing his father doing the ploughing ceremony was a surprise, it was a joy for him. And with that, what we now understand to be *sati*, that awareness, *sati paññā*, with intuitive intelligence, just that receptiveness, which is the definition of equanimity, remember, the ability to receive without reaction. He went and sat, and luckily for him, and for us of course, he finally cracked the puzzle, his koan. Is there an end to suffering?

And the context of his awakening, it's the normal one that's accepted, was his insight into past lives, his own past lives. His insight or his being able to see how people were reborn according to their moral or immoral actions. And that he knew that the *asava* were completely destroyed. The floods, we'll come back to them.

So there are these three things that he understood. The first one, when he was able to review his past lives and understand how he got to where he was then, it became a personal understanding, you might say a personal law. But when that ability to go beyond himself, to see other beings arising and passing away according to what became the law of karma, what had been a personal law then becomes a cosmic law. And that's what he taught. He taught the law of karma and the law of rebirth.

And the *asava*, these floods, as they're called, there are three of them. Normally there are three, then somebody added a fourth one in the later scriptures. The first one is, of course, the flood of *asava* desire for sensual pleasure. Here sensual you have to stretch out a bit to include emotional, emotional pleasure. It's the pleasure of the senses which includes the mind and heart, so it's the whole pleasure syndrome, seeking pleasure in the phenomenal world or in the transient world. And the second one is of course the desire to become, to continue to keep reappearing as myself. And the third one is ignorance. And the ignorance was then reinforced by the idea of this flood of wrong view. So in a sense the wrong view is an expression of ignorance as to why they added on, I don't know. But those three were the basic *asava* that he had destroyed.

These *asava*, these floods, it's like the image that I have is of a painting of a watercolour, where the artist first puts a wash across the back. Sometimes you get watercolours on a black background, don't you? Or at least I've seen them like that. They might use oil, I can't remember. But anyway, they put a wash on the back. And this wash gives the whole picture a certain tone. So if we look at our mind-heart complex, the psyche, then it has these three basic tones. It has the tone of seeking happiness in sensual pleasure, the tone of wanting to become, to become, to become, and the tone of that ignorance, which is that wrong relationship that we have with the world we're in.

Now, when he talks about the world we're in, he then talks about the Four Noble Truths. And these Four Noble Truths, the truth of, that there is suffering, just a straightforward statement, the cause of suffering, which is that desire for sensual pleasure in the phenomenal world, and that there is an end, so there's your prognosis, not bad, is it? That there is an end to this constant misery, and that there's a path which leads to that place. And in the Four Noble Truths you'll get one way he says it where he says *loke*, in this world there is suffering. When he then defines *loke* he says in this fathom length body. So this suffering, this karma, this onward going, this *samsara*, is happening actually within us, within the mind itself. And what he discovered was that there was a position which lay beyond that. A position which lay beyond that.

And I've got a couple of quotes, if I can find them here. So, one of them is, for instance, there is a sphere. Now, a sphere, an *āyātana*, is a level of experience which don't overlap. So, for instance, through our eyes we see form and colour. Through our nose we have this smell or aroma. And you can't see through your nose and you can't smell through your eyes. I mean, you can try, but it doesn't happen. And that's what he means by a sphere. So there are six spheres, the sixth one being the mind itself. And now he's saying that there is another sphere. There is a sphere which is to be experienced, direct experience, where the eye stops and perception, and the perception of form fades away, or disappears. And that perception is the mental noting.

So there's a sphere where form and perception disappears, to do with the eye. The same with ear and sound, they disappear. The perception of sound disappears, like that's a bird or that's pleasant. The nose and smells, aroma, the tongue and its tastes, body with its sensation, and the intellect with its mental objects, so the images and the thoughts. All that disappear. And he says this sphere should be realized. So there he is pointing to something which goes beyond this body, this mind, this heart, the five *khandhas*, the five aggregates, and as he uses them here, the six spheres or the six avenues of consciousness. So we can only know the world through these six consciousnesses. We can only see it, smell it, hear it and so on and we can only know it as an internal image. So what he's saying is that there's a place beyond that.

Having stated that, he points out that this can't be got by a simple act of will. You just can't get there by saying, well, okay, let's take a rocket or something and get up to that sphere. It just doesn't happen like that. It's beyond the will. It's beyond the self.

And if you remember his next talk, having laid out, at least this is in the mythology, the way the scriptures were later collected, he then talked about the self. Now this sphere that is to be known which is beyond all else is beyond the dualistic world, it's beyond objects and therefore it can't be known as an object. So it's something which is totally subjective experience and it cannot be known as an object, and therefore, somehow, we have to, as it were, approach it by some little trick. So, what all the Buddha is saying is, all you have to do is look at whatever is arising and passing away and simply know that that's not me, not mine.

So here, the knowledge comes into a direct practice. And that's what he means by this *satipaṇṇā*, this awareness and intelligence. And he's saying that if we can take this position within ourselves of the observer, if we can find that observation post and begin to see things within ourselves as objects, then very slowly at least we'll be very clear as to what we are not. And it's presumed that if we're very clear as to what we're not, then hopefully, eventually, we'll be very clear as to what we actually are. That's the idea, anyway, of the practice.

So, how do we do that? What process do we use in order to access that vantage point? We can begin to investigate things so that it liberates. What's it liberating? It's liberating that which is this special sphere. And what is the content or what is that made up of? It's the *sati*, it's the *pañṇā*, it's the awareness and the wisdom, it's the looking, it's the seeing, it's the looking and the seeing.

So he always says, first of all, you look and then you see. So if you take that into your life, in ordinary day life, you can see that first of all, you've got to look. If something goes wrong with the car, you've got to open the bonnet and have a look. And then when you look, you see. So it's the same with anything, that process of looking, but we're looking, remember, with that attitude of wanting to know. So that has to be there. There has to be that desire of wanting to know.

What is it that we want to know? We cannot know *Nibbāna*, we cannot know the end of suffering directly, we cannot turn round upon it and say, gotcha. See, it doesn't work like that. So, if you think of an archer, this is an image that works for me anyway, when they are firing the arrow at the distant target, they never point it at the target directly, they're always pointing it up in the air somewhere. And they know that if it travels at a certain speed and it passes through that point, it's going to hit the target.

So the Buddha shifts that sort of investigation away from *Nibbāna*. He says, don't worry about that. He says, that will arise in its own good time. He says, just shift it towards the way you are looking. So this element that we have in us, in Theravada, it's dryly referred to as the *Nibbāna dhātu*, the element of *Nibbāna*, which I think takes on a certain fleshy quality when you call it *bodhicitta*, the heart-seeking enlightenment.

So when that arises, when we actually bring that forward by lifting this awareness to look at what is happening within the body and mind, he says don't worry about *Nibbāna*, he says just see how you're looking. And then he gives us these three vantage points, the *anicca*, the *dukkha*, the *anattā*, the sense of impermanence. Where is the suffering? Where is it? Where is it in this complex of the body, mind, heart? Where is the suffering? Where is it arising from? What's actually the cause of that suffering? And then the more subtle teaching of not-self.

So, he's taken our gaze away from worrying about *Nibbāna*, worrying about liberation, lots of stuff, and he says, why not investigate what you are experiencing from these three vantage points? So, when we're looking, and we take the vantage point of *anicca*, of transience and impermanence, we're becoming aware of that quality that everything is in a process of change. Now, if we center simply on that, then you'll find that the mind is very much aware of the beginning of things, but not the end of things. Because beginning, new for us, symbolizes something exciting. Even if it's something horrible, there's still a sense of awareness that it is beginning. Then as it begins to end, our attention really goes to what is the next beginning. So we always know who the new film star is or pop star, but we never actually know what happens to them. They've disappeared. They just fade away from consciousness, from cultural consciousness.

So by putting the attention on the ending of things, on the ending of things, we begin to see that actually this process, this process of change is not a continuum. There is an actual stopping. There is an actual stopping. The image there is of a row of billiard balls. So they're all joined up together but they're actually all separate. Usually that's explained as showing the difference between the Buddhist position on this and the Hindu position which says that there's something which continues through the arising and passing away of things. So it's like a row of beads with a string through it. But the Buddhist position is radical change. It's actually something completely finishes before something else can begin.

And that radical change, as we get into it, so as we get into it, there's a seeing of it from the point of view of the intellect, the point of view of actually understanding things arise and pass away, but it's actually at the emotional level, it's at the heart level that it begins to strike home. So even though in our school we go for the minuscule, we

go for the actual seeing of things in the minute, watching the rising and falling of the breath and even eventually the rising and falling of a sequence of sensations, at the heart level, it doesn't have to be that particular find at all. Somebody close to us who dies can hit you just as hard as watching the arising and falling of the breath. And it's hitting at a point of attitude. And when that attitude is broken, this has some continuity. When that attitude is broken, it reverberates back onto our understanding.

So there's always different ways in which the quality of transience can strike us and it's constantly putting that attention there that there is this slow beginning to understand what's happening. Now what is it that's arising and passing away? So remember that the Buddha's teaching is that everything is mind. Our knowledge of the outside world is totally dependent upon the senses that we have. So even though we're in this room together and nobody would dispute that this meditation hall actually sort of exists when we go away, in other words our mind is not actually creating this hall, the fact of the matter is all of us have walked into it, we all have a different view of it, a slightly different feel of it and so on. So in a sense our experience of this hall is all varied, individual, and that's true for everything we experience.

It's only through language and general communication that we can get across to people that we generally see the world as they do and of course some we don't and therefore you get this image of parallel universes. We're all sort of running parallel to each other in some way. Sometimes we sort of crash a bit but the idea is that everything that I know is within my mind. So all these stimuli, the light, the smells, the touch and all that, they're all being brought into this central box which we call the brain, but there's also, in Buddhist understanding, a mind matter there, which is a more subtle form, which produces for us a picture.

Now we know that from our own knowledge of how the brain works. This picture that we get is, shall we say, that act of cognition. And there's something that knows it. There's something that knows, that has a double take on it. It knows it knows. And that picture as it were is arising and passing away, holding an image for us so that we can grasp it and then it disappears and the next image comes up dependent on the stimuli coming in from the outside through the senses or from the inside through our memories.

And when we see that the world is arising and passing away, I think personally it would be truer to say that what we're watching is our minds arising and passing away. The actual act of cognition. Now to see that is of course undermines the idea that I can

be that. So *anicca*, the quality of transience does refer back to the self and this is what the Buddha said, if you remember in the discourse that I read, is something which arises and passes away to be understood as me, mine and so on.

So that quality of radical impermanence does reflect back to the not-self. And in so doing, of course, it ruptures a type of relationship that we have, which is a holding on. Remember that the self is constantly trying to build a world of comfort around itself, a sort of castle, so that it doesn't shake, it doesn't fear anything, it doesn't fear death. But to see that *anicca* quality, that real radical arising and passing away, reverberates back onto the self in its relationship to the world it's in.

Now, there I said the relationship of the self. That was wrong. It's a relationship of this *satipaṇṇā*, of this *bodhicitta* or this *Nibbāna dhātu*. It depends what school you're in and what you feel happy with, what expression you feel happy with.

So now we're getting this idea that there is something within us, this awareness, this very basic intuitive intelligence which is at the root of our being, and it moves into every moment with some sort of wrong view, some sort of wrong view, and that not knowing. It comes from the position of not knowing is the basis of, the beginning of, the wheel of dependent origination, which is how the Buddha explains how we come to suffer.

Now, I think I said before in an earlier talk, when I was answering a question, if we go back to our little origins in this particular life, remember that we became alive as just a bundle of cells. So in that bundle, what did we know? And it's only through the growth of the senses that we come to collect, as it were, enough information. And then finally we find ourselves out in the open world and gasping for a bit of breath. And then we grow up. And all the time there's this presumption, which is gained right back there in the womb, that this must be me, because this is what I experience.

Now, that delusion stays with us all the time, and it's only through meditation, by taking this objective position in ourselves, that we begin to break through that delusion. And the process of *anicca*, the nature of transience, of impermanence, is coming from a slightly different angle, which is saying that even if you hold on to it, it's going to disappear. Nothing stays the same. Everything is in a state of radical change. So that even the effort to try and hold on to something, to maintain a comfort, is a non-starter. It's not going to get you anywhere. So watching *anicca*, even at the breath, is a constant undermining of that wrong view.

A wrong view, remember, that has not come from a position of stupidity. That's the unfortunate thing about this English word ignorance. There is another word, nescience, but nobody knows it, so there's no point in it. Only the dictionary knows that word. And it means a simple don't know. Don't know, you see. And from that don't know is a frightening place to be. So one throws oneself into something, defines oneself as something.

Now this has happened to you all, I'm sure, at a time when you've, say, been in a strange hotel or in somebody's house and you've just woken up and you don't know where you are. And there's that sudden sort of rush of panic as to who you are. And it's only when you remember that, oh, you're in this hotel, that you can breathe again. Now that panic, you see, is the self. At that moment, the self can't define itself. So it's rushing around like a mad fool, trying to work out what the hell it is. And so when it grasps it, fantastic, then it's happy. Oh, it's me again.

So that sense of transience, really seeing transience, is not only coming back to the idea that nothing in this world is worth holding on to, that's a direct quote from the Buddha, but the fact that if it's transient it can't be me, because it's arising and passing away. So as we're watching it at all levels, remember at all levels, whether it's right there in the minuscule arising and passing away of a sensation, or whether we're just watching these leaves fall, and just watching the change of leaves, and just catching our feeling towards it. Sometimes if you stand by a river, just watch the river coming at you and just catch your feelings that come up with that coming, the newness. And then turn around and watch it flowing away and just catch how your feelings are at letting something go. If there's a puddle around or a pond, look into that and see how you feel when there is no flow.

So it's not as though we have to do this meditation in order to break through these things. All this meditation is doing for us is making more and more clear to us what this *satipaṇṇā* is. So if we sit with the idea that right now I'm going to crack it, I'm going to really break through this sitting like the Buddha did, you can try it. It usually ends up with severe frustration. So if we see our sitting simply as training, all we're doing is we're just training ourselves to constantly lift ourselves into this position of at least the objective observer.

Now, from this position of not-self, we've created these delusions. The fundamental delusion is that I am this person. That's the fundamental delusion. I am this personality and I am this body. And those we call our *sankhāra*. And a *sankhāra* is all those things that we've been able to create through an act of will. So once you've got a body and you've got an eye, the eye will see, that's not a *sankhāra*. Whatever's coming into the eye is a given. What we do with that which comes into the eye, or with the image that

comes, that's our *sankhāra*, because there comes that intention into what we're doing. And that's building up a mood, it's building up an attitude, and it's building up a whole series of thoughts, it's building up a history.

These intentions, remember, at all levels in all areas of our lives turn into an action. So you have an intention, it turns into an action. When you've got similar actions going on you've produced a habit. And once you've got a compendium of these habits, a collection of habits, that's your personality. And once you've got a personality, it just drives you towards your destiny, until, of course, you come to meditate. And then you can reverse some of it, and hopefully end up with a decent destiny.

So, here we are, with this *satipaṇṇā*, this awareness, this *buddho* within ourselves, and then we're born. So that's the next stage, *nāma-rūpa*, you're born. And with that being born, there arises these acts of cognition. So this body-mind complex and the act of cognition rebound off each other. The one can't arise without the other. You can't cognize something if there's nothing there. So there can't be a cognition unless there's something coming in through the perceptual faculties, the eye and so on. So once that's started, once you've got that, once you've got the consciousness and the basic body, which has these six senses, so that's your next step, the *salāyatana*, the six sense bases, then finally you can have some contact. And that's your next stage, your contact.

At the point of contact, there has to be these three things. You have to have a sense base, you have to have something that stimulates that sense base, and you've got to have that consciousness. Once that arises, then the mind, the perceptual faculty comes in, which knows what it is, but then that quality of judgment, now this isn't a judgment to do with good and bad and all that, it just experiences what comes in as pleasant or unpleasant. It's as simple as that. So sometimes we get a sensation which is pleasant, like when we're eating, and sometimes we get something which is unpleasant, like when it's getting cold. So whatever sensation comes in, after the contact, there is this relationship built up with it. So the relationship is, like it, don't like it.

Now, once the self grabs hold of that as a position, pleasant, unpleasant, you see, then it has to take a position. Now, its position comes from that fundamental misunderstanding that this is what it is. And it knows there is suffering. It's not happy. Now, what is it that's not happy? See, what is it that's not happy? So we started off way back there in the womb, being this, shall we say, this *satipaṇṇā*, this Buddha nature. And it's formed a relationship. So when we talk about the self, we're not talking about something, we're not talking about an object, we're talking about a relationship. We're talking about a relationship.

So, when we're suffering, what is it that's suffering? If it's not this very nature, which is our essential nature of the Buddha. That's what's suffering. And it's suffering because it's formed this wrong relationship. So when we say the self, you see, there's a tendency to substantiate it. There's a tendency to think that it's an object. But we're much closer, I think, to understanding what the self is when we realize it's to do with our relationship.

So when this perception comes, that this is pleasant and unpleasant, the knowing, which is ignorant, which is creating the delusion, says to itself, I've got to make myself happy. This is where happiness is. I've got to make it now or else I've had it. So whatever it sees creates a certain state, a mental state, which is happy, it'll want to grab it, hold it and develop it. And once it's into that relationship, that's when we get that greed in all its forms. It doesn't matter what it is, power, sex, drugs, rock and roll. It doesn't matter what it is. The fact is that the more I can have of it, the happier I will be. It's as simple as that.

Having built that little castle, that little place of joy, now, of course, it has to protect it. So anything which it sees is not pleasant, then it'll want to destroy, want to annihilate, get it out, push it away. And whenever that is too much, when it's overwhelming, then it runs. It runs for it. It picks up its bags and goes for it. So there we have the fundamental psychology which arises out of that wrong perception of the self. This is me. This is mine. So you've got on one side the attachment, the holding, the developing, and on the other side, the protection and the pushing away. And the running away. That's all included in that word aversion.

So having got to that stage, we then very quickly can move into immoral action, which is basically doing harm. It's doing harm to others and doing harm to myself. And then once I've started doing harm, I'm into the second level of emotions to do with shame, guilt, horror, all that sort of stuff, remorse, regret. All those flow in once I start doing something which is unwholesome. And of course, there are those, there's that side of the development which we take pleasure in, but which are horrible. So, you know, we like getting angry at people. It's a relief. We like banging the door. We like being cruel. We like, you know, stepping on people's toes and doing things like that. And saying that little sentence which really digs them. And like cruelty and then not being generous, being selfish, you see, all these things can be very pleasant. So there's a whole area of unpleasant behavior which we enjoy and that of course is creating further psychological problems for us.

Now all that, all that is included in those three little steps after *vedanā*. So the *tanhā*, the *upādāna* and the *bhava*. So the *tanhā* is that movement from the self moving towards it because it likes it, it wants it. So having perceived something as likeable, it now moves towards it as wantable. I want that. Just a minute. Want, want that, okay.

Once that want has come, and this is the sequence of psychological events, according to the Buddha, the I comes in. See, the I doesn't come in first. In our language we say, I want that. But it's not, it's want I. First the desire arises, and then there's the association with the desire, there's the identification with desire, and that's the *upādāna*, that's the grasping.

Once that's happened it's very difficult to stop the action coming in which is the will and the reason is this because that delusion of I, I want is coming, remember, directly from the Buddha, the Buddha within which is deluded. And with it there comes the power of the will and that's also coming from that centre. It's also coming from that center. So immediately we say I, it's very difficult to stop the grasping, the actual going for the object. And that's the *bhava*, that's the becoming. At that point we've created an act. And that act now, as I say, repeated, becomes a habit.

Now what we're trying to do in our meditation in terms of seeing the path through understanding *dukkha*, understanding how we create this unsatisfactory situation for ourselves, is to put our attention right in between that which we perceive as likeable and unlikable, and of course neutral, and to catch that relationship of wanting, not wanting and ignoring, not wanting, just simply ignoring it, simply not knowing it. And if we put our attention there it can't go, it can't move anywhere else, it can't go into I. Why is that, you see? It's because the awareness, this intelligence we have, this Buddha nature within us has taken a completely different position. It's now become transcendent to the whole psychological process. It's now above it or beyond it and it's watching it from above. So, if we stay in that position, it can't go into that identity. It just can't do it.

So, in that position, we're actually snapping the idea of me or mine. As soon as you see a desire and let it go, you're destroying constantly the idea that desire is me. I am the desire. And it's through that process of seeing that that we can find this realization through just understanding how we create suffering for ourselves.

When I was in Thailand, I did a tour of all the different techniques. The Thais are very creative, you know. And I went down to a place called Boonkanchan around, which is on the bay around Bangkok. And when I got there, the teaching, I'd heard about it. She had died. She's obviously a very good teacher. But the instructions are very simple. You don't stop doing what you're doing until it hurts. Really hurts. Really, really,

really hurts. So you sit and it starts to hurt and you're not supposed to do anything until it really, really, really hurts. And then, when it really, really, really hurts, and you can't handle it anymore, you then change your posture. But you do it very, very slowly, and all you're looking at is, as the pain arises, as the discomfort arises, you're just watching your reactions to it. And as it gets to the point where you can't take it anymore, and you're shaking with it, you just watch your reactions to that, you see? And then when it comes to a point where you really can't take it anymore, you say intending to change. And as you change, you watch very carefully how the physical body, the physical sensations are changing and how the mind is changing. And then you come back to a state of comfort. So from walking you might go to sitting, to lying down, whatever you're doing, but you keep doing it until you get to that point where you're able to see that change.

And in seeing that change, you're seeing the distinction between pain, which is both physical and mental, and how you can take a position to it whereby you're not actually suffering. And by observing that process, you're actually undoing the idea of a self. Because the self is always identifying with that process. It says, oh, it's pain, I'd better go and get an aspirin. It's always moving off it. It's unable to stay with it. So even by going through this process of understanding *dukkha*, of understanding how we create suffering for ourselves, we again undermine that wrong relationship which lies at the base, which is the idea that this is me, this is mine.

Now, when it when that is finished, of course, you're also cutting the end of that process of the wheel of dependent origination, which is birth, aging, death, or arising, decay, death, arising and passing away. Should we say the traditional teaching is three lives, but the other teaching which is right there in the scriptures and is right there in the commentaries is of course moment to moment. So as we see something which we like and we indulge in it, then we become the indulger and that arises and passes away.

So with every sequence of actions in which we've indulged or which we've pushed away or which we've run away, we've become somebody and there was a beginning, there was a middle, there was a decaying and there was an end. So not everything we do is part of the wheel of dependent origination. Not everything we do is continuing with the self, because for instance just some simple action like opening a door, there's not a moral problem there. It's only where a moral and ethical situation arises of greed, hatred or aversion that wheel can actually turn.

So when we do something out of a correct intention, when we eat in order to nourish the body, we eat to live, not live to eat, when we eat to nourish the body then we're not turning the wheel. In fact we're going backwards on the wheel.

Now, why is it that the wheel doesn't come back on itself? So you start off with not becoming, and then you go down to not grasping, no I, then you come back to desire. No, the Buddha starts the negative side of the wheel, the wheel which is drawing us to enlightenment, back at ignorance again, back at the point of this wrong view. And the reason he does that is because when we're meditating, we're always correcting that view. And whenever you correct a view, whenever you correct the way you're looking at something, the whole castle of cards that we've built on that wrong view simply collapses. You don't have to take everything apart. As soon as you see transience, the whole thing that you've built on transience completely collapses. And that's why these insights are immediate. Not all these insights, of course, have a colossal effect on us. We don't sort of jump up and down and all that sort of stuff. But they're little. They're slowly just cutting away at the delusion. Slowly cutting away at the delusion. And that's why the whole of the Buddha's teaching is concerned with right view. As soon as you see something, everything, you know, corrects itself.

There was a friend of mine who was going to pick me up and we were going to go for a walk and his car broke down. And it was parked by the road there, so I, being an expert mechanic, said, well, open the bonnet. So he opened the bonnet, and he told me what had happened. The engine just cut. So my immediate diagnosis was, well, it's electrics.

The Years of Teaching and Parinibbāna

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 32 min read

In this concluding talk of his series on the Buddha's life, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching years and parinibbāna. After his Awakening under the Bodhi tree, the Buddha's first impulse was compassionate—who could he teach? The talk explores how wisdom naturally expresses itself as compassion through the Eightfold Path, moving from right understanding to right attitude and outward into skilful action.

Through memorable stories—Āṅgulimāla the reformed murderer, Bāhiya of the Bark-cloth who achieved instant liberation, and Kisāgotamī learning about universal death—we see the Buddha's skilful means in teaching. The talk also covers his engagement with society, including water disputes and political conflicts, showing his understanding of the limits of influence.

The final sections poignantly describe the Buddha's last days, his relationship with faithful Ānanda, the challenge from Devadatta, and his final teaching: 'Whatever is formed and compounded will dissolve. Work diligently for your own liberation.' Bhante emphasizes how the Buddha remains both archetype and exemplar—a fully human teacher who points the way while leaving us to do the liberating work ourselves.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambuddhasa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambuddhasa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So for one or two who have just joined us, I've been over these past few weeks going through the Buddha's life and using it as a basis to consider his teachings. We finally come now to the years of teaching and his final hours, his final days. If we recall to mind that wonderful night when he became enlightened, with the dawn – that's how they put it – in the full moon of May, he became fully awakened and understood exactly why he had been in a state of dissatisfaction or suffering. He spent the next night or so considering the Dharma and going through especially the Wheel of Dependent Origination, which was his psychological paradigm as to why we get ourselves into such a dreadful state.

After that, his first thought was who can I teach? Who can I pass this on to? Then came the doubt that people weren't ready, that there wasn't anybody who could think of that really would be open to this. If you consider that at that time, all the philo-

sophies, all the understandings were all about the self. They were about, did the self annihilate? There were some people who just presumed that when you died you annihilated, which would be equal to our materialists. There were those who believed in some sort of future life, rebirth, but eventually you would annihilate. There were those who thought that actually that's all you did, you just kept being reborn and there was not much you could do about it, it was just the way it was. There were some who were so convinced of that that they said, one teacher said, if you went down to one side of the Ganges and did all sorts of compassionate and wonderful deeds and came up the other side burning, murdering and thieving, it wouldn't make a jot of difference. Your karmic line is already set, it was fated and there's nothing you can do. So all the philosophies around that time were to do with the self and what happens to the self.

When he suddenly realized that this self that they were talking about was a phantasm, didn't actually exist, was just a concept in the mind, then as he's thinking, well, who can I get this message across to, then he gets this block. This is my own interpretation, you understand. So it says in the scriptures that the great Brahma Sahampati came and said, "No, Lord, do teach, for some people have only a little dust in their eyes."

Now, we can either be rather cynical of Brahma Sahampati turning up. It's more in the sense that he had a second thought about it. But you must remember that there's always a little bit of propaganda in the Buddhist texts. Brahma, of course, is the highest of all gods in the Hindu pantheon. That he should be coming down and asking the Buddha to teach was simply saying that the Buddha had gone beyond the teachings of his day.

Leaving that aside, he then decides to teach. There are some writers whom you'll come across who said that he hesitated to teach, that he could have just sat there and simply done nothing, just sat in bliss until the body gave up. But this goes completely contrary to his own teachings. The Eightfold Path, that we call the Eightfold Path, is one path. We can think of it as a highway with eight lanes in it, but I think we're closer to the mark if we think of a tightrope made of eight strands, because it's so easy to fall off. That's how we find it's difficult to walk the path.

These eight strands move together. It's not possible in the Buddha's teaching to separate out right understanding from its expression in action, in what we do. Wisdom will naturally express itself into compassion. That's the whole point, that there's a flow downward and outward, downward, inward, into the very heart of our existence, of our being, for want of a better word. Once we've understood such things, then of course there's that change of attitude in the heart. That's why in the Eightfold Path we go from right understanding to right attitude.

Right understanding is always about these three characteristics. It's always about understanding the role of desire. It's always about undercutting the idea of self. When that translates, of course, that idea translates into the heart, then it manifests as an outward going. When he talks about himself as a teacher, the word he uses is *anukampan*. He says, I as a teacher have done everything that a teacher could do for you out of compassion. But the word isn't the usual word *karuna*, which we've come across, but *anukampan*, which means moving towards the other, an empathy, a sympathy. That's what drives him to teach.

When the self goes, or as the self goes, we begin to understand this idea, this understanding of interdependency, interconnections, all that sort of stuff. But of course when that goes into the heart, that expresses itself in love, compassion, sympathetic joy. If it doesn't do that, then it can remain as an idea, as a notion, but it's not going to affect our behavior until it moves into the heart. In the Zen tradition they will tell you that compassion arises naturally with wisdom and I think we can take that as fairly true, but even so we should budget along a bit because sometimes we can stay up in the head a bit too long.

When it moves into the heart and we are in communication with people, then that naturally expresses itself by the way we speak kindly, appropriately and how we behave in a gentle manner, not getting angry and killing people and in our livelihood. You can see there's an outward flow. So there's the Buddha, he's had this amazing insight, he's suddenly understood something to which there is no further profundity. He's thinking about it, and he's worked it through, and as it drops into the heart, there's that movement outward of, who can I bring to this sort of liberation? The doubt isn't whether he should do it or not. The doubt is whether people are ready for it. Once he's overcome that, he moves forward.

The first two that come to mind are his old teachers. Because they trained him and he knew their religious and spiritual depth. But they died. When I was in Burma last, there was a statue which I'd never seen before, the actual *mudra*, the shape of it. The Buddha was sitting there and his hand was pointing like that towards the heart centre. I'd never seen it before and asked what it was. I was rather touched when they said that it was the sadness he felt when he realised his two teachers were dead and he wasn't able to pass on the message of his teachings.

Then the next people he thought about, of course, were his own five companions. So he walks, it's about 100 and odd miles from where he was up to Isiputana Park, perhaps a little more, and finds them there, and that's where he begins his teaching.

Even we ourselves have to accept that once you're on the path, whether you like it or not, you become a teacher. It might not be an official post, and you might not get paid for it, but you're immediately there as an exemplar. I think I've mentioned before that if you tell somebody that you meditate, and that it's done you a powerful lot of good, and then they find you completely drunk in the gutter, then they have second thoughts about whether they want to do any of this meditation. As soon as we take on a path, whether we like it or not, we have the responsibility of being as best we can an exemplar. By that way, we are a teacher.

That question that you'll see discussed in various books, as far as I'm concerned there is no doubt about the Buddha's desire to pass on the message. The compassion must come forward. When we look at the other tradition, that is the Pacceka Buddha, the Buddha who's a private Buddha, in other words somebody who simply becomes enlightened, it's not that they don't want to teach, the idea is that they can't, they don't have that ability, something that has to be learned.

This comes out in the Buddha himself. He's now got up from his seat and he's off searching his disciples and he comes across a *samana*, another ascetic. The ascetic looks at him and says, you look very bright, you look very clear. Who's your teacher? The Buddha announces, I have no teacher, I'm the fully enlightened being, I know the cosmos in and out and so on and so forth. The ascetic simply says, "Oh no," shakes his head and moves on. So he obviously learnt very quickly that's not quite the way that you teach somebody.

Then you'll see that in the scriptures. If you read the early parts of the scriptures, like the Nipata Sutta, it's not so formalized, four of these, ten of those, twelve of them. It's very personal. You can see that they are memories of actual conversations that he's had with people. It's only as he's teaching and as people come to him and want to remember what he's teaching that these mnemonics are worked out. It's easy to remember if there are five of these and four of those and 37 factors of enlightenment. Of course by the end of his life it was beginning to turn into almost an academic exercise which later on turned into the *Abhidhamma*.

The teaching was just part and parcel of his nature. When you go through his life there's all sorts of incidents that happen. I only covered a few but just the sense of his teaching. There was one very dull monk who was so dull that it said that as he remembered one phrase it pushed the other phrase out, so he never got beyond this one phrase. His brother said to him that he really wasn't fit to be in the order because a part of it was trying to remember the Buddha's teaching. He couldn't remember the Buddha's teaching, what the heck would he do?

When the Buddha heard about this he went to visit and immediately gave him an exercise of just rubbing a piece, just actually taking a piece of clean cloth, wiping his face, the sweat on his face, and rubbing the cloth, and simply saying, "*Anicca*, impermanence, impermanence." And lo and behold, in no short time, as the scriptures say, he became fully liberated. The gloss on that, the gloss on these "in no length of time," in the commentaries, is around about 25 to 30 years. So it's not as though he just wiped his face a few times and bingo. I don't know whether you ever want to try that. It didn't work for me.

It's a case of understanding that he has this ability to actually get into the person and just catch what they want. Another one is, of course, the very famous story of Angulimala. Angulimala is a murderer of sorts. He's actually, according to the story, fulfilling a demand made of him by his teacher who was jealous of him, fearful of him taking over his position. He demanded of him as his guru reward, in fact you give a present to your guru in those days, that he collect, so to say, a thousand little fingers.

Off he goes and does that. At some point the Buddha either meets him by chance or he's heard about him or through his powers understands that Angulimala is not a murderer in his heart, he's just been driven to this. I wouldn't be surprised if he knew of him because he was supposed to be a Brahmin, he was of a Brahmin caste. So the tale goes, when Angulimala spies him and starts to hunt him down, the Buddha produces this magical trick of walking and yet always staying ahead of Angulimala who's racing and racing trying to catch up. Then when Angulimala shouts out, "Stop monk!" or "Stop ascetic!" the Buddha turns around and says, "Well I have stopped, it's you that haven't stopped."

Somehow that just cuts into Angulimala and makes him consider what he's actually doing. Presumably in the following conversations with the Buddha, he recognizes that he's fallen foul of his own heart by following a tradition of giving a present to the guru even though that present was unwholesome. Again he then takes on the Buddha's teaching, he becomes a member of the order, which saves him from execution by the king by the way who comes looking for him, and in no length of time becomes fully liberated.

The other one which I'm sure you all know is Bahiya of the Bark Cloth. Bahiya is a very old man and he only wears a bark cloth. He's a long time ascetic and he's not getting anywhere. He's stuck and he hears about this *samana*, the great *samana*, the great ascetic, and off he goes to find the Buddha. When he finds the Buddha, he says to him, can you give me some teaching? He wants to sit down and talk about all his issues, and the Buddha says, "Well, this isn't the time," he says, "because I'm off on alms

round." Bahiya of the Bark Cloth, he's a very elderly person, so he says, "Listen, I could die any minute, so any minute I could die, it's very important for me to hear any teachings you've got."

So the Buddha simply says to him, "In the seeing there's only the seeing, in the hearing there's only the hearing, in the cognition or in cognising there's only the cognising." Right there and then Bahiya breaks through the delusion and becomes fully enlightened. As the story goes, not long after leaving the Buddha, walking along the street, an angry cow butted him to death. So he was extremely lucky that the Buddha actually answered his question there and then. I love these stories.

There's also another little story from Nanda, who was his half-brother. He joins the order and he's struggling and struggling to practice and falling into the area of over-effort. Realizing that he's not getting anywhere, he immediately thinks, which is understandable, that he's wasting his time, and he may as well leave the holy life, go back, live the good lay life, bring up some children, and hope for a better rebirth.

When the Buddha hears this and actually what's drawing him away is lust, he sends him up into the highest, he drags him up it seems into the highest heaven to see these most beautiful nymphs and setting this as a goal that he could actually attain that, rather than go off and just be with human women. He then carries on with his practice, and lucky for him, he also, in no length of time, becomes fully liberated.

There's all these lovely little stories about how he was able just to really see what was necessary in a person as they approach him, see right into their heart and give them just the technique that they needed to make a break. You'll see that although in the scriptures you do get this idea that there's a basic technique around the breath and so on and so forth, you can see from these stories that actually anything that works will do, anything that brings us to some sort of realization of these three characteristics: the transience, how we create suffering for ourselves and the not-self will do.

Just last one to finish this off, there's his sense of humour that comes through. Humour doesn't carry very well and you've got to presume that this must have been a rather humorous scene. In those days if you remember there was this great idea of ascetic practice. Somebody leaves the sensual world recognising that the sensual world is not going to be a place where they're going to be happy. So they go off and they practice *jhāna*, following the same path as the Buddha. The Buddha isn't doing anything up until he's sitting under that tree that lots of people weren't doing at that time. They get into the *jhāna* and all that, and the happy states, and then they realize, well, that doesn't do it. Then the next thing is to blame the body. The body's at fault, so then we get into this sort of ascetic practice.

There was some very strange ideas. If you think there's some wacko ideas going around these days, it must have been living at the time of the Buddha. There are these two ascetics who are called the dog ascetic and the cow ascetic. The understanding is that they're going to preempt any future rebirth as a cow or as a dog by living as a cow or as a dog right here in this very life.

The dog ascetic approaches the Buddha with his friend the cow ascetic and says, "Lord, my friend here is practicing the cow ascetic practice. What will be his future? What will be his born? What happens to him when he dies?" And the Buddha says, "Don't ask me." And his second time, the dog ascetic said, "Lord, please." "Please don't ask me." For the third time they insisted that the Lord give them some answer.

So the Blessed One said, "This cow ascetic, he is developing cow perceptions. He is developing cow feelings. He is developing cow consciousness. Therefore upon death he will be reborn as a cow." And the cow ascetic wept heavily and finally came to his senses. Then having come to his senses he approaches the Lord and says, "Blessed one, my friend is practicing the dog ascetic practice," and I'll leave you to finish the story. You get these lovely little instances in the scripture where obviously the Buddha is having a bit of a pulling somebody's leg.

I heard somebody say, I can't remember where, that the Buddha was only, there's only one or two incidences in the scriptures where he's actually engaged in a compassionate act. In a sense that undermines the whole point of teaching. The teacher is, or a teacher is compassionate. When somebody is actually teaching anybody, that is a compassionate act. Whether it's a parent teaching a child or a teacher in a school or a Dharma teacher, anybody. Once you teach, you're offering something. What you're offering is your own wisdom and skills and understandings.

When we talk about compassionate acts, it needn't be something quite so obvious as, say, serving in a leper colony or something. Compassionate acts can be very small and very simple and they might not need at all any sense of bravery or anything of that nature. When it comes to what you might look at, what you might see as actual acts of compassion, as these days people might see it, there are just one or two.

Remember the lovely story of Kisagotami. She had lost her child and the dead child was looking around for somebody to bring it back to life or to do something for the dead child. Bringing it to the Buddha, he simply set her this task of finding a mustard seed, of which of course there are over plenty in India, from a house, but with the proviso that nobody had died in that house.

Kisagotami is in a state of desperate bereavement, leaves the child with the Buddha and goes off searching for the seed. Going from house to house, the message is the same. "Sure, I've got plenty of mustard seeds, but my Lord, this house has known death. It's known death from who knows when, right up to this present day, so-and-so died, grandfather died, this child died, and so on." Very slowly it dawns on her that death is just part of life and this brings her to her senses. Coming back to the Buddha she takes refuge in him and again later on joins the order and in no length of time becomes fully liberated.

There's also a lovely scene where there's a monk who's sick and the Buddha hears about this and goes to visit him and the poor man's got dysentery and he's in a dreadful state. It's all over him. He says, "Well, why aren't the monks helping you?" And the monk replies, "Well, I don't do anything for the monks, so they're not going to do anything for me."

The Buddha goes to the monks and says, "Look, this man is sick, he's dying, why aren't you doing anything for him?" And they say, "Well, he doesn't do anything for us, so we won't do anything for him." Seeing the callousness of the monks, the Buddha with Ananda go and tend to this fellow and then he gave the talk to the monks saying, "You have no mother and no father and if you don't look after each other who will?" And there he is, he's being a nurse to this monk. It's one of these little incidences which brings out his humanity.

Even there on his deathbed, I mean, he's actually... He himself, of course, dies of dysentery. He's on his deathbed and presumably getting weaker and weaker, when somebody turns up, a sub-Buddha, and asks for ordination, a direct ordination from the Buddha. He keeps asking, knowing that the Buddha's dying, and Ananda keeps saying, "Go away, this isn't the time, the Buddha's dying, come back afterwards and I'll ordain you." But the Buddha, on hearing this, insists that he be ordained right there and then.

One of the blessings, you might say, of the Theravada scriptures is that you really do get a feel of just an ordinary human being walking around the place and being in contact. There's a little tale in there where somebody walks into a room with, and he's there amongst these monks. They have to ask him, which one is the blessed one? So they get that sort of sense of orderliness, ordinariness, and just a real sense of humanity about him. Something which gets lost when you move into the Mahayana scriptures, where, of course, he only appears in his Sambhogakaya, the body of bliss, teaching to hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas. This brings us back to his simple humanity.

Apart from that, there's a whole business where he's actually engaged in society, in the politics of the time. One of the disputes that he helped to disarm was around the water rights between his own people, the Sakyas and the Kolyans. He went up there to help them overcome this argument. They were going to enter into some sort of war or something. He simply asked them what was more precious to them, the water in the river or the blood in their veins.

There's a lovely little tale that goes with it where he asks the people who are the leaders, the warrior caste, what is the fight about? And they're not very clear. Then as he comes down to strafing society, they don't quite know why they're fighting. They're just very angry. They hate the Kolyans. The Kolyans hate the others. It's only when it gets down to the farmers that the farmers actually make it clear. "Oh, we're fighting over water rights." I think that has a certain resonance for these days, exactly why we're fighting. There's only a few people actually know why we go for war.

There's another incident where, right towards the end of his life, where so much is happening, the king Ajatasattu wants to attack the Vajjian confederacy and sends an ambassador along to ask the Buddha whether in fact this was the right time to do it. It's a rather strange thing to do. The Buddha actually gives him some directions as to what maintains a good society. I thought I might just read out his things, which some of them, I think, make sense to us.

He turns to Ananda and he says, "Ananda, have you heard whether the Vajjians hold frequent and well-attended meetings?"

"They do, Lord."

"As long as they do so, Ananda, they can expect to prosper and not decline. Have you heard whether they assemble in concord, rise in concord, and do their duty as Vajjians in concord? Whether they avoid enacting the unenacted or abolishing existing enactments and proceed in accordance with the ancient Vajjian laws as enacted? Whether they honour, respect, revere and venerate the Vajjian elders and think they should be heeded? Whether they honor and respect and venerate the Vajjian shrines both in the towns and country without allowing the lawful oblations hitherto given and made to lapse? Where the lawful protection, defense, and guarding is provided among the Vajjians for the religious." Here you see Arahats.

He's got these various ways in which he says that a community will remain strong. When the ambassador hears this, he goes back and tells Ajatasattu that it's not quite the right time to attack them. In that way he was able to undermine that. Later on of course through devious means Ajatasattu did actually attack and take over the Vajjian territory.

There's also this quite astonishing story when you think about it. Virudhaka became the next king after Pasenadi of Kosala and he was the overlord of the Sakyans. When Virudhaka wanted to marry into the Sakyan clan, the Sakyans thought that his caste was too low for them so they tricked him into marrying a lower caste. When Virudhaka found out about this of course he was utterly mortified and determined to attack the Sakyans and destroy them.

The Buddha having heard this and knowing that he was out on his elephant went out and stood before him and was able to turn him back. He did that a second time and a third time. The fourth time, and this is something to record, when he was told the fourth time he'd gone out, the Buddha said he could do nothing and it seems those people were attacked and the city was destroyed and they moved Kapilavastu.

This has, I think, a teaching for us these days because of our understanding of being engaged in society and how much you can do and being aware of the circle of power we have and the circle of influence. Once we touch the edge of those circles, there's nothing more you can do. Any frustration, any disappointment, any despair about the situation, which you can't do anything about, is actually unnecessary and is coming from some other center, which is not being humble about oneself. Like, what can I do? Anything else after that, one has to simply accept. It's part of what you might call our social *kamma*, for want of a better phrase.

The Buddha's done his best. He's been out there three times. When the fourth time comes, he says he can't do anything. That's the end of it.

Towards the end of his life, there's all sorts of things happen. Ajatasattu, this king, kills his father, starves his father to death so that he can take over the kingdom. He's supporting Devadatta, whom I'm sure some of you know. Devadatta was the monk who decided that he should lead the order. There's a lovely passage here where he approaches the Buddha.

"Lord, the Blessed One is now old, aged, burdened with years, advanced in life and come to the last stage. Let the blessed one now rest, let him dwell in bliss in the present life. I demand over the Sangha Bhikkhus to me. I will govern the Sangha Bhikkhus."

And the Buddha's reply is, "Enough Devadatta, do not aspire to govern the Sangha Bhikkhus," and so he rebukes him.

Devadatta then of course as I'm sure you know tries to kill him. He sets the elephant, Nalagiri, to rage upon him. There's a lovely story where the Buddha, as the elephant's coming towards him, just actually offers his loving kindness towards the elephant, and the elephant actually stops before him, sucks dust from his feet, and blows it over his body, his own body, not over the Buddha's.

The other story is of course he rolled a boulder down a hill which caught the Buddha's big toe and made it bleed. So Devadatta has really bad press, but actually if you think about what he was trying to do, then in a sense one can understand what was happening. The Buddha, remember, his early life as an ascetic had been quite basic, living under tree roots, living off rag robes, only taking what was in the bowl to eat. Very, very basic life of a beggar.

As the order grew, and there were invitations to come into the families, to food, to be served food by his supporters, he was given monasteries with rooms and carpets and things like that. You can understand that Devadatta, and it would seem quite a few monks at the time, just thought the whole thing was getting very soft.

He comes with these 60 men that they live only in the forest and not live in villages. That they eat only from alms round and not go to houses. That they only wear robes that are made from the rags from dead bodies. That's what they used to get them from. That they lived at the root of a tree and that they were vegetarian and not meat-eaters.

What this brings us to is the Buddha's feel for not being fundamentalist, not being rigid, recognizing that within any society there has to be some sort of latitude, there has to be some sort of give and take. When he starts the order, he doesn't seem to come from any ideal. He's not sat down and thought, now, what sort of order do I want to create? There were the basic rules of those times of how you should live if you had left the lay life and undertaken what became of the Brahmacharya, the holy life. He was simply following the customs of the day.

As people said to him, "Well, we'd like to join you, we'd like you to be our teacher, our guru," as they would say. He said, "Well, do likewise." For 20 years, such were the quality of people who joined him that there wasn't any need to create a rule. Then as people with less integrity, you might say, joined, then things began to get done which were against the customs of the day and he would make a rule about it.

The institution of the Sangha as it grew up wasn't something which came from an ideal, it just gathered this law as people did wrong, as people made mistakes and then he would make a rule. Eventually there came this sort of body of law by the end of his life which constitutes the institution. If you think about an institution, an institution has an aim and it has a body of law, the body of rules and regulations which hopefully make that aim possible.

When he's instituting or when he's developing the Sangha, the only duties that he says that order members have is to study the Dharma and to practice *vipassana*. That's the actual duties that a monk or nun have. There's actually no duty there to teach. There came this complaint where the lay people had gathered on a full moon day where the Buddhist monks and nuns were gathered in a park. That was the custom of the day, the full moon, very bright, very easy to see. They would spend the moonlit hours discussing Dharma. That was what seems to have been the great custom of the day.

They complained to the Buddha that when they approached his monks and nuns, they just sat there like dumb pigs. Then there came this rule that if you were asked a question of Dharma, you had to answer it. But it's interesting to know that that's something that the monastic does because of a response. It's not within the tradition to go out and proselytize. One has to wait. One has to wait to be asked.

I wanted to, we have the idea of the Buddha being a very warm, compassionate, huggy-wuggy, touchy-feely sort of person. But I thought I'd read out to you what happened when somebody actually goes against the rule. Unless you've read the Vinaya, the books on the Vinaya, you probably won't have come across this. Now, the only one in this book, unfortunately, is to do with the first Parājika. Now, a Parājika, there are four Parājikas, whereby if a monk or nun, as you know, the nun order died out about a thousand years ago, but it has been re-established, and there are, to date, I heard anyway, about 200 fully ordained nuns in Sri Lanka now.

Suddhinma had left his wife because of his urge to seek liberation. But when he went back home, they cajoled and insisted that he cohabit with his wife to produce a child so that the family would continue. Falling for the argument, Suddhinma does cohabit with his wife and she gives birth and a son. However, when the monks heard about this, they of course rushed to the Buddha and said, do you know what he did? So the Buddha brings him to him and I'll just give you a bit of the language so you can get a feel for him as the leader, the tough leader.

"Misguided man, it is unfitting, unseemly, improper and unworthy of a monk. It is unrighteous and must not be done. How can you not live out the holy life in complete perfection and purity after going forth into homelessness in the Dharma and discipline as well as proclaimed as this? Misguided man, have I not taught the Dharma in various ways for the sake of dispassion, not for the sake of passion? Have I not taught the dhamma for the sake of unfettering, not for the sake of fettering? Have I not taught the dhamma for the sake of relinquishing, not for the sake of clinging? The dhamma thus taught by me for dispassion, unfettering and relinquishment, you would conceive to be for passion, fettering and clinging. Has the dhamma not been taught by me in various ways for dispassion, for disintoxication, for curing thirst, for abolishing attachment, for severing the round of being, for exhausting craving, for dispassion, for cessation, for *Nibbāna*? Have I not described in many ways the abandoning of sensual desires, the full understanding of perceptions of sensual desires, the curing of thirst for sensual desires, the eradication of thoughts of sensual desires, the allaying of the fever of sensual desires? Misguided man, it would be better for you as one gone forth that your member should have entered the mouth of a hideous venomous viper or a cobra than it should have entered a woman. It were better for you that your member should enter into a pit of coals burning, blazing and glowing that it should have entered a woman. Why is that? For the former reason, you would risk death and deadly suffering, but you would not, on the dissolution of the body after death, reappear in a state of privation, in an unhappy destination in perdition, even in hell. But for the latter reason, you would do so. Therefore, misguided man, by this act, you would pursue the Dharma's opposite. You would pursue the low, vulgar ideal that is impure and ends in ablution."

And he carries on like that. You can see he holds no punches, doesn't mince his words, he's very clear about if you undertake the rule then that's what you do, you don't fall for arguments of this and arguments of that.

We also have to balance our idea of the Buddha as somebody who's very clear, very precise about the way he wants people to behave. This *sīla*, this conduct, which we've just chanted before, so the five basic ones, of course, are to do with our moral behavior. What we have to really grasp is that our unethical behavior is a measure of our delusion. Delusion expresses itself in the way we speak, act and what we do. Therefore, whenever we do something wrong, it mirrors back to us the level of our delusion. That's another reason why if you

Ethical Behaviour and the Awakening Are One

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min read

In this profound dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses a common misunderstanding in Buddhist practice: the false separation between wisdom (paññā) and ethical conduct (sīla). Drawing from the Buddha's own description as vijjā-caraṇa-sampanno (accomplished in both understanding and conduct), he demonstrates how insight and ethical behavior arise together as one unified process.

The talk examines the distinction between "Nibbānic Buddhism" (focused on liberation) and "Karmic Buddhism" (focused on merit-making), showing how true practice integrates both. Using the story of Aṅgulimāla and examples from the Noble Eightfold Path, Bhante explains how genuine understanding naturally manifests as compassionate action, while ethical living purifies the heart for deeper insight.

Key concepts explored include kusala (skillful/virtuous action), puñña (merit), and the practical application of ethical reflection in daily life. This teaching offers essential guidance for practitioners seeking to understand how meditation practice and moral conduct work together as inseparable aspects of the path to awakening.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I was just going to talk about this confusion sometimes that people have between *paññā*, insight, the awakening, and *sīla*, conduct. I think it's still in some circles when you say morality, it gets people very angry. They don't want to know about morality as such, or the ethical life. In the chant in the morning, we say of the Buddha that he's *vijjā-caraṇa-sampanno*, that he's accomplished both in his understanding and in his conduct. And he himself says that understanding and conduct are like the Ganges and the Yamuna rivers that join and flow into the sea. He doesn't make a distinction between understanding and how it expresses itself.

Some of you will know that the Eightfold Path is normally split into three sections: *sīla*, *samādhi*, *paññā* — right conduct, right meditation, and right understanding. And that *samādhi* normally usually refers to the absorptions. But in the Buddha's teachings those are not actually necessary, so that the whole teaching can be reduced in terms of

the process of purification and awakening to those two words: *paññā* and *sīla*. *Paññā* is this business of trying to understand how things really are, and *sīla* is right conduct, ethical behaviour. Those two sum up the Buddha's teachings.

But then you'll come across writers who split them. And when you go to the East and you see how people behave, you can understand how they might come to these conclusions from their fieldwork, from their anthropological fieldwork. And one writer talks about Nibbanic Buddhism and Karmic Buddhism. Often when you speak to Eastern Buddhists, or born Buddhists anyway, they won't have a doubt that the end point is to become liberated, *Nibbāna*, and that's the point. But their whole life is really centred around *sīla*, which is right conduct. And when you follow that train of thought through, they're not concerned so much with getting rid of this self, but more in the sense of making it a good self, a happy self, insofar as the self can be happy. And so their whole lives are about doing right things, and this is where the word *kusala* comes in, in order to gain merit, and that's *puñña*. These two words, *kusala* and *puñña*, are also key words in the Buddha's teachings.

And the general idea is that you stop doing harm, you do as much good as you can, and you get reborn in the heavenly realm. And in the heavenly realm, it's a little easier to seek *Nibbāna*. Even amongst monks and nuns, you'll find that that is the prevalent attitude. And you'll find the monks in Sri Lanka — I'm not so sure about Burma and Thailand and other places — but being influenced by Hinduism, the hierarchy will tell you that this is the Kali Yuga. And it's impossible for anybody to become enlightened during this particular time, so forget it. The best thing you can do is to do good and get reborn into a better place. It's a bit disheartening, really. But they're happy with that. In a sense, it's a let-out. I mean, if you say to yourself, I can't become enlightened, phew, I may as well enjoy myself. That's the case. So, you've got to be careful with that sort of mentality.

But both in the actual way the Buddha behaves, his actual behaviour, and in the general teachings, and even in the psychology, what we chant in the morning, you can begin to see that you can't split the one from the other. The one arises out of the other.

There's this point in the Buddha's life once he's become enlightened, once he's become liberated and he has this deep understanding into the way things are and he spends some time recollecting over it. Mythically it's said three nights he goes through this wheel of dependent origination, forward, backward, both forward and backward. But obviously he sat there and that insight had to permeate his understanding. And then at that point there is this idea arise in his head to teach — who can he teach? So that has arisen spontaneously in his mind.

Now when he looks around and he sees through his powers that his old teachers have died. And he gets the doubt. And the doubt is that anybody can receive this teaching. It's too subtle. He doesn't believe for a moment there. He doesn't think that people are ready for this. Now you'll find in some writers that they call this the great hesitation, and they argue that therefore the Buddha's accomplishment is twofold. His accomplishment was both the enlightenment, his liberation, and secondly his teaching, and that he need not necessarily have taught. He could have said, no, I won't, I'll sit here in this bliss until I pop off. And that's where you get some idea that perhaps there's a choice, that you can become liberated and yet not do anything. That it doesn't manifest outwardly into the world.

Supporting that is that myth of the Paccekabuddha, the private Buddha. The person who's become fully liberated, but what it really says about that is that they can't teach. That's the normal thing. Not that they don't want to, they just can't. They don't have the skills or the capacity. And if you think of just ordinary life, sometimes you get people who are very clever in their subject but they just can't get it across. So that's another skill. So in the sense that the Buddha had a special skill whereby he could actually get this stuff across to people is one thing. But the hesitation was only around this — this is just my own understanding — the hesitation was only around whether people were actually ready to receive it. The hesitation wasn't in whether to teach or not. Which is a distinction, isn't it? So the desire to teach, the desire to actually share what he had with others, arose spontaneously after he had understood what it was that he had gained.

In the Zen tradition, you'll hear it said that with wisdom, compassion arises naturally. So it's not possible to continue in the path and for our behaviour not to change. To take it at a ridiculous level, you couldn't have a neurotic Buddha. That would be awful, wouldn't it? Worrying about his fingernails while he's teaching. Worrying whether he'll be liked. Worrying whether he'll get any food today. It doesn't sit, does it? And it would be awful if he were immoral. He's teaching all this stuff and going around robbing banks. So there's something that jars when you consider what the behaviour of somebody who is spiritually advanced might be if it doesn't connect with understanding. There's got to be that immediate connection between a person's understanding and purity. I mean, the whole point is that there's a purification of the heart going on.

So here we are, we're meditating, we're doing this *vipassanā*, and we can see that, A, there's this insight going on, there's this understanding about ourselves and how we're creating suffering for ourselves, but there's also this purification going on. In fact, we are getting less and less depressed, less and less angry, or at least not for such a long

period. And there's a certain progression. If you're not progressing, then you have to look at your practice and find out why. Because that's the point. The point is to progress, both in understanding and in our happiness, our contentedness.

So, that business of the slow gaining of understanding into the way we are, manifesting as good action, is right there in the Noble Eightfold Path. It flows right down. So, right understanding changes your attitude to life. So for the Buddha, once the understanding had come, the compassion arose. And he himself is constantly saying, *anukampā*, he says, out of empathy, out of sympathy, I teach you. Whatever a teacher can do for his students, I've done for you. And then that manifests: right speech, right action, right livelihood.

Now, we also know that it can go back the other way. Depending on your livelihood, you yourself can be changed, can't you? I mean, just imagine now if we all joined the SAS, the Special Army Services. It would be different, wouldn't it? You'd be out there with your machine gun waiting to kill somebody, or at least protecting yourself. So your whole mentality would change, wouldn't it? Or if you, like a policeman — a policeman's always suspicious. A policeman walks in here, he'd be suspicious. I have my brother-in-law in special service. He protects politicians. He's always suspicious. He's got to be. He's trained to be suspicious. He wanted to be suspicious. A teacher never asks a question they don't know the answer. They always make sure they know the answer.

What we do affects us, doesn't it, directly? Our personality, the way we speak, our friendships, our acquaintances, what politics we follow, what particular religion we follow, all that has an effect on us and produces a certain way of behaving, but it also comes with an understanding. And that understanding is either going to take us into further happiness or further unhappiness. So it runs both ways through our understanding, which is at three levels: actually hearing something which has an effect on us that we haven't heard before, through our own mental processes, our own reflection, and then through this direct insight, through direct experience. So our understanding changes. But it can also change by what we do. So there's an intimate relationship between our conduct and our understanding. It would be false to separate that.

So when you understand that, in lay life, because most of the time you have to be doing something, your job, whatever it is, you can really see quite clearly that this is the path, the path of action. What we're actually doing at any present time, at any present moment, is a path leading us either towards or away from this liberation. And therefore, anytime we do something, there is the importance of that moment of reflection about whether it's *kusala* or *akusala*.

Now this word *kusala*, it has two meanings in English. One is that it's skillful. Unfortunately, if you say, well, I'm only doing this because it's skillful, I'm only being good, I'm only being generous and compassionate because it's skillful, then, as it were, the action is taken off the action itself for some future purpose. So I'm being skillful now, so I can be liberated later. And immediately you cut in between these two processes, *paññā* and *sīla*. So it becomes a utilitarian thing. I'm only being good so that I can become enlightened. I'm only helping you so that I can become... See what I mean? There's a split there.

So now you'll often see in the books that that word is translated as skillful. But that's the danger. And it means that a *sīla* itself is not an end in itself. But in fact, the end in this life is perfect conduct, *vijjā-caraṇa-sampanno*, perfected, accomplished in his understanding and his behaviour. So, although we might say skillful in the sense that it's wholesome and it's right and all that, you also have to use the word virtuous. It is virtuous as opposed to being non-virtuous or vicious. And the question is, is virtue an end in itself? Is it?

Is the virtuous life an end in itself? Now, you wouldn't be virtuous if you look at it the other way. You wouldn't be virtuous unless you knew why you're being virtuous. There has to be an insight into it. It needn't be an intellectual insight. It needn't be something that you can scribble on a piece of paper.

When we feel a certain compassion towards somebody, when we want to help somebody, when that feeling comes out, the underlying understanding there is our interrelatedness. So although we can talk about interrelatedness from this high intellectual level, about how things all fit together, about how things are related to each other, everything is conditioned by everything else and all that. The actual experience of it in terms of our relationship to other beings, and to plants and the earth and all that, is this heart relationship of compassion, love, sympathetic joy. And that's a heart understanding.

If you split the two, then you move towards a dry intellectual understanding. And you miss out on the heart level. On the other hand, if you stick with the heart level without some understanding, then it can so easily slip into mawkish behaviour. So that's where we were saying last time about the slippage of compassion into pity or grief.

Now when we have this word *kusala*, this word virtuous or skillful, there's always this follow-on of *puñña*, which translates as merit. And it begins to sound a bit like some Christian doctrines, like grace. And you'll often hear in Buddhist circles — born Buddhists, cultural Buddhists, I don't know what you call them — it's like a bank ac-

count. You've got all this merit, and you can draw on it at any time, and you can share it with people. And that's meritorious, so you get more merit because you've shared your merit. It's a bank account that manufactures itself, which is wonderful, isn't it?

But when you actually read the psychology of the Buddha, this *puñña* has nothing to do with the outside. Of course the outside might change. For instance, if I make a decision to move away from a certain job or a certain set of friendships which I can see are not virtuous, they're not quite supporting the life I want to lead. That movement away may be painful because I have certain friendships. But in doing so, I am moving into another area. The decision takes me into another area of experience which does support me. So we can say that the friendships that I meet here and the job that I'm doing now is my *puñña*. That's my merit for shifting across. But, in a sense, that misses the point. That's all well and good. But the real *puñña*, the real merit, is within the heart itself.

So that's why, when we become fully liberated, in a couple of days, you'll see that there's no more *puñña*. There is no more merit to be had. Because the liberated person is completely full. They're completely contented and completely happy, so they cannot increase their *puñña*. And this is what it says in the scriptures. You can't increase that. That's it, they've made it. Yet they still behave out of this compassionate action. And that's when it becomes selfless, because whether we like it or not, when we do good, we are increasing our own goodness within ourselves. So while we're not liberated, we do get the benefit of this *puñña*. But once a person becomes liberated, then there's no more *puñña*.

I'm reminded of, I think it was Sister Teresa of Lisieux. I think it was Teresa of Lisieux, Saint Teresa of Lisieux. And she was asked, if everybody goes to heaven, some people have obviously been better than others. And everybody's in heaven. So how can you all be happy? Because some will have more happiness than others. Probably a bit of jealousy. And her answer was, well, everybody gets a glass and it's completely full, but each glass is of a different size. Everybody gets a glass and it's completely full, but everybody has a different size, depending on their craftsmanship.

If you look at the different arahats, if you look at the different people of the Buddha's time like Sāriputta and Moggallāna, then you can see that. You can see that quite clearly that they have different areas which for them produce, what can we say, a different type of contentment. So Sāriputta is known as the general of the Dharma. So his whole interest was in understanding and it's understood that he's only second to the Buddha,

perhaps even equal in his understanding to the Buddha. The Buddha definitely praises him as being quite exceptional in his insight. And because of that, because of that whole interest in understanding, he doesn't develop the powers.

Moggallāna, who's the other chief disciple, isn't so interested in that angle of things but develops the powers. And when Moggallāna asks Sāriputta, why don't you develop the powers? Sāriputta's answer is, I'm not interested. Not interested. So there's something about Sāriputta's state, where he is totally content with the way he is, and he doesn't see any point in levitation, or moving from here to there, or doing amazing things. But from Moggallāna's point of view, that was part of his *puñña*, that was part of his happiness.

So there are these three concepts, there are these three different, or three or four different concepts that we have to be fairly clear on just to make sure that we are guiding ourselves properly. *Paññā* and *sīla*, our understanding and our conduct are completely interrelated. And that if we constantly reflect upon our conduct as virtuous, then our understanding will grow naturally. And if we understand that our understanding must be translated into right conduct, then we should progress.

Secondly, that this whole *kamma*, the whole teaching around *kamma* which is action — that's what it is, it's an action, although it also means the consequence of action — has to be guided by our principles, our virtuous principles, which is this *kusala*. So the idea of reflecting about why we're doing something, even the most mundane things, like you might decide that you might want to watch a bit of TV. So when you turn it on, you have to ask yourself, do I want to watch this program or not? What am I putting into my heart when I watch this program? What am I doing to my head when I'm watching this program? And as soon as you see that it's not quite doing you good, then we have to have that strength of will to turn it off.

One exercise that I've set people is to sit in front of your favourite programme, EastEnders, and get a cup of tea, make yourself comfortable. And when the time comes, you don't turn the TV on. You just sit there watching that screen. And just feel that compulsion to actually know what's going on. And your mind's making up little stories, trying to work out, just in case you might have missed the plot. And you keep doing that until you don't want to watch it anymore. You do it every day, or whatever it takes. And then when you're totally equanimous with sitting in front of that screen knowing that EastEnders is on now, then you can turn it back on. When you turn it back on, then you can ask yourself, should I be watching this or not? Should I be watching this program or not?

What about listening to the radio? All of it. TV, it doesn't matter. Whatever entertainment. Friendships. Even going for a walk. Everything has to be questioned. Is this the right thing to be doing now? Is this the virtuous thing to be doing now? Remember, skillful, virtuous. You've got to balance that.

How could you explain that to a friend? Like, I feel maybe it's not a virtuous relationship and I don't want to see your friend. Well, you can be stark. You can say that if you want. I find my relationship with you utterly unskillful and unvirtuous, and I have no wish to see you again. That's it. Well, you can be assured that that would be the end of that relationship. I mean, that's what you call a sword of wisdom. But I'm sure there are more kindly ways of getting the message across that you don't particularly want to see them again. Just showing a lack of interest. Making little white lies. It depends. Well, it's up to you. But at some point, if you decide that a friendship is not virtuous, then you have to get rid of it. Full stop.

Angulimāla. He'd done dreadful things and raised a child when he was found dead. But the Buddha said because he decided to be good, because he'd changed, that it was all forgiven. I mean, isn't there any *kamma*?

Angulimāla is one of these stories like the good thief on the cross. And what the story does is to show that no matter how awful you've been, yet you can become totally liberated. Now, again, you have to make a distinction between this *puñña*, this merit, and... The merit that Angulimāla finished up with when he met the Buddha was an angry — I'm just guessing — an angry, hateful, fearful, vengeful, grudgeful, you name it, full mind. Now that's in his mind.

So when he meets the Buddha and something happens there, some magic happens where he suddenly sees how badly he's behaved and the consequences of it. And remember in those days, the whole idea of *kamma* would have been fully accepted and rebirth and all that and going to the hells. And suddenly when he realizes what he's done, he has to come back on that. So the first thing he does is he joins the order. So immediately, as it were, from what we've been talking about, he cuts away from one type of behaviour into another, like a knife. He just moves out of all that business of murder, whatever it was, into the brahmacharya life. That's a direct cut.

Now, it's said that he was unarmed, round people threw stones at him and bricks and whatnot. Because he was in robes, because of people's respect for people in robes, it seems nobody really went for him, tried to lynch him or anything like that. But he still had that outside effect of children running away from him and people throwing things, spitting at him, things like that. So that's his *kamma*. But that's not... that's only the outside, shall we say, reflection back to him, or that's other people's reaction to him, right?

The process of liberation is now him within himself dealing with all that horror of remorse, guilt, which will be with him because of his past actions. So if you take the Moors murderer, Ian Brady, his biographer — I've not read the book. I don't even know if the book's out, actually. I just read a little bit in the newspaper about it — his biographer asked him, does he ever think about the children he tortured? For those of you who don't know, it's a dreadful thing. He and a woman called Myra Hindley tortured little children, actually put it on cassette, so they were actually heard in court. It was in the 60s. And he was asked by this biographer, does he ever think about the suffering he caused those children? And his answer was, if I did that, it would drive me mad.

So even in the most dastardly of human beings, the most awful of human beings, there's always that seed of compassion, that seed of recognition of our total humanity. So here he is. Now, is he going to be able to turn on that? Is he going to be able to turn around and see it?

Some of you might have read that book, *The Man Who Mistook His Wife for a Hat*. Have you come across that? It's a great old book. Oliver Sacks. Definitely worth a read. And it's just about people with mental illnesses because parts of the brain go. But there's one story in there which is very apt for somebody who is into the Buddha Dharma. There's a man who murders his daughter atrociously, so much so that the facts are never actually publicised, even in court. It's horrific, absolutely horrific. But the man can't remember. He has no memory whatsoever, so they can't convict him. What they can do is put him in a mental home. And in the mental home he acts perfectly normally and within a certain amount of time the staff have enough confidence to let him go out for bike rides. And on one of these bike rides a car hits him and he lands on his head. And this little bump on his head awakens that memory. And according to the book, it took over six months for the staff to stop this man wanting to commit suicide. They had to actually time down. You'd have to read it for the details.

So when Angulimāla, no matter how horrific his murders and all that has been, there is that, being able to turn upon oneself and to sit within himself with his sense of misery, sense of remorse. Now, you see, what we have to understand is that once we've acted, once we've done an act, you can't go back on it. If you steal something, that's it, it is done. You can do something to assuage or to undermine the consequences by slipping the money back that you stole. But the action is done, and therefore the consequence will be there.

That consequence outwardly, the effect of that consequence outwardly will be totally dependent on circumstance completely beyond your control. It might never be known, and you die very rich. On the other hand, it might be known, and you end up in jail.

And all that has been completely out of your ability to control. But this inner guilt, this inner feelings of remorse and all that will be there to be handled. And you'll never escape from that because that's the world you're actually living in. The world we're living in is this mental world that I'm creating. So there's no escape from that.

So it doesn't say how long it took for Angulimāla to become liberated, but it was years. So once he was given the same instructions that we've been given, he would have had to sit with the horror inside him about all the stuff that he's created. And just like we sit with our depressions and our guilts and our remorse, so he would have had to do that. And at some point that would have all passed away, that would have all gone.

Now that for us is one of these stories that allows us to have tremendous hope. Because if somebody who has been truly evil can become liberated within a lifetime, then there's a good chance for us, isn't there? Before next new year, perhaps? I mean, it's like it's a story of hope. It's a story that nobody is incapable of becoming liberated. That's what it means.

And in Buddhist history, there was only one time when there was a heresy where a particular school began to teach that there were some people who were so thick that they just wouldn't be able to make it. And they were called the *icchantikas*, the ones who go on forever. There was no escape from *saṃsāra* for these people. And that's the only time. And of course, that is definitely not mainstream Buddhism.

So that's the underlying hope within the Buddha's teaching. And Angulimāla stands as an example of that. No matter how extreme and horrible we've been, yet the liberation from all suffering is ours to achieve.

So just to sum up there, there's just those things to reflect upon every so often, that relationship between our understanding and our conduct, and the other way around, our conduct and our understanding, that at an ethical level, which is where we're actually creating our mental states which are going to cause us happiness or unhappiness. Is it virtuous, you see? And remember it's not just tied to the basic precepts about not to kill and steal and all that. That's basically fundamental. It now becomes much more subtle about the relationship we ought to have to our own emotions.

So we were talking yesterday about attachment. You can't say attachment's evil. But it's not skillful, it's not virtuous, it's not skillful for the person who is the object of your attachment, because remember, attachment is always coming from the self, and necessarily turns the other person into an object, an object to service your needs. So you dehumanize somebody, actually, as soon as you attach to them, whether you like it or not, which may not be your intention, but that's what happens.

So that business of *kusala*, and to understand that, there's always this *puñña*, this merit, this merit to be gained. So, the spiritual life is constantly rewarding us for what we're doing. There's a reward. There's always this consequence for correct understanding and ethical behaviour.

It doesn't always seem like that, does it? I mean, it's slightly different, but like you just have to drink it down for the last drinks and then drink the drinks I can't see... You know, like your dad says to your mother, how can you be a Buddhist and not a log? The world doesn't seem to get any better, but the practice seems to, the insight seems to get better. Then you go through the barrier, if you like.

When I first began to meditate, I was doing Zen meditation in Birmingham. When I first began to meditate, I had this dream. And the dream was, I was running like mad. Running, running, running, running. And there was a shower of javelins coming after me. And then I stopped, and every javelin just went into my back.

So when we start practicing, that's exactly how it feels. Because you're always running ahead of your suffering. You're always trying to escape your immediate suffering. A bit of discomfort, so you shift your seat. A bit bored, so you phone up a friend. You're always moving off the discomfort. And as soon as you begin practicing, you can't do that anymore. And all that conditioning, all that horrible stuff just hits you from behind of all places. So it definitely feels it's getting worse.

And it's the same when, for instance, when you join the Order. You join anything, actually, even if you join a new group or a new work. There's that lovely honeymoon bit which lasts a few months. And then there's the struggle because you have to enculturate yourself. You have to change into what the institution wants you to change into, behave in a certain way. So the first three years, for some forever, is a miserable process. That torturing, you have to behave in this way. And sometimes it gets, some people don't, some people decide it's not what they want. They don't want to be maneuvered that way.

So the understanding is, in those wonderful terms, it has to get much worse before it gets better. And that's where your faith has to be. You have to hang on in there just to see.

The Buddha as Exemplar and Archetype

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 32 min read

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the Buddha's life as an archetypal spiritual journey, divided into twelve contemplative stages that offer guidance for our own practice. Beginning with the Buddha's initial resolution before Dīpaṅkara Buddha to achieve sammā-sambodhi (complete self-awakening), the talk traces his countless lifetimes of purification, his privileged birth, the four divine messengers (sickness, old age, death, and the ascetic), and the Great Renunciation.

Bhante explores the Buddha's training under meditation masters in jhānic absorption states, his turn to self-mortification practices, and the crucial moment of despair that led to remembering his childhood experience of natural awareness during the ploughing ceremony. The teaching culminates in the Great Determination under the Bodhi tree, the six-hour awakening experience, and his subsequent understanding of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination).

The talk emphasizes how each stage offers practical contemplations for modern practitioners - from making daily spiritual resolutions and crossing our own 'Rubicon' moments, to understanding that the path requires everything while giving nothing back until we make leaps of faith. Bhante addresses the ongoing presence of Māra even after awakening, representing subtle traces of worldly attraction, and concludes with the Buddha's peaceful parinibbāna as the ultimate letting go.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened ones.

So this is just trying to look at the Buddha's life from the point of view as an exemplar. And I've chopped it up into 12 different things so that you can see the sort of passage that he went through, his own peculiar journey. I hate that cliché, but I'll have to use it for the time being.

So it's said that way in the distant mists of time when he was born in a particular era of a particular Buddha called Dipankara, that he met this Buddha and put a cloak down to stop him stepping into a puddle. And he was so amazed by this Buddha that he made there and then a determination to become self-enlightened, a fully self-enlightened Buddha just like this man Dipankara.

Now I don't think it's of any use to try and discuss whether in fact Dipankara ever existed or not, because remember Eastern mythology is very circular and the way that you substantiate a leader is by saying that it's all happened before. So all these eastern traditions have leaders which have come before. The Naganthas is number so and so in a whole line of Naganthas which produced the Jain tradition.

But for us what's important is this act of resolution, an act of resolution to really make the process of purification, the process of enlightenment, the full aim of our lives. And that total determination. Total determination. And in his case, self-enlightened. But although we have this teaching, that doesn't mean to say that we don't become self-enlightened. Because ultimately it's we that have to do the work. All we can say is that the distinction between us and the Buddha was that he gave us some clues as to which way to go. But the fact is that the whole process is completely internally dependent on us.

So that's the first thing that you can contemplate is the importance of making that decision, of making a resolution in your own time and your own way. Now, just to make it once in a lifetime isn't enough, because it has to be constantly reinforced, constantly reinforced. If you think of any other situation in people's lives, for instance, just a partnership or a marriage, they might go through a small ceremony and they think that's it. And of course, seven, 15 years down the line, they're sort of walking away from each other. And the problem has been is that they haven't recommitted themselves, recommitted themselves and gone through the pain of a relationship. Other people are hell, remember. So it's a case of understanding that this resolution, this complete commitment of the heart to the path, is the kernel position you have to take, that resolution. So that's the first thing to contemplate.

The second one, of course, is that after he made this great resolution, he was then born, it is said, for countless lifetimes trying to get it right, trying to get the perfections right, trying to purify his heart. Now again, from our point of view, it's not necessary to believe that he lived thousands of lifetimes, but the myth is telling us that this path is very long, very gradual, and very difficult. Now, I don't want to depress you, but that's what it's telling us, that it's okay to make this decision, but actually, we've entered into a path which is going to demand everything from us, everything, eventually.

In the spiritual life, remember, you don't get anything back until you've given up something. And you never know what you're going to get. It's not like you've got an old car which is broken down and you think, well, I'll get rid of it, I'll go and get a new one. And you know which one you're going to get when you drop yours. In the spiritual life, you don't really know at all what you're going to get until you make that leap of faith and give something up. So that's the next thing, is to really consider that.

And the Buddha, of course, reinforces that in his own teachings. He's constantly telling people this is gradual. It's gradual. There's no sudden enlightenment. Now, I know there are certain schools of Buddhism that talk about the sudden enlightenment, but it's not sudden in that sense at all. If you talk to, for instance, Zen monks about their sudden enlightenment, you find they've been meditating for 25 years before this sudden enlightenment came from them. So it's not nothing in other words. You don't get anything for nothing. You have to go through the training.

And this training is two-fold. It's both the purification of the heart and the growth of the heart. Heart here meaning our whole disposition, our whole disposition. So as soon as you sit you can see these hindrances, you can see these impurities arising. And they're there just within deep conditioning within us. Even if you only believe in appearing in this world just this once with birth, we've picked up all this stuff, all this conditioning, and as soon as you come to sit, then of course the stuff begins to arise. And the whole process of meditation is the purification of that part of us.

But the other side, remember, is the growth of all these perfections. One of them, of course, is resolution, the determination to do what you say you're going to do. And that's one of the things that you can impress upon yourself just these three days. Once you've set yourself the rhythm of the retreat that you want, then you maintain it. That's your discipline, that's your courage, and that's your resolution.

If you fail, of course, you haven't got to get into beating yourself up and saying you're useless and all that. Sometimes you have to have an act of humility to recognize that you've reached too far. So it's always good to make sure that you're not pushing yourself too much, but on the other hand, you are pushing yourself a bit. As one of my early teachers, Roshi Kennett, used to say, that you have to push yourself gently. Some of you know, I think, Roshi Kennett, or used to know her. She started Throstle Hole.

So that's the next thing, is to recognize that the path is one of effort, and it takes that commitment, and that it's one of purification. You have to work at it. You have to really work at it.

So finally, the Buddha's ready for the big thing. He's ready for the full self-enlightenment show. And he's waiting in the Tushita heaven. Just waiting for the opportunity to arise. And there it comes. North India, born to a prince, a local governor. In actuality, he was what you might call a local lord who was under the local king of Kosala. But as it comes to the scriptures, he's this big king in North India. I suppose we would call him that, sort of upper middle class manager.

And he decides there's a decision there to be born. And here's your classic Freudian trauma. His mother dies, mother dies probably because of his birth. And that's that's somewhere in his heart isn't it. And he loses his mother and he's passed on, I think it's a week after he's born, he's passed on to his mother's sister. And he must have felt that. So already, you might say, this little child has not only gone through the pangs of rebirth, but the pangs of losing his mother. So already, as it were, he's come into life with real suffering already in that heart. The touch of suffering is already there. I might be a bit too Freudian there, but you understand what I'm saying.

And he's obviously precocious. Now that shouldn't amaze us. I mean if you think of somebody like Mozart, I think he wrote his first symphony when he was three or something. So when you realise that there are little beings who arise who are absolutely unbelievable, it was obvious that this little boy was something special.

And the tale always goes, and you get it in other myths, that of course they meet the wise man. And the wise man recognizes that here is an extraordinary human being. And what he says about this little human being is that either he'll become a world conqueror, a total world conqueror, or a fully self-enlightened person.

Now, that's the same for us. Now, it's not that we're all going to become world conquerors, but the choice is there. Is our lives going to be devoted to being great in the world or to being great spiritually? And that isn't just a decision we make at the beginning of our lives or somewhere. It's constant. Every time we say to ourselves, well, I'm going to have this cup of tea because I want to really enjoy it, we've chosen the world. If you have a cup of tea in order to investigate the process and with the intention to feed the body, not feed our emotional life with it, then we've chosen the spiritual path. So that division is with us all the time. That's not a problem. And in this particular story, it's put at this very heightened level. Here we have a little being who could have conquered the whole world or he could have become self-enlightened.

So that's the next thing to contemplate, this idea that all the time the choice is there before us, that choice between choosing the world or choosing spiritual life, choosing our enlightenment.

So, of course, when his father heard this, he was in a state of horror, because this was, at that time, his only son. And as far as I know, it remained his only son. I think I'm correct, yeah. So, obviously, he wanted his only son to be heir.

So then we have this part of the myth that tells us that his father went to this great extent to make sure that his son never suffered, make sure he had all the food he wanted and as he grew older all the sex, drugs and rock and roll. And as he approaches

and he gets through teenage and what not, then he comes to a point of going through all that loveliness of getting married and all that. But there must be something, should we say, disturbing him at that point.

And it comes again through a particular myth. Before we go into that, do remember that the whole of our society is drawn, is manufactured, the whole of our economic, political life is there to draw us into the world. The whole of capitalism, everything that we have, is to make us emboldened in the world, is to make us see our life in the world. So he's born into the world and the world wants him. But again, there's this little pain.

And it comes out in the story of his meeting, before *devadūta*, before, how do you translate that? The messengers from the gods. That's how it's put. So he's out there hunting and doing his thing, killing beasts and all that. And he comes across, in sequence, somebody who's very sick on the road there. If you've been to India you know exactly what that means. Somebody who's very old and crooked and really old, a corpse, and finally this ascetic sitting under a tree.

Each time he asks, what is this? Because he's been shielded from this. This is what the myth tells us. He hasn't actually looked at this stuff. And after they've described it to him, there's the kernel question. Does this happen to me?

So here's a young man, full of energy, full of all that virility and all that, and he suddenly sees sickness, old age, and death. And of course there's this ascetic sitting under a tree which in the story symbolises hope, the escape from sickness, old age and death. But for him it's obviously become a psychological crisis. I think what we would call today an identity crisis. He's into a proper identity crisis, an existential identity crisis.

And when does it hit him? It hits him somewhere in his middle 20s. Now if you think of your lives, I don't know about you, how old are you Gabriel? It's coming. So if you think of your life and you look back into your middle 20s, you'll see that there's a change of mentality because there's a sudden, there's a realisation that youth is over. And that's when people get serious. They get married, they take their job seriously, some even take out pensions. And it all happens in that sort of period as you move towards the first ugly inklings of middle age.

So there he is at that point. And he decides that he's got to go and really work this out. He's in a psychological crisis. He needs to work it out. And the only way he can think of doing it is to join the ascetics because they are the only people at that time who are offering anything beyond the worldly life. He probably spent hours talking to the Brahmins, talking about their philosophy and understandings, because later on, of

course, he knows it deeply. He knows all the arguments, and he must have picked it up during that youthful time. He studied the Vedas. So he's sort of abandoned that sort of scholastic thing. He wants to abandon the good life.

And there are two things. Well, the other thing that makes him abandon life is that they've obviously had a big party. And in the morning when he wakes up, he's got all these bodies around him. And there's puke and saliva. It's all horrible. And he sees the other side of pleasure, which is, of course, the hangover. And he sees that pleasure is not going to bring that sort of happiness, it's not going to bring an end to the suffering that he feels, this existential suffering of sickness, old age, and ultimately death.

So it hits hard, doesn't it? Those of you who've had a scrape with death know what he might have been going through. Those of you who've had people who've died around you know that it can hit you hard. In fact, the Buddha says there are four types of people. Those who wake up, in other words, who really see that their life has to be the spiritual dimension, upon the hearing of death, just the word will wake them up. Some don't wake up until they sort of realize that somebody has died, comes on the TV or something. Some people don't wake up until somebody very close to them dies, and some unfortunates don't wake up until, of course, it's their turn to die. So you don't want to leave it that late.

So there he is, and two things have shaken him. Sickness, old age, and death, and the vanity, the emptiness of pleasure, of worldly pleasure, the emptiness of it. Even sex, for instance, which might bring a lot of pleasure, is ultimately empty. Or just sex, shall we say. And I always remember Woody Allen saying that the experience of sex is an empty experience, but as empty experiences go... So, it's that sort of realization.

And for us, we wouldn't be here now, actually. We wouldn't at all be in this room, any of us, if we hadn't had some sort of inkling around those sort of areas. But, again, it's not something that becomes a huge crisis for everybody. It's something that can be very gradual, a gradual pulling away because of the little bits of suffering that come from it, little bits of realization.

And of course, our own bodies are our own teachers. That's why I said this morning at the meal time, we're so dependent on the body for our teaching, because it's the body which gets ill, it's the body which grows old, and it's the body which dies. And it's when we realise that we are embodied, we are actually in this body, this body is the way we know the world, it's the way we experience the world, that we suddenly realise, or we begin to realise, that in fact we take care of it, not smash it around too much.

So those are contemplations, those are daily, hourly, moment to moment contemplations. As it arises one contemplates that, one reflects upon these things. And what it's urging us to do is to abandon, is to let go, is not to attach to these things. Remember, when we talk about abandonment, letting go, it's not a destruction. We're not talking about not eating. We talk about eating in a particular way.

So take, for instance, sleep. We're not talking about abandoning sleep, because it's a lovely time and we all want to spend some time in oblivion every day. It's recognizing that sleep has a purpose, it's there to rest the body. But if we seek happiness in oblivion, then of course the bed constantly beckons us. Every time we feel a bit tired, we launch ourselves onto the bed. So as you go to bed you look upon it as a stinking pit. So you don't see it as a place where you're going to get pleasure, it's just there to rest the body. Just like food is there to nourish the body. These are contemplations to be taken up.

So he's now on the point now of leaving. So here's what's known as the Great Renunciation. The Great Renunciation. And it's not as though people haven't done this before. Both men and women have had to leave everything to go to war, for instance. People are often drawn out of their style of life for one reason or another. Some people are shaken and they leave everything. Some people are kicked out anyway. Some, I can't remember the Churchillian things, some are born to leave, some have to leave and whatever.

So there comes this point where he abandons, he renounces the worldly life. And it's put in the story that he even saw the birth of his son. So there's that huge attachment to this little child. And yet even so he gets on his favorite horse, his special horse Kanthaka with his servant Channa, and off he goes.

These days that can be, I think, harshly judged as sort of his abandoning his family and all that. But you must remember in those days they're very extended families and I can't imagine that he did it without long consultation and argument and all that sort of stuff and cajoling. And then finally I'm sure he said to them, as I said to my mother, I'm only doing it for three years. When I said that she disappeared with this cloud of absolute... I said to her I'm going to join the order and she just collapsed into this awful weeping and I put my arm around and said mom, I said, I'm only going for three years. And she stopped. It was just because it was because, yes, because she saw it as an abandonment. So one presumes that he did have the goodwill of the family behind him.

And there comes this point where he reaches a river. So here it is, crossing the Rubicon. See, there's a point where we make that crossing, where we've built up the faith, we've built up the understanding, and finally we make that leap of faith. Now, in terms of the Buddha, okay, it was a big dramatic moment. It's part of the myth. But for us, it's

every day. Every day you have to make that leap of faith. Every day you've got to cross that Rubicon. And it's crossing from what? It's crossing from the worldly life to the spiritual life.

And he cuts off all his hair, which was the idea of those days, throws all his rich clothes away, dons rag robes. And even leaves his horse, Kanthaka, who dies out of grief. See? It was terrible. But Channa can't leave him. I think he follows him in the end. Is that right? He follows him, doesn't he, Channa? Eventually. Later on, is it? No, that's right. So he goes off first. So there we have it. So finally, you might say, he's cut from the world in life.

So that's another point of contemplation for us. In our own lives, the idea that we have to really make that commitment some way. And that's the whole point really of taking, in the Buddhist tradition, taking refuges and precepts, of actually joining a specific tradition within Buddhism. It's in all religions. And that's why it's always ceremonious. That's why it's always done in community. It's just like a marriage ceremony.

People I know who've been in partnership for a long time. I mean, I did a little marriage ceremony for a very old friend of mine. Partnership for 15 years. But then a marriage ceremony was something else. It deepens the commitment to the person. It's a funny thing, but anybody who's been in a long relationship who goes to a marriage ceremony, and I'm not talking about a religious thing, it's a communal declaration. Much the way, say, the Quakers do it. And it has an effect. It has an effect of deepening that commitment to the other person as person, as an individual.

So you'll find that in all traditions there is that ceremony of being of commitment by the person. And when I myself became a Buddhist, I did it up at Throstle Hall, and it's five days. So it's not just a matter of saying a few words. It was a five-day long... There were five different ceremonies. And it was all about this business of renouncing, of burning one's *kamma*. I can't remember the full gist of it now, but by the end of it, you definitely felt you'd joined something. And there was that feeling of settlement. There was that feeling of coming home.

That's one of the big feelings in the spiritual life, that finally you've found your tradition, you've found your teacher. And it might, I mean, as you know, I didn't stay in the same tradition, I started with Zen. It's not as though it's blocked in time, that you can't move, but there's that feeling of grounding yourself finally in a spiritual practice. So that's this crossing of the Rubicon, that's this crossing of the river, and letting go.

So then he joins the great meditation traditions of the time and he goes through two teachers. And what these teachers teach him is how to establish ecstasy within himself. And that means that you don't actually need the world. Just through the practices of *samatha* meditation, concentration meditation, the practices of mantra, the practices of what we call looking at *kasīnas*, images, which you then internalize, one begins to recognize that you can actually attain enormous ecstasy within your own heart without any help from the outside world at all.

So you don't need sex, drugs, rock and roll, you don't need cinema, you don't need anything. You can actually sit there and develop this enormous state within yourself because that's the capability of the mind and heart within itself. And once you've established it on an object and you've internalized it, you don't even need that object. So one of the main places is using the breath. So you just need the body as it were. So all you need is, in India anyway, all you need is a bit of shelter, a tree, a bit of clothes, somebody to give you a bit of rice every day, and you sit in ecstasy. And that's it. So you can imagine why it was attractive. This is one of the attractions of the monastic life for those who can practice it. It's not within everybody's gift.

So what does that teach us? That teaches us that there is another way of actually producing happiness. But every time he came out of these states, he found himself back in dear old Gautama, back in dear old Siddhartha, just lumped with all this suffering. It wasn't an answer to sickness, old age and death. It wasn't an answer to his existential crisis. It was just another way of displacing his life into a cloud of beauty. A pink cloud. It was lovely when he was there, but when he came out, it was pretty horrible.

And of course you can get addicted to that like any drug. So as soon as he began to realize this, of course he recognized that that wasn't the path. And each time it is said he was so brilliant at his meditation that the teacher would ask him to be a teacher with him. And each time he said, well, I can't, I don't, I'm not fully satisfied. There must be something else.

So that's the first thing, that when in your meditation beautiful states arise, fine, we're not trying to get rid of them, we're not trying to destroy beauty or happiness, but that's not the end of the path, that's not what it's about. So it arises, fantastic, and then you notice it passing away. And when you see yourself grasping for it as it's passing away, when you come back to the meditation hall with the intention of re-establishing that state, then know that you've fallen into a relationship of attachment, which could cause suffering, which could cause dissatisfaction.

So then abandoning that, he then went into self-mortification. Now the psychology of self-mortification rests on the idea that all suffering is bodily based. Now if you think about that, most of it is. Where do you experience suffering if it's not in the body? The hunger, wanting to eat, wanting to see something. Just the physical pain of the body.

So self-mortification or those exercises, especially the one that he chose, which was to starve oneself, really reduces the body to, shall we say, almost a skeletal state where, as it were, suffering is lessened in the body. Now, for those of you, if you've done a 10, if you've done a, anybody done a 10-day fast? Right. So I don't know whether you experienced it, but normally the first three days are horrible because there's this huge, all these horrible things are pouring out of the body. But then you keep drinking water and then there suddenly comes this place where it's absolutely beautiful. And it remains like that. It's just absolutely beautiful. The body doesn't feel hungry. Of course, it's eating itself, but it doesn't feel hungry. And your passions are down. You don't feel passionate about anything. Everything is lovely subdued, beautifully subdued. And, of course, you can go on like that until you get close to death, and I think it begins to hurt.

So the idea is just to eat enough just to keep that idea of the body of not exciting the body because it's all based excitement has its base in the senses. So all that happened there of course was that he obviously reached these points of suffering and there came this point where we could say he despaired. You're despaired.

Now, that will come to us, the sense of despair about our practice. And it comes to us because of expectation. It comes to us because we think we should be somewhere else than where we are. So there will come these little moments in our spiritual life where we think, nothing's happening, I'm not getting anywhere, and all this sort of stuff. And they're little jabs of despair. So you have to be careful of those.

He himself abandoned that self-mortification business and with it his five disciples left him because he said he'd gone soft. So anyway he wanders off by himself and he's sitting on the roadside and a woman comes along with a bowl of rice pudding which is a very sacred food in Buddhism. So he comes along with this bowl of rice pudding and she sees this monk by the roadside and the myth tells us that she thought that it was a god and she offered this food to a god. But I think we can realistically say that what she saw was somebody who was on death's door and looking pretty sad and she probably was carrying it to some sort of family as a gift and when she had a little chat with him she said look you better have this rice pudding.

So he eats this rice pudding and of course it lifts, it lifts his body, it lifts his spirits. And he can't let go of the idea that there must be an end to suffering. It's there within the kernel, the idea is within him. And he must have been reviewing his life and he must have been reviewing everything he's been through and perhaps he's wandered over the three years that he promised his family and he's thinking he might go back.

And as he's reviewing he remembers this point in childhood. And he must have been about six, seven, maybe eight, and he's watching his father during the ploughing ceremony, just watching his father. And for some reason, he remembers the quality of that watching, something which obviously he hadn't been aware of, either through the *jhānic* meditations, the absorption meditations, or through all these practices which are to do with self-mortification.

And if you think about it, that's quite reasonable because all those practices are about gaining something, about getting something. You're doing something for something else. I'm doing the *jhāna* in order to get over sickness, old age and death. I'm self-mortificating in order to get over. So it's always drawing that person out of the present moment. But here he remembers this point where he's watching his father and he's just in the present moment.

Now, if you think of children, especially around the age of three, four, two, three, four, you see it comes naturally. They see a bug and you see they just absorb into it. Now they don't have the language to think about it. And they just absorb into it just out of a total interest. They're completely there. And one of the signs that a child is in that state, and we ourselves in that state, is the jaw drops. And you get parents like my old man used to tell me to shut my mouth. Shut your mouth son. You see kids don't you see. And what it is is that when there's no jaw when there's no tongue there's no thought. If you're in your meditation you might catch that when a thought comes there's a vibration on the tongue because it's just so intimately connected.

So it's just like a child, just an absorb into that. And then after the absorption, after that business of taking in the image, then there's a stop and the child turns around and says, what is it? So mum says, it's a slug. So from that point on, there's a title, there's a name, it's a slug. So that child will never look at a slug again. What they will see is the image that they had of a slug imposed upon the slug that they now see. And that's the whole distortion that conceptual thinking does for us.

To get back through all that language and all that conception, back to the original mind, back to that original way of seeing things, is the process of enlightenment. Because once we're back there we're back to that amazing intelligence that we have which is now informed. That's the paradox. It's been informed through language. We

couldn't have got here without language. We couldn't have got here without the teaching. But now the intelligence is informed, it clarifies itself of all those conceptual thinking and it sees anew.

So here's the Buddha. He remembers that moment and he's so inspired by it. And also remember he's despaired. He knows now this is it because he doesn't see anything else. He's been through all the traditions. He's done everything. The world can't offer him anything else. So he approaches the tree which we now call the Bodhi tree of course. And interestingly enough the leaves are shaped like a heart are they not? And he sits under this big leafy Bodhi tree by the side of the river and he makes this great determination.

So we've had the great renunciation. So now we have the great determination. And the determination is right, I've done everything, this is it, I'm going to sit here and crack this problem or I will die. Or I will die. That's the commitment.

And it was interesting because when one of my teachers came to the *vihāra* in Birmingham and I'd been, I was already ordained for about four or five years or something. And he came along and I'd been practicing a little bit in India, I remember, but I was living at the *vihāra* anyway. And I'd been to Burma before and I'd got very ill with amoebic dysentery and amoebic hepatitis and all sorts of things. And he wanted me to join him, and he sent one of the monks to tell me, he said, he said, if Anita wants you to come and join him. So I said, well, frankly, I said, the last time I was in Burma, I nearly died. I said, I don't particularly have a, I really don't want to go east again. So he went back, and he came back with a message. If you're not prepared to die, forget it. So obviously he was mirroring back to me the memory of the Buddha.

So there's the Buddha. He's now made this great determination. So for us, it's little bits, making that determination, determination. So every time you sit, one of the big mistakes we make is because it's become habitual, we just take a seat. We just sit here. And of course, nothing much happens. The mind wanders, we just get caught up in it, and we might feel a bit more relaxed. So every time you sit, you have to re-establish that commitment. And that's your determination. It's not a great determination, we don't have to worry too much about death. It's a great determination here, now. The great determination to commit ourselves 101% to this moment of meditation. And that's when you get the fruit. That's when you get the fruits of your practice.

So, as the story goes, of course, he did become enlightened. It took him six hours. There's your standard. If you can sit six hours, you'll probably make it. So, he became enlightened at that point.

Now, he then spends the first night, the first three nights, trying to understand what he's seen. Now, when we chant in the morning, I chant the Wheel of Dependent Origination. So that's the psychology, that's what he understood. It tells us about why we suffer, the psychology of suffering. And I do it three times in the thing to commemorate that moment, because he went forward on it, then he saw how it came back on itself, and then he did it again, forward and back, to make sure that he had fully understood the process. So that's what that chanting is about. It commemorates that moment. And that victory verse is what he was supposed to have told Ananda was what he spontaneously spoke when he became enlightened.

So now, having done that, having now made this, which is a moment of realization, realizing what the whole thing was, what is the next thought? What is the next thought that comes to mind? Who can I teach? With wisdom, compassion arises naturally. There was no break within that. It's not, ah, I've done it, fine, great, get back into bed. It was like it didn't end there. There was this immediate movement out of the heart. Who can I teach?

And of course, there's that little doubt. And again, it's put mythically as the great Brahma Sahampati comes down and says to him, look, he says, there are some with only a little dust in their eyes. There are people who will understand this stuff. So it's with that sort of reflection that when he looks at the world, he thinks, who is going to understand this stuff? And then when he reflects, well, what about my old teachers? And then he realizes they're dead, they've gone. So there's a sadness.

And I saw this lovely statue in Burma the last time I was there. I'd never seen this before. And he sat in posture like this, but one hand is pointed to his heart like this. And I said to them, what's the meaning of that? I'd never seen that *mudrā*. It's called a *mudrā* posture. He says it's the sadness he felt when he realized his teachers had died.

So, having done that, he then thinks about this five disciples, remember, who've called him a scab and a deserter, and sort of turned away from him and gone off. And he wanders off, and he walks, I think it's well

Meditation and Ordinary Daily Life

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 27 min read

In this comprehensive talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses the common difficulty practitioners face in connecting meditation practice with daily life. Drawing from his early experience with Zen Buddhism, he explains how awareness at the six sense doors creates a natural bridge between formal sitting practice and worldly activities. The talk explores the Buddha's teaching on 'the all' (sabbam) - the totality of consciousness experienced through the six senses - and how we live within this 'bubble of consciousness.' Bhante explains the Vipassanā method of stepping back from our usual identification with thoughts, emotions, and sensations to observe them objectively. He describes how this cultivation of detached awareness leads to stillness of thought, calmness of heart, and stillness of body. The discussion then examines how this wisdom naturally expresses itself through the Noble Eightfold Path, particularly right speech, right action, and right livelihood. Emphasizing service as the proper attitude toward work, Bhante shows how meditation prepares us to engage with the world from a place of care and attention rather than self-centered desire. The talk concludes with practical advice for maintaining awareness throughout daily activities, including strategic pausing, time boundaries for tasks, and regular morning and evening meditation sessions to support continuous mindfulness.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

There's always this blank when I begin a talk. It starts somewhere. I suppose what I'd like to do is make a link between what we're doing in meditation and what we do in the world out there. And people find that difficult. I was rather fortunate. When I say people find it difficult, I mean people in this particular tradition, especially Theravāda, also in other traditions, but I always feel fortunate because I began with Zen Buddhism up in North England, the Throstile Hole Abbey Foundation.

And Zen practice is very much based on work. You do a lot of work, physical work. I'm talking about the monastic routine up there. Obviously when they do a special course of just meditation there tends to be more meditation — they call it a sesshin — but just in their ordinary daily rota they do a lot of work, physical work. They keep gar-

dens. And this came about because of the history of Buddhism in China which then spread to Japan where the idea of begging was just not on. And so the Chinese monks began to grow their own food, things like that.

The reason you worked hard — I mean you put a lot of energy into it — was because in the work you got your concentration and your mindfulness so that when you went to sit there was that attention, there was the ability to watch. So that mixture of working, even though it was physical work, and meditation, made it quite easy for me to see how the meditation worked in daily life, how it just moved into it. There was no real thought about it, it just went into daily life. Whatever you were doing, you attended to it.

And one thing that helps, of course, is the way that Zen or Chan or Dzogchen — some of you might know Dzogchen from the Tibetan tradition — begin their meditation. You might describe it as awareness at the six sense doors. In Buddhism you have the five senses, which we're all aware of, and the sixth sense, which is the mind itself. It's a sensing thing, it receives. It receives thoughts, it receives emotions. And being at the forefront, within the all, it's easy to maintain that general awareness when you go out into the world. So there didn't seem to be this huge distinction.

Now I just used the word there, the all. That's the Buddha, you see. He says the all. The six senses is the all. So to understand that, we have to get the idea that we are actually living in this bubble, this bubble of consciousness. It doesn't have an edge to it which is contained. It's just this space. So at this present time, in terms of my eye consciousness, I'm just caught within this room. It's difficult for me to see outside this room. So visually, I'm caught within the bubble of this visual consciousness. And that's all I know, isn't it? And it's a truism — all you know is what you know. You can't go beyond what you know, and what you know is that which the senses give you and your own mind and your own heart. There's nothing else. You can't go beyond that. So in a sense we're living in this enclosed little universe of my consciousness. And it's obviously similar, but different from yours. Otherwise we couldn't communicate.

But walking into this room, nobody will deny that the room has, as it were, its own existence, for want of a better word. So if we all leave, nobody believes the room disappears. It's not here because we see it. But on the other hand, thinking subjectively, this room, there exist as many rooms as there are people in it, in terms of how the room is experienced. So we all walk in here and there's your room and my room, and with it we have our relationship to it.

So that's the all, that's the all that the Buddha's talking about. Within that all, there is the whole of *saṃsāra*, the whole of onward going, the whole of unsatisfactoriness, and within that whole, eventually, is the Nibbanic experience. So the Nibbanic experience

isn't outside consciousness — we're not going somewhere to experience *Nibbāna*. It's not like you take a train down from Manchester to London, and it's over there. *Nibbāna* is simply another way of being in the world.

So what we're investigating is the way we're being, or perhaps better, becoming — this constant sense of becoming somebody in the world. So now, with the Zen Dzogchen approach, that distance between being up in the front of your mind, as it were, and then going out into the world didn't seem so separate.

But in this other tradition, which is the Theravāda tradition, and also in the Tibetan tradition known as the Mahāmudrā tradition, they also have this form of meditation. We're actually trying to find within ourselves an observation post, a position which is at the interface of consciousness and what the mind is offering, what the senses are offering. It's as though we've stepped out of ourselves, stood behind it and just watched. Or above it or below it, it doesn't matter what image you want to use. But it's as though we are exiting from the personality. Yeah? Finding a place where you're up front as to where thoughts arise. They arise there.

Now, you see, as I'm speaking to you now, I can't be looking at my thoughts that way, or else I'd lose it. If I become objective to my thoughts, I'll just know thinking, and the talk comes to an end and we'll have to do some walking meditation. I can't do... I've got to be up there in the thought.

So it's the same with my emotional life. If I'm now, say, depressed, and I start feeling my depression, well, it's going to be really depressing for you all, because I'm just going to express how depressed I am. Somehow, I've got to maintain that distance, but in a sense, when I'm talking, I've got to manufacture. I've got to manufacture a particular mood to go with the talk. I manufacture a particular mood to go with when I meet somebody. I know happiness arises. So but I've got to be up there, I've got to be in that emotion as it were.

Whereas here I can somehow step behind it, I can see it, I can point to it. So I can say joy and it's there as it were in front of me. When we have a pain — a headache or something — and we're trying to do some work, it's there, we're in it, it's very difficult for us to separate entirely from it and we immediately search for pills to get rid of it. But here I can form a space as it were between that which knows — the knowing — and the headache, the knee ache, the back ache. The sneeze. I can see the body going, "Achoo," like that in front of me.

So there's some way in which I can objectify the whole psychophysical organism that usually I'm in. I'm in it and being it, walking around the world as this being. And to do that, we use this little technique of pointing with a word. You don't have to do that. There are perfectly viable *vipassanā* techniques that don't do the pointing with the word. But they still get that position. They still know it as an object.

The reason why the noting is there is, as we discussed last night, just to keep the intellect pointed, but there's a more subtle reason in that even when you are not using a word, you are still conceptualising what you look at. You're still seeing it by way of a concept. So just to say the word, at least as it were, brings that concept to mind, and then we can move towards it.

So one thing might be, you see, is that you might have an itch. So you recognise it, itching, itching, and you can feel it. I've got one in here now. And you feel the itching, and so long as I say itching, there comes that whole response to it. Got to scratch it, get rid of the itch. If I can just keep saying itching, but I put my attention directly on to the sensation, it's as though I'm going beyond the idea of itching, and when that idea of itching goes, the idea of reacting to it goes, because I only react to something that I recognise. When I get down to an itch as an itch, as it really manifests in the body, it's just a little sense disturbance, like a little scratching on the surface of the skin. And being with that, it means that this awareness I've got, this intelligence I've got, is pulling itself out of its embeddedness, confusion with the intellect.

When I was at the college I used to work at, I once went to a colleague who was a fundamental materialist. There is the body, full stop — when you're dead that's the end of it. And I said to him, is there an intelligence which doesn't think? And he looked at me. We used to have these silly conversations. And he looked at me, and just for a moment, he looked. And he never said it. He just turned around and walked away. And I was left with the guy thinking, what the hell have I said? And he took about ten, twenty paces, stopped, turned around, came straight back at me and said, "No," and then walked off. So presumably he's still stuck in the mire of delusion.

So what we recognise by noting and by seeing thought, by recognising thought, there must be something that recognises the thought. There must be something outside thought which knows thought. And then we begin to see that thought is just there.

What do we mean by concept? They're symbols, aren't they? They're just symbols which carry history. If I say, for instance, ice cream. What comes immediately? It's not just the word, is it? A cornet came with a swirl of ice cream. And then I'm on the beach and there's donkeys. There's all sorts of things. Blackpool and stuff. All these things

come up just with the word ice cream. If you said it to me another time, I might get a whole load of different history. And there comes with it this deliciousness. See, got to have an ice cream.

So whenever we have a word, we always bring with it our understanding, which is historical, and our emotional involvement in whatever it is that we're conceiving. And that's okay. That's okay. You need it in ordinary life. But here, in our meditation, we actually want to see that process and how it stops us from directly experiencing what we're actually experiencing.

So, for instance, today we had lasagne. Am I correct? I think it was lasagne. So, there'll be, I'm sure there'll be amongst us, a specialised cook who knows what exactly a lasagne ought to be, what it should be cooked. So the pasta was not al dente. It wasn't quite right. Teeth should go through it, but there should be a hardness to it. It shouldn't be too soft. If there's a little hardness in the middle, it's not properly... So anybody going there with a concept of what lasagne ought to be like because they are this expert lasagne user, they might not like that at all. They might have formed a real aversion to it, unable to eat it. You get that with gourmets, don't you? It's terrible, take it away, I can't stand it. And it's perfectly good food.

So, as we're eating, we can see how the concept is affecting us. The chips. So, when the chips came, I thought, oh, it's lovely. The chips came, but I had no vinegar, so I could feel this disappointment. I had salt, but I had no vinegar. Where's the vinegar? And I thought, well, relax. It's not the end of the world. Chips without vinegar. No HP. Terrible. And this just arises naturally because of my conditioning with chips. What can you do? If you battle that, if you think, well, you shouldn't be thinking that. That's terrible. That's just suppressive, isn't it? You're just layering another negativity.

So here we are, we're taking this position always behind the mind, if you'll excuse that image, and you're just watching things arise and pass away. I mean, what is there? There's sensations, sensations coming from the body, pleasant, unpleasant, feelings from the heart, pleasant, unpleasant, thoughts and images. That's it. And it all works in unison with different little habits and it produces this personality. And the personality changes, doesn't it? You're this way with this person and then you're slightly different with another person and you're slightly different when you're by yourself. It's not as though the personality is a static thing. It's got all sorts of shades and nuances depending on the situation you're in. Different types of habits arise.

Next time you happen to talk to a policeman, just watch your body. Or even seeing a policeman as well. All the guilt comes up. Not me. I didn't do it. Or when you're standing next to somebody over whom you have some sort of position. You just watch your

body posture. You always lift it. Lift your chin. Even if the person is six foot six. Just engaging. And if you walk into a room of somebody whom you have to have respect for, even a doctor — very few people have the old respect for doctors. But even so, walking into a doctor, just notice, you just lower yourself a bit. But this is just normal body language. In the West, where we've come to this wonderful state of total equality, of course, we deny all this. We behave as though we're all perfectly equal. But in fact, if you watch yourself closely, you change. You change depending on who you meet, who you're with.

One of the more obvious ones is when you meet little children. You suddenly take on this baby voice and act in a stupid way. The kid thinks there's something wrong with this adult. As far as you're concerned, you have this special communication with a child. "Hello, how are you doing?"

So here we are, taking this position within ourselves, and the process is a detachment. We're not getting involved. It's one of allowing things to manifest and watching them die away. So it's very passive. It's not active. We're not actually manufacturing anything in the mind. What it's leading us to is a stillness of thought, a complete calmness of the heart, and a stillness of the body. Silence in the mind, calmness in the heart, stillness in the body. That's what *vipassanā* would lead you to. It would lead you to that point of just bringing all that energy, finally just rolling down to this perfect stasis. Perfect stasis.

Now, if that was it, if that was the end of the plot, then of course that would be the end of the practice. You would just meditate, come to this end point and that would be it. Now if you go back to the Buddha's life, so he's struggling to find a way out of his question. Why do we suffer? Why are we unhappy? Why don't we find perfect fulfilment? Why am I here? All these existential questions.

And just as an aside, remember that he remembers this point in childhood. This is really very crucial, very important. These stories that come through, they give you a pointer as to where the insight about how to go beyond suffering comes. He's tried all these different methods, the absorptions and the mortifications. And he comes to this point, he remembers this point in childhood, where he's watching his father doing the plowing ceremony.

So what is it about that attention that he had there, which is different from all the attention that he'd got through all this practice with these teachers, and through his mortification practices? And it goes back to that mind, that the child has best recognised before seven — that pre-conceptual, when the mind, before it begins to really proliferate, where you can see, especially young children, where they might see something

which they'd never seen before, a bug or something. I have a picture of two little girls watching this bug and it's perfect. And they just lock on to it. It's like the world shuts down. And all they know is this little bug. And the jaw drops.

Now, that's why in your meditation the jaw has to be relaxed. Because the jaw and the tongue are intimately connected to thought. And sometimes you'll actually catch, if you watch, you'll actually catch your tongue moving with thought. It's already ready to speak. It's just tickling away on the top. So by relaxing that, you immediately relax the whole process of thinking.

And after it's actually observed this little bug, only then, when it's absorbed it, when it's really absorbed what it's looking at, will it ask for its name. And once it's told it's a beetle, it has a concept and a history. So the next time it sees a beetle, it's much more interested to tell the parent that it recognises what it is — a beetle. But it's not seen the beetle. It's not seeing the beetle like it saw the beetle before. From now on, all beetles are seen with that history, with that word, with that concept. Even if the beetle is slightly different, it's still a beetle. That's a beetle. That's the end of it.

And that's what we're doing. We're not seeing what's coming in without the clarity of that historical garbage that comes with everything that we experience. So here, we're trying to cleanse that. And that means that we have to go through the process of very gently allowing the mind to calm down, to bring it to a stop. Calm down, bring it to a stop. To let these emotions become, to let them express themselves, because that's the emotional history we have. That's the baggage we're carrying from all the past. And to allow it to pass away, to burn itself out.

Now, if that were the end of the process, when the Buddha was enlightened, that would have been it, wouldn't it? He'd have just turned into a blob. He'd have just sat there and people would have come and said, what's wrong with you? And he wouldn't be able to speak, would he? He'd have just said, "Ugh," or something. I mean, enlightened, shut up, go away. So he just sat there and did nothing because he's done it. He's perfectly happy.

But peculiarly enough, that doesn't happen at all. The first thought, or the first thoughts that arise in his mind is, who? Who can I teach this to? Who can I teach this to? So now we have a very different thing arising. There must be some connection. There must be some connection between this wisdom, this intelligence we have, and the world it finds itself in, the world it finds itself in, and the people that it finds itself connected to.

Now that's put into the Eightfold Path. So as soon as there is right understanding, there moves into a right attitude. And it happens naturally. I mean, we do have exercises. We do *mettā* practice. That's a practice on developing goodwill, developing our compassion. There are all sorts of practices in Buddhism to do that. But actually, it's not necessary because that wisdom will always want to express itself.

How do we know this wisdom always wants to express itself? Because this same intelligence, which has now become, shall we say, very wise, when it was deluded, wanted to express itself. So this intelligence we have, this intuitive intelligence, is always in a state of wanting to express what it knows. And the reason for that is that it doesn't know what it knows until it's expressed. If it did not express anything, it would stay in a complete state of original ignorance.

And that's the beginning of the Eightfold Path, the one that we chant in the morning. *Avijjā*, not knowing. This ignorance isn't a culpable thing. It's not as though we're evil because we don't know. We don't know because we don't know. So it's like little children. They don't know. They have to be taught. So it's a case of not knowing. It's the function, it's the inner quality of intelligence that it wants to know. That's how it's defined. It wants to know. Intelligence wants to know.

And in wanting to know, it needs to be able to know it knows. And it can only know it knows when it expresses something, when it says something, paints something, creates music, talks to people, relates to people, does something in the world, creates something in the world, a business, whatever it is. Those are all expressions of the either delusive nature in our intelligence or its wisdom nature. So in other words, you can't exist and not express. Otherwise you just remain a vegetable.

So there's the Buddha. He's become fully enlightened. And he says, I've attained the unconditioned consciousness. Unconditioned. Perhaps a better word is unbound, unbounded. So this intelligence that we have, it's bounded, it's caught up in the sensual world. So it thinks itself to be what it sees, and the seeing process. It experiences itself as not only the hearing, but I hear, I am the one who hears. That binds us to hearing, and it binds us to seeking in hearing the happiness that it craves.

I mean, what is suffering? I don't mean, that's not a definition of suffering. I mean, what is it that is suffering? Does the body suffer? I mean, when you get pain in the knees, is the body suffering? It's just a sensation, isn't it? The knee isn't saying, "Ouch, I'm suffering." The knee is just giving off certain sensations. When you're depressed and the depression is there in front of you, is the depression depressed about being de-

pressed? The depression is just a feeling. It doesn't have any intelligence. It doesn't know anything. It's just there as depression. Does the word, does the intellect understand what it's actually saying? Words are just little symbols, aren't they?

So that which understands, that which has a relationship to emotions, that which has a knowledge, understanding of sensations from the body, that is something else. So it must be that that suffers. So the answer lies not in the pain of the body, or in the emotional state of the heart, or in the way the mind thinks, but in the relationship that this intelligence has to the psychophysical organism it finds itself in.

So the relationship we have now is, this is me. And because of that, we're constantly expecting this to give us that sense of peace and joy, calm, that we want. And we get upset when it doesn't. Pain in the knee, and all that.

So, there's an intimate link between the wisdom that we gain from observing ourselves, the purity that we gain from allowing these emotions to expend their energy, and the new attitudes that arise in the heart which we recognise as sharing, love, giving, generosity, compassion, sympathetic joy, because of that communication we have with other people. And when that drops further outward, as it were, as an expression, even if you're stuck there with this love, what use is that?

If you went to a cave and just sat there and said, "May all beings be happy." Well, you might. Of course, you might. I mean, I'm not being cynical about this. You might be sending out waves, colossal waves of love with changing the world and all that. But in a sense, it might also be just you in this cave feeling very happy about how much you love people. And if somebody comes along and says, "Can you help me shift this bowl?" You say, "Go away. Don't disturb me, I'm in a state of perfect love here."

So, you can get stuck at these stages. You might think, well, the whole purpose of life is just to sit and meditate and get into this perfect state of peace and happiness. But that's not what the Buddha did. Remember that he's the exemplar, he's the paradigm of our path. And you might think, well, in that case, I might stop that attitude and just develop this huge compassion, the Buddha heart. But that just turns you into just a self-regarding person. You just sit there beaming out this love.

So it has to move out, it has to express itself, and it expresses itself through right speech, right action, and right livelihood. So you can see how the Eightfold Path just follows, follows the one after the other. So the way we speak, the way we communicate is an expression of that heart, the kindness, compassionate way, sympathy, joyfulness, which is an expression of our understanding, of the way we relate to the world.

When we start doing something, it's done with that attention because that's what this intelligence is. It's a state of attention. And that's a nice word in English because there's also the word attend, to attend to. Nurses attend to their patients. There's a sense of, in that word, there's almost an inclusive, the idea of caring, attention and care, care and attention.

So you could say that those are the hallmarks of your daily life. There are some things that you have to pay more attention to, like a phone call. And there are some things that you have to be more careful with, like when you're cooking. Be careful. So the two are one and the same, but they're coming from, shall we say, a different type of relationship. One is more based on the intellect, the understanding, and one is more based in the heart, on a sense of care. They're always there.

So now you can see how this intelligence which we've been training to sit back and watch, to sit back and watch and understand and see and understand what's going on, how it now begins to as it were come down into the attitude, into the heart, and how it begins to flow outward into the world in the way we speak and the way we act and finally the very livelihood that we have.

So here's the Buddha putting livelihood. Logically speaking, there's no need to put livelihood there because it's included in right action. But such is his understanding of the fact that most of our lives are doing something, unless we're unfortunate not to have a job. But even then, in the West anyway, they come and go.

So now, your attitude. What is your attitude to the work you're doing? Yesterday I was talking to somebody who was going through one of these awful periods where there's that vanity about what they're doing, about the uselessness — why am I doing this? It means nothing to me, and all that. And what you often find when you get into that mood is that actually it's coming again from this idea of self that all we're concerned about is making the job interesting to me. It's interesting to me. What's it for me? How much am I earning?

And there's always going to arise that dissatisfaction because the I always wants to aggrandise. That's the self. It always wants to accumulate. Because the more it accumulates, the safer it feels. I mean, you feel much safer if you had a million pounds in the bank than just a hundred. I would. You'd have this fallback. I can't remember, there was, I think, one of these rich people said, "I did poverty, I've done poverty, and I've done riches, and being rich is better." So, there's no particular virtue in being poor, it's just the way you end up.

But you can see how the self is always trying to make the world safe and wonderful around itself. So what's missing is missing that connection with the other person. So again, as soon as we do that, people become objects. You're just using them, using them to fulfil your desires. And that's bound to bring a dissatisfaction because people refuse to be objects to your desire. They always do something which you don't want them to do. And then you get angry and say, "Why did you do that?"

If we now turn around in ourselves and we say, right, well... What would be a proper attitude to my work? Well, there has to be, obviously, some self-care. So we've tried to make that distinction with our eating, that we're not eating just to gain happiness, just to feel blissed out on chips. We're not doing that. We're actually trying to feed the body, we're trying to change our relationship to food, seeing it as medicine, seeing it as nourishment. That gives us a very different attitude.

So now, when I'm doing my work, when we're doing work in society, surely the attitude which I ought to give out is one of service, isn't it? Service. As soon as you serve other people, you're immediately in a state of communication to them as people, because you're trying to be of service to them. So to be of service to somebody means that you have to open up to them as individuals. They have to speak to you. They have to tell you what they want. Even if it's just brushing the streets, for heaven's sake. You're doing it as a service.

So this puts a very different timbre on life, doesn't it? It puts a very different shading on life. I mean, we do it naturally with people whom we love, with family members. We'll do things for them and do it with a good heart and with an open heart. And when you do that, you get that good feeling, don't you? You get that glow. So that's the attitude of livelihood. It's one of being of service.

That doesn't take away the fact that there has to be that self-regard as well. You have to do something which is good for you, good for them. So in this way you can see how the meditation is preparing us to develop a completely different, not completely, I'm sure you all have this sense of service, is to develop the attitude of service and to distinguish between doing something just simply for ourselves out of selfish motivations and doing something which is caring for us, caring for the other.

And that brings us into that area where people get stuck, where they say, well, should I go for a position? Where does ambition come in? Should I then just say, well, I want to serve society, I want to serve people, and I'll just wait for the job to come? And you end up on the dole.

Again, it's always, if you're serving, what you want to serve is your best, isn't it? If you invite a person round for a meal, you want to serve the best food that you can make, don't you? You want to serve them the best. You want to offer what you have as the best. If you invite a friend round for beans on toast, it can be depressing. Unless you told them, of course.

So when you offer your services to society, you're offering your best. So if there's an opening which you feel you can do, then you go and offer your service to that. If you don't get the job you want, if you don't get the position you wanted, because you did it out of an attitude of service, in other words, there's an acceptance that you don't fit into what they want, then there's no pain, there's no hurt. The potential to do that job still lies there. It's just they either found somebody else or whatever.

We had a case just recently at Gaia House where somebody came to apply for a job, one of the managers' jobs. And we knew her. She was a fairly regular visitor. And she'd set her heart on becoming a manager. But there was another person who applied for the same position. And eventually it was this other person who got the job. Well, it was like a disaster, really. Weeping, despair. And it was only a year's job. I mean, you'd be out after a year. There wasn't some huge life commitment to it.

But the suffering that she went through because of that belies that even though there was that wanting to serve, there was something else there which attached her to that job. And not getting it brought about the pain. So it's a case of offering ourselves as a service and then recognising that it might not be received, it might not be accepted. And that's okay. That's okay. So it doesn't stop you from following an ambitious route. There's nothing stopping any of you becoming Prime Minister if you feel that's where your talent lies.

So I hope that makes a connection between what we're doing here in the sitting and your daily life. I hope it makes you connect. There's a very intimate connection to it, very intimate. So to reinforce that, you have to take some of the tricks that you gain from your meditation retreat into your daily life.

And one of the most powerful ones is to stop. Keep stopping. Very simple occasions like, if the phone rings. So when you get the first ring, you don't have to launch yourself at the phone, do you? You can note that the phone is ringing. And just relax. Like most people will hold on for three rings. I hold on for seven, ten rings for heaven's sake. I'm very patient. Well, three rings at least. So there's just that recognition, the phone is ringing, and then you just finish off what you're doing. You don't just forget, and then

when you come back, you've lost your place. Then the next one goes, and you pick it up on the third ring. You're calm, you're collected, you're not in a rush, and therefore you're open to the telephone call.

After you've, when you set yourself a task at work or just in your daily life, if you're aware of that intention, then put an end time to that intention. Like, for instance, I mess around a lot with this crazy computer stuff. And if I don't put a time on it, like two hours passes. I'm sure you've all experienced that. You wake up and two hours are gone. Two and a half hours. Whoa!

And I've got in the habit, I have this little watch here which gives me a beep every forty minutes. So just stop for a minute. It stops you getting caught up in something. So when you set yourself a job, no matter what it is, it doesn't matter of length, you could be just mowing the lawn. So you say to yourself at the end of that, I'll just stop. You just relax. And then the accumulation of that job, maybe you got a bit of an irritation, who knows, maybe you picked up some irritation, maybe you developed unwittingly some irritation around it, some rush, some pressure. Just stop, let it. And in this way, throughout the day, we're constantly bringing ourselves back to this very posture, this posture of just being here, then you move again from that base.

And for those of you who haven't done this before, it's important to do meditation in the morning and evening. Two hours is good. But twenty minutes is enough. You just need enough time to access this level of consciousness. It's a level of consciousness. A way of being in the world. Just remind yourself, this is where I'm supposed to be at all day.

And then throughout the day you do these little stoppings. Keep bringing yourself back. Remember how it was in that sitting. And then in the evening when you come back, always better before you eat, before you have an evening ahead of you. Just to sit for twenty minutes and just see what you've accumulated during the day. The tensions, the irritations, the disappointment. Just let them calm down, calm down. And of course it makes your evening much more pleasant. If you do it too late, you just fall asleep. If you do it just before you go to bed, it's just preparation for falling asleep really. Nothing happens. So do it when you're still awake, especially before you eat. And then you'll see it has an effect on the evening.

So just very slowly, very slowly. And after each of these meditations, just a moment of developing *mettā*, goodwill, which we'll do tomorrow. And that prepares this intelligence to move into the world with a proper attitude. So that's the path in a nutshell

Free Will

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min read

In this penetrating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma tackles the Western philosophical problem of free will from the perspective of the Buddha's teaching. Drawing from the Brahmajāla Sutta (DN 1), he explores how our speculative views about control and freedom are "merely the feeling of those who do not know and see." Through the lens of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), Bhante examines how contact leads to feeling and perception, which then proliferate into our sense of a controlling self.

The talk traces three Western philosophical positions—fatalism, libertarianism, and determinism—showing how each arises from the fundamental delusion of self. Whether we believe we have complete control or no control at all, both perspectives miss the Buddha's central insight: we're asking the wrong question entirely. Rather than seeking freedom of choice, the path to ending dukkha lies in developing clarity and wisdom to see the way forward.

Bhante emphasizes that spiritual progress isn't about choice but discovery—like consulting a map when reaching a fork in the road. He distinguishes between honest doubt (which leads to investigation) and skeptical doubt (which prevents commitment), explaining how the Noble Eightfold Path begins with right view informing our will. The talk concludes with the liberating understanding that what we call 'will' is actually conditioned action, and freedom comes not through control but through surrender to the Dhamma.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So, I thought I'd tackle the problem of free will. How does that come up in the Buddha's teaching? Free will. Well, this idea of free will has been with us for a heck of a long time. Even going back, were we at the mercy of the gods or could we instruct the gods to do things for us? So in terms of polytheism, that's how it began, this idea that there was some controlling deity or deities, and the idea was to get them on your side, sympathetic magic, things like that. And then somehow it corrupted into the idea that if you actually did the ritual perfectly, you could then control. And that was when the Buddha appeared. So the Brahmins there, who controlled the whole business of sacrifice, they knew the specific words, nobody else could learn them, and they knew the

specific action, exactly what to do, and this would bring about the desired results. So there's some sort of free will thrown in there with some sense of control. That's what we want, isn't it? Control.

I think in the West we've cornered ourselves into a very sharp individualism. We don't really see ourselves too much as social beings, as social will. We tend to see ourselves as very little individual pods who demand to do what we want to do. So the idea of free will, especially from the Enlightenment, is something that's core stuff for us. And it comes out, as you'll see when I talk later, in capitalism, the idea of freedom, freedom of choice, all that sort of stuff.

The other thing is that with the Enlightenment, that's ours, 18th century, which I totally believe in, the idea of rational. So free will is to do with something about thinking about it and about coming to some sort of philosophical conclusion that we have or we don't have free will. But there's a very interesting discourse here, or at least there's a part that really interests me, from the Brahmajāla Sutta, the opening discourse, actually the longer of the longer discourses and he lists quite a huge amount I think 64 different speculative views some of them you'll have heard of whether the cosmos was infinite or finite whether the enlightened person was born or died or what not and everybody has a view on these things and this is what he says he says all such views are merely the feeling of those who do not know and see, the worry and uncertainty of those immersed in craving.

And what catches my attention is merely the feeling. See, we tend to be up here, and if we can work something out logically, it sort of separates out from feeling. Therefore you believe in free will, whether you actually feel it or not, or rather you discard feeling, you push it away, on the understanding that there is free will. Even if I don't feel free, so long as I say to myself I am free, I go around thinking that I am free. I don't know if that makes sense. Hopefully, as we go on, it will get more obvious.

If we take another discourse, which the Buddha actually called his honey bowl discourse, it's a delicious sweet you can still buy in India. And he gave a cryptic teaching there, and all these monks who were listening to him didn't ask him anything about it. They went off to this other monk called Mahākaccāna, who was very good at expounding the short teachings of the Buddha. So they ask him, and he says to them, why don't you ask him? And they go right there. They say, well, whatever. So he gives them the longer teaching, and then they go back to the Buddha and say, this is what Mahākaccāna said. It's funny, isn't it? And the Buddha says, well, if you'd have asked me, I would have said the same thing. Sort of a roundabout way of getting there.

Anyway, the core of it is this. What we know is dependent on contact. That's the part of the Wheel of Dependent Origination, contact. So if it's something that's visual, there's got to be contact at the visual base, the retina. But remember there's also the sixth sense in Buddhism, which is emotion, thought. So something must arise into the mind to make contact, your stimulus. So that's, for instance, when you wake up in the morning. The first thing that comes up, you don't beckon it, it just arises. So much of our day is just stuff arising, either coming from an outside stimulus or from something inside us.

And then he says that upon this, feelings arise, feelings and perceptions. Now, in Buddhist psychology, feeling and perception arises at the same time. And all a feeling is, is a distinguishing in the mind between what is experienced as pleasant or unpleasant. And that's your perception. So whatever feeling arises, as it arises, it's always experienced as neutral. But as soon as you flip into a perception of it, it immediately cuts the world up into likeable, unlikable.

So, for instance, in your meditation, you might find some emotion arising, which you describe or which you label as, or at least your attitude towards it is unlikable. It's a bit of depression or something. Now, if you, as it were, take your attention away from the emotional value of it to the sensation value of it in the body, and you get down to just thick feelings or those funny feelings that come up with depression, whatever, heat, whatever it is, then you'll see as you move towards that base, the idea of like and dislike begin to fade out a bit, until you can get to a point where there's just sensation. And at that point, you're at the point where the stimulus comes in. So you've gone back on it, you see.

When you do something like that, you begin to realize that it's our definition of things. It's our definition of things which is the core problem, because it comes from our view, our view of something. So, for instance, if we're conditioned to be racist, as soon as we see somebody of another race, unpleasant feelings arise. It'll just happen naturally. If you're not conditioned that way, it doesn't arise. So these feelings that we get are also based on our views and opinions. And they arise with feeling. So the heart-mind work in unison. It's we in the West that have split these two up. If you go East, for instance, to Thailand, when they say, I can't remember what their word is for mind, something like *citta*, they're not pointing to the head, they're pointing to the heart.

Then he says, as soon as we perceive something, we'll start thinking about it, and then you get that proliferation. So now, at the root of this feeling perception is the me. That self-awareness. When you're in meditation and you get that very strong feeling of being an observer, you've distanced so much away from your body, your feelings, your sensations, that you get this feeling of the watcher. If you're aware of the watcher, you

can't be the watcher. As soon as you make something an object, you can't be it. So, if you're observing and there's that feeling of watching, of a watcher, just shift your attention and try and catch where that feeling's arising from.

So now, as it's most deluded, this me thinks it's this body and mind. And what's its purpose? What does the self want? It just wants to be happy, doesn't it? I want to be happy, full stop. So, in order to be happy, it has that feeling, that need to control. If something painful comes up in the body, it wants to get rid of it, so you take a tablet. If emotions come up that it doesn't like, it just suppresses it. And underneath all that, remember, it's always afraid of the body falling sick, the body dying, the body growing old.

So this business of always wanting to live in a pleasant atmosphere, in a happy atmosphere, is the motivation behind the self. But it's coming from that root misunderstanding that we are this body and this mind and this heart, and the happiness of this body, heart and mind is also dependent on the world. So good food makes me happy. So I want to control my food. I want to be able to cook beautiful things for myself.

So this, of course, the Buddha points out in the second sermon that he gives to these five companions who deserted him because he'd gone a bit soft eating rice pudding. And he points out, he says, well, if the self were the body, it'd be able to say, be like this, be like that, be able to control it. He's not talking here about simple movements of lifting something. He's talking about what we really want, which is not to grow old, a bit more beautiful, a bit more handsome, and definitely not to die.

So that we have, that wanting to control is, I think, what we mean by free will, the desire for free will. That's actually what I think we mean at the root of it. Because if we're to receive what we desire, then we need to control the source of pleasure. Full stop. Simple as that.

Now it's because we fail to do that, in the West anyway, we have these three ideas. They split into fatalism, libertarianism and determinism. So you can read all these philosophers and they'll slot into one of these one way or the other.

So fatalism is just that understanding that actually you don't have any free will at all. In fact the self is utterly impotent. So acts of free will don't have any effect. We don't really have any control over our lives. Anything that happens to us was previously ordained, it's going to happen. So now if on Thursday I'm driving into Newton Abbot, it doesn't matter if I go fast or slow, whether I take this turn or that turn, if I'm going to have a crash, I'm going to have a crash. Full stop. It's bound to happen.

You get this view from people who believe in the stars, don't they? And then you get that psychology of self-fulfilling prophecy. So if the stars say, you're bound to fall in love, then they'll find any, a chicken, a horse, whatever, they'll fall in love. It's got to happen. And when you think about it, the real important things of our lives, well, it's difficult to say we've got any control at all. For instance, we didn't choose to be born. We definitely don't know the hour and day of our death. We didn't have a choice in cultural conditioning. What about things like economic, social, cultural? We just ended up with that. And then there's the elements, mercy of the elements. We don't even choose to fall in love, now that I've mentioned it, actually.

And I suppose there's a bit to do with the personality as well. If you're a fatalist, sort of that hopeless resignation. If you're that sort of person, you tend to be one, I think. Or the other side, sanguine optimist or something. I suppose at best it might build up a sort of stoic patience, a fortitude, a stiff upper lip. And on with the British.

So this whole idea that we don't have choice, everything's predestined. I mean, it comes up in the spiritual literature too. So in terms of the Buddha's day, there was a Makkhali Gosāla. And all he said was, if you went down one side of the Ganges, doing great acts of compassion and huge donations and he came up the other side murdering and pillaging it wouldn't make a blind bit of difference because the whole road of *kamma* was set every soul that was born would have to go through the whole process of karmic refinement and in his case it did actually lead to some sort of heavenly state but of course it undermines any morality because it doesn't matter what you do in the end because the universe is so manufactured through *saṃsāra* that it'll push you to that definite end sort of an absolute fatalism.

In Christianity you've got Saint Augustine of course he started the one about predestination if God knew everything he knew whether you were saved or not and at worst that was Calvinism and Scottish Presbyterianism you're predestined. From that there came the Protestant work ethic, of course. So that even though you couldn't tell whether somebody was going to go to heaven or hell by their earthly deeds, you can understand that one presumed that if you were successful in business, basically you had to go to heaven. So then you get that work ethic, and people who are rich get to heaven, and people who don't, well, they don't go to heaven. They go to hell.

Islam is also fatalistic. It's all written on the tablet, this original tablet. Your life's written on this tablet. And there was a lovely case I heard of where a friend of mine was working on an oil rig out in the Middle East. And two people fell off the rig, two Westerners. And the current was taking them away, and they were shouting for help. And there were two soldiers just standing there watching them. And the manager came

rushing down and threw out the lifeboard, pulled it back in. And he said to these soldiers, you know, why didn't you do that? Why didn't you help them? He said, the will of Allah. Heavy, isn't it?

And in our existentialism, we've got Albert Camus. He's the one who wrote the myth of Sisyphus. Now, Sisyphus ended up in hell, if I remember rightly, because of avarice. And his job, if you remember, was to roll a boulder up a hill, and then, of course, it would go down the other side, so he had to go back down and roll it back up. And for Camus, that was the metaphor of life. Every morning, you roll this thing to the top, and overnight it fell back down again. And when he came to make a judgment about what was the point of having a consciousness which suffered? What was the point of that? It's absolutely absurd. Take God away, take any ultimate freedom away, take the idea of salvation or *nibbāna* or liberation away. What's the point of being conscious when it's such a misery? So his idea was that a human being, really to maintain his dignity, he only had one choice, which was to commit suicide. Luckily he was saved from the consequence of his own philosophy. Died in a car accident. One wonders whether he'd have carried that one through, actually.

So that's fatalism, and definitely the Buddha wasn't into that. predestination, everything's set. The opposite of that, of course, is libertarianism. And that, I think, is definitely the fruit of our enlightenment, 18th century enlightenment. Here, of course, it gets corrupted when a person says they want to do their own thing in their own way in their own time, sort of a teenage rebellion. But the idea is that we do feel empowered to make choices. And when you look back, of course, you do see that you have made certain choices. I mean, you could think that those choices are conditioned, but from a libertarian point of view, there's this bit of rationality come in.

So that things just don't happen, you can stop, you can think about whether this is good or this is bad. And those decisions, a libertarian would say, are not random, they're not random, and they're not predetermined. So there's a sense of freedom, a sense of being able to guide one's life. And you can choose, you see, the idea of choice, and thereby we affect our decision-making.

So that sort of view went on to support things like individual rights, freedom of speech, freedom of voting, and indeed the capitalist market, because it's the individual now who has to make choices for themselves, and they build up their own wealth. I mean, that's at its most painful. On the other hand, it does make an individual entirely responsible for their actions. So if a person ends up a robber, you can't suggest mitigating circumstance. Poverty, it's their choice. It will be a robber, so we'll hang them. Get

on your bike when there's unemployment. You blame the worker for lack of skills because they've not got jobs and stuff like that. It leads, doesn't it, to a sort of dog-eat-dog society, if you take it to an extreme.

But the idea of that at a spiritual level, unfortunately from a Buddhist point of view, it does give the idea of something inside us, this little person, that is a sort of rational self, detached from the world, is able to see things from this vast, indifferent plane, and make decisions about it. Now, from the Buddha's point of view, that's the source of our misery, actually.

So, I mean, if you walk into a supermarket with the idea of buying biscuits, and you're walking down the aisle, you come across a brand you hadn't seen before, Goblet or something. And you pick it up and it says, Goblet makes you happy. You look at multi-flavoured biscuits. Then you think, well, in my mind I'm going to buy my favourite figs. So there you're stuck between a so-called choice. Well, I mean, you can always say, well, all that's heavily conditioned, but there's some sort of rationality there. Do I want this? Do I want that? Feeling. See, that's the problem with libertarianism, it lifts choice, it lifts freedom into this idea that it's up in the head somewhere. But actually you can see, even on a simple thing like choosing a biscuit, or making a vote, making a vote which we call a freedom of vote, but actually it's your feeling, isn't it? When you see certain politicians, you feel sick. When you see others, you feel happy.

So this business of capitalist freedom of choice, I mean, you can definitely argue that it's just juggling with conditioning. And it's based on this immediate fix. See, it's very interesting because before the war, if you look at the adverts before the war for products, they were very centred on the product and very pragmatic. And people only bought what they needed. That was the idea. You only bought what you needed. So if you were selling a clock in an earlier advert, you would simply point out that it has an alarm. It's got red lighting so you can see it in the night. And you'd buy it if you needed it. If you do it these days, because this was Freud coming through, you've got to put a naked woman next to it. And the desire that comes up is immediately latched onto the clock so you buy it. It keeps you awake.

So finally, that business of a separate rational self, that won't work in the Buddha's teaching. Because that's also embedded. And the third position is this determinism. So now, here there's the idea that the personal self, that the self does have a choice and it does affect things. So it's unlike fatalism. But unlike libertarianism, even the choices you make are determined. So whatever's going to happen is going to happen.

Now, if you think about that, if everything is just cause and effect, cause and effect, as a sequel from the past, it's very difficult to imagine anything but a repetitive universe. I mean, where does the newness come in? Where does something stop this chain of cause and events? How is it that we have actually a very creative universe? So it can't be just as simple as a direct historical cause and effect.

The Jains seem to have held that in the Buddhist scriptures. Now, you've got to be careful here because this is Buddhist propaganda. There's a man called Upāli, for instance, who was a great supporter of the Buddha, a very rich person. And he told the Jain leader, Nigaṇṭha, some teaching about what the Buddha had given. and the Nigaṇṭha sent him, delegated him to go to the Buddha to prove him wrong. So, of course, Upāli gets up to the Buddha there and starts his discussion. And by the end of it, he becomes a follower of the Buddha, you see.

So, he wants to become a follower. He says, and I shall leave the Nigaṇṭha. This is where the Buddha's magnanimity, one of the little examples of his magnanimity, is, well, don't. Don't stop supporting your other teacher. You can support me, but don't stop supporting him, you see. Anyway, Upāli returns back to the Nigaṇṭha and tells him that he's now been converted. And the Nigaṇṭha, it seems, is so angry that he spews blood and dies. So it's that sort of tale which makes you think, well, when they're talking about Jains, maybe it's a bit of propaganda. I think he died in the Jain way, starving himself to death.

And what the Buddha points out about the Jain theory, which was some idea of pre-destination, you had to stop. You had to stop doing. So you stopped killing, and eventually you stopped eating. The idea was just to draw *kamma* to an end. So the Buddhist saint actually dies of starvation. You build up your courage for it, I suppose. What the Buddha points out is that even that decision is part of *kamma*. That actually won't end the sequence of cause and effect.

It's like when we don't do something has an effect. Even if you take this gathering now, you see, we've all come from different paths to create this particular situation. And in this situation, hopefully something creative is happening. Only because we've all come here from different places. So there is something about the way the universe works which is about different lines of cause and effect meeting at a certain point to create something new.

So we see that these three perspectives, fatalism, determinism, libertarianism, I think we might argue that if you look back in time, you might just get the feeling that everything has been predetermined. Your life's actually been fairly set, and you didn't have much of a choice, and you've ended up where you are because. But when you're

actually stuck in a present dilemma, when you're actually stuck between this and that, it definitely feels like you've got a choice. So again, it's to do with feeling. It's to do with the way we're looking at something as to which side of this business you tend to fall on.

Anyway, you might be relieved to know that from the Buddha's point of view, we're simply asking the wrong question. So you can now forget the first part of this particular essay. Because this whole business of free will just arises out of this profound delusion beneath us, it's a sort of nebulous idea of me, me in control. So as the self discovers the world, there's pleasant, unpleasant experiences, so it wants to create something out of it, this dualistic world. So all things are over there as rivals or this side as accomplices. It's just driven by greed, aversion, indulging, accumulating, rejecting, annihilating. And it's this way that the self gains this idea of power. It's just a little game it's playing.

So obviously the right question is, how do we put an end to suffering? Remember that the Buddha always reduced his teaching to a very simple statement, suffering and the end of suffering, full stop. So the question is, how do we end suffering? And how do you get down to really cut the root?

The first thing is to understand this business about conditionality. And as we've already said, it's a concurrence of past events meeting present situations, which allows us this feeling of creativity, something new all the time.

Secondly, the aim is not concerned with freedom of choice at all. The aim to end suffering is not to do with choice at all. It's to do with clarity. It's to do with seeing where the path is. It's to do with investigation and exploration of our lives and the way things are and how it is that we keep falling into suffering.

If you, like for instance, if we set out for a walk in the country, you've already decided where you want to go. It's not random. You've decided where you want to go. So in our sense, you want to be happy. You want to find this happiness. And you've got your map. You've got your compass. When you come to a fork in the road, you don't choose, well, shall I go down this one or shall I go down that one? You already know where you're going to go. And all you've got to do is consult the map and make the right decision.

So in the Buddha's path, the path is already delineated. So this choice, this feeling of choice that we have, turns out to be nothing but a doubt. It's not actually. See, the self lifts it up to the idea of, well, shall I do this or shall I do that? But actually, if you know all the facts, you wouldn't have a choice. The path would be just directly in front of you. Spiritually speaking, especially.

So, there's two types of when I say doubt, there's two types here. There's what you might call honest doubt and sceptical doubt. So, honest doubt is just coming from that business of not knowing. And it comes from a sense of a grounded humility. I don't know. I really don't know. Accepting that. And it's a very difficult place to be, isn't it? We like to know. That not knowing can cause us extreme anxiety. Like you don't know whether you're going to have the job next week. You don't know whether the cheque's going to come. It creates anxiety.

But if we can sit patiently, if we can sit calmly within that not knowing and accept that state and then just keep looking, keep observing, then the path manifests. It either manifests because somebody's pointed it out to us or because our own experience manifests it. One of the points in the process of these *vipassanā ñāṇas*, the *vipassanā* understandings, is the business of what is the path and what is not the path.

And it's a very simple thing, most of you have probably been there, is that in your meditation you'll suddenly start maybe getting these beautiful states. They're very peaceful, very spaced out, very lovely and joyful. And of course there's the self immediately wants to get in there and say, well this is it, finally I made it. I remember one man told me he had this, quite deluded really, he had this amazing experience while sitting on the toilet. Now that's not relevant. You can have these amazing experiences anywhere. Remember that Luther had his great breakthrough while he was sitting on the toilet. It's faith only. But he absolutely insisted it was *Nibbāna*. And just what he was describing was just amazing. Just a blissful state, really.

So, knowing that whatever *nibbāna* is, it is not felt. Whatever *nibbāna* is, it is not an emotional state. Whatever *nibbāna* is, it cannot be described. Immediately, it takes you off that indulgence. That's a correction. That's a correction to that not knowing, that doubt which comes up from this desire to seek the end of suffering. That's a wisdom thing. That's coming from something deeper than the self.

When you get the doubt which is really a sceptical doubt, a doubt which is a mental illness in the same way that sloth and torpor and all these addictions are, then of course there's something else going on there, and that's usually a fear of commitment, usually a fear of giving yourself to something because you don't know what's going to happen, but that fear stops you committing and therefore stops you meditating.

one of the people who used to organise the doubling group, his father, when he was a young child, put him on a table and opened up his arms and said, jump, son, and he jumped and he moved away. Splat on the ground, he said. And he says, that'll teach you. See, don't trust anybody. You can imagine. So, I mean, when they come to the Buddha's teaching, it was quite amazing that he should actually put his heart and soul into it.

So, just to be aware of that, that the path isn't about, shall I do this or shall I do that? And that's one reason for a schedule, you see. You set your schedule down, a schedule that you know you can follow, and you just do that religiously. You don't let this little self come in and say, well, shall I do it? Can't do it? Maybe a little kip. I'll go for a walk. Don't feel like it. See? And all the time you're just feeding the self.

When it comes to joining the order, you say, look, I don't get up in the morning and say, shall I wear blue? It doesn't occur. Even the idea of what shall I eat? What am I going to eat? So it's taking out all that edge around where the self can manifest. It doesn't mean to say it doesn't manifest in very peculiar and staged ways, but at least one try and draw a circle around what you can do, what you can't do.

And then you liberate. See, that's the benefit. You then liberate this wisdom factor, this *paññā*, this intuitive intelligence to investigate. If this intuitive intelligence gets locked into what the self wants to do, then it's just taken all over the place. Fine, you feel nice when you get out for a walk, but has it helped you overcome suffering? Not at all. All it's done is it's given you a greater addiction to walking the countryside. Just deepening your attachment to the country. Which I've learnt since coming down to Devon, by the way. Terrible.

We could almost say, if you really think about it, when have you been most happy? Isn't it when you've been doing exactly what you wanted to do? I mean, the actual doing of it. It's never occurred, has it? When you've been doing exactly what you wanted to do, it's never occurred, shall I do this or shall I not do that? And it's the same with interest. If you notice, whenever you're interested in something, do you ever have any problems with concentration? No. So a lot of our practice is giving up that choice, is raising the interest to discover the path. And all that stuff just follows naturally, the clarity and all that, and the energy and the concentration.

Now when it comes to will itself, there is will, there is will in terms of power. The Buddha equates that to action. So he states it quite clearly. Will I call action. So those of you who know the Wheel of Dependent Origination, there comes that point, so we say it starts off with that contact we talked about. It starts off with a perception feeling of being pleasant, unpleasant. It would then have that reaction of wanting, not wanting. That's your *taṇhā*. Only then does this self come in. Which is very interesting because in language we say, I want that. But actually it's, that want I. That's how it happens in terms of psychology. As soon as that I comes in, you can't stop it, you've empowered it. As soon as that I says, I want, then you get that empowerment, that's the will coming in, and you have that next link, *bhava*, which is becoming. That's when you become, that's your act. Act of thought, word or deed.

So that's why in your meditation, when it comes to things like pleasant, unpleasant, you just want to keep the mind very close to that business of wanting, not wanting, liking, not liking, wanting, not wanting. And that's the way out to liberation by understanding *dukkha*, by understanding suffering and unsatisfactoriness.

So this power that we have is quite mysterious. It's totally neutral. It's not good or bad. It depends how you use it. It depends on your attitude. And you can't separate it from the action. You can try. When you do walking meditation, just stand there. Keep saying, intending to walk. Intending to walk. And even though you're saying it and intending it, nothing's going to happen. And then suddenly the foot lifts. So what is it that has taken something out of a potential into an actual? That's what the Buddha's calling will. And you can't separate it from your foot. You can't say, well, that's it over here, and this is my foot over here. It's one and the same thing. It's within the structure of this whole becoming business.

But the power of that will is your conditioning. So remember, an action forms an intention, moves you to an action. And if that action is wholesome or unwholesome, then you're going to get the product of that conditioning. So if it's an unwholesome action, it moves you towards an unwholesome conditioning. This is inwardly. Remember, all *kamma* in terms of liberation is inward. It's not something to do with the outside world at all, actually. And anything you do which is wholesome, it will produce that wholesome conditioning within you. And in Buddhist understanding, that's what's driving us to a particular destiny.

And that's why, of course, in the Noble Eightfold Path, right view heads it. As soon as you understand, as soon as there's a seeing, as soon as there's a perception of the way things are, this immediately informs your attitude. Of course, when it gets down into the attitude, you may find the opposite attitude to be too strong. So you might go down and you very clearly perceive that the body does not need tea. But that's not going to stop you doing it because of this huge conditioning to drink tea. But at least there's the perception that at this present time the body doesn't actually need tea and it's hanging on to that and waiting for that to drop into the heart as an attitude and then it balances up with the desire to have tea and eventually because you're not feeding the desire to have tea anymore that drops away and the right attitude of seeing food and water and all that as nourishment for the body not as a place for seeking happiness begins to get the upper hand and lead you to the enlightenment that's the one I'm struggling with so that's called *Dhamma-caitanya* the will for *Dhamma* and that translates into *Mahāyāna* as the *Bodhicitta* the heart seeking enlightenment.

So eventually, that's the force. That's the force behind your drive to liberation. And just finally, to end off with this lovely refrain, when anybody gets liberated, you always get this little refrain at the end of it. Birth is destroyed. Now, this is the birth of self, remember. The holy life has been lived. What had to be done has been done. There is no more coming into any state of self-existence. Can you feel the relief in that? What had to be done has been done.

So it's a case really of being clear that the path to enlightenment isn't a choice. It's not a choice. It's a discovery. What leads us to it is the general dissatisfaction about our lives. And once you perceive which way to go, then it's a case of building up that courage, that determination, resolution to follow it. And then, of course, you get the benefit of it. That's the answer. That's what we have to do.

So, what's the message? Abandon free will. Devote yourself. Surrender to the path. May these words have been of awesome help to you in your path to liberation. Thank you very much.

Karma Specific Conditionality the Five Laws ethical behaviour social karma Neoliberalism

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 27 min read

In this comprehensive dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on specific conditionality (idappaccayatā) - the fundamental law of "when this is, that is; when this isn't, that isn't" - which underlies all phenomena. He explores the five laws (niyāmas) that govern existence: natural law (utu-niyāma), genetics (bīja-niyāma), psychology (citta-niyāma), ethical action (kamma-niyāma), and the Buddha's teachings (dhamma-niyāma).

The talk clarifies that not all suffering stems from personal kamma - distinguishing between natural disasters, genetic conditions, psychological predispositions, and the consequences of ethical choices. Bhante discusses how intended actions create habits that shape personality and destiny, emphasizing that moral purification remains possible through understanding cause and effect.

Expanding into social kamma, he examines how collective ideologies like neoliberalism create systemic suffering through institutionalized greed and competition. Drawing parallels between personal defilements and societal structures, he explores how individual ethical transformation can contribute to social healing. The talk concludes with reflections on the Buddha's approach to conflict resolution and the importance of acting without hatred even in defensive situations.

This teaching offers both personal guidance for ethical development and broader perspective on how Buddhist principles apply to contemporary social and economic challenges.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

We're going to approach the problem of *kamma*. The first thing is the question of how does the Buddha describe how anything happens? How do things happen? It's called the law of "this and that." The specific law of conditionality is also called that. I shall read the equations. When this is, that is. From the arising of this, comes the arising of that. When this isn't, that isn't. From the stopping of this comes the stopping of that. Got it?

When I first read it I thought, "What?" If we now put two statements together it becomes a little more obvious. The first one is: from the arising of this comes the arising of that, and from the stopping of this comes the stopping of that. This is linear cause and effect. The fact that you came here - you decided at some point to come on the course, you made that decision, you empowered it, and you came here. From the arising of that, you arose at Gaia House. If you had thought about it, or you had some reason that you couldn't come, because you stopped coming, you did not arise at Gaia House. This is a linear way that we would normally think about cause and effect.

The other one is: when this is, that is, and when this isn't, that isn't. Now that brings us directly into the present moment where things happen simultaneously. We all arrive here and the course begins, and every time you arrive it's a new occasion for meditating together, listening to talks. If you didn't arrive, it wouldn't happen, right? It's extremely simple.

Now, if it were just linear, then where would creativity come in? Wouldn't it suggest a repetitiveness, a monotony, one after the other? There'd be nothing to stop the original intention - it would just keep repeating itself. If it were just immediate then there would be no order, so it would be chaotic. Things would arise, collapse, and then for no other reason things would arise and collapse.

When you put these two together you get a cause coming from the past into the present moment where it meets other causes coming from the past into this present moment. It's much clearer to talk about how things happen as a process of contingency. Every moment, lines of decisions, not only that, nature, whatever's happening in the outside world, the birds, constantly coming to meet into this present moment. When we think about *kamma* in that sense, you can see it's very difficult to sort out what's my personal *kamma*, what's the *kamma* from somebody else, what's the *kamma* of the situation, but we'll come to that in a minute.

If we have that idea of contingency rather than some linear process, we're getting close to what the Buddha talked about. This is suggestive of chaos theory, some of you might know, where an initial impulse supported by conditions just changes and grows or diminishes. The example that's normally given is the weather. One scientist said, if there's a butterfly wing in the south of America, with supporting conditions it becomes a tornado in North America. In any given moment, we don't actually know what is coming into that present moment. Luckily, when you live in a peaceful country, you can almost predict what's going to happen. But of course, that would lead us into a delusion that the future is predictable.

So that specific conditionality is underlying everything. It not only underlies what's happening in the world out there, it underlies our own minds. Because you don't know what is coming in from the outside and how you're responding from the inside. It's a constant moment after moment creativity. Nothing can repeat itself.

When we come to the actual *kamma* that's important, which is our moral actions, our ethical actions, again, it's very difficult to know when we're receiving something, when something is happening, to know whether it's personal *kamma* or not. The Buddha talks about five different laws.

The first one is called the law of heat and it refers to just basic chemistry and physics - something like a tsunami. A tsunami is caused by shifting plates and when the tsunami hit Sri Lanka, Thailand, places like that, of course a lot of people died. Some would have thought that this was caused by bad *kamma* in the past. Somewhere in the past they'd harmed a few dogs or something. They'd have to find some excuse for that tsunami creating such suffering. Others would have been a bit more philosophical in the sense of, well, everything's impermanent. It was these sorts of arguments that undermined the strength of trauma that people can have when something like that happens. I was told that when Western counsellors went out there to see if they could help, they found that people weren't particularly traumatized because they have this understanding. Nothing is safe, nothing is permanent. Things happen. That's one law, which is to do with just nature.

The next one is to do with seed - that's what it's called - so it's genetics. The body you've ended up with is not your personal *kamma*. We know it's part of the family, it's coming from your family's genetic history. If for instance somebody is born with a genetic disease, that is not personal *kamma*. That is something that has happened through that birth process. If somebody has a bad birth process and ends up with trauma, that isn't their personal *kamma*. It's not as though they were meant to have that. It's just that when you enter into this life form, things happen, and that's the end of it. You have to be careful of that because sometimes people get confused that what happens to them physically through their genetics is somehow caused because of some bad action in a past life.

The third one is the *citta*, the mind. This is our psychology. Here we're talking about just the basic ability of the mind - its ability to think, to speak, to solve problems. It's just what we would normally think of as our psychology. Again, we're born with this body, perhaps the brain is not quite so quick as somebody else's brain, but if you were to say

that this is my personal *kamma*, in other words, I've caused it because of some action in the past, that would be either untrue or unprovable. It seems the whole body-mind process that we have is not specifically caused by moral or immoral actions in the past.

The fourth one is *kamma*, but I'll just go on to the next one, which is *dhamma*. That's all the teachings of the Buddha. The Four Noble Truths, Eightfold Path, Dependent Origination, that you heard. All these are *dhamma*, the teachings which allow us to escape from suffering. So that's the fifth category.

If we go back to *kamma*: an intention comes, we've seen that clearly, we empower it, and it produces an action. When you repeat similar actions, then you get a habit. When you put all your habits together, that's your personality. Once you've got a personality and character, then you're moving towards your destiny. Things will happen because of your character and personality. Our job from a karmic point of view is to realize that it's our moral decisions that are going to have the effect as to whether we suffer or not.

In the Buddha's own experience, when he went through the process of awakening, he saw three things clearly. He saw all his past lives, which showed him how he ended up being fully liberated. He saw how beings moved from one realm to another according to their moral, ethical actions, and he knew that he himself had no more defilements. He was purified of his defilements. What was a personal law for him, seeing the process of his life after life and how he became fully liberated, then became a universal law as far as he was concerned.

So our actions, our intended actions, even habitual actions that we don't consciously decide but have a moral or ethical quality to them, are going to produce certain results. The general law is, if you do something good, well, good comes of it. If you do something harmful, some harm comes of it. But it's a case of recognizing that even if you do something good, you could undermine it by doing something harmful. If you do something harmful, you can undermine its effect by doing something good.

For instance, if I were to say a sharp word to somebody and I upset them, I very easily stop the possibility of their hating me and doing horrible things to me by simply apologizing. It's not as though there's some rigid process that once we do something harmful that will happen, because it goes into a matrix out there in the world and a matrix in us. The effect we can never be absolutely sure of.

For instance, there was a charity which sent clothes, second-hand clothes, to an African country. What happened was it undermined the local tailor trade. In doing so, it undermined the local economy. So they had to pull out. Compassionate action also has to be accompanied by wisdom, by knowledge. You can't just do something because you

think it's a good thing. They did something which they thought was good, and it was, there's no problem with it, but within the situation it created an unfortunate situation and they had to withdraw.

You can see that the whole process of *kamma* is very difficult to work with if you're going to be logical, if you're going to try and think about consequences. Because you can do something, a person might do something terrible, but because of the surrounding situation, nothing happens. We know that so many burglaries are not being even approached by the police. There's a lot of burglars out there who are getting away with it. They might be getting away with it in terms of society, but not within the heart. Because every time they burgle, they are actually developing that desire of taking something not given and enjoying it, and taking it for their own personal enjoyment. At some point, there has to be some reflection of that, either in themselves as something which is harmful and there's a sense of guilt and shame, or they get caught and they get stuck in prison.

In the process of rebirth, again, it's not as though it's a linear thing, that in the next lifetime they will be caught and hanged. It simply is that when they are reborn, they take with them that attitude. At some point, the universe, the cosmos, or the people around them, perhaps a bit more grounded, begin to mirror back to them exactly what they're doing. There's a moral justice that's written into this process, as far as the Buddha's concerned.

Some talks mention this rebirth business. Do remember that this isn't a belief system. It's not as though you have to believe any of this stuff, because the process of liberation is the process of investigation. If you believe something, then there's a possibility you don't make it true for you. "I believe what the Buddha said, and therefore I'll become enlightened." It doesn't work like that. He's always putting to us certain propositions and saying, "Is this true for you?" It's not a matter of whether we believe in rebirth or not. It's a case of just leaving open that possibility. Don't shut it down.

I'm reminded of Pascal's dictum. Pascal was an 18th century mathematician. It was the growth of science and everything, and there were people who didn't believe in God anymore, positivists and things like that. What he said was, there may or may not be a God, but it might be wise to act as if there was one. There may or may not be rebirth, but it might be wise to act as if there is rebirth.

So that actually takes us to this law. We've understood this basic underlying conditionality, which is to do with contingency. It's not linear. You never know exactly what's going to happen. Within that we have all these laws to do with nature, to do with hered-

itary, to do with psychology, which of course is also to do with society, and I'll come back to that, which takes us into social *kamma*. Then finally there's the *kamma*, which is this specific area to do with suffering, and finally this *dhamma*.

So be clear about the ethical part. The ethical part, what the Buddha is saying is that it's the way we behave ethically which is either going to make us happy or unhappy. That's what we've been really investigating with this whole business of eating. We notice that when we fall into a habit of "me" or "mine," some level of greed or self-service, there's always going to be this dissatisfaction. That's where the suffering lies. The suffering lies in trying to seek happiness in the wrong place. This seeking of happiness in the sensual world is the cause of all our mental diseases.

If we go back to a child being abused - this is quite difficult to accept. If a child is abused, the reaction is the child's reaction. It's not caused directly by the person who's abused the child. The abuse is physical, it may be emotional, but the suffering comes because of that reaction. The trauma is an inward process. For instance, if somebody came and hit me on the nose and shouted at me, the pain stops here, and the feeling of anger hits me here. Everything else is an internal process as a reaction, and that's my trauma. That's why I can be cured of it. If my suffering was caused by you, in order to bring about the end of my suffering, I'd have to get rid of you. It's only because my suffering is caused by me that I can be rid of it.

That doesn't excuse the abuser when we think about that. It's not a case of saying, "Oh well, the abuser didn't cause the trauma, so we don't have to worry about that." No. The abuser also has to accept that he was the initial impetus that caused the whole problem. The triggers are just opening up that trauma. So it's an occasion for the person to work with it.

In my own experience, I've had childhood traumas come up. When we talk about traumas, there's undoubtedly harm done by parents, family members, and others to children. But remember also that the child comes in with their own mentality.

In my own experience, I walked into the front room. My grandfather was sat on a chair. I couldn't have been much more than two years old, two, three, four months. I went to shake him and he didn't move. So I said to myself, "They've killed him. Now they're going to kill me." When that memory came to mind, I was that child. That's always a sign of a trauma that you relive that moment totally. It's the same with past lives. If you have a memory from a past life, you remember it as that person. You're not this person remembering something. That's the telltale sign of the past life.

My body was suffused with fear, right? It was total. Fortunately, my father was still alive, so I said to my dad, "It was me that found grandfather dead in a chair in the front room." He said, "No, I was living. He was in bed when he died." The child, somewhere in me there was a fear, and I can only presume that my parents were arguing, and I decided they were arguing against me. I don't know, but that's what happened. It's good for us to remember that a child is also living this imaginative life arising out of their own particular conditioning.

Now, I want to move to an area which isn't often dealt with. This is really just an attempt to discuss collective or social *kamma*. The last century saw three secular ideologies. The first was communism, the second was nationalism, national socialism, and the third was neoliberalism. An ideology always has some Shangri-La that you're moving towards. If you do this and this and this, you end up being tremendously rich, or tremendously happy. In which case, it always loses its grounding in what's happening in the present moment. As Marx said of capitalism, and he could have said it of communism as well, all these isms have the seeds of their own destruction. The reason is that they're always trying to fit the present moment into some future heavenly place.

I'm fortunate to be old enough to have lived through two different systems. The system that came here after the war had a lot of effects of socialism, a very watered-down communism. This was expressed through the national health system, through support for people to move from one class to another, through the system of grammar schools and all that. The caring was taken on by the state. There was a whole movement after the war to create a state-based service which was for the benefit of the people.

Running alongside that was industry. I remember having discussions or being told that if you went into industry, you got more money, but your job was insecure. But if you worked in one of the government-based systems, then of course your job was secure. If you became a teacher, your job was secure. That was the little bargain that you had between the two. They ran fairly parallel.

But then, as always, you've got this grit which is going to undermine the system. What happened was the workers began to gain tremendous power. Perhaps it can be argued they went over the top. I know that the union boss, the head of the car union, the automobile union, Scanlon, confessed that he'd actually ruined the automobile industry because they were demanding more and more and more. Of course then we got Mrs Thatcher.

What Mrs Thatcher did was to begin to change the system to neoliberalism. This neoliberalism is another ideology. It's a corruption of capitalism in a way, because even - I'm not an economist by the way, this is just general knowledge, you'll have to check it

all out for yourselves afterwards - when Smith wrote the basic book on capitalism, he always had a sense of social justice in there. When he talked about the hidden hand, what he was being, according to one writer, was sardonic. Because all these selfish, self-serving businessmen unwittingly were creating jobs that were helping people who would have been poor. It was a side effect. That's what he meant by the hidden hand.

What neoliberalism did is it made the market the purpose and be-all of society. Everybody has to be part of the market. Everybody is an entrepreneur. You've got to make your way in the market. We've seen Uber in London trying to do that. There's an immediate lowering of wages because you have to bid for a lift to take the person. Three or four bids come up, and of course it's the lowest that gets the lift. So there's a constant pushing down of wages. It just happens naturally. Luckily, they were taken to law, and now they have to employ people. But we saw a worse case just recently with the P&O ferries, where they simply fired 800 people because they were losing 100 million a year, but they just paid out 270 million to their shareholders. The idea that the money will trickle down is actually a tsunami going up, as we know.

The fundamental attitude is acquisitiveness, it's to get money because when you get money you can do what you want. Greed is actually driving the system and what it does is it puts us into an aggressive competitiveness. This has come into - it was never defined. It was just slipped in as an economic program. It was never quite defined as to what was the underlying understanding. It's coming to, Carl mentioned it, that on these programs, from America especially, when everybody says "I'll do something," they're always asking how much they get, how much do you want? Everything has to be some transaction. The idea of giving something or doing something for nothing goes out of the window.

This has become a general feeling in our societies so that when Covid hit everybody suddenly realised they were neighbours and they were helping each other and they said, "Oh look, we're neighbours, we can help each other" and it was just like a revelation because before you just worked out your own life and they lived over there.

Now what happens is that it's the one with the best talent, with the greatest greed, with the ability to fight this competition that's going to win. That's not what Darwin said. He says that it wasn't the strongest or the most intelligent, but the most adaptable. But it's been translated through neoliberalism as greed is good and competition is what we really want, an aggressive competition.

In a pure neoliberalist situation, the worker has no rights. They have to negotiate with the employer. The government must keep away from restricting the market. If you remember Gordon Brown and the light touch, well, it led to this huge collapse in 2008

because the banks were greedy. Everybody's greedy. Trade unions are simply not to be allowed because they just undermine this bargaining, this entrepreneurial spirit. Just recently, Amazon went and fired all the managers in New York because the workers were beginning to form a union.

Charities are a real bind because they're doing something which you could make money out of. So these things are not particularly welcomed and it undermines the entrepreneurial spirit. What about the unemployed? What about the sick and the aged and the mentally ill? Well, they become drags on the whole system. They're just drawing money out of the system. You shouldn't tax people who've made all this money. That's simply not fair. Because they've actually won in the system.

The only way to make it work within a neoliberal system is to privatize it. Then somebody makes the money. Somebody rents the system out to you. This is exactly what's happening now with our GPs. They're selling it to a company called Centene, which even the Daily Mail calls rapacious. It's just going on all the time.

In the system, there's no particular social responsibility. By the way, everything is privatized. The water, the electricity, the transport, everything becomes owned by somebody else who takes their little percentage. All these, the electricity for instance, I know because we had to have three-phase electricity put into our centre. I was talking to the man who organised it and they take 10%. I don't know whether that's 10% after they've paid their shareholders or before, but they take 10%. They're all 10%ers. All these people, these companies, have all taken their little 10%.

This really comes down to this wonderful phrase which most of you will remember from Maggie Thatcher, that there is no such thing as society, there's only individuals. In doing that, you isolate people. One person is up against the other. What's missing there is that the whole is always greater than the sum of the parts. When you have people together, you create community. That's why the miners were so angry when they gave her a state funeral. Because she completely ruined their community and gave them nothing back. It wasn't as though she said, "Well, I'm taking the coal industry away from you, but instead I'm going to put this in its stead so you can earn money and maintain your community." No, she just took everything off.

I was at the process of that, I was teaching at the time at an FE college, Further Education college, and when she took away all the support for industry, the Chamber of Commerce were going berserk. There were so many collapses of businesses. The unemployment rose from 6% to 16% in six months. That's what happened. If you look at the

process, what happened in Chile and to Russia after the collapse of communism, you'll see that's exactly what they did, and it just created enormous poverty. It's something that sticks in the craw of somebody like Putin, that they were so humiliated.

Sorry about that. I'm on my hobby horse, as you can see. When it comes to suppression, when it comes to opposition, then we're beginning to see this suppression and oppression. A bill has just been passed, the Police Crime Sentencing and Courts Bill. You can now be arrested for being a single protester. If you go out with a placard and protest, you can be arrested. You can see, they don't like people who try to buck the system.

Now the real point of this, from a Buddhist point of view - I'm really getting to it - that it would seem the report from Davos, which is where all the rich and mighty meet, was they were absolutely overjoyed at hearing about mindfulness and stress reduction. Because now, when their workers said, "Look, I'm absolutely stressed out," they said, "Look, take this course, go sit in the corner for a while." It's been called the religion of neoliberalism. This amazing technique that the Buddha has given us to liberate ourselves from suffering is actually being used for a system which is so contrary to the Buddha's teachings. It's unbelievable. It's based on greed, for instance.

Finally, what can we do in this situation? Well, it's the usual thing about consumerism because that's what's powering it. Remember that boredom is a big underlying engine to greed. Because if you're in a bored state, well, you go out and do some retail therapy. It's a case of recognizing that what we buy is a fuel in the system. That doesn't mean you can't buy anything, but you might just consider where it's made and whether you need it.

The other thing is that from a personal point of view, just to get back to generosity. Have you noticed, you might not have noticed, but when you do something good for yourself, like you might buy some thermal underwear - I say that because I did it for myself - and it feels fantastic, it feels so warm, you think, "My God, why haven't I discovered this before?" And you feel very good about yourself, you've been so careful, kind to yourself. Now, if I had bought thermal underwear for somebody else, and they had said, "I'm so grateful for this thermal underwear," the joy that I get from that would have lasted longer. Check it out.

When I do something for myself, I get a joy, and it lasts a little bit. But when I do something generous and beautiful for somebody else, it lasts. Every time I bring that to mind, it gives me that little lift of the joy of having brought some happiness into somebody else's life.

I want to quote the Buddha here, and it's around eating. "If beings knew, as I know, the results of giving and sharing, they would not eat without having given, nor would the stain of miserliness overcome their minds. Even if it were their last bite, their last mouthful, they would not eat without having shared if there was somebody to receive the gift. But because beings do not know, as I know, the results of giving and sharing, they eat without having given. The stain of miserliness overcomes their minds."

I'm done with neoliberalism. The next thing brings us into what's happening in Ukraine. What was the Buddha's position when it came to war? He himself was involved in three conflicts of one sort or another.

The first one was up in his own clan, the Sakyans and the Koliyas. They shared this river and they got into a real argy-bargy about it and they were going to have a fist-icuffs. He was up there, he seemed to be up there, and he must have talked to them about the unwholesomeness, the unskillfulness of war. What he asked them was, "What is more precious, the water in the river or the blood in your veins?" This seemed to have brought them to their senses around the old conference table, and they came to an agreement over things.

There's another case where King Virudhaka, who was the king of Kosala. His father, Pasenadi, was a great supporter of the Buddha. This young fellow, he was now the king there. He had asked for a bride from the Sakyans. So it was aristocracy marrying into another. The Sakyans were vassals of Kosala. They were under the Kosalan king, Virudhaka. Well, it came about that he came to know that this woman he'd married was actually low caste. So he was very angry. He vowed to wipe out the Sakyans. He got on his four-fold army: his elephants, his chariots, his cavalry, and his infantry. The Buddha must have heard about this because he went to speak to him. Who knows what he said, but probably on an ethical basis, the idea of rebirth, with hatred, revenge in your heart, is going to have this ongoing problem. So he turned back. He no sooner got back than he got back on his elephant. The Buddha's out there again and this time he was able again to turn him around. He no sooner got back than he got back on his elephant and the Buddha's out there again and he convinces him to turn back. He gets on his elephant again and the Buddha said, "I can't do any more." So he went and he razed the village, the town of Kapilavastu, which was the capital of the Sakyans. I don't know whether he killed anybody. Presumably they just ran off. He damaged the city and then went back home. They built another capital, it seems. Interestingly enough, one is in India and one is in Nepal. There's only a brick wall there. But at least it gives some credence to that story. Again, he's trying to stop war, and I presume his arguments are to do with morality.

The final one is a rather interesting one, where Ajatasattu, who was the son of Bimbisara, who was also a great supporter of the Buddha, and the king of Magadha. He sent his counselor to talk to the Buddha and ask him - it's crazy when you think about it - he asked the Buddha, was it a good time to attack the Vajjian Confederacy? The Buddha did not reply, "It might be good, it might not." He gave principles for the monastic order as to what makes a society strong. I haven't written them down here because we don't need to go into that detail. This particular counselor went back to Ajatasattu and he said, "Well, he gave these principles for a strong *sangha*, a monastic *sangha*, so he must be telling us that the Vajjians are strong." So that's how they interpreted it. But what they did was they sent in the CIA and by bribery and setting people up against one another, they finally undermined the Confederacy and he walked in and took it.

In all these cases, the Buddha is definitely working against conflict, against any form of conflict. Some writers will argue, well, no way would he have supported an offensive war, but he would have supported a defensive war. But frankly, I don't really get that.

These two kings I've mentioned, Pasenadi of Kosala which was up towards Delhi and Bimbisara down here in the Ganges. Bimbisara attacked Kosala and he defeated them. But Pasenadi got his army together and came back and smacked old Bimbisara. In those days, believe it or not, armies just fought against each other. There's a Greek ambassador who says that he watched a battle between two armies and while that was happening the farmers were still working around them. Those were the days of chivalry.

Now, if the Buddha - see, by this time, especially as his order grew, his order is everywhere. There are Buddhist monks everywhere, there are disciples, there are lay disciples, just stretching right across the north of that Gangetic plain. It doesn't go as far as Calcutta, but definitely from about a bit to the east of present-day Benares, all the way up to Delhi, because he gives talks to people called Kurus who live close to present-day Delhi. He's walking around this whole area all his life. He's always on the move.

If he were to say, if he were to side with anybody - this is the Buddha being pragmatic - obviously, the king who he was arguing against would have kicked all his monks and all his members out of his kingdom. That's to make the Buddha sound as though he's a schemer, but on the other hand, he is pragmatic. He's right there grounded in what would happen if he were to support one king against another.

But there's a deeper reason why he doesn't talk about defensive or offensive war. That's because his teaching is always concerned with the individual. It's always about you. I think what he would say to somebody who was going to war would be, "Can you kill another human being without anger or hatred in your heart?" If you can't do that,

then there's going to be consequences for you and the violence will carry on. The Chinese have a saying: those who seek revenge should prepare two graves. There's no end to that violence if you're going to hit violence with violence.

In Buddhist history, in China for instance, the monks, the orders and the Buddhists were persecuted or supported depending on the winds of the emperor. That's why the monks disappeared into the jungles and whatnot and developed this form of fighting Kung Fu. The idea was that you stop the enemy from damaging you, from killing you, but without any hatred, without anything in your heart. This ethos passed over to Japan. There's the story of a samurai who has beaten his opponent, and he's raised his sword to cleave him in two, and he walks away. When they ask him why did he do that, he said, "I felt angry."

Here's, I think, a more nuanced way of looking at the Buddha. He's not supporting any war, but if you are going to go to war, then you have to be very careful that you're doing it not from the heart of hatred, revenge.

I read an article actually about that. It's very difficult to kill a living human being. To actually stand in front of them and kill that person. They did a survey of American soldiers. I can't remember the percentage, but it was shockingly high. It was around about 45-50% did not shoot to kill. They either shot over the enemy or around the enemy. They couldn't actually shoot to kill. They couldn't bring themselves around to doing that. That tells you that it's something very difficult for a human being to do. The way that they can do it is by giving them an object of hate. If you want to get a Russian soldier in a really hateful mood, what you say is your enemy are Nazis, because if you remember they lost 20 million in the war against the German invasion. That's what happened.

I think that brings me to the end of my little effort here. We've been through this whole business of *kamma* and the real message, the real message in terms of ourselves, personal self, is to purify the heart of what is unwholesome and to build up wholesomeness. Then to try to enact that wholesomeness in society in one way or the other. Then the society begins to mirror back to us the wholesomeness that we have put into it. We are intimately connected. In fact, we are our relationships. That's what we actually are. We're in a constant state of relationship. Either with the physical world, the human world, the animal world. As soon as you get up in the morning and you hear the birds, you're in relationship.

Our job is to get that relationship into a place which has got rid of this wrong attitude of seeking happiness in the sensual world. But that doesn't mean to say that we cannot enjoy life, or that we can't enjoy pleasures. It's just recognizing that this is not the be-all and end-all of our existence.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion, and that by your commitment to the ethical and spiritual life you will be relieved of all suffering sooner rather than later.

Right Livelihood

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 36 min read

In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines Right Livelihood (sammā ājīva) as the fifth factor of the Noble Eightfold Path within the context of the Four Noble Truths. He explores how the Buddha distinguished between harmful occupations (trading in weapons, living beings, intoxicants) and skillful work that serves others without causing harm.

The talk addresses common challenges of modern work life: dealing with difficult colleagues, managing repetitive tasks mindfully, and maintaining spiritual practice within secular environments. Bhante discusses the importance of attitude over profession—how motivation for wealth, power, or fame can corrupt any occupation, while service-oriented intention can sanctify even mundane work.

Drawing on examples like Anāthapiṇḍika, the wealthy merchant who supported the Buddha, he demonstrates how entrepreneurship and material success need not conflict with spiritual development when guided by compassion and generosity. The talk offers practical guidance for transforming workplace relationships into opportunities for developing patience, loving-kindness, and present-moment awareness, making the workplace itself a vehicle for liberation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. —
Homage to the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

I thought to say something about right livelihood this evening, and then if there's time to answer one or two of these questions.

When the Buddha formulated his teaching, it didn't come immediately. It was something that grew as he taught. He ended up with the path, the Eightfold Path, and that's part of the Four Noble Truths.

The First Noble Truth simply states that there is *dukkha*. Dukkha translates as a hard place. We're in a hard place. That's what it means. He defined that as being because it was in a constant state of change. Then there was this ordinary suffering that we get through our unfulfilled desires and so on. And then there's that more subtle suffering of knowing that the self is not real anymore. There's an underlying feeling, I think, about life because of death, because it's not steady, because it's always there in the back-

ground. The sense of self doesn't have a ground and that causes a deep anxiety within us. Indeed, you can say that all anxiety and all fear is the fear of death, fear of disappearance.

Then he goes on to be a bit more specific and he says that the cause of suffering is this desire. He simply points to that as a kernel psychological position that we have, seeking happiness in things that are simply not going to deliver, that's all. You wouldn't invest in a stock which was told to you by everybody that it would fail. So life will fail us. We're going to die. And yet there we are, investing everything in it. That desire is a psychological point and from that he then goes on to give us the wheel of dependent origination which is a template of all sentient beings, that's what he says, not just human beings, which is definitely common to all human beings as to how we cause suffering for ourselves.

That's the basic psychology that he's into. It's not developmental psychology. I mean, there is a little bit about the psychology of perception, but he's very clear, one-pointed, always centring on this problem of dukkha. Therefore, the whole psychology is centred on that. In that Second Noble Truth, he pinpoints where the problem lies psychologically and then the third one of course he states quite categorically that there is an end to dukkha. He doesn't use the word *nibbāna* — *nibbāna* is in other texts but in terms of the formulation of the Four Noble Truths the third noble truth is there is an end to dukkha — *dukkha nirodha*. And then finally of course he states the path leading out of it.

The formulation of the Four Noble Truths simply follows the way that doctors wrote their, or at least worked with an illness. First it was diagnosed, like dukkha, and the cause of the illness was discovered. And then finally the prognosis, which in this case is perfect health and happiness. Not health, perfect happiness. And the fourth was the actual medicine to be used. So the medicine that we're using is the Eightfold Path.

We begin, through this practice of meditation, with trying to correct this *sammā-ditṭhi*, this right understanding, to see the world in a correct way. And when we do that, it has a systemic change, which doesn't mean to say that we can't work on these other parts of the path. So the second part, of course, is getting the attitude right, getting the right attitude to things. So today, for instance, we've been trying to develop a much clearer attitude around food. Why are we eating? Sit there and say, no, the pleasure is secondary. It comes up, but I'm not eating for that purpose. I'm eating specifically for nourishment of the body.

Then, having got the intelligence right and the heart right — got the mind and the heart right — there is that natural flow into action. So it's through speech, through action, right action, and then right livelihood. Interestingly enough, there's really no need

logically to put right livelihood in there because it's included in right action. Livelihood is an action. But he obviously felt it to be so important as to have its own particular category.

There's an interesting passage which relates to this where Ānanda, who was his companion for the last twenty-odd years of his life, comes to one of these conclusions where he seems to always get it wrong. And one of these conclusions was that good companionship was half the spiritual life. And the Buddha says, oh no, Ānanda, it's the whole of the spiritual life. So that's how important our companions are, the people whom we mix with, because, of course, they affect us. We're in constant conversation with them. We relate to people who are close to us, work with us, etcetera.

So then he states this right livelihood as a section on its own. It's worth just thinking about it a little bit, reflecting on it and seeing what pointers we can get. The fact of the matter is that livelihood takes up so much of our life, generally speaking, that obviously it has to become a vehicle through which we can practice and hopefully liberate ourselves.

Just very quickly, we can dismiss all those things that are not right livelihood. Anything that brings harm to other people. Trading in arms, in living beings, intoxicating drinks, poison, slaughtering, fishing, soldiering, deceit, treachery, soothsaying, trickery, usury, etcetera. There's a whole load of things which would not be considered skilful because they are inherently doing other people harm. Remember that all ethics, the whole of the ethical life in the Buddha's teaching simply comes down to doing harm. To do harm to somebody else in any way is considered to be unwholesome. So any job that you can see is actually doing harm to another person, or we can extend it these days to the planet, may give you cause for concern. I hope I've not made anybody redundant.

Just on that note, if, of course, one finds oneself in a job which the person has ethical problems around, then you have to be kind to yourself. You can't just drop it there and then. But just by deciding that you don't want to do this job anymore and inclining towards another job, then you'll slowly find your way out of it. There are other conditions to be taken into consideration, generally speaking.

For instance, I know somebody who was in the beer trade, sold beer for a company. And once he became into the Dharma, then he had this problem about should he be selling beer. I never quite got a straight answer from him as to how he finally rationalised himself into keeping the job. But the fact was that he wanted to know what I felt. I said, well, if I really felt strongly about that, I would move towards another job, but I'd

have to take into consideration the effects on my family. So I don't want to take a hard position on something and then find myself being redundant and putting a huge pressure.

I know somebody else who was in the police and had similar problems. He really didn't like the way the police worked. He got a lot of ethical problems about the way the police force worked. So he wanted to move, and he was interested in some sort of therapy, I remember. But he took the road of trying to get some funding for it, and eventually he couldn't get it. So he simply found a corner within the police force where he felt at least he wasn't joining in those parts which he felt were unethical. He ended up in special branch. Looking after politicians. Yeah, that's an ethical problem. Don't be too cynical.

Leaving all that aside, we can then also delineate those motivations which are not particularly — I mean, they're not as bad as selling human beings and that sort of stuff, but are unwholesome, they're unskilful. And here we come to this whole area of — we've got this word now, haven't we? — the celebs. So, who are these? What is a celebrity? It's somebody who's made it either with riches, power, or fame, isn't it? They've done something that makes them well-known in their own field.

Now, you can understand if that's the aim of your life, to get rich or to get power in order to realise your aims or simply to become famous, then it puts a twist on the job you're doing, doesn't it? It puts a twist on the job. I know that we have downers on people who've made a lot of money out of their business. Poor old Bill Gates comes in for a hammering. But the interview that I saw, I mean, his interest wasn't so much in making money, but it began with a real interest in the whole idea of computers and what computers could do. Then, of course, he's very successful and you build an empire. And then, of course, you're into defence and you're up against Sony and people like that. And the whole thing becomes slightly twisted.

Again, whenever we look at the — again, it's to do with attitude. It's not about not getting money. The Buddha, again, is quite clear. It's not how much you earn that's important. It's how you earn it. The amount you get is neither here nor there. And then, of course, what you do with the amount. What do you do with the money you have? And if it's done for the benefit of others, then obviously it's a very wholesome thing.

So the Buddha is definitely into entrepreneurship, and I'm sure he'd be a supporter of some form of capitalism if he was here. I hope nobody's going to shoot me. So the case is that this business of making money, if you look at somebody like Anāthapiṇḍika, he was one of his great supporters. Anāthapiṇḍika was a merchant, made a lot of money and bought grounds for a monastery. In fact, the tale goes that he wanted to buy

this park from Prince Jeta and the prince didn't want to sell it at all so he said he would only sell it if it was completely covered with gold coins. So Anāthapiṇḍika, wanting to make this gift to the Buddha, completely covered with gold coins, and got it from Prince Jeta. And it's known as the Jetavana Monastery. And obviously the Buddha liked being there. It was a nice place.

So Anāthapiṇḍika then it seems loses all his money and even in abject poverty never comes to the monastery without something. So at one point he arrives just with soil in his hands that he's picked up from his own garden, good soil, and he spreads it onto the monastery grounds. Later it seems he does become rich again and in the end, as the story goes, he dies as a sort of *arahant*, so in other words he's one of the noble ones, one who has intuited *nibbāna*. So there's hope for us, hope for us all, even hope for the rich.

It's a case of there's nothing actually wrong with being rich. That's the point from the Buddha's point of view. And of course the same can go for power. People who use power just for perfect selfish reasons, well, we've got lots of examples of those these days. It's one of the big problems, for instance, in Africa, isn't it? Really bad governance where people just screw their own people from all sorts of things. But obviously when you get somebody who is in power and has power for the benefit of the society that they're in, then obviously it's not something to be seen as unskilful and unwholesome. Somebody has to make decisions. Even in a small workplace, somebody has to make decisions. Whoever makes decisions has the power.

So it's a case of, again, power not in itself being something unskilful or unwholesome, but basically how we use it. And just on a side of that, in our lives, especially, say, places at work, we all of us have, shall we say, a ring of power. We can all do something, affect something. And then there's another ring, which is about influence, so we can influence people to do things. And then, of course, it stops.

A lot of our problems arise because we don't recognise where the end of that ring is. So when we try to exercise more power than we have, then of course we tend to become frustrated. And if we find ourselves not using our power but being overridden by others who are less powerful than us, then we feel that we've let people down, we've not lived up to our responsibility because with power there comes that responsibility.

And it's the same with influence. Whatever influence we have, we should use for the benefit of others. But when we see that our influence is not working, then you have to be very careful that you accept that boundary. If you don't accept that boundary, then again you start feeling frustrated and all sorts of stuff. So people, especially in those areas which are caught up in that work where there's a lot of emotional value put on it — like ecological issues and political issues — and if they don't accept where their

boundary of power and influence lies, then they just get burnout, and that doesn't help anybody at all. So that's important too, isn't it? To know the extent of what we're capable of doing ourselves and of how much we are capable of getting other people to do things.

And then fame. Fame is probably the shallowest of them all, really. But as you know, famous people, either film stars or football stars and whatnot, I mean, you can use it for the benefit of others. I mean, I suppose a very good example of that is Bob Geldof, isn't it? I mean, after all, he's only a musician. And yet he's able to motivate people. And so anything that we have, even within our small area of influence, which is done for the benefit of others, is thereby wholesome. I mean, if one becomes famous and then one gets a very big head, then it just becomes a headache in the end, doesn't it?

And all these things, of course, when they're taken from you, they cause misery. They cause a lot of misery. I always remember that case of a very young East European immigrant to Australia, who in a very short length of time built up this huge property empire. And when property dropped in, I think it was in the eighties, he committed suicide.

So you can see how we can make this mistake of actually identifying with the power we have, no matter how little it is, and the riches and the fame. And that's one of the big problems with being made redundant, isn't it? I mean, being made redundant in our society, sure, it's a catastrophe in a sense that your wage can go, your sense of work can go, all that sort of stuff. But what turns people, what makes it despairing, of course, is that relationship that the person had with the job. You lose your sense of identity because unwittingly you define yourself by the work you do, don't you? Whether you like it or not.

If anybody says, what are you? What do you do? You don't say, well, I clean the toilet at home. You say, well, I teach. You don't say, I cook a meal every so often. You say, what do you do? Even our crucial questions always point to actually what do you do in society? And from what you do in society, we tend to build up our self-esteem, our self-importance. All those sorts of areas. And of course our basic wealth.

So when these are taken from us in an act of redundancy, that's when you hit that despair because you have to redefine yourself. And the definition of being unemployed isn't a particularly happy one in our society.

So it's really just being aware of that. And if things happen to us which take away our wealth and power and good name — I mean fame doesn't here just mean famous in the sense of pop stars, it just means your good name — so somebody can take away

your good name. And to do that, you have to watch that and watch your reaction to it, if that happens to you, and recognise that the suffering you're getting from it is the measure of your attachment to the wealth you had and the power you had and the good name you had.

And in that way, you don't justify it. This is the problem with these negative emotions. We actually justify them. We say we ought to be angry, we ought to be depressed, we ought to be fearful. And as soon as you do that, you empower these states. So whenever something like that happens, you have to really back off and sit in your meditation and recognise that these are actually all measures of some form of attachment, some form of wrong view.

Even if we look at various jobs, most people can find some sort of compassionate angle to what they do. I mean, it's easy in areas of service, health workers, people like that, teaching profession, doctors. All that sort of area is, and even the police, for heaven's sake. All that sort of area is, I would have thought, fairly easy to develop the right attitude. To see the job as something that is being done for others, a sense of service.

When it comes to other jobs such as even entrepreneurship, business work and all that, you often get a bit of a downer on that, making money, setting up a business and all that. But actually, it's another service, isn't it? And depending on your attitude, depending on the purpose of what you're doing, then it can be tremendously worthwhile, wholesome.

Now when it comes to even those jobs that at one point we used to use the word workers, now it's more politically correct to talk about operatives. So when you're a machine operative and you're doing something very repetitive, very monotonous, then I think that you can engender that sense of it being a service — somebody has to do the job, I mean, that's a bit of a negative way of looking at it, but in the sense that whatever the product is, so long as it's a wholesome product, a good product, then this is what the society's offered you at this particular point, and one does what one can within that situation.

Now, there are some jobs which, shall we say, are more directly effective upon the heart. I mean, to work with the sick, with the dying and all that, immediately, especially working with people, has an immediate effect with right attitude of extending the heart, of making it grow in those areas that we call the immeasurables, because they can be developed indefinitely. So love, compassion, sympathetic joy, care, all those lovely attitudes can be developed.

But when you get into a job where you're working with a machine, say in an office or in a factory, then of course it's difficult to have the same value of compassion towards a machine and whatnot. But there is an opportunity there to see it as a meditative exercise. And I often think about people these days even, but even more so in earlier times in our society where so many people had very repetitive jobs doing the same thing. And of course that's all we're doing, isn't it? Rising, falling. You couldn't get more repetitive than watching the breath. And if you were to take that same attitude to a repetitive job, no matter what you're doing, of using it to establish this constant mindfulness, then you can see it would definitely have a strong spiritual effort to it.

I remember, even I myself, when I was a kid, used to get a job, aged sixteen, seventeen, get a job after school. And one job I had was in this bakery, this cake factory. And there was a line of women who followed this, who followed the process from when the dough arrived or whatever, when the baked, and it sort of swung round and went round this little machine and things were added onto this cake as it came round. And I was given the job of adding the cherry round the top. It was the last point. And as it swung round, I had to get this cherry and stick it on.

Well, occasionally, of course, I'd miss, or it wasn't centred, and I'd sort of go after it and try and put it. And eventually they shifted me. I was absolutely useless. Even though I protested that I was school captain, I was dexterous with my feet, and if they'd just give me time, I could actually do this job. And I remember these lovely, kindly, simpering looks from the women, oh, he's only a boy, and all that sort of stuff.

But the thing is that just being able to accept one's position there and just to use it as a concentration exercise, you can see that even something so repetitive can be turned to spiritual advantage.

So you might think then, well, how would you profile a good day at work? How would you set your mind to take as much spiritual advantage out of the work that you can get?

So the first thing, of course, is to get up and do your two-hour meditation. And then after that, to develop a bit of loving-kindness. Now, in that loving-kindness that you're developing, to actually bring the people whom you work with to mind, to bring the place to mind, to bring everybody associated to mind, and what you're doing is you're establishing a right relationship. So right attitude is right relationship. And if there's somebody whom you're having problems with, to at least offer an attitude of no harm and occasionally just think of their brighter side. So in a sense, you're setting yourself right with the people, with the people whom you have to work with.

But there's also the job. Now, I can't think of a job which doesn't have this quality of repetition to it. Everything in life has this repetitive quality about it. And we go through periods of boredom with it and periods of not wanting to do it. So if you get out of bed in the morning and there's just this huge desire to take a day off, then to actually stay with that, not to be hijacked by it, no matter how much you can justify it, for all sorts of reasons. And to let that feeling, that down feeling, to just evaporate a little bit, and then to make that commitment to give your best to the job in hand. And by doing that, the heart will lift. The heart won't lift unless you make a decision. Once you make a decision to do something, the heart will follow your decision.

So it's a case of, for instance, if you want to do a job, and you want to do the job, if there's a negativity towards it, now it's the same in meditation, if you suppress it, then it remains there as a rumbling within the psyche. But if you accept that there's a negativity towards the job, right, and you're just there with it and you can distance from it, with this wonderful noting technique, and it's there, you know it's there, and then you override it with right attitude. And that lifts the heart.

On a slightly parallel situation is when you might feel angry towards a colleague or a workmate. These days, especially through certain therapies, not all of them, you get these things about owning your emotion. Now, that's all right. It's just that people confuse that owning with actually being. So it's all right to say, there is anger arising with this person. But you shouldn't say, I am angry with this person. And then, of course, you have to be authentic, inverted commas, and you have to tell the person that you're angry with them.

Now, how do you feel when somebody comes up and says, I'm angry with you? I mean, what's your response to that? While I was at Gaia House, I had a manager who was forever coming to see me and would sit there and say, I've got problems with you. What am I supposed to say? I'd say, oh, what can I do about that? And she was being authentic, she was being truthful. And of course, the presumption is that I am the cause of her dissatisfaction with me. And when you go to work and you say, look, I'm very angry with you, what you're saying is, you are the cause of my anger, what are you going to do about it?

So it's recognising that all those negative states are arising out of me because of some wrong attitude. Now we know from our meditation that we can't sink them, we can't push them away, try to bury them, but we can, as it were, shift them to the side. This is being skilful. So it's not me, it's not I am angry, there is anger, and I'll deal with you when the opportunity occurs. So it's not a case of pushing it away and suppressing it, it's simply putting it to the side, dealing with it at an appropriate time. And then, of

course, one raises the attitude of kindness. Kindly words, a smile. And then, of course, you find your heart lifts towards that attitude and supports you. But again, it would be a mistake to think that, therefore, I am kind. It's just that there is now kindness and this is the relationship that I'm engendering towards this particular person.

So getting the attitude right every morning is important. So now, when it comes to the work itself, to re-establish why it is you're doing this work, and give it an attitude which is worthwhile and meaningful spiritually. You can do that. Apart from these dreadful jobs that some people do, most times you can find a worthwhile reason for doing the work.

So then one goes into the workplace and one sits at one's place or takes up the position of your workplace and just to stop for a minute and to re-establish, to constantly re-establish that sense of mindfulness, right attitude and then to give yourself to the work.

Now, it's a case of being loose in that situation and of recognising that we're in relationship with other people. This is if you're working with other people. You're in relationship with other people. So it's much the same as our meditation. When you're sitting here in meditation, we've got this desire to investigate what's going on inside me. But if somebody comes in here now and starts talking and draws our attention, if we see that as a disturbance, we're immediately in conflict. So we're immediately raising all those dreadful states that here we're supposed to be trying to let go of.

So it's the same at work, where you're doing work and a colleague comes and they're all flustered or whatever, and it's a case of just one minute, and you just know where you are, and then you respond.

And remember that when somebody comes to you with flutter, with anger and what-not, it's putting your concentration on what they're saying, not how they're saying. If you put your concentration on how they're saying, it's very difficult to stop that reaction of that immediate reaction coming from us of anger towards anger, anger towards their dumping their anxiety on us. But so long as your attention is on what they're saying, then you can guard yourself from that immediate reaction that arises.

Just on that point too, when you're with somebody who is coming at you in that way, one of the things you can do is image, if you're quick enough that is, or at least have the idea of the Buddha hand. So remember this, there's a statue called the Abhaya posture, the fearlessness. And this goes back to when the dastardly Devadatta tried to kill the Buddha, three times I can say. And the third time was this dreadful elephant whom he set loose. And Nalagiri, the raging bull elephant, paced down upon the Buddha. And the

Buddha stood there, held up his hand in a fearless posture, and blasted the elephant with compassion. And the elephant, of course, immediately stopped and adored the Buddha.

Now, whether we believe the fullness of that story, the fact of the matter is that that tells us how to deal with situations where we find negativity coming towards us. So it's a case of protecting ourselves. So you don't have to receive somebody's anger. You don't have to accept it. You don't have to take it in. You don't have to empower it by actually reacting to it. This is what we do, isn't it? You empower anger when you react to it. So it's a case of — and by doing that, you protect your own heart. But from behind the hand, at least you're offering an attitude of no harm. And I personally find that easier if I'm actually listening to what they're saying and not how they're saying.

So in my job, of course, I get occasionally very strange people. And I was running — nobody here. Nobody here at all. And there was this occasion of a Christmas retreat that I run at Sharpham House, which is a very beautiful place, by the way. It's a lovely place to have a Christmas retreat. And because of some mistake on the calendar, one advert said the Wednesday and another one said Tuesday.

So this elderly lady came who had seen it was Wednesday and when she came and realised that she was late and it was all, she got very, very angry and flustered about it. So I was working with a very good manager who'd been a manager at Gaia House. And she went out of her way to, she gave her back a day's money, tried to make her feel at home, showed her around, etcetera. And when we met, she was still very, very angry about it all. So a huge heart of compassion embraced this elderly lady and to make her feel at home, and explained everything, and then the next day, she arrived in the evening, so the next day I spent some time with her and showed her around the house, and she was still very angry, and once she realised that it wasn't the retreat she wanted, she wanted a hard retreat like Zen, and the one I was leading was more of a reflective, contemplative time, just spending our time a lot in reflection. She was angry about that.

So I was still, keeping my hand up and beaming out an amazing amount of compassion and all that sort of stuff. And then, of course, we had, on Christmas Day, we broke the silence and we had cake. And everybody got fairly loud and all that sort of stuff. And the conversation was about twenty-odd people. And she was sitting there by the side. And earlier I'd seen her chatting quite well or openly with these other people. So I just went over to her and said, oh, how is everything? And off she went, moaning and groaning. Well, I said, oh, for heaven's sake. I said, you've been giving them nothing but — and so there, I'd lost my guard. I'd chewed into it. Well, of course, she didn't moan

again. Not in front of me, anyway. Unfortunately, we didn't have the opportunity, because we were leaving about the next day, to make it up, really. But I doubt if I'll be seeing her again.

So, now, what did I do? Well, frankly, I found it rather funny. But the last thing I tend to do is to get into this big self-judgment of, for God's sake, you're supposed to be a monk, you're not supposed to lose your temper. I just accept that there was a failure there. So one records it. One says, ah, right. You've got to be on your toes because you never know where somebody's at.

This whole business of working with people who, remember, like ourselves, are going through various ranges of emotion within one day. I mean, just think. If you were to log the amount of mental states that arise from the time you get up and the time you fall asleep, I mean, it's just madness, isn't it? I mean, you're happy, you're sad, you're depressed, you're angry, and you're fed up and you're bored. I mean, it's constant. Every so often there's a little blip of peace. Oh, God, a relaxation of happy. I'm happy. You tell the world and suddenly, oh, you get angry again.

So they sort of held the skeleton of our emotional life. And when you actually catch that that's how I am and I expect other people to be compassionate and kind towards me and not to get angry and to understand me and give me a hug every so often, it asks us to behave in the same way towards other people. So that whole business of interrelationship at work, and especially where there's difficulty with colleagues, these for us are real points of growth. Another bloody opportunity for growth, as somebody said. To look upon things positively, to see these other people who are absolutely awful as our teachers — that's the attitude we ought to have.

Then of course there's that constant effort to bring us back into the present moment. Some of you might know Thich Nhat Hanh and Plum Village and one of the little techniques they use there is they have somebody who randomly rings a bell every so often. And when the bell goes, you have to stop. Whatever you're doing, you just stop. And then you wait for the third bell and then you can carry on. And they even do that with telephones.

Now, most of us work around telephones or have a telephone at home. So when the telephone goes, normally we launch ourselves towards it. So ask yourself, most people will hang on for three or four rings. And it's a case of acknowledging it. So if you're doing a piece of work, it's very confusing, at least for males, to have to do two or three things at once. So it's a case of seeing where you are, acknowledging the phone call, and then just that moment of clarification, of clearing the mind, stopping, and then so that when you answer the phone you've actually given yourself to the phone call.

So half the mind isn't still doing your work, half the mind isn't still over there, you're actually dedicating this time to the phone call. And then of course when you put the phone down, the same thing — that moment of reflection as to what has passed, anything that needs to be done from that phone call whatever, and then a return back to the work you're doing. A moment of stopping, a recognition, because you've left it mindfully, it's so much easier to remember where you were at, and off you go.

Now, by doing that, you stop this rollercoaster of how emotions gather during the day like a storm. Even simple occasions where people have said something which upset you a little bit. So, you've all been through this, where there's been that little irritation, but you've sort of palmed it aside. It's just the way they are. But it's not been dealt with and it's a little suppression. And then just when the mind relaxes and you're having a cup of tea or something, how dare you, all that sort of stuff. And you get into this, telling them exactly what you feel and that sort of stuff. And then of course it builds up and by evening you're sort of hanging them and ripping them apart and then you have to take an aspirin.

So it's a case of watching that, being very clear as to when that happens, to actually stop. And that's where this meditation we're doing has an immediate role to play in our everyday life. Because that's what we're learning. We're learning that as soon as I feel any sense of irritation, immediately there's that alarm bell goes and I'm with it. I don't join it. I don't get into it. There is irritation or there's anxiety. As soon as it's there, the alarm bell should go and I should be awake to it. It only takes a second. And then to make sure that there's a right attitude and a right understanding from which you're acting and not from this negativity. Otherwise, you just get hijacked, don't you? You just find yourself being angry, being anxious.

So, if we take the workplace as a place to train spiritually, you can see it's got massive potential. And then when you finish work and you come home, that evening meditation really is very important because that's the point where you allow the day to come up. So at the end of each sitting, I ask people to reflect. So what are we reflecting on? We're reflecting upon how skilful we've been through this past three quarters of an hour, an hour. And by bringing that reflection

Qì Gōng Movement Guidance

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1 min read

In this practical session, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides practitioners through a series of gentle qì gōng movements designed to prepare the body and cultivate mindfulness before meditation. The practice includes stretching exercises, joint rotations, and coordinated breathing techniques that help release physical tension and center awareness in the present moment.

While qì gōng originates from Chinese tradition, Bhante demonstrates how mindful movement can complement Buddhist meditation practice by developing bodily awareness (kāyagatāsati) and establishing a foundation of comfort for sitting meditation. The session emphasizes coordinated breathing—inhaling through the nose and exhaling through the mouth—while maintaining present-moment awareness throughout each movement.

This guidance is particularly valuable for practitioners who experience physical stiffness or restlessness before meditation, offering a skillful means to prepare both body and mind for deeper contemplative practice. The movements are accessible to practitioners of all levels and can be incorporated into daily routine as preparation for formal meditation sessions.

Pointing your hands in front and bowing. So putting your hands on top of your head, leaning the body to the right. To the left. Up hands at the back leaning backwards and straightening up, bending down on the knees and stretching the toes, rising and holding the knees and turning them round, first to the right and then to the left.

Hands on the hip and swinging the hips round to the right three times and three times to the left. Stretching up into the air and bringing the arms down behind you, lifting up behind you and stretching the arms in front of you, bending the fingers and then bending each finger one after the other, shaking the hands.

Standing on one leg, begin to turn one of them in a circle three times and then the other way, pointing outwards, stretching the foot forward. Standing on the other leg three times turning and the other way, and stretching forward. Legs apart and stretching the shoulders, just lifting them up and turning them in as great a circle as you can, and the other way, and giving them a shake.

Look behind you to the right and then to the left, to the right and to the left, to the right and to the left. Bending the head backwards, backwards and forwards, backwards and forwards. Bringing the hands down, twisting the arms round and coming to a stop.

From now on you're breathing in through the nose and out through the mouth. Just lowering the body downwards and lifting it up straight up into the sky, and with the out-breath drawing your arms down towards the front and back down to the sides. With the out-breath into the standing pose. Bending down and lifting up with the in-breath. Breathing out, stretching up. Breathing in and bringing the arms down and out and then turning the hands.

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